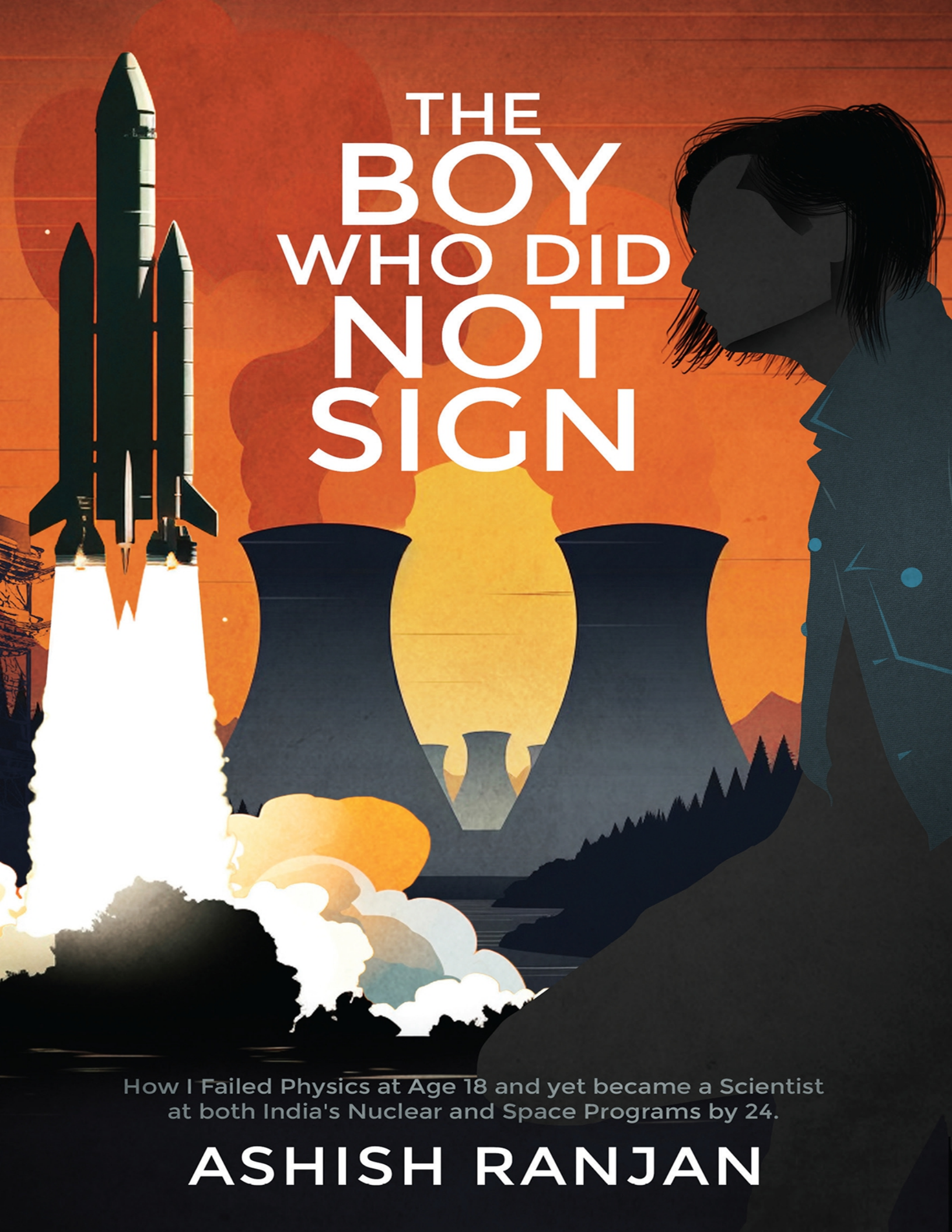


The background of the book cover is a stylized illustration. On the left, a space shuttle is launching, with a large plume of white smoke and fire. In the center, there are two large, dark, hourglass-shaped structures, likely representing nuclear reactors, with a smaller one in the distance. The sky is a warm orange color, and there are dark silhouettes of trees and mountains in the background. On the right side, there is a dark silhouette of a person's head and shoulders, looking towards the left.

THE BOY WHO DID NOT SIGN

How I Failed Physics at Age 18 and yet became a Scientist
at both India's Nuclear and Space Programs by 24.

ASHISH RANJAN

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INDIA • SINGAPORE • MALAYSIA



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Dedicated to
Komal Taya,
One of the very few who saw me for what I could become,
not what I was.

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Prologue

The Boy Who Did Not Sign

12th June 2018, 10:00 am | Outside the Green Room, SCAR, Mumbai.

I was 24, stood 6 ft tall, and weighed 55 kilos. Sleep deprivation had left dark circles under my eyes — More conspicuous than the craters on Moon — My devil red eyes caused a pinching pain every time I tried to focus on anything longer than a second — Hair long, messy and greasy — White checked shirt over my shoulders, loosely tucked into my factory worker grade rugged brown trousers — Pair of *chappals* under my feet — My appearance, a spat on the face of professionalism. I had a persistent feeling that I was about to puke my insides out — Physically, I was the weakest I have ever been. If you ever wanted to kick my ass because you found me arrogant and self-centered in my YouTube videos, you missed your chance.

I, along with other graduating Scientists, was standing on the tiles of an establishment that had cemented its place amongst the scientific gems of the world — An institution that empowered a Nation — Born in the turbulent times of the 1940s, right when the world was rearranging its puzzle pieces — *Scientific Center of Atomic Research* or SCAR for short is a technological marvel — The beating heart of the Nuclear strength of the World's largest Democracy.

It was the long-awaited Placement Day — An annual ceremony going on for 61 years. Nuclear Energy Agency (NEA) as the agency and SCAR as its first research facility, were established at Mumbai on 1st August 1948. Across the next 8 years, NEA started 3 more research centers: *Fast Breeder Research Center* (FBRC) at Vishvenpuram, *Cryogenic Technology Research Center* (CTRC) at Delhi, and

Cyclotron Research Center (CRC) at Kolkata — Received Government funding and decided to structure out their recruitment process. NEA assigned the task of training fresh recruits for the Scientist position to SCAR, which then established its Academy in 1956. Over the next six decades, NEA expanded to dozens of departments, facilities, research centers, production factories, and Nuclear Power Plants, spread across a country larger than the continent of Europe. Basically, anything the country needs relating to Nuclear is taken care of by NEA.

For 61 years, SCAR's Academy has been organizing a year-long training of fresh recruits, with its demand rising yearly. Now, here are a few facts:

- The population of India: 1.3 Billion
- Average age: 28
- Most preferred profession: Engineering
- Mechanical Engineering graduates every year: Roughly 600,000
- Total Engineering graduates every year: Roughly 5,000,000
- Most preferred category of jobs: Government Jobs

Every year, out of 1,000,000 graduates that appear in the SCAR's written test for the Scientist position, 2800 make it to the Interview round, out of which 140 get selected into the program — Percentage selected out of total appeared: 0.014%. After you crack the notoriously difficult SCAR Interview, you don't become a Nuclear Scientist right away. You first have to go through a grueling one-year course on "Nuclear Science and Engineering" at the SCAR Academy — Waiting at the tail-end of which is the placement day where you reap what you have sown for a year — The department that you will work at throughout your career is based on your relative performance in the hyper-competitive training program.

The Academy is not competitive because it's brimming with the most skilled graduates of the country, but because there, competition is an obligation. At the end of the training, for example, if 10 Mechanical Engineers successfully graduate through the Academy, NEA will release 10 vacancies. The choice is given rank-wise, i.e., Rank 1 gets in the Green Room first — Picks any of the vacancies he or she likes the best — gets out. Rank 2 then gets 9 options, and so on. You don't need to be a Math major to derive that the last one doesn't get a choice. That person, the *Bottomer*, has to accept whatever is left on the table. This has happened in SCAR for 61 years, and when something goes on for that long, people just

accept it like the weather changes across the year. Guess who was the *Bottomer* this year?

“Ashwin Taksh!! Get in.” called the manager.

I honestly believed that they might not call me in. After all, what are they going to ask me? What am I going to pick? I had no options. I think they called me out of courtesy, out of generosity, or maybe just out of professionalism. Whatever the reason might be, they were about to regret it.

I entered the Green Room, which was disappointingly not green at all. It had a huge rectangular table — Around 15-20 senior scientists were sitting along each long side of the table — All level ‘G’ or above — Few were Deputy Directors and Directors. They were from the *FBRC - Bureau of Reactor Design* (F-BRD), *Nuclear Fuel Rod Fabrication Center* (NFRFC), *Fast Breeder Test Department* (FBTD), *SCAR Automation Division* (SAD), *Moderator Production Entity* (MPE), *Nuclear Regulation Entity* (NRE), CTRC, CRC, FBRC and SCAR. The room was well-lit with giant windows — Most were chatting amongst themselves — Some enjoying their fifth tea of the day — Few staring at the wall thinking about the meaning of life — None cared to take a look at me. The chairman of the Placement committee, Amar Pratap Singh, was sitting at the short side end of the table — The farthest end observed from the entry door I had just walked in through. He looked older than he was, 32 years of Nuclear Engineering had wiped away every last trace of hair off his head — Now it was an infertile radioactive dead zone — Forever deprived of vegetation. I would like to say that the permanent grumpy look on his face was because of it, but then again, there’s a reciprocity theorem that seems highly feasible. It’s a chicken-egg problem that we’ll try to solve some other day. With a wide smile, he looked at me and asked,

“Ashwin, how are you?”

“Ahh... I... I am fine, sir.” I said with a gloomy tone.

“So, here’s the situation. Of the 12 vacancies, 11 are taken by those who performed better than you in the Academy. Unlike others, you don’t have options...”

His voice faded and took the back seat as I wondered how my life came to this. Or rather, came back to this. I had been a *Bottomer* before — All along the school life till the age of 18, struggling to even pass the subjects. In 11th Standard, I failed Physics — Barely qualifying to appear for 12th boards, where I ultimately scored

53/100 in Math and 61/100 in Physics. But those kinds don't get into an institution like SCAR, so what changed?

It was June 2012, and I was 18 years old when I found my interest in Mechanical Engineering — Found a reason to study. Out of 24 hours a day, I started spending at least 12 studying. For the next 4 years, most of my college life went by in libraries. I graduated in June 2016 with a CGPA of 9.57 and a Bronze Medal. This gave me enough confidence to overlook average jobs and run for the best: *Indian Space Research Organisation* (ISRO). So, for one more year after graduating, living in Delhi PGs, I did nothing but work day and night for competitive exams. I used to study till my backbone screamed for bloody mercy — After which I would lie down and study some more till my eyes cursed their fate to be plugged in my eye sockets — For 6 years, I slept for no more than 6 hours in a 24-hour cycle. Every morning, at 5:00 a.m., before the Sun or my brain could wake up, my ass was already on the chair, and my hand already running to solve numericals of Mechanical Engineering. By 2017, I had cracked the SCAR interview and simultaneously got selected for a master's at the Indian Institute of Technology, Bombay — The IIT tag for which the youth of this country has done far worse. I did more in 6 years than anybody, including me, would have ever expected of me. So, how did my life come back to this?

“You there?... Thought I lost you there. Let's make it quick, Ashwin. Sign here. We want to end the formalities as early as possible.”, said Amar pointing at a clipboard with a list of names and their placements beside them.

Well, for starters, I failed to qualify for the ISRO exam in May 2017. You do not know how deep a cut a failure can leave behind unless you've ever failed at something you really wanted to achieve. I was a Bronze Medalist but an unemployed one — So I settled for the best job I could get. 11 others did perform better than me for reasons that will be uncovered as you read more. Still, the question is, after passing 18 graduate-level courses, 52 written exams, 120 assignments, and over 10 hours of viva by the best scientists in the country, do I deserve to have a mediocre plant maintenance job when I could have gone to IIT for my master's? How did this happen for 60 years? How can someone who has gone through such academic screening could ever settle for a position like that? — I did not know, never did understand *Mediocres* well. But I did know everything there was to know about the *Extremes*, and when it comes to *Bottomers*, there are two kinds: The sleeping kind and the wide awake kind. The one thing common in

both is that none can give two craps about some pecking order. I knew this because I had been both. Guess which *Bottomer* was standing in that Green Room being patronized about why he does not deserve an option?

One year of Nuclear Engineering, they taught me a lot about Fission reactions — How Uranium is the heaviest natural material — That Plutonium 239 is man-made and wasn't found until we started altering the world that created us — How we can use Einstein's $E=mc^2$ to generate enormous energies locked within the atoms — That Thorium locked in coastal sands of India can make the country power independent forever. They taught us a lot about how you can use Nuclear Fission to continuously produce clean energy, but they never really focused on how to fabricate an Atom Bomb. For good reasons, I'm sure, but everything you learn need not be taught, and right there — I dropped one — when I said,

“S... sorry sir... I will not accept this posting.”

It was Austrian Lise Meitner, a Jew in Hitler's *Third Reich* who first realized how to split an atom back in 1939 while she was on the run from the *Holocaust*. She was never awarded the Nobel prize that she deserved for being the first to join the dots between Einstein's scientific magic and practicality. Six years later, on 6th August 1945, the first Atom bomb based on Uranium was dropped on Hiroshima — It instantly obliterated an entire city along with 66,000 of its civilians — But couldn't even put a scratch on the Japanese pride. Three days later, a second drop on Nagasaki annihilated 39,000 more and the pride. It brought an end to a 6 year-long global conflict. But the one that I had just dropped started one — A war with a 6-decade old system which I believed had been rusted by some of the foul components which were not replaced at the right time — A war which could have been avoided only if I decided to shut my eyes to what was happening. We hate conflicts, but some conflicts are necessary. Sooner or later, the world will put its spotlight on you, and when it does, you can either choose to close your eyes or do what needs to be done, disregarding the consequences.

“How dare you?! YOU WILL HAVE TO ACCEPT! YOU ARE THE BOTTOMER!! YOU HAVE NO CHOICE!! If you don't, you will be blacklisted forever in the NEA. Your entire career will be ruined! We won't even give you a N.O.C. to apply for other jobs!” the chairman roared — His voice and cheek muscles trembled in anger. All his casual attitude was now wiped by the tide of hearing something he never expected from a fresh graduate.

“I am sorry, sir. I didn’t join SCAR for this.” I said in a low tone and stood quietly with my vision glued to the floor.

After a few seconds of unsettling silence again, he brought his volume a little lower to pull himself back into the professional domain and said,

“Fine. You don’t want to have a career... So be it. Open a shop somewhere; your Engineering days are over. I will make sure it is. We don’t have time for all of this. You can leave now.”

As soon as I took steps toward the exit,

“Wait...” Said the chairman.

I turned back and saw him holding the clipboard with a page with the Government’s seal. He continued,

“...You will have to sign here before you go.”

I said,

“Sorry, sir. I do not accept this placement, and hence I cannot sign.” and walked out the exit door beside him as I heard the clipboard being tossed on the desk.

SCAR doesn’t just train you amongst the most cutting-edge technology, invests lakhs of Rupees in you getting senior NEA scientists to take courses and pay you a monthly stipend so that you take it all and say your goodbyes at the end of the training. Before you join, it makes you sign a Bond amount of Rs 4,38,000, which binds you to serve NEA for at least 3 years after completing your training. I knew very well that I did not have the money to pay the bond and resign via proper channel. My family was not going to support me as they loved their son with a Government job way more than they loved their son. One year of neighbors and colony members praising them for their son being a Nuclear Scientist at SCAR had made their heads big and their ignorance bigger. I bought a one-way ticket to Bangalore without informing anyone and decided to run away from NEA. But why wouldn’t I just accept the position? After all, it was still better than being an Unemployed Rogue Scientist with a permanent stain on my career. Why not just accept what’s handed over?

Once I drank this vile of possibilities, there was no end to it. And it all started with taking responsibilities and putting an end to excuses. I had learned that we are not victims of our pre-planned fate but the creators of reality. We can make our own

decisions, act upon them and create real changes in the real world. It came simple to my logical mind:

1. We are the architects of our lives and responsible for how it looks right now.
2. Thus, we have control to shape how it will look in times to come.

Most people are terrified of the first part, and thus they use God's plan and Destiny to ease their anxiety. But I started to look at control as a tool and embraced the chaos of control.

"If you are whatever you did, you will be whatever you do."

Control was addictive, and I was young. The power was new to me, the possibilities were overwhelming, and the fear of regret was palpable. I was ready to offer everything I could for what I wanted and in that, I betted all that I had earned so far. And then I lost. It brought me to the point right where I started, or some would say, even worse. Unlike my decisions, actions and reactions, what happened to me, I could have neither expected nor controlled.

What happened, you ask? As usual... what kicks all good men and women down for a hell visit — I fell in love. Not the romantic kind, though... I mean... there was a girl, yes... well... I don't really know. I'll let you decide. But I certainly did fall in love with ISRO. Like a moth getting attracted to a lamp, I could not help it. I could risk everything for it and could do anything for it. And as you read more and more, you'll agree that I ended up doing it all. It's as big as you let it be — The most difficult goal is the one you really want to accomplish. A simple idea of a career in Space Science and Engineering kept me running day and night for 6 damn years. That honorable ambition, before I knew it, turned into an obsession — Fueled by my ego, it lit a fire so wild & intense that it went out of control — Its frails danced like a fierce - mad - drunk - demon that whispers in your ears that you'll get anything you want if you let it take control. From a third-person perspective, it is insanity — Nothing but a self-destructive scheme that would terrify anyone sane from going down the same road. From the first-person perspective, what was it like, you ask? It was the most logical set of decisions and actions I ever took — Every move was necessary. This book is nothing but a medium to give you that perspective.

Chapter 1

Ordinary is the Father of Extraordinary

9th June 2017, 10:00 a.m. | SCAR, Mumbai

It was a bright sunny morning at SCAR township — Birds chirping, old people taking walks, and street dogs taking naps. At the SCAR Trainee's Hostel (STH) entry, I saw Kailash dressed up in formals. I waved and said,

“How are you doing, bro?”

We shook hands, and he replied,

“Terrible... Fucking 3 people cramped in a room with 2 beds. How about you? Got any sleep?” He asked while he rubbed his eyes.

“Same. Woke up at 4. Not in a good way.”

Kailash had been my classmate in college for four years, and one year after graduating at Delhi coachings. He was around 5’4” tall and always had a goatee inspired by Heisenberg from *Breaking Bad*. He had a big genius head but a tiny pair of bitch hands — That’s the first thing you will notice when you shake his hands.

After undergoing the general document verification process, we were directed towards the *Waiting Room*, which was on the 1st floor of the *Souresh Chattopadhyay Building* (SCB). When we reached the spot, two of us stood at the door for a couple of seconds with our shoulders low and our jaws lower as we saw around 30 aspirants from Mechanical and Physics disciplines voraciously going through books and notes. Their glares were so intense that you could almost see the letters flying

off the pages and into their eyes. We spotted the only two vacant seats in that room and sat quietly — Like you would in front of your father to get a signature on a test you failed. Neither I nor Kailash brought any material to revise before the interview. Other candidates studying so seriously and quietly were already making us feel guilty, and talking to each other would have made it worse, so we decided to concentrate on the fine details of our palms.

A few minutes later, when I paid attention to my surroundings, I saw right in front of me — Around 4 feet apart — Facing my direction but eyes glued to her notes — The first time I saw that Angel of Pain. There she was: Luscious, naturally brown hair — Long and curly, tied back decently — Black eyes with Blackhole capabilities to sink you in — Lips which defined the color pink — A tiny cute mole on the right of her lips — A single strand of her helical hair that decorated her forehead. I felt my heartbeat slowing down, an uncharted chill along my jaws, and a cold sweep of goosebumps right above my knees for some absurd reason. With my breathing now voluntary, my vision resolution enhanced from 1080p to 8K. I wanted to capture every corner of her face. She wore a pair of star-shaped red and black earrings, light blue jeans, and a *Mehndi-colored* designer top with a traditional *Rajasthani* pattern. Her soft fingers turned those pages painted with her artistic handwriting radiating delicacies probably borrowed straight from the royal families of Great Britain. She sat with one leg crossed over the other. The innocence on her face paralleled the deep concentration, which clearly conveyed that she doesn't give a fuck about a skinny guy sitting 4 feet apart. But I am getting ahead of myself. Let me give you a perspective.

Indian Institute of Technology, since the 1980s, has organized the Graduate Aptitude Test in Engineering (GATE) — National level, annual entrance exam for Graduate Studies in the top institutes of India. Over time, dozens of Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) Companies and Central Government Jobs made GATE their screening exam for the final interviews. This did the following:

1. Cut down the recruitment cost for these companies.
2. Increased the competition for this single exam.
3. Brought the fate of the careers of fresh graduates down to a single exam.

People who appear in GATE every year can be divided into 3 categories based on the All India Rank (AIR):

1. Class A (AIR 1 - 500)
2. Class B (AIR 500 - 15,000)
3. Class C (Rest)

Class A (0.01 %) are the only ones that get something out of this exam that they prepared for over a year. They either got a top-of-the-food chain Government job; or a Master's admission in IITs. GATE worked in their favor — They collect their chips and walk out into the sunset of their careers. Class C, though they did not get anything out of it, would walk out and never look back at this exam again. Class B did the same work as Class A, but the day did not go as well for them — They would get nothing other than the taste of what could have happened if that day had gone the other way. These are the only ones who will stay one more year and spin again. They shall be the only ones to see the horrors of the GATE roulette.

I graduated in June 2016. Throughout my college days, I was so unaware, and the GATE so hyped up that I didn't even know that ISRO recruited fresh graduates through its separate exam. I thought that you needed to be a Ph.D. to become a Scientist at ISRO and was aiming for a master's admission into IIT Bombay by getting an AIR under 100 in GATE — Which went out of the window when I secured AIR-9008 in GATE 2016. I immediately decided to go to Delhi and dedicate a year with the best resources. It was only when I stepped foot in the Country's Competitive Exam Industry capital that I found that there were a total of four annual National Level Exams for Engineering Graduates:

1. ISRO
 - Written Test + Interview
2. GATE
 - Written Test
3. UPSC - ESE (Union Public Service Commission - Engineering Service Examination)
 - Prelims + Mains + Interview

4. SCAR

- Written Test + Interview

Precisely one unemployed year later, with no industrial skills acquired, my scenario was:

1. ISRO — Did Not qualify the written test.
2. GATE — AIR 1825
3. ESE — Did Not qualify Prelims.
4. SCAR — Qualified written test.

Written tests are screening tests for you to get a call for interviews. So the SCAR interview was my one shot to get a job, and saying it was a bloody long shot is an understatement. SCAR is one of the three Major research organizations of the country, along with ISRO and DRDO (Defense Research and Development Organization). These organizations were attractive to every graduate of the country. For people like me, the high-level cutting-edge technology of Nuclear Science, Space Science, and Military Warfare was fascinating; for others, the Government Job safety, the reputation of being a scientist, and the Gazetted Officer attestation were worth fighting for. Whatever the reasons might be, everyone wants SCAR. But SCAR wants a few 'Extraordinary' STEM grads. Its Interview was independent of the written test that screened you in, independent of your graduation GPA, independent of your research publications, GATE score, or recommendations. It all depended on an hour-long interview. People would say it doesn't even matter if you cleared the first round, as the interview is the real deciding factor and has been infamous for rejecting the toppers of GATE, ESE, and even ISRO in the past decades. The interview panel would have 5-6 senior SCAR Scientists who will open up your brain and search for any trace of excellence. The word on the coaching streets was,

“SCAR Interview is Impossible to crack.”

“You have to be 'Extraordinary' to crack the SCAR interview.” was the most common answer when you would ask a senior who has appeared in that interview... or, has heard from someone who appeared... or has talked to someone who heard from someone who appeared in that interview... or has heard from... You get the point, SCAR Interview was a Myth!

After poor performances in GATE, ESE & ISRO, I had come to an agreement that I am no *'Extraordinary'*. But it was a matter of need, not desire. GATE single-handedly slaughtered all my chances of any interview calls from any of the government jobs like IOCL, BPCL, DRDO, ONGC, etc., and admission to IITs. I had a written test call for a Research Assistant Master's program at IIT Bombay scheduled for July. However, I couldn't rely on it as everyone under AIR-7000 got a call for that. On 7th May 2017, ISRO 2017 written test was in the history books. I knew that I was not getting in for now. SCAR would rank 1 among my backups. The situation was: Go for the Best or Go Home. But,

"There's a Beauty in Simplicity of Adversity."

When you don't have options, you don't ask questions. You just do what needs to be done.

Since May 8th, I spent every last ounce of my energy preparing for this *"Impossible to Crack"* interview. I researched it on the Internet like a madman. I went through every last interview experience available, fake or real. I even went to those weird exam sites you would only find on the 3rd page of Google search, which showed sex chat ads besides the technical questions. The more I researched, the more this interview seemed Possible. I realized that everyone was wrong. Complicated as it might be, there was still a clear-cut pattern to it. You would easily find the time and dedication to look deep enough for this pattern if you were 23, had No Job, No Girlfriend, and less than a hundred Rupees in your pocket. I had 3 other unemployed people I could marginally call friends because we met less than twice a week — I talked to my parents for less than 10 minutes a month. If there's one person you could say *"Get a Life"* and not go wrong, it was me. But, like I said, there's beauty to it. Within a month, I reached a state where I had built a perfect strategy and more importantly, a bulletproof confidence. For me, it now seemed like an *"Impossible Not to crack"* interview. In this journey between two Impossibles, I learned two essential lessons:

1. The majority is always wrong.
2. Not everyone has every capability, but every capability can be developed everyone.

After the GATE 2017 exam in February, even though I was not taking coaching anymore and had no business being in Delhi, I still stayed there instead of going home. Being at home unemployed puts a load of questions from your parents like: “*How’s your preparation going?*”, “*Are you sure you can crack the next exam?*” and a lot more, which are heavier than the lift-off weight of *Saturn V*. This, superimposed with the pressure of neighbors talking about their sons working in some MNC in Mumbai, is higher than the chamber pressure of a *Semi-Cryo* engines. Indian society is a concentration camp for failures. Staying in Delhi with hundreds of other unemployed boys who had also failed in the same exams despite their competence was the only place I knew where my sanity could be preserved a little longer. It was a place where people were aware of the reality of scarcity of jobs — A place overwhelmingly stuffed with rejected talents — A place where all hopes of succeeding were not systematically pulverized by those who live in their own imaginary paradise. I felt like these aspirants who saved every last penny to barely pay for the rents of parasitic PGs and studied tenaciously without any appreciation understood me better than those I grew up in front of. It was a place where I was surrounded by soldiers who had also shed blood in the same war, which just like any other war, the more you fight the more pointless it seems. The more you bleed, the more you realize that you are bleeding for someone else’s lust — Someone who hasn’t even stepped a foot in the battlefield.

So I decided to eat vile PG food and stayed in its congested sunlight-deprived rooms for a little longer to give it all to SCAR Interview. The plan was a simple 5 step plan:

Step 1: Get into SCAR.

Step 2: Prepare for ISRO at the Academy.

Step 3: Crack ISRO 2018.

Step 4: Resign from SCAR.

Step 5: Join ISRO.

1st June 2017, 12:00 pm | Saket, New Delhi

I was in the final phases of my SCAR Interview preparation. Standing in my PG room, I was rehearsing a few previously asked interview questions to see how I would hold up in a real interview scenario. With the list of questions written on a piece of paper and stuck on the wall, I was explaining at my summit volume —

Imagining the bed, wardrobe, table and bottle to be the interview panel members. That's when I was interrupted by a knock on the door. On opening, I saw a 6 '2" tall dude with a huge belly peeking out his under-sized t-shirt. He was unshaven and had a man bun made worse with a mean look on his face. He was that one bouncer guy PG owners had around to threaten nerdy GATE aspirants into paying their rent on time. So naturally, I knew he wasn't there to wish me luck for my upcoming interview. But if that look was supposed to scare me, it wasn't working because I had seen him playing *Gulli Cricket* with a bunch of 14-year-olds every evening at 5 — Jumping around with a broad smile.

"You need to empty the room today by 1:00 pm." He said in his thick *Haryanvi* accent.

The guy who rented this room had arrived after a 6-hour drive to occupy it. He was here with his caring mummy and pappa, who ain't leaving until their prince is all settled up.

"But wait a second Ashwin, why would you live in a room rented by someone else?" You'd ask.

The problem was that I too, had booked this room — Paid the rent for the next 7 days in advance, and had pre-informed the owner about the interview. Probably because of this, the bouncer guy said he'd give me another room for now. I still would need to move — Thrashing very valuable 3600 seconds at this point of time. But realizing I don't really have a say in it, I decided to check out my options.

The first thing that turned me off was that the alternate room was on the fourth floor. A top-floor room in New Delhi in June, is equivalent to a furnace. Literally, they should be used as a melting facility by the Steel Authority of India to save some coal costs. When we reached the place, the door looked like it hadn't been touched since the Independence of this Country. After removing some cobwebs off the doorknob, he opened the door, and we were welcomed by about two thousand feathers and two pigeons which flew right by our ears. For the sake of having pure harmony with nature, they had decided to never repair the broken window, which probably broke when the last person living there tried to jump off. The room looked like a place where cows were raised. I took two steps in and immediately took a step back, as a third step would have definitely given me swine flu.

“*Bahiya*, I cannot live here. You should convert this into a stable because no boy is going to live here.” I said in a relatively calm voice because 1 year of staying in Delhi PGs made me accustomed to owners pulling off this kind of shit every now and then.

“That won’t be possible as horses can’t climb stairs. This is the only room we have.” he said after carefully considering my suggestion.

He then handed me the key and gave me an ultimatum,

“1 hour.” He said.

Realizing that all my logic would fall on deaf ears, I decided to pack my bags and stay with Kailash & his roommate Justin. They lived in the neighboring PG. When I reached their place, they were having lunch at their PG mess, which was nothing but a bare wooden bed surrounded by 6-7 plastic chairs placed in garage of the building. The bed was supposed to be the dining table. Kailash loved weed and smoked it at least 5 times a day. I knew he was high. Justin, who was sitting next to him, had his classic smile on and was enjoying lunch. I told them the full story. After analyzing the situation, Kailash reacted just as I expected,

“I got you, maaaaaan... you can totally crash with us. Will help me with SCAR interview prep too... Brooo... you tell that dumb PG owner to go fuck himself. Just bring on your stuff here maaaaaan... If you need to kick his ass to get the advance back... call us... we will observe while you do your *Kaaarrattte* on him.” He said.

Justin was the wise one, and so he brought up some logical problems. Their room was only big enough to accommodate one person, but still, there were two adjusting in it. He brought some rational solutions as well and said,

“It would be difficult for the three of us to adjust but we’ll manage. We have Pandey’s mattress in the shaft. Using that one of us can sleep on the floor. We can Alternate.”

Then, as soon as we solved the problem, we started discussing some more pressing issues like,

“... is Swati single now?” Asked Kailash.

“Naah... I saw her going to the gym with Kritik.” I replied

“But they broke up, no?” Asked Justin

“What does it matter... You ain’t got no chance...” I said

Kailash retaliated,

“Bro. Fuck You. She smiles at me all the time.”

“I bet she smiles at her kid brother all the time too.” Said Justin and continued to chew his rice.

As I said, Justin was the wise one. Kailash’s rebuttal,

“Dude! 3 days ago...”

That’s when their PG owner, a tiny fellow who was also the cook at the mess, came and placed a new set of hot chapatis on the dining bed. Kailash changed tracks. With saliva dripping from the side of his mouth said,

“...Thank you *Bhaiya*! You are so awesome. Freshly cooked *Rotis* are the best! No PG around here makes better food!... Now *Bhaiya*, do you think Sawti likes me?”

“Both of you need to vacate the room by the end of the day.” said cook/ PG Owner.

“THE FUCK, Bhaiya?!” was Kailash’s knee-jerk reaction.

The owner explained that it was because they had not yet given any confirmation of whether they would occupy the room for the next 6 months. The room was now booked by someone from the next batch. What are the odds, right? All three of us, thrown out on the same day. Actually, it wasn’t as improbable as you might think. This was happening in all the PGs. New batches had arrived to start their run at the 2018 exams. Every fresh aspirant who found out that we were here for one year and didn’t get a job had an apparent disdain for us in their eyes. For them, we were losers. For some reason, they had a strong belief that this would never happen to them. PG owners needed those who would definitely pay rent for their rooms for the next 6 months, as not many aspirants come to get a room post-June. As we had zero conformance of what was going to happen with our interviews, we couldn’t guarantee that we would stay, unlike the new batch. So these greedy owners decided to get rid of us despite the fact that we paid their bills in the off-season.

PG stands for “Paying Guest”, a glorified name for a place that will cost you overpriced rents for undersized rooms of an apartment that you’ll share with 5

others. Their tasteless and riskful food will be complementary and compulsory — Doesn't matter if you like it or not — Doesn't matter if you eat it or not — Cost is added to your rent. Every month, they were sucking Rs 8,000 per student for a room worth less than Rs 2,000. Only because their ancestors built an apartment on the outskirts and twenty years later, the place became a coaching Institute hub. Their dumb sons with high school degrees would now think that they made it through their entrepreneurial mindset and that people going to college and studying were stupid. PG owners being assholes was the most common phenomenon in Delhi, followed by power cuts and post-exam depression. One of my coaching institute classmates, Ashutosh, had this situation where his broker just disappeared after taking Rs 20,000 of rent advance. The owner then asked Ashutosh to pay again because he couldn't find his broker. This doesn't make any sense, right? That's the kind of place PGs are, the Nonsensical kind. Poor guy had just left his well-paying job at *Bajaj*, hoping to crack ESE. He had saved a calculated amount of money which was supposed to last for exactly 6 months. He further failed in both GATE, and his 6 months became 12. All this miscalculation ultimately led him to turn toward his family by April. Don't forget this guy; I found us sitting in the same class again in SCAR. Which reminds me that this story is about SCAR, not Delhi coaching hubs. But I gotta tell you one last incident before we get back to the Interview day.

We found a guy whose flatmate had gone for IOCL interview and would return only after the 12th. The guy agreed to provide us shelter as Kailash had been providing him weed for six months. At 2:00 p.m., I went back to my room and started packing. The door of my room was open, and the new guy's father walked straight in without a knock. According to him, the room was already his, and I was the intruder. In a tone even my father wouldn't dare talk to me in, he said,

“Why is it taking so long?! Empty this room quickly!”

“You dumb fuck! Do you have the slightest clue that I found out today itself that I have to empty this room, and I've been living here for three months?! Forget about you disrupting my interview preparation; I have to figure out where I am gonna stay next, and you can't wait? Do you have something better to do? Of course you don't because if you did, you wouldn't be here with your wife to tuck your 22-year-old graduate son in bed.” I said in my mind but stared at him in a way that said way worse and got back to packing.

“How much longer will it take?” he asked repeatedly as if his record was stuck.

“Let’s see.” I said with my veins trying hard to contain the pressure surge due to the blood boil — Its hoop stress limits truly being tested. Needless to say, I didn’t say this politely. He stormed out, and the next thing I knew was the bouncer guy showing up at my door again. This time with a meaner and grumpier look. While he scratched his beard, he said,

“Viru *bhaiya* is calling you in the office. Let’s go.”

Viru was the PG owner. The PG office had “NBC PG” written on the glass door. As I entered, I saw Viru with his younger brother, Mukesh glaring at me with a look worse than the bouncer’s. I guess, the richer you are in these streets, the grumpier the face you make. I don’t know what it is with these people born far up north, but their genetics summons jealousy. Viru and his brother had those strong genes where their hair was just *Blaker*. I don’t know if that’s an actual word, but if not, I just created it for these fine creations of Gods. It’s like your hair is black, his hair is black, but yours will look pale if placed beside his. Their nose sharp, and eyes extra symmetric. Mukesh looked like he had just walked out of a *Calvin Klein* modeling shoot. The brothers had a fair complexion and wide wrists. On top of it, they owned the place you are living in. What are you gonna do? I guess life’s not fair.

I knew that I had pissed off the new kid’s daddy but never expected him to bitch about it to Viru. As I walked a few steps in to take a seat, Mukesh shouted,

“Sit Down!”

His high-frequency screechy voice reassured me that life is pretty fair after all. Before I could adjust my ass, Viru said in his assertive tone,

“Over here, we respect our elders. Don’t show your attitude.”

“Here we go again, older people asking you to respect other older people who decided to disrespect you for no fucking reason. The worst part is that when you ask them ‘why?’ They have multiple answers, all of them, if broken down logically, say the same damn thing: Because they were born before you. Do you every now and then ask yourself why this country, with its pleasant weather, shielded by the Great Himalayas up north and a perfect Peninsular mineral-rich land facilitating trade over the oceans down south, with all sorts of geographical advantages and natural resources allied with a rich history doesn’t grow faster? All you need to do is observe society’s shackles: A person who has lived

longer is automatically considered superior.” I got lost in my thoughts, and my self-talk was soon interrupted as Viru continued after a pause,

“This is my generosity that I am giving you another room. I could have just thrown you out.”

For those confused, let me clarify: Yes, he was talking about that generous pigeon room, and yes, he could have thrown me out. If you think I could have gone to the police as I had already paid the rent in advance, don’t sweat it, this guy had strong political connections. Besides, PGs have their own wild west laws. None of us ever signed any rental agreements before taking the accommodation. We just paid the money in cash — Took a room — Threw our bags in a corner, and started studying.

He gave me a final set of instructions:

“Now, quietly and quickly, take your shit to the fourth floor. I give you half an hour.”

Realizing that this beautiful bitch with superior genetics actually thinks that he owns me, I said,

“I’m leaving your PG today. Return my advance by the end of the day.”, got up and turned back to leave the office.

“Sit down!!” Shouted Mukesh.

Seemed like the only responsibility that Mukesh had apart from looking like a model was to tell people to sit down while his elder brother lives his 80s *Amitabh Bachchan* movie fantasy. I turned back, didn’t sit, and glared at Mukesh. On my rear, I sensed the bouncer guy creeping closer. A fourth guy at 8 o’clock handed him over a hockey stick. The hockey stick, by the way, was always present in their office to maintain the professionalism of their workplace. The bouncer started banging it on the floor with an average frequency of 0.5 Hz. Viru said,

“This attitude that you have, you should have left it at Ranchi. You are an Engineer, right? And you don’t even have a job. Let’s say if you did get a job by mistake, how much would you earn?... Maximum one lakh per month. I can keep twelve of you as my assistants. That’s how much money I make. So in front of me, your voice should be low, and your sight stuck to the floor. Move your stuff to the fourth floor in half an hour.”

I looked straight into his eyes and said,

“Doesn’t matter how much money you make. You are stuck in this street for the rest of your life. Outside this place, you have no value. So don’t tell me what to do and what not to.” and turned back to walk out.

By the time I had said 60% of my heroic statement, I was already regretting it. The bouncer was still banging the hockey stick, only louder now with a higher frequency. He was so huge that I had to take a side step to get past him. I don’t think he gets paid more than an Engineer for being huge and banging a hockey stick on the floor. If he does, Viru really does need to hire Engineers. Fuck a dozen; two will do to prevent him from making terrible business decisions. While walking out of that “Office”, I had only one plan: If the banging stops, I’ll run without looking back. Because when the banging on the floor stops, the banging on my head starts. Where would I run? I had no idea, but I’m a pretty good runner, and I was confident that this fat fuck won’t be able to keep up. I was shivering inside because I wasn’t too psyched about having brain damage a few days before SCAR interview. I didn’t, however, show any of it on the outside as I couldn’t afford them sniffing the fear — After all, that’s what they play upon.

Surprisingly, they didn’t stop me. The new kid’s father found me returning from the PG office and acted as if he had nothing to do with all that. He asked me,

“*Beta*, where is the electric meter of your room? I need to check the initial reading.” That sly bastard even had a smile on his face this time.

I again gave him a 2-second stare and walked away without saying a word. Nobody came to check half an hour later. I took my last bag out by 4:30 p.m. Eight days later, I reached Mumbai.

9th June 2017, 11:00 am | SCAR Township, Mumbai

Back in the waiting room, the girl with star earrings was still busy reviewing her notes. Kailash had given up on being quiet for the sanity of his brain. He was now busy telling me about the history of Physics and Nuclear Science. I was busy not giving a fuck about what he was saying. All I could think of was how to start a conversation with the girl? Yes sir, SCAR was my only chance to get a job, maybe for her too, but this is where boys and girls differ. You’ll find plenty examples of it throughout this book. It didn’t matter to me if I had never seen her before and

might never see her again; my brain had already created 50 valid questions to start a conversation and about 1000 possible responses I might get. Now the only thing left was gathering the courage to say something. For the next 2 hours, she kept on reading, Kailash kept on yapping, and I kept on being a pussy. At 2:00 pm, the interview manager suggested we have lunch as there were a lot of candidates before us on the list. It would take at least 2-3 hours of further waiting before our interview turns.

After lunch, Kailash and I strolled to the hall near the main entrance. In front of us was a small-scale model of the first phase Nuclear Power Plant and a statue of the late Dr. Souresh Chattopadhyay. I keenly observed the model while slowly circumambulating around it, trying to comprehend what part would be used for what purpose. Meanwhile, in the background, Kailash, sitting on the couch next to the statue, was now explaining the history of SCAR,

“... and broooo... you know...World war II started it all, bro.....” he said.

“What do you mean?” I asked casually with my hands in my pant’s pockets.

“If there was no war, there would be no Nuclear Power, bro.”

“I thought it was the other way round. Isn’t that why Einstein didn’t join Project Manhattan?”

“1909’s paper was theoretical, bro. Why do you think there were no implementations until 1945? All the technologies we operate on today were the results of wars.” he said as he got off the couch and walked towards the statue.

“So I’ve heard.”

“So it is, bro... Also, if there had been no war, Dr. Souresh Chattopadhyay would have never returned to India. No war, no SCAR.”

“Yeah...What’s the story of that dude, anyway? I heard that he escaped Germany in 37.”

“Brooo.... That dude was working on Nuclear shit with the German Scientists but saw things changing drastically for those not of the Pure *Aryan* race. Using that smart brain under his hood, he figured it was time to bounce.... Waaaay before anyone else did bro... Escaped to Cambridge.”

“And then? How did he return to India?”

“Well, he saw the Nazis occupying Paris in 41. Britain was being bombarded, so he returned back to the Motherland.” he said as he gazed at the statue. In a few seconds, he continued,

“Bro... 7... For 7 Goddamn years... He was straight-up broke. It was only after Independence that his capabilities were recognized. He was then offered the responsibility of starting an Institute for Nuclear Research by the newly formed Government. That’s the birth of the institution you and I are standing at today. If India’s borders are holding strong today, it’s because of its Nuclear capabilities, bro... If you breathe in the freedom of Democracy and make your own choices irrespective of where and with what you are born, it’s because scientists like him empowered the nation with the technology to protect its freedom. It’s easy to complain bro... I think today’s generation does not give enough credit to the visionaries who picked the country in 47 and brought it to where it is today.”

“It would be so awesome if you and I get super high and sit in a class where such scientists are teaching us high-level Nuclear stuff, bro... best trip ever!” I said with uncontainable excitement.

With a sigh, he sat back down on the couch and said,

“It would be amazing, but I don’t know bro... They say that this interview is next to impossible.”

I immediately stopped my revolution, turned to him, and said,

“This interview is over-hyped, they are just trying to see how good your concepts are, and we are bloody good at that. Now, let’s go back.”

“Hey, hang back and chill... There’s nothing to do over there. Our interview won’t be until 5.”

“Well... umm... you know... I was thinking of talking to that girl.” I said, unable to make proper eye contact.

“Which girl?” he asked, looking confused.

“The girl with the star earrings bro.”

His eyes almost shut close while his head slid back in a fashion Michael Jackson could have taken some inspiration off as he said,

“The fuck bro? I didn’t check every girl’s earrings in that room stuffed with nerds!”

“Man, the girl was right in front of us.” I said as I couldn’t stop laughing.

“Ooohhhh... that girl?... Yeah, she’s cute. Come on, let’s go. I’ll create an opening for you”.

At 3:00 pm, back in the waiting room, Just 10 candidates remained. I saw her right where she was. For the next hour, after every 10 minutes, Kailash would whisper in my ears,

“Are you going to talk to her or not?”

Yes, she was beautiful, and I was single, but I wanted to talk to her mainly because I wanted to talk to her. Confused? I knew I had ruined my GATE & ISRO exams because I couldn’t deal with the pressure of a crucial moment. This indicated my lack of confidence. I wanted to be calm under pressure and knew that “Dealing with Pressure” is a skill of tremendous value. Like any other skill, it would require practice, patience, failures & repetition to master. The cut of a loss infected me with the following Philosophy:

“If you want to do something and if it is possible, Doing it gains you confidence. Not doing it gains you regret. Regret is a serial killer of confidence.”

To live a life without regrets, I followed this 3-Point Code:

1. *You want to do it?*
2. *Are you physically capable of doing it?*
3. *Do it.*

If the answer to (1.) & (2.) are ‘Yes’, then (3.) is an absolute must.

This if-else loop has been tested for several input values since February. Still, I was concerned about the soul-crushing underconfidence & insecurity that would follow if she decided to ignore me. I couldn’t afford it right before the most critical hour of my life. Confusions like this can be solved by simple math: If I don’t talk to her, there’s a hundred percent chance of a confidence drop. If I speak to her, it can go in three ways: Positive, neutral and negative. So I have a 33.33% chance of a steep rise in confidence, a 33.33% chance of a moderate climb, and a 33.33% chance of a Tormenting plummet.

By 4:15 pm, only me, Kailash and the girl were left in the room. Kailash whispered in my ears,

“I’m going to the washroom. When I come back bro... I better see you talking to her.”

He returned in 10 minutes only to find her eyes glued to her notes and mine glued to the ceiling. He sat next to me disappointed and whispered in aggression,

“What the fuck bitch!?! Either you talk to her, or I will!”

My immediate response was to shout like a retard,

“Are you from Physics background?”

For the first time, she looked at me — Her expression confirmed that I might have been a little louder than needed. The thrill of making something happen in the real world, which would have never happened if I had done nothing, overshadowed the embarrassment in front of a girl who didn’t know who I was and a guy who thought I was a bitch anyways. She smiled. My question was dumb as she literally had a book titled “Nuclear PHYSICS” on her lap. But she decided to be kind and answered anyway,

“Yes.” followed by an intestine-squeezing silence.

I immediately questioned my code and missed that silence prior to this, where everyone was not silently thinking that I was a weirdo. But I had already crossed the Rubicon, so might as well go with it. With a bit more normal voice this time, I said,

“Are you the last one in Physics?” while trying to make proper eye contact.

Again a dumb question — But she responded,

“Yes. Are you the last one as well?” she asked.

“God damn, who needs to be an Astronaut when looking into her eyes is also possible.” I thought. Maybe I should have said that to her. At least it wouldn’t be obvious.

“No, I’m the second last. He is last.” I said, pointing at Kailash.

Kailash gave a smile back with a wave. I continued with,

“H-how many times have you revised those notes since morning?” I said, masking my tremble with a chuckle.

“Not enough, I guess.” she giggled and directed her gorgeous eyes back to her notes.

Not knowing what to do next, I directed my not-so-gorgeous eyes back to the ceiling.

“Is that the best you got?” Kailash jibed with a whisper in my ears.

“Yup.” I replied with a sigh.

A few seconds later, I tried for a comeback and asked her,

“Hey! What’s your name?”.

“SIMAR KAUR!!...” the interview manager shouted and continued as he walked in through the door,

“... you’re next.”

“Ok, that’s me.” she said as she packed her books and notes.

“All the best!” me and Kailash wished in chorus as she got up. She smiled and replied,

“Thanks.”

We both checked out her ass with a synchronous head movement as she walked out of the waiting room.

“She’s hot.” Kailash said.

“Yeah, no shit. I just hope that she makes it.” I replied as my eyes never stopped searching for one more glimpse of her.

“Bro... First, worry about you making it. Others who are done with their interviews say that the interviewers are asking brutally difficult questions. This question asked a few hours ago has been bothering me. What’s the maximum deflection in a beam with UDL fixed on both ends? I’m getting too many variables. It looks like it’s unsolvable. But that’s what the guy I was talking to answered, and his interview ended right there!” he said, panicking.

“There are two ways of solving it. First, turn the beam into fixed at one side. Add an upward moment and load on the other side equal to load and moment of resistance by the fixed support...” I said and further explained it on a piece of paper with diagrams and equations using both methods. By 5:15 p.m., we were the only two remaining in the waiting room. The sun was setting, and that’s when I was finally called to sit on a bench outside the interview room — To wait for the

preceding guy to get out. I took out my pen from my pants pocket and tucked it in my shirt's front pocket. After all, a pen shows professionalism. Moreover, If need be, you don't wanna be one of those candidates who asks the interviewer,

"Sir, can I please borrow your pen?"

Sitting on that bench, in that moment, I felt a calmness I had never felt before. I was neither positive nor negative. My thoughts were neither in the past nor in the future. It was blank in the present. No preconceived notions. I had faith in my preparation to deal with anything thrown at me. Every second during my preparation, I was thinking about that one formula that I was forgetting, that one question that I've not gotten the answer to, the next mock test, the next step, the planning, or the strategy. Something or the other, constantly hurling in my mind like a whirlwind — Never settled. But right there, for the first time in 5 years, I had no questions. I sought no answers. I was satisfied with what I did and knew no one could have done better. The still water with glass of a surface was perturbed by the ripple of,

"Ashwin Taksh! Get in. You're the last one." announced the manager.

I stood up and took a deep breath — Felt the friction of the blood flow down my veins — Shock waves of my heart pumping them — The inertia that my feet worked against — My toes in those polished black shoes pushing the floor back to displace my body towards the door which opens to a new life. I slightly pushed the door, and a vertical slit of bright light diverged into a white room with giant windows — A round table in the center with 5 scientists sitting around it — One chair left empty for the candidate, which I took upon their permission. Placed on the table were: 4-5 A-4 sheets — A sharpened Pencil — A bare naked eraser half used. Sitting at 12 O'clock was the chairman of the interview panel — Fair fellow in his early 50s — No hair on the top surface of his head — Thick spectacles aided his eyesight, and his proud smile complimented his high designation of "Scientist G" — I read off of his Identity card neatly tucked on his shirt pocket. On his right was someone who looked like his twin brother, only around 5 years younger but lacked hair on the side surfaces as well. With kindness on his face & innocence in his eyes, he looked like the kid who would get beaten down in the school playground for his lunchbox. His sweet smile was a little like that of the famous Bollywood actor *Anupam Kher*. On the left of the Chairman was the youngest Scientist in the room, whose job was just to go through my certificates. He

chuckled and whispered something in the ears of the chairman, who then smiled and asked me,

“You got your documents attested at CIL?”

“Yes, sir. My father works there. He got it done from his senior, who is a *Gazetted Officer*.”

The scientist on my right — A grumpy man — Looked like the kind who would beat that *Anupam Kher* look alike and snatch his lunch, said in a brash Bihari accent,

“Prove us that you deserve to get into SCAR, and soon you’ll become a Gazetted Officer yourself.”

“Yes, sir.” I responded with a smile.

He responded with a stone face which quickly evaporated my smile as well.

“Ashwin, what are your favorite subjects?” asked the chairman.

“Strength of Materials, Fluid Mechanics, Heat Transfer, Machine Design and Basic Thermodynamics.” I responded as planned.

The chairman directed the guy sitting left of me to start the interview. He had the sweetest voice on this planet and started with his sweet rudimentary Strength of Material (SOM) questions. After each of my answers however, he would strengthen the bitterness. Nothing I couldn’t handle. I was expecting this SCAR’s way of increasing the level gradually. What these Scientists care about most is not the extent of your knowledge but the extent to which you can apply it, which clearly illustrates the depth of your knowledge. I knew they wanted me to reach a point where my knowledge was exhausted, as that’s where my thinking abilities would take the steering wheel. They intended to find who could think beyond what had been taught in Engineering colleges. But with preparation like mine, I knew what questions they might ask and even what counter questions would follow when I answered correctly. If I answered rapid-fire, within 30 minutes, they would bring up questions never asked before. As I have said before, I am no extraordinary, but I am good enough to pretend that I am that one-in-a-million SCAR was looking for. I had no luxury of playing it fair. For all I cared, fair play is for rich old hags, not for struggling men in their 20s who get no respect in society and are stripped of all opportunities. We do what needs to be done to get what we need. Then and there,

I needed a job, so I pretended to be someone I was not. I had knowledge and skill, but they sought talent and brilliance. Skill beats talent 10 out of 10 times. Do you know how? Let me show you.

I portrayed my knowledge bar lower than it was. A couple of times, I just pretended to be thinking when I already knew the exact answers. I would answer only what was asked, not a word more, even though I knew ten times more than what was asked. Lasting long in this interview was vital. Previous statistics showed that whoever had their interview done earlier than an hour failed to qualify. You need to survive long to leave an impression — You need to leave an impression to get selected. I knew that the interviewers didn't think like this, but their thought had a pattern. This was my strategy to beat it.

“Hyper Skill is a twin to Talent. They look alike, but they are not the same.”

Once the Scientist on my left was done checking my Strength of Materials (SOM) in his own bitter-sweet manner, the grumpy dude on my right took over and started testing my Fluid Mechanics. I was sitting up straight, shoulders wide, pencil gripped firmly between my fingers, and focused on the questions asked. I answered all his questions without a hitch, but he was determined to contradict everything I said, to the point that the chairman had to calm him down a couple of times.

“Relax Choudhari, don't get started again.” said the chairman in a charismatic tone with a chuckle.

I did my best to deal with this impossible-to-satisfy fuck who was then followed by *Anupam Kher look alike*. He asked a few questions from Machine Design. It was more than half an hour into the interview, and the level of questions had risen significantly despite my active retardation. Every now and then, when I was thinking for more than 30-40 seconds, the chairman would calmly give me small hints. It looked like he was already inclined toward hiring me. After the three were done, the Chairman finally left the pavilion and stepped in. He began with a simple question from Heat Transfer.

“So Ashwin, let us consider a pipe in which water enters at 20°C. Exit temperature is 400°C. Please draw the temperature profile.” he said.

The solution was pretty simple, but dealing with a hailstorm of questions from the previous 3 interviewers had enervated me. They hadn't offered me a sip of water even though I was continuously speaking, explaining, and justifying every

movement of my pencil. To make it worse, they were sipping tea, eating biscuits, and having the time of their life. This same question had been asked 3 years ago in a SCAR interview, which I had read in an interview experience. At this point however, with only a fraction of my brain functioning, I made the exact same mistake that the guy who had shared the experience made. I drew a straight line from 20°C to 400°C. The chairman gave me the same hint that was written in that experience,

“Ashwin, what do you think is leaving the pipe?”

Somehow the same words triggered that buried deep memory, and unlike that guy, I was ready with an answer. I responded,

“Sir, It'll be steam. Phase transformation will be present. We will have a constant temperature part in which latent heat transfer will take place.”

I saw a smile on his face. On some site on the third page of Google search, besides a sex game advertisement, I had once read that SCAR Scientists love it when you are unable to get the answer at first but yet catch it with a hint — Makes them feel that you are trainable. I had not worn a watch, so I took a short look at the chairman's watch. It was 6:55 pm. I had a sigh of relief as my interview lasted for 1.5 hours, and I answered the last question well. Leaving a long interview on a positive note was a perfect execution.

“Ok Ashwin, draw a frustum followed by a cylinder and put temperatures 25 degrees centigrade on one side.” Said the chairman.

In my head, I went,

“The fuck, dude! I am completely exhausted. I waited for 9 hours just to get into the interview room. Before that, I had a shitty stay at your shitty hostel room, which had 3 candidates but somehow had only two beds! You guys grilled my brains till it's burnt to a crisp while sipping your lovely tea, watching me exert myself with a parched mouth, and now you got more questions?! This is madness!!”

The chairman in a calmer scientist analogous to *King Leonidas*, responded with a smirk that said,

“No, boy. This is S-C-A-R.”

I folded my sleeves and started to solve the question with only one of my six brain cylinders firing. We were way past the part where I was playing a game. They had

stretched me to a point where I wasn't even able to understand their questions. They would ask me something, and I would just answer something completely different. I always knew that sooner or later, they were going to catch up to me. After all, there's a limit to how low your decoy bar can go without you sounding like a dumbass, which will disqualify you as well. That moment felt like gassing out in the middle of a fight — Felt helpless. The chairman made the question easier for me to understand. He drew two graphs and asked,

“Just tell me, which one is correct?”

“The kid doesn't know, sir. Let him go. It's getting late anyways.” said the grumpy one on my right.

If that was another one of his attempts to get me rejected, then this was the stupidest thing he had said since the inception of this interview. Never talk shit to an opponent in a fight — You are literally giving him a motivational speech when he needs it the most. He had just popped open my *'Ego Valve'*. It gave me an energy that didn't even seem mine.

“Two minutes Choudhary, let him answer.” said the chairman

Time dilated as I realized that my response decides my selection.

“Most of their brutally difficult questions are brutally basic. It's just that people complicate it by having distorted preconceived notions.” I reminded myself.

Because this was their final question, I was assuming that it must be difficult, but when I really looked at it with a clean slate, it was from the first page of the first chapter of Heat Transfer. I said,

“Since Temperature gradient is inversely proportional to the area of cross-section, the second graph is correct.”

The chairman took off his glasses and said,

“Ok, Ashwin. You can go now.”

I could feel the disappointment in his voice. I got up on my shivering legs, said “Thank you” in a shaky voice, and walked towards the door. Just when I was about to pull open the door, the chairman shouted,

“Ashwin!”

I turned around and took a look at the 5 panel members who had already started a discussion amongst themselves, going through all the A-4 sheets with my solutions.

“Please leave the pencil on the table.” he said.

I had no idea what I was wearing or which year it was, so naturally, I forgot that I walked away with the pencil still clutched in my fingers. I gently placed it on the table and said,

“Sorry, sir.” with a monstrous effort to smile.

I walked out of the room, and my exact words to myself were,

“After all this, did I really fuck it up in the end?”

My legs were trembling, and I wasn’t even able to think of the correct way out of the building. They had already turned off most of the lights. In those dark corridors, half of my mind was thinking, *“How the hell do I get out of this building?”* and the other half was thinking, *“How the hell do I get out of this unemployment?”*. I tasted the bitterness of losing again, and with my long-dead and traumatized brain, I struggled to navigate my way back to my hostel room. When I finally reached the room, my two temporary roommates were waiting for me. I unbuttoned my shirt, loosened my belt, and sat on the bed like I just got fired. They asked me the usual question,

“How was it?”

I gave the usual answer,

“Ok-ok.”

They asked what the questions were. I took a few sips of water and started telling them one by one. That’s when I was surprised that they didn’t know the answers to most of them, and when I gave them the answer, they said in chorus,

“Oh, that was easy.”

Finally, I reached the last question — By now, my brain was rejuvenated — While explaining how I gave the answer to the last question wrong, I paused for a second — All 6 cylinders firing at their optimum performance now — Flywheel at its max R.P.M. — *Fourier’s Law* resurrected in my head — I vividly remembered the option that I had picked — The visual of me picking the second option played 3 times in my head, zoomed further every time.

“What happened?” one of my roommates asked.

“No, no... My answer was actually correct. Heat flow is constant, and the gradient is in fact inversely proportional to the area of cross-section and since it's a circular cross-section...”

While explaining the ‘how’ to them, Kailash walked into the room with his shirt unbuttoned. He asked,

“How was it bro?”

I pressed my palms against my knees and got up as I said, “Pretty good, actually. And you?”

“Ok-ok... I think they are looking for really Extraordinary people.” He said.

“And so they say.” I said.

Chapter 2

World on the Other Side

27th June 2017, 9:00 a.m. | Saket, New Delhi

“Ashwin! Wake up, Ashwin!” Justin screamed like someone had stepped on his dick. He was aggressively trying to turn my body sideways by my shoulders as if I was dying of a drug overdose. I had insufficient voluntary control to open my eyes and barely enough to say,

“What?”

Completely ignoring my short but valid question, he responded with an insulting one of his own,

“What’s your Full name?”

Now that I was more awake than I wanted to be, I found myself lying on the floor of a filthy PG, drenched in my own sweat. Delhi heat sucks, and the electricity board gives no fucks. As usual, there was a power cut. I was in Justin’s new PG, where he had decided to continue his GATE & ESE preparation for one more year. Unfortunately, it was a top floor, so Justin would have no shortage of thermal energy for the next 4 months. We had just appeared in the Vizag Steel written test a day before. After the exam, we decided to smoke a little weed — Go out — Eat pizza — Talk about some stuff that doesn’t matter and pass out. Just like you are supposed to after an exam. Unemployed aspirants have only a few festivals around the year to celebrate, called ‘*Post Exam Evenings*’. You are supposed to enjoy it, else you are a step closer to a tied-up living body in your closet. There’s something else you are supposed to do after an exam: Sleep without an alarm and wake up whenever the fuck your body naturally wakes up — An Unsaid Aspirant Code that

we all abide by. An Unsaid Aspirant Code that our friend Justin here seemingly did not respect anymore.

My chest was pressed against that nasty bachelor's apartment floor by my body weight — It made a fart noise as I pushed myself up. I said,

“The fuck bro? You’ve known me for a year and don’t know my full name yet?”

Justin swept that question aside quickly as well by saying,

“Never needed it. Now tell me.”

With my index finger pointed at him, I said it with pride,

“Ashwin TAKSH! Never. Eve...”

Before I could complete it with something cringe straight out of *Bollywood*, I was interrupted by his iconic wide smile that I last saw when Pandey got selected for IIT Madras. I sat on my ass which was still in those mint chinos I was wearing last night. One of the only two pants I had been rotating for over 2 years. Kailash cleared all my confusion by saying something which would wipe my sleep out for days to come,

“Congrats, bro. You did it.” as he pulled me up on my feet with his tiny bitch hand and gave me a warm hug.

“Your name is on the final list of SCAR.” said Justin with his hand on my shoulder.

My immediate response was to ask Kailash,

“And you?”

With a shoulder shrug, he said,

“Didn’t make it, man... I never had a chance”.

“That’s bullshit!!” I exclaimed.

“SCAR has selected the minimum number of candidates in its history this year. Only 35 in Mechanical.” said Justin in his calm voice and classy *Marathi* accent. Kailash followed and said,

“But it’s good though. There’s a standard that should be maintained. Bro, it’s time for you to leave Delhi. You are no longer an aspirant. You are now a Scientist.”

The next day we found that the VIZAG exam got canceled. 7 days later, on the 4th of July, I appeared in the written test and subsequently the Interview for the Research Assistant position at IIT, Bombay. With AIR-10, I got selected for a Master's in Mechanical Engineering with a Design specialization. Just a week ago, I was unemployed for over a year after graduating, with no clear future. And then, I had call letters from both a premier Research Organization and a premier Institute. I guess, just like bad days, good days come with their own inertia. I now knew what it is like to build Something from Nothing. I would need it because as good as both of these offers were, the call letter that I really wanted was miles away.

IIT or SCAR, I was going to stick with neither, and either way, I'd be preparing for ISRO again. My interests were more inclined toward Design than Nuclear Engineering. SCAR had a monthly stipend of Rs 36,500 but also a bond. I'd get a monthly stipend of Rs 12,000 in IIT without bond, but around Rs 50,000 of tuition fees had to be paid upfront. Something for which I'd need the help of my father. In SCAR, on the other hand, you just walk in, sign the bond and start earning. I called my father to ask if he would support me financially for the first couple of months if I chose to go for IIT Bombay. I got my answer within the first minute of the conversation. Let's just say, most Indian parents would like their kids to have a Government job over anything else. On the bright side, SCAR's Nuclear Science and Engineering experience would look better on my resume for my further career — The sheer brand weight difference between Ex- Scientist at SCAR & Master's from IIT Bombay was enormous. If I managed my money well, I could pay back the bond. And thus, thinking it was a good career move, I took my step into India's Nuclear Program.

26th July 2017, 10:00 am | SCAR Auditorium, SCAR, Mumbai

By now, the ISRO 2017 results were out. As expected, I had failed. Right after the SCAR interview, I restarted my full-fledged preparation for next year's ISRO exam. Meanwhile, at SCAR, all 120 of us fresh graduates from all across the country, from 12 different streams of Engineering & Sciences, were made to sit in the largest auditorium I had ever stepped foot in. It was a massive stepped seating gallery — 150 degrees around a giant stage 10 times the size of my 1 RK room back in Delhi. Huge *Panasonic* Speakers ensured that even a gush of wind on stage into those *Shure* dynamic microphones was heard at the last rows. Each of those

seats seemed like they cost more than three months of my PG rent — They had cushions that my butt had never had the privilege to be placed on ever before — Each had its own mini mic that could be used to ask questions and participate in talks by flick of a button.

The giant hall was obviously air-conditioned, something I was not conditioned for. It was too cold for my skinny body with a high surface area to volume ratio, and so it caused an urge to pee. I walked to the washroom, where the neat and clean toilet had urinals that automatically detects you and flushes before and after you pee. A flash memory of restrooms back in my Delhi coaching institute struck me. They were worse than public toilets found at third-tier Indian city bus stands. After a 4 hour class, we had to stand in a queue behind 20 others who also had to pee. Somehow that institute talked about Engineering & Mathematics 10 hours a day but calculated to conclude that 25 urinals could cater to the piss of 400 students within 15 minutes. Forget about an automatic flushing system, there wasn't even a manual one. The only way your piss gets flushed is by the piss of the next dude. As there were no partitions, the guy on your left and right could get a scenery of your package. But since we unemployed boys were not getting any pussy anyways, we would never make it worse by increasing dick sight count. And so we focused on that nasty unpainted concrete wall in front of us — Another one of those Unsaid Aspirant Codes.

They all said: *“Go for government jobs!”*. This was when I started to realize why:

In a country that got its independence less than 75 years ago, if you want to sit within those massive structures, be a part of a hierarchy that is spread across 2000 kilometers, employs tens of thousands of people, study and work with the most cutting edge technology, get job security, proper work-life balance and medical benefits, it is all possible simultaneously only with a Government job. After this profound awakening climaxed by the automatic urinal flusher operating for the second time, I walked to wash my hands. I tried to dry them using some automatic blower thing. The alien technology seemed useless, and post placing my hands in front of that noisy stream of air for 20 seconds, it ultimately dried by classic and highly efficient, *putting-hands-in-pockets* technology.

Back at the hall, more seats were now occupied. Mine was also taken, so I had to compromise and sit at a location terrifyingly far away from the last row. We were here to attend the orientation program for us Trainee Scientists (TS) of the 61st

batch of SCAR Academy and the coupled Convocation of the graduating 60th Batch — An annual tradition. We were waiting for the director, Academy dean, and guest of honor to arrive. Meanwhile, playing on the big screen was a slideshow of photographs of the 60th batch. Some of the seniors were clapping, some laughing, some trying to hide their tears, and some all at the same time. They were cherishing their fun memories and deep relationships. It didn't look like they had known each other for just a year; rather, it seemed like they had grown up together. All the seniors were in the SCAR signature Navy Blue Blazers — Tailored to fit — They all looked sharp — Their attire was complete with their recently acquired token of pride: The *SCAR Badge* — Well-recognized circular logo of a picture of an atom at the center — *Science Center for Atomic Research* and *Nuclear Energy Agency* embedded on its periphery. They had a smile on their faces, a lot similar to the ones on ours. It was the smile of completing a journey. But unlike us, their eyes radiated a repugnant despair. The reason for which perhaps only someone with those Navy Blue Blazers over the shoulder would understand. For me, though, if things go as planned, I'd be attending an ISRO Induction Program instead of a SCAR convocation at the same time next year. I wasn't there to make friends or memories. I was there to earn a monthly stipend, enhance my C.V., and crack ISRO.

When I glanced at the two batches collectively, the cheering and applause muffled as I identified that moment to be one where you could see both Future and Past in the Present. The seniors saw their past in us, and we saw our future in them. Something within both of us whispered gently: The cycle will repeat. On the left-most front corner, you could see a group of the most senior scientists aged between 55 and 60. There, I realized that these mammoth organizations are run by no one. Fresh scientists like us get in, and in 30 years, some of us will reach the positions of Directors and the Chairman, retire after a few more years of service, and the cycle continues. Thousands and thousands of Engineers, Scientists, and Technicians join, and dozens of them reach the zenith of control. Are these humongous organizations working for us, or are we working for them? Because the way I saw it that day, it appeared like this organization was an organism that was not dependent on any single human being. No one owns it, all of us are replaceable, and all of us will be replaced someday or the other. The only irreplaceable thing is the machine itself. Problem statement, potential solution, chain of commands and hierarchy written on a few pieces of paper enchanted the spell and blew life into the beast. It's only that our life span is too short to see the change. People talk a lot about

Artificial Intelligence; how about these organizations thriving and growing long after their founders are dead? It uses humans to keep things running and expand its extents — To keep producing products and creating technology. It's almost like humans and machines live in harmony; we use one another to survive. It's just that the beast has a way longer lifespan.

“No man... got rejected in ISRO. That's why I'm here...” said someone on my right. I immediately turned toward the source. It was a guy with thick glasses talking to Arun Rathore. He continued,

“...Yeah, I am passionate about Aerospace Engineering, mainly Space Propulsion, but unfortunately, it's getting harder every year to get into ISRO.”

Who is Arun Rathore, and how do I know him, you ask? Everybody knew who he was. He was AIR-6 in GATE 2017. Toppers in these competitive exams become celebrities overnight. They would be on news channels, newspapers, big posters on the streets of Delhi coaching institutes, and your YouTube recommendations, with videos getting millions of views. In a country obsessed with Government jobs, where everyone firmly believes that education is the surest way out of their miseries, these exams decide the dynamics of the country. These exams are not just a means to grab a job but a sport where people who come on top date instant fame. People want to listen to them; whatever shit comes out of their mouths turns gold before it hits the ears of the fresh aspirants counted with 6 zeros. As if cracking these exams is somehow a sign of enlightenment. But in Arun's defense, he really did seem like a genuine guy. He was smiling, charismatic, well-spoken, friendly, and had lots of knowledge to drop. Or maybe, I was under the influence of the hype on social media as well.

“What was your score, bro?” I asked the guy with specs.

“137.” he replied with regret on his face.

The cut-off was 139.

“Shit! 2 marks? That sucks... Ashu *Paji* cleared that written test with AIR-3. He has interview in September. What about you?” Arun asked as he turned the spotlight of those sparkly eyes towards me.

“I... uhh... umm... got... 136.” I answered with awkward eye contact.

I don't know why I lied. I had actually scored 111, but the pressure of talents around me was overwhelming.

"Oh... that's hard luck as well. No worries, SCAR is good too. Good level of research. Some would say, even better than ISRO." Arun replied with that charming smile of his.

"Yeah, but nothing is going to leave the stratosphere here. I'll try again." I replied.

Arun chuckled and replied,

"Yeah, right bro. The course work & competition at SCAR itself will be unbearable. You won't get time."

"We'll see." I said and turned towards the screen to get out of this conversation which was both demotivating & suffocating.

At that very moment, that luscious brunette set of curly hair passed by me. Alaska chills blitzed down my spine. With those insane goosebumps, I asked myself,

"Is it really her?"

She was wearing a white salwar suit. My eyes were fixated on her like I just needed her. She entered the row right in front of us and passed a gorgeous smile to the girls sitting there. Those black eyes and those pink lips... who says magic doesn't exist?! She sat right in front of me — Those brown strands fell delicately on her white Kurta — Which was whiter than white — Angel's apparel white. Kinda like Viru and Mukesh's Beard but on the other side of the spectrum.

The next minute, as if it was all waiting just on her, the chief guests walked in, and the event began. It started with all the graduates receiving their degrees in Nuclear Science and Engineering from the chief guest of honor, who was a director at DRDO — Followed by department toppers receiving the *Souresh Chattopadhyay Medal of Excellence* and a special medal for the Overall Topper. Then, 5-10 minute speeches by toppers of every department, post which we broke for lunch where I had two objectives:

1. Talk to Simar.
2. Talk to Seniors.

If college taught me one thing, it's that one should make good relations with seniors. Even the dumbest senior will beat you in experience.

As I walked out of the auditorium into the Courtyard where the lunch was organized, I quickly found out that I was not the only one who went to college. Around forty fucking trainees surrounded the *Overall Topper* — Complementing him on his speech which was dog shit — Congratulating him for becoming the overall topper, and asking him how they could do it themselves. I kid you not, examining their ferocity, any one of them, in a heartbeat, would blow the ears off of 39 others who were also listening to what The Great Topper was saying — If only they had guns — If only, these bozos knew how to use it — If only shooting off the ears of nerds was legal. Yeah, I know, too many *Ifs* — The only reason their ears survived.

When you want unique results, it is important for you to take unique action as well. If you are running in a herd, even if you win, you won't be the only one. The herd comes with the comfort of safety but at the cost of individuality. Explore the road less traveled because, along the ones well constructed, all the hidden diamonds have already been claimed. I knew what was important to do but also that if everyone else was doing it, it was important not to do it. That, or I just didn't like the sight of me pushing against 40 others trying to listen to what one guy says — like a beta. What if, 25 years in the future, my son travels back in time and sees his dad acting like a total bitch? Might drive him to make some bad decisions.

All the other toppers were surrounded as well, so I decided to go to the *Overall Bottomer*. I said 'Hi' and introduced myself. His name was Faiz.

"So... Can we give competitive exams while in Academy? Given that it's written in our bond contract that we are not allowed to." I asked.

"Plate is empty." he said.

"Sorry?"

Faiz was tall, lean, handsome, and looked like someone who had achieved the ultimate salvation. While all the other seniors were suited up in their radiant, tight pressed shirt, tie and trousers — Mirror polish on their shoes and tight combed hair; Faiz walked in sneakers, jeans, and a printed green shirt with 3 top buttons unused. Just a compulsory blazer over his shoulders. He paid all his attention to what deserved it the most: Food.

“I need to refill. Follow me... Take a plate and start eating dude... You think you’ll get this kinda food every day over here!?” he said with a stoner-level calmness and walked towards the food counters.

“We won’t?” I said as I followed.

“Expecting this kind of food every day is like expecting these fuckers to dress like this every day.”

“Fair point.” I replied as I picked a plate.

With our plates weighing heavy, we found a tree far away from the crowd and sat under its shade.

“Sooo... those doc--nts ain’t shit bro.” he said and focused on chewing.

“Huh?” I couldn’t hear him well as he ate a few syllables along with food.

“Everybody prepares for exams here, especially the Engineers... why wouldn’t they? They have so many options.” he said and stuffed Chole Puri in his mouth — Chewed it for 10 seconds until his mouth was partially clear enough to speak and said,

“Give exams without any worries, but don’t you fucking inform anyone who is part of the Academy, or they’ll be after your ass for the entire year. They’ll tell you that you can tell them and that they’ll let you prepare, but they’ll do the exact opposite. They play these cunning foxy games every year.”

“Got it!” I said with a combination of relief & excitement.

“Also dude, it’s not important if you can prepare or not. If you want, you will, and ain’t nobody’s daddy is stopin you. But the question is, can you prepare?” he said and just walked away like a gangsta... To get more food.

After talking to a couple more bottomers, I had gained enough information about how to prepare for exams simultaneously and bypass the system. I placed my plate in the bin and brought my focus to Simar. But here’s the problem with girls: They are never alone! They are always with some other girl who has already told her that you are checking her out so she can turn her I-Don’t-See-You Mode on and regulate it to maximum capacity. That’s when even if you stood right in front of her, she would act like,

“Oh, that tree behind you looks interesting.”

After about half an hour of talking to random people, always facing in her direction, when we finally made eye contact, I gathered some courage to give her a smile. She instantaneously looked away in a nervous fashion. Obviously, the wise side of my brain helped me decide not to walk to her and make it any more agonizing. The stupid side, meanwhile, tried to convince me that she acted like that because she secretly liked me.

Here's a philosophy by some random YouTuber/ Dating Guru that I can't remember the name of:

"If you don't talk to a girl you like within a week, you turn out to seem like a creep to her. If you end up talking to her later, she will never take you seriously and put you in the friend zone forever."

This, combined with my 3-point code, was a lethal recipe for a calamity. The next thing you know, I gave myself a 7 days deadline to talk to her.

Room No. 804 at STH was assigned for my housing. When I reached the eighth-floor corridor, I found a bald man dancing with his son to some *Punjabi* song. As I moved closer, I recognized they were two of my batchmates with massive age and genetic differences. That *just-missed-ISRO* guy was standing at the corner awkwardly, trying to get involved. He looked like that one sober kid in the bar, sworn not to drink for life. Arun was the DJ on stereo and was moving with the beats — Switching songs as the situation demanded. To reach my room, I had to pass this herd of passionate and fanatic dancers who I presumed must have just won the World War that I wasn't aware of. I thought I'd just smile — Move past them — Get to my room and get 4 hours of Heat Transfer revision. But the dancing couple decided to stop their performance and socialize with me. The drenched in sweat, skinny short guy who was still panting said,

"Hi! I'm Raj, but you can call me Raju."

"Hi, I'm Ashwin." I replied with a handshake.

The other dancer wasn't new to me. Remember that guy whose broker ran away with all his money? That's him, Ashutosh Rana — Graduated in 2013, NIT Kurukshetra — Worked for a year at Bajaj — Found out that his girlfriend, who was also his colleague, had been all along fucking his best friend, who was also his colleague — Got heartbroken and quitted his job. His tool of redemption: Become an IES officer. Packed for Delhi — Dumped all his savings. One year later: GATE

2017, AIR 4366, ESE Prelims qualified but failed in Mains. Threw his last dart at SCAR and got in.

“Hey bro, how are you?” I asked Ashutosh.

“So! You finally arrived!!” he exclaimed with no smile — Grabbed my right shoulder and tried to crush it into rubbles.

With evident agony on my face, I exclaimed,

“Hey, bro!! I’m gonna need my shoulders, you know... like for the rest of my life! You can crush it afterward.”

“Hey! I’m Sumit” said the *just-missed-ISRO* guy.

I shook his hand and moved past the social dancers. Right in front of my room, I saw one of my batchmates — Roaming around in a white *Rupa* tank top, red boxers, and green earphones plugged in — A skinny guy with a slouchy posture.

“Hi! I’m Ashwin.” I said with a smile and extended my arms for a handshake.

“Mahinder.” he said, completely ignoring the handshake and walked away.

I later noticed that he was talking to someone over the phone.

Like most of the boys in India, all the new recruits loved the sport of Cricket, so they spent their entire evenings and Sundays playing the sport — Abiding by the King’s wish from a hundred years ago. On the other hand, I had already started giving online subject-wise test series as a revision catalyst. The hostel had a terrible cell phone network, so I had to get to a particular spot near the elevator to get a proper signal and get it on with the online practice tests. After every 5 minutes, the elevator would make a Beep noise — Announce “8th Floor” — Someone would walk out — Look at me all confused — Wondering why I was studying even after getting a Government job, and would walk away scratching their heads — Confused if there was a test in Academy they were not aware of.

I bonded quickly with Arun, Raju, Ashutosh and Sumit, as their rooms were next to mine. Sumit was a brilliant Engineer, brighter than any fresh graduate I had ever seen. I sat down with him later and spoke for over an hour. He did his B.Tech from IIT Delhi — Received a Gold Medal — Cracked SCAR in his final year itself — Without any coaching, which is extremely rare in Mechanical stream. He did his major project at IISc Bangalore in Rocket Propulsion under a professor who had

done his Ph.D. at Caltech. He said that Aerospace Engineering is his passion, so SCAR was not the place for him either.

“So, will you appear in ISRO again?” I asked.

“Definitely.” he replied with certainty in his eyes that equaled mine.

His achievements made me question my capabilities to become a Rocket Scientist. Still, I was happy that I was not alone on this path.

Once, the five of us were having lunch when we met Chandan. 6 ft. tall — White as milk — Hair almost brown — Blue eyes — Pink lips — Naturally chiseled body. If Hitler ran shit today, he would hire Chandan under the ‘*Superior Race*’ category. He would get a 10/10 on looks by almost every girl with eyes. Chandan was talented too: Could sing, play many musical instruments, was terrific at photography, and had a particular interest in Mathematics. I was just hoping he somehow never gets in front of Simar for a year. Because guess what? He - Was - Single!! Matter of fact, he never had a girlfriend. Guess you can have it all but make a tiny mistake of being a Mechanical Engineer in India, and you’ll stay a virgin. That or it was the chink in his armor: His tongue. The foul mouth this guy carried was preposterous. He couldn’t say two lines without saying *fuck, shit, motherfucker, dick or Blowjob*. Never aggressively though — In his own mellow and chill manner that always left the boys howling laughing and the girls with dried vaginas. He didn’t give a fuck either and used to say the most explicit stuff right in front of the girls — Who would then walk away disgusted. It could mostly be attributed to where he did his B.Tech., a government college in Shimla. The stories he had from his college days were both horrifying and hilarious. No electricity for days, no water for weeks, and classes next to a cow shed are just a few examples to set the stage. One time, everyone in his class was cheating in some lab exam; the HOD walks into the lab by surprise and shouts,

“What is this FUCKERY?!?!?” and literally starts slapping the shit out of each and every student one by one — Including the girls! Another time, a guy submits his assignment a day late and the professor out loud, in front of a class stuffed with 50 students says,

“What should I do with it now? Do one thing, roll it up like a joint and shove it up your ass.”

1st August 2017, 9:00 am | SCAR Academy

It was our first class at the SCAR Training Academy — Subject: Reactor Physics. It was compulsory to stay 9-5 at the Academy Monday to Friday. The Research center came under the category of national intelligence and hence did not allow any electronic devices, including phones. Therefore, I had to rely on printouts rather than pictures and .pdfs on my phone. Carrying a 500-page GATE Previous Year question bank daily would be too uncool, so I tore it into 12 parts and carried only the one I needed on a particular day.

Academy timeline:

Aug - Nov 2017	Nov 2017 - Feb 2018	March - May 2018	June - July 2018
1 st Quarter	2 nd Quarter	3 rd Quarter	Project
• 25th Sept - Midterms • 6th Nov - Finals	• 18th Dec - Midterms • 22nd January - Finals	• 2nd April - Midterms • 14th May - Finals	• 20th July - Presentation • 26th July - Convocation

Classrooms were pretty well maintained, none of those cheap coaching institute classrooms anymore. We had a well-furnished class having a capacity of 100 but contained only 70. For the first day, my objective was to test the water of how much of these 8 hours could be spent towards ISRO. Everyone else was earnest regarding grades. They knew that it decided the final placements, which for most of them, was their entire career and life. Since nobody knew for sure about the postings that NEA would release after the completion of 3 quarters, most could not clearly know where they'd end up being posted. But we all knew two things for certain:

1. Topper will get Mumbai up North.
2. Bottomer will get Vishvenpura down South.

More than 90% of us, including me, were North Indians, and none wanted to go to hot-as-hell Southern India. In complete contrast to my classmates back in

college, my colleagues at SCAR literally fought to sit on the front benches. All the last benches were deserted except the left corner where I, with my notes, was sitting and the right corner where Chandan, with his head against the wall, was sleeping. There were giggles, gossip, and attempts of inexperienced Mechanical boys hitting on Chemistry girls with their lame *Bollywood* tactics. To my surprise, it worked and cracked smiles out of those girls. This new environment would provide them a good strategized and well-planned love marriage which their parents would approve. I saw that “*Hum Aapke Hain Kaun*” style flirting with my palm on my face and my notes on my lap until the faculty arrived.

Enter Dr. Anand Prakash Tivari — Ph.D. in Nuclear Shielding — A jolly fellow with a special interest in teaching. He started the class with the basics of Nuclear Fission. The guys in front of me grasped most of it quick as they had all been excellent students back in senior secondary. Sitting in that class, observing how obvious the splitting of U-235 is to others, made me wonder if I was a meth head throughout High School.

14th June 2012, 9:45 am | Axis Institute of Technology (AIT), Sikkim

“...Let’s explain the work done sign convention with an example. Now, you must all know what an IC engine is, right?” asked Professor Thakur.

It was the first semester of my undergraduate studies. The first two semesters of Indian Engineering colleges have students study subjects of all branches. This particular class was called “Elements of Mechanical Engineering” — Subject of a branch I wanted to pursue. Right there, I was sitting with my name in the Information Technology branch. The only way to upgrade it to Mechanical was through an excellent GPA. Apart from Mechanical, the class was occupied by a mixture of students who wanted to pursue a degree in Electrical, Electronics, Computer Science and Civil Engineering. Yet, everyone responded in chorus,

“Yes, sir.”

I had no idea what this IC was. For all I knew, it could be Internet Compatible. But to avoid being the odd one out, I followed suit — Made sure I didn’t make any eye contact — My voice blended well in the crowd — I was good and well experienced at it.

“Ok, let’s pick someone who can do the job for me...” He said as he passed by me.

Then I felt a hand on my shoulder. He continued,

“...How about y... Wow, those bones kid. Aren't they feeding you in the mess?”

I did what I was trained to do via the Indian education system: You are asked a question by the teacher, you stand up.

“So... What's an IC engine?”

Everyone looking at me made my head spin. I leaned and placed my hand on the desk to stabilize and said,

“Umm... aaa...”

Professor Thakur was the scariest professor in the entire college. He had some serious unattended anger issues and had raised hands on students uncountable times. Not only did they let him keep his job, but also made him the Hostel Warden to keep the boys in order.

There is a Boys Hostel culture you need to know: Whenever there would be a power cut, the boys would shout stuff like,

“Fuck AIT!”

“Warden sucks dick!”

“I fucked Director's daughter!” Even though our director had no daughter and wasn't even married, but that was the thing to do ever since “*5 point Someone*”.

You would shout all this because the entire hostel was now a black hole, and nobody would know who said what. That's an excellent strategy to vent your teenage frustration on the system until you are shouting,

“Thakur Motherfucker!!” on the peak of your lungs — Power comes back, and Thakur is right in front of you with a stick in his hand and two goons on his side who are not there to protect him, but you.

So Dr. Thakur beats this kid who was betrayed by Sikkim Electricity Board across the lobby, while he is falling down the stairs and all the way to the hospital. You would imagine that Thakur would lose his job for that, but all he lost that night was his Warden position and a stick.

“Son, you better speak up quick.” Thakur said as he checked his watch and strolled to the last bench.

To make it worse, Thakur was also the H.O.D. of the Mechanical Engineering Department, and I was at loss for words on how to confess that I didn't know something about Mechanical Engineering, which even these Electronics Engineers knew.

"Psss..." the boy sitting left of me slid his notebook towards me. In large fonts, he had written,

"INTERNAL COMBUSTION - IN CAR"

I turned the page smoothly and said,

"Sir, it..it is.. it stands for Itern... Internal Cum... Combustion Engine. Used... Used in c..cars."

"Kid, you have no energy. You need to eat more. Sit down."

I stayed silent for the rest of the class, as that's what you do in Thakur's class. Then, once he was gone, I turned towards the guy left of me,

"Thanks man. You... umm... you saved me."

"Think nothing of it." he said.

"I... I am Ashwin." I said with a handshake gesture.

He shook my hand and said,

"Akash."

Up until High school, I did enough to get a passing grade, and many times failed even at that. I just liked Physics because of how it explains things around us, but not enough to read books. I was too busy with Video Games and Martial Arts. Growing up in a small city in India, an academic career is what you'll end up choosing. Your parents are not rockstars, your neighbors are not entrepreneurial, your cousins are not actors, your aunts are not models, and your uncles are not athletes. All of them just got by life trying to make a living. Visiting metropolitan cities like Delhi, Mumbai or Bangalore was a life goal for those who raised us, and going to another country was like going to another planet. So I picked Engineering just like everyone else. But unlike everyone else, I got into a 3rd tier college after my crappy performance in all the college entrance exams. This was when I realized that if I did not study now, I would soon be an unemployed bum living with my parents. I had acute guilt that I had not done enough with my life, which is why it

was stale. The first few days of college, my first time away from my family in a remote village surrounded by hills, were daunting. I always had a tough time making friends, and the friends I grew up with were in different and way better colleges — The girl I spent my entire high school sharing the tiniest of details of my life with stopped responding to my texts overnight. I was alone, which gave me a lot of time to think and ask questions that we usually avoid, like,

- What am I good at?
- What values do I provide?
- Why should someone pay me?
- What do I want to do with my life?
- Why does nobody want to be with me?

From that point, I resolved to change. I developed a routine: Wake up at 5:30 am in the morning — Eat clean — Workout before classes — Hit the library as soon as the classes were over, and crash on the bed by 11:00 pm — Repeat it the next day — Regardless of weekends or semester breaks, new year or Christmas. I called it “*The Regiment*”. When I started paying attention to my education, I realized that at every second of our life, each and every one of us is surrounded by thousands of products of Engineering. This is where I fell in love with the beauty of Mechanical Engineering and decided to pursue a career in it. The concoction of guilt, need & a newfound passion kept me in the library for as long as it remained open. Asking questions about how machines work was a slippery slope. Next thing you know, I was overwhelmed by thousands of ‘*Hows*’, ‘*Whats*’ and ‘*Whys*’. The hunt for answers led me through all the books I could lay my hands on, from Automobile Engineering to Black Holes. And so my education started with Engineering at the age of 18. But, all 5 years of mastering Mechanical Engineering never took me through the fundamental Nuclear Physics and Chemistry I missed in high school.

1st August 2017, 9:45 am | SCAR Academy

“See, this is the nucleus of the atom, either the neutron will come or not come?” asked Tiwari, looking straight at me.

“Come sir!” I said in panic.

Hopelessly he directed his attention to those who agreeably deserved it more. The seniors had told me that Academy exam questions are from class notes. Now, if I had to make both passing SCAR exams and ISRO preparation work out, I had to understand the maximum in class itself. Biometric attendance was a compulsion for every class to keep people like me in class. For every hour you skipped class, your stipend would be deducted. Furthermore, stipend would be on hold if you fail a course — Passing marks for each course: 50/100. But what to do when Dr. Tiwari teaches chain reactions of a critical reactor, and you have the brain of an ape? Within an hour though, I was not alone. Cut to him in the middle of a mathematical derivation which filled the board and emptied our self esteems. So I did the smartest thing I could: Look for God's chosen few keeping up with the lecture. I'd pester them later. I looked around and found Three: Sumit, Arun and Poornima. Poornima was a girl from the Physics department — Around 5'3" tall with an innocent smile and froggy eyes. Much like Kailash, her head was relatively bigger for her size, which explains why she was asking questions in a class where others were reanalyzing their career choices. Religious people say it's written in the Bible: *"God, grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and wisdom to know the difference"*. And so I accepted that my rudimentary chimp brain could not understand how an atom splits at the pace this dude with a Ph.D. was teaching. I got back to my GATE notes — Leave this nuclear shit for later. Reactor Physics continued in the background, while competitive exam formulas had the cream of my concentration.

After an indefinite amount of time, my ear drums sensed that a particular white noise was not present anymore. My vision swept from the lengthy gear drive formulas on my notes to a lengthier Neutron flux formula on the whiteboard. All the other trainees had vanished like Ninjas, dispersed into the ether. Even Chandan was smart enough to bounce. It was just 3 of us in the room now: Me, the Professor and an acute silence. Professor Tiwari looked keenly at me as he walked closer with threatening steps. It is said that some survival instincts are embedded within us because of our stone age ancestors. At that moment, I felt it firsthand as my body seized any kind of activity, including breathing. He now stood 2 feet from me and asked,

"I was looking you for half hour. What you studying?"

Under pressure to save myself from both being reported to HR and disclosing that I'm preparing for ISRO on the first day itself, I came up with the following

bullshit:

“Sir, I’m revising some of my Engineering concepts. It’ll help me in further classes.”

“Aaaeeeeee.... You think me stupid?”

I was frozen while he awaited my answer for a second and then answered himself,

“Not!”

“Not sir, indeed.” I agreed immediately.

“You preparing for GATE naaaaaaa..... you think I don’t know?!... Not!! I know people like you come every year!” he shouted.

Professor was from Bihar and wasn’t great at English. I kept quiet and hoped for *Zeus* to magically come down to the land of mortals with his chiseled pecs and ripped abs, just to evaporate this dude with his thunderbolt. When that didn’t happen, I took matters into my own hands and said,

“Uhhhh... Physics... ummmm... Reactor... Revision... aaaa... yes.” and realized that my English somehow turned worse than his. So I guess we can conclude that the speaking skill of a person is all subjective to the situation.

Confused Tiwari rotated the chair in front of me — Pulled it towards me — Took a seat and said,

“What was your GATE rank?”

With my sight stuck to the floor, kind of like what Viru bhaiya expected of me, I replied,

“1825, sir.”

With a surprise on his face, he said,

“Still you selected in SCAR?!?! My son trying for 2 years. Did he get select?”

He looked for an answer, again. I didn’t meet his expectations, again. He answered himself, again,

“Not!! This his last chance. Will you help him?”

All of a sudden, a smile popped on my face. I replied,

“Sure, sir.”

After Tiwari took my number and walked away, I decided to go out and stretch my legs. Other boys and girls were having tea at the local canteen. My eyes were naturally scanning for Simar — At one particular angle, it was almost like a magnetic field restricted its mobility — 2 seconds seemed more like 10 minutes as I saw her walking down the stairs. It's moments like these which make me feel like it was a girl who made Einstein realize of *Theory of Relativity*. My eyes were glued to hers, even though hers were unaware of my presence. The only degree of freedom my eyeballs had at that moment was to sweep down towards her lips — Along the way, they met her nose, which was of perfect shape and size and boy o' boy, those lips — They had a shine that leaves has early in the morning.

"Seven Days - Clock's Ticking!" I said to myself.

3:00 pm | Gandharv Prototype Test Reactor (GPTR), Santacruz, Mumbai

"What's beneath your foot is a thousand-tonne radiation shield. Below that: Fuel rods of enriched U-235 *Demon* and Cadmium Control rod *Tamers*..." said with pride the local engineer, Jayant Sen.

He explained that he joined SCAR 10 years ago and was a part of the 51st batch. His eyes, focused at infinity, depicted endless stories colliding with an array of information as he continued,

"...August 6th 1945, Hiroshima, the same Uranium-based Little Boy. August 9th 1945, Nagasaki, Plutonium-based Fat Man. April 26th, 1986, Pripyat, modern-day Ukraine, Uranium-based *Reaktor Bolshoy Moshchnosty Kanalny* - RBMK Reactor, Chernobyl. March 11th 2011, Plutonium-Based Fukushima Daiichi Nuclear Power Plant. What's common in all four?"

In my head, I went,

"Yo homie, you lost me when you started speaking Jewish."

"Examples of Uncontrolled Nuclear Explosions." the voice came from my right — I turned around — It was Sumit.

"Exactly!" Jayant exclaimed with dead seriousness in his eyes. Possessed with passion for science, he continued,

“You young boys and girls are being introduced to a technology which, whenever went out of control, has killed thousands and made 100s of square kilometers of fertile land inhabitable for the next thousands of years. It is important for you to realize that this cool and clean pulchritudinous form of power generation has its own ugly side. This is the power of the Gods that we humans have learned to play with.”

He later told us that *Reaktor Bolshoy Moshchnosty Kanalny* was Russian for *High Power Channel Reactor*.

Simar was standing 4 feet away, so I acted like I totally knew it from the get-go. On a side note: *Jewish* is not a language.

“Bro, will you just keep staring, or will you go and talk to her?” asked Raju standing beside me.

I looked at him surprised. He continued,

“I don’t know what you like about her, but you should talk to her. You are checking her out more frequently than I check Facebook...”

And then he ended with the statement that has fucked Billions of men since the beginning of time,

“... I think she likes you. I saw her checking you out as well.”

Blushing like a 24-year-old Indian girl bringing tea for the boy’s family with an arranged marriage proposal, I replied,

“Yeah, man. I’ll talk to her by the end of the week.”

“By the end of the week?!? Where the fuck do you think you are? It’s a research organization in India! She is a fair girl who is not fat! Here, that’s all it takes for a girl to be considered hot. By Friday, she’ll have 20 relationship proposals and at least 5 marriage proposals. Then she’ll do a S.W.O.T. analysis with her gals to make the final decision. A Mechanical Engineer doesn’t risk missing such opportunities. He pounces *Fast!* He pounces *First!*”.

Made sense. It’s the first time the boys here didn’t have to worry about their careers. 50% of them were Mechanical Engineers, and 100% of them had a dick. Around 90% of those dicks had never touched a pussy, which made them 3 times more competitive and opportunistic. I recognized the invisible race to approach her first.

She was wearing a red and black check shirt with the sleeves folded — Blue skin tight jeans folded near the ankles and sneakers, which again had stars on them. To be honest, her dressing sense sucked a thousand dicks. But me being the optimistic lad I am, decided to overlook that for now — I'd work on it when she was my girlfriend. I spent the rest of the tour that day following her jiggling ass, trying to decrease the distance below 100 meters — It never happened.

5:00 pm | STH, SCAR

The bus brought us back to the hostel. Simar got down with her new friend Vaishnavi. I got down behind them like a creep and again found myself walking 100 meters behind her. That inside voice asked,

“Are you going to do it? Or will you act like a pussy again?”

Moments like these prove the difference between doing it in your head and doing it in reality. This is reality — If you make a move, all eyes on you — You will be judged — There will be consequences, and the most crucial part: You can't take it back. There's no replay button, nor are there Sands of Time that will rewind your actions. Like a bullet, once it leaves the barrel, it might do its job, or it might not. But it's never coming back, and everyone heard the Bang! Some people ask,

“What is Reality?”

To them, I'll say, do what you're afraid to, and the sensation that flows down your bloodstream just before you do it is the only proof of Reality.

“Death is the only proof of Life. Consequence is the only proof of Reality.”

People play too safe. They want the opportunity to walk to them. If she happens to be alone — If I know for sure that she likes me — If we happen to conveniently be in front of each other — If no one is looking — Then I'll approach her. That's too many *'ifs'* to make any event impossible. I used to think like that too, only to find that the wait for the perfect opportunity never ends. The opportunity is always there; if you are waiting for a better one, the problem lies not with its availability but your inaction. At some point, when I saw too many probable opportunities lost because they were not handed over to me perfectly arranged on a platter, I understood that no God is sitting up there with a register taking notes of my deeds for which I should be rewarded fairly — Pulling strings for me. On the contrary, we are the builders who construct our individual fates with the bricks of

opportunity randomly scattered in the world across space and time. If I want things to happen my way, I have to pull strings myself and act accordingly towards whatever happens next.

I was wearing my mint chinos — Black *Reebok* Polo shirt with its collar up — Slippers below my feet. I took a pen out of my bag and kept it in my pant's right pocket. My legs moving faster now, decreasing those 100 meters. My sight: confident, determined and focused, couldn't care less about more and more eyes turning towards me with every next step I took. 60m — 50m — 30m — 10m — and soon, I was walking beside her. Somehow, I managed to mask my shivering bones with confident eyes. It was time to execute,

"Hi, Simar!" I said with a smile.

"Hi." she replied with a surprised smile accompanied by nervousness.

"We met in the Interview, remember? Ashwin."

"Oh yeah, how are you?"

"Doing great. What are you doing in the evening?"

She looked at Vaishnavi and said with a nervous laugh,

"We don't do anything in the evenings."

"If you're free, shall we go to the beach around 7?"

Maybe a move way too strong. Moments like these make me feel that Bravery is not the only ingredient in the recipe for success. Other spices, like Patience, play a significant role as well. But bravery does help you kill a big chunk of competition with a single shot, for there are not nearly as many brave ones as there are patient ones.

"Sure... Umm... Let's all go. I have been added to the birthday committee. I think one of us new joinees has his birthday today. So we can plan that after that." She said.

"Sure. Give me your number." I replied immediately with confidence that could cut titanium.

I took my pen out of my pocket, wrote her number on my inner left forearm, and walked away into the STH.

Chapter 3

Choices & Consequences

1st August 2017, 5:15 pm | #804, STH

When I returned back to my room, a message on my phone said,

“Hi! Found out about your selection in SCAR. Proud of you Ashwin!! Congrats. - Dibya”.

I dated Dibya back in college. She wanted me to take a job and move to Mumbai with her instead of going to Delhi. Two months later, in August, she dumped me, and two days later, she got a new boyfriend. Now I don't want to make judgments without knowing the full picture, so I'll let you decide what would have happened. It was my first breakup, and the pain was agonizing. She was pretty much my only friend. Indian parents and siblings usually don't know about your relationships, or else they'd do their best to end it themselves — One step closer to your arranged marriage — One step closer to 200 years in the past. I had to focus on the upcoming exams, which were in less than 6 months. So I came up with the *Logical Breakup Code of Conduct (LBCC)* involving the following simple steps:

1. Blocked her everywhere.
2. Deleted her contact.
3. Deleted all her pictures.
4. Never talk to her again.

We had never talked since. She had texted me with her new number, and I felt strange in my chest.

“Thanks.” I replied.

Then dropped a message to Simar about going to the beach.

She replied after typing forever,

DING!

“Actually.”

Typing... *DING!*

“as we are in a hurry to get the cake for the birthday boy by 8”

Typing... *DING!*

“We are going directly to the cake shop.”

Typing... *DING!*

“Raj is in the Birthday committee as well.”

DING!

He, along with Vaishnavi, Sumit and Arun is coming too.”

Typing... *DING!*

“Join us.”

Why can't people write in a paragraph and hit send ONCE?! The only way this method of texting could be any more annoying is if sHe TyPed LiKe thiS.

Now obviously, I liked Simar, but there's an extent to which I would tolerate bullshit. First of all, who the fuck cuts cake past the age of 5? Witnessing that act alone would be equivalent to an axe to my balls. Corroborating to organize one was blasphemy! She'd not be alone anyways, so I'd rather sit back and solve some ISRO Previous year Questions (PYQs).

An hour with my books later, Mahinder entered my room and was again on a call. He exclaimed as he plugged out the earphones,

“Broooooo!!!!.....” and told the person on call to hold up, especially for me.

He even shook my hand this time! Then, gave me a salute. Which was kinda stupid cuz we not in the Military, son.

“What a stud you are! The first one to get a girl's number, and that too of Simar! And the way you did it, seemed like you've done it a thousand times... You should

have seen the faces of other boys! And Vaishnavi, dude!!!... She was red with anger that you approached Simar instead of her. Give me some tips, bro. I want to lose my virginity by the end of this year.”

He walked across me all the time for 4 days but never talked, and now when he did, he could not stop. To be fair, he never spoke to anyone — He was always on a phone call with his ears plugged. I gave him some classic Gyan about approaching girls, which I know now would have scored him more slaps than phone numbers. He told me about his girlfriend back in *Sonipat*. Who, by the way, was still 17. He said he had been in love with her since he was 14, which freaked me out as I did the calculation real quick. He told me about how he loves her more than life itself. He then took a comfortable seat on the chair in front of me and started explaining his ideas and philosophies about what love really is — How passionate lovers can stay away for months — Even years without any contact but still will be drenched in each other’s warmth.

“... Love is a different kind of drug Ashwin... The one that takes you to the deepest depths of the ocean. The one which feels like a bliss of cold air in 45 Degrees Delhi heat. One that you can wrap around yourself in a lonely cold night, and you’ll neither feel cold nor loneliness.” He said.

All of it finally started to answer my ever-longing question of “*What is Love?*” until he said,

“I need to fuck at least one girl here in Academy before I graduate... Preferably Kavita.”

As soon as Mahinder left my room, I returned to ISRO prep, but something bothered me. So much had happened that day, but the one thing that kept bugging me was Sumit outclassing me at GPTR. Twelve O’clock at night, unable to sleep, I got up and said,

“What is this Churnobill bullshit anyways?”, opened my laptop lid and walked to the elevator section to get some wifi.

Next, I watched a bunch of YouTube videos on all the nuclear disasters and subdued to the rabbit hole. This inevitably took me from *Hiroshima & Nagasaki* to *Chernobyl* to *Fukushima* and back to *World War II*. By 4:00 am, it brought me to the German V-2 rocket project and its project director, *Wernher von Braun*. Guess what was his employment after the war?... NASA, of course! That’s where I joined

the dots between Military warfare, Nuclear Technology, Aerospace Engineering, and Space Propulsion. This made me realize the value of the place where I was. I hence concluded that I might not take the exams seriously, but I better take the opportunity to learn Nuclear Science and Engineering.

Exact 180 was the thought process of most of my colleagues. It was pretty obvious that everyone wanted to be a topper. Some still pretended that they didn't, but the competition in their eyes was apparent and, to be honest, quite disturbing. The Scientists who took the role of professors were brilliant minds but lacked teaching experience — None of us could understand 100% in class, nor could anybody stay awake in 100% of the classes. Trainees understood that they were going to need some help. Micro groups of 4-5 spontaneously coalesced — Politics shadowed. It was a reality show minus the cameras and TV network — Cut throat competition, where people next to you could score one point more and achieve a better career — Imagine competing to get into a university, then 4 years of college competition, 1 year of National level competition only to get into another round — Now go to India and find it all in existence. Chandan and I were the only ones who decided to stay the fuck out of this mess. Me because I gave higher importance to ISRO and him because he gave higher importance to sleep. That fucker could sleep for days. He would go to sleep at 10 p.m. — Wake up at 8 a.m. and be sleepy again by 9 a.m. We started to sit next to each other in classes — His being brilliant in Mathematics helped me with questions I would be stuck at in my ISRO preparation. He would go unconscious the moment a faculty would start teaching and was hilarious while awake — His nature of not changing his ways in front of girls made me comfortable around him. Other boys, behind the back of the girls, could talk about nothing but their boobs, ass and about fucking them — While in front of them, they'd transform into this exclusive vegans with their gardening hobbies, *Swachch Bharat Abhiyan* and charity beliefs.

“Oh, for fuck sake! Next thing you know, they'll be talking about animal rights and adopting a Nigerian baby.” Chandan said in his iconic mellow tone but loud enough. I started howling laughing — Simar, sitting a row ahead of this cult, turned back, chuckling. Boys and girls under the crosshairs pretended as if this never happened.

Over time, when I met more people, I realized that most had ambitions of leaving NEA. Some wanted to join Indian Railways, others aimed for Civil Services, and a few were zeroed in at DRDO — Apart from me, Sumit and Rohit wanted to join

ISRO. Ashutosh already had an interview call letter for ISRO, which he said he had always held the top spot of priority following IES. He was going to attend ISRO Interview in September, and I was looking forward to getting first-hand experience which would help my attempt next year. Arun and Adil had an interview call letter for Engineering services (Adil and Rohit are yet to be introduced). More than 70% of Engineers had their dreams outside NEA. But their approach was different than mine. The first year of your career in NEA, when you are in the Academy, is the most difficult and the most pivotal one. You are not an employee yet, and the competition is not over yet. This was why many trainees dropped their immediate plans, decided to get a good placement first and then prepare for exams next year — Comfortably. However, all of them knew the value of the momentum of preparation, so they'd appear in the 2018 exams, but Academy would be their first priority. I applauded their patience but knew that it wasn't possible for me. The way I looked at it, I should have been in ISRO already, and every day of me not being there was painful. They did sometimes gracefully and sometimes sarcastically try to tell me that I was making a mistake — Which did increase my doubts and insecurities.

"This is what I do. This is all I know how to do. I look at what I want and take action to move towards it. Now." I would tell myself.

Plus, seeing people like Sumit, Arun, Ashu, Adil, and a few others who also decided not to wait was reassuring. However, Sumit believed that he could be a topper at the Academy and, at the same time, crack ISRO. I didn't doubt him, but I wondered that if you were going to leave NEA anyways, why would you invest your energy in anything other than just passing the exams, putting ISRO at risk?

'Impatient' is how they looked at me. *"It's Possible"* is how I looked at my plan. Even though passing Academy exams was tough, the major burden would prevail only a couple of weeks before the exams. Like any other college exam in the country, it'd test your short-term knowledge — Unlike competitive exams, which test your concepts & application dexterity. Apart from taking classes seriously, other trainees were mostly chilling post 5:00 pm. They'd spend the evenings and weekends gossiping, making new friends, and celebrating their new job. This was time, I couldn't justify the expenditure on leisure. Time is such a weird currency,

1. It's more valuable than money.
2. Young has it more than the rich.

3. Rich knows how to use it better.
4. It will be spent regardless of whether you use it or not.

Imagine your money being spent a penny a second, and you didn't even buy stuff with it. Or think of it like this, either you can buy healthy food with it, which will give you proper nutrition and make you more productive, or you can buy a fucking donut. I felt an obligation to utilize time for my development and couldn't spend a second with four people without asking myself the question,

"How is this helping you to get closer to your goal?"

I kept hearing them talk about how they didn't have time while discussing the latest Vine video while sipping tea and scrolling through Facebook. It was like flushing hundreds of dollars down the toilet while simultaneously complaining about not having enough money.

"But Ashwin, some of life is supposed to be enjoyed."

"Sorry, but I can't enjoy this shithole I am in now."

"But this is a great place. A lot of people would do anything to be here."

"If they did, they would be here. Just because I have a better life doesn't mean I have to love it — There's more above & below. What's your point?"

"You should not hate what you have."

"Unless I hate it, I won't use every last second to get the fuck out of here. Never make home at the place you want to leave."

"But Ashwin, You can do both."

"No. Fuck you. You don't know what the fuck you are talking about. End of discussion."

I had these mental tug-of-wars all the time. I could not stop questioning how I could use this time better,

- While on the bus.
- While taking a bath.
- While eating.
- In between classes.
- While walking to the grocery store.

– While riding a bike.

It was an obsession to *Utilize Every Last Second* — Maybe an unhealthy one, but It showed me the possibility, and that was good enough for me.

“The classes, the exams, the practicals and vivas... How will you compete with those preparing day and night in Delhi, Ashwin *Bhai*?” asked Rohit.

The two of us were standing next to the canteen with a Rs 5 coffee in our hands, trying to wake us up before the next class. Rohit Kerketta was a gregarious guy with curly hair. He was an extrovert and would walk to everyone by himself to start a conversation. Every morning, before the teacher would arrive, he would walk from seat to seat and talk to everyone:

“How are you Ashutosh *Bhai*, did you start interview preparation?...”

Then he would walk to the next one,

“How are you Arun *Bhai*! Your Crackify Interview doesn’t stop going viral! My kid brother wants your autograph...”

Then he would walk to the next one,

“How are you Poornima? Did the warden fix your ceiling fan issue?...”

Then he would walk to the next one,

“How are you, Sumit *Bhai*!?”

“...Adil *Bhai*!”

“...Chandan *Bhai*!”

“...Ashwin *Bhai*!”

“...Raju *Bhai*!”

“Kerketta *Bhai*! Why didn’t you use a ‘Suffix’ for Poornima?” Raju asked this morning with a chuckle.

Everyone loved Rohit. His social skill was a life goal for me. Because of his morning routine, people started to call him ‘*Bhai*’ out of love, which meant ‘Brother’ in Hindi. His only nightmare was: Girls would follow suit soon. Maybe too much love can become a problem.

“Those are newbies, *Bhai*... You and I have already cracked SCAR. Don't you think there's an advantage in our hands as well?” I responded as I took a sip.

“Doesn't matter. You and I both know that these exams need the pinnacle of your touch with numerical solving skills. One year you are selected in SCAR, and in the next, you don't even qualify GATE! That's how independent these exams are from one another. It's impossible along with Academy burden.”

“How do you know? Have you seen the future?”

“You want the future? Talk to seniors, Ashwin *Bhai*. Those who tried neither cracked the exams nor got a decent posting. Now they are on pills to deal with depression.”

“Maybe they didn't prepare that seriously.” I replied before you could flip a coin.

“How do you know?...” he chuckled hopelessly — As if he was trying to explain a child, why not play with fire?

“I don't... Anyways *Bhai*, did you know Rajeeb? He was at *Kalu Sarai* too. He and I went to the same school.”

“Oh yeah!! That lazy fuck was always late. You know he was after this girl Supria, but she...”

There was no use arguing. Nobody knows. Whether the seniors gave their best — Whether they were as close to it as I am — We don't know. Even if there's someone who did exactly what you want to do, under the exact same circumstances, will you be able to repeat it? — You don't know. The only way to know is to see it through.

I observed from a distance, people who said it was not possible and meanwhile went out drinking every weekend. People who said I'll do it next year and planned trips to Goa months in advance. And then there were people like Sumit, who said he wanted to crack ISRO during Academy, but I never found him going through his GATE notes or skipping social gatherings. They said, “It's impossible.” and tried hard to make sure it didn't happen — I said, “It's possible.” and tried hard to make sure that it did. Nothing is written on stone. Our thoughts and our actions decide what's possible for us and what's not.

“What the hell do I know? Maybe they are smarter than me. Maybe they don't need it. Maybe Sumit won't need the extra effort and will still crack ISRO because he is smarter than me. I know that everyone over here is smarter than me. I am here because I figured

out a way to play the SCAR interview. They are here because they are actually 'Extraordinary'. Or maybe they are not. I don't know. Only one way to know is to see it through." I thought as I was running towards the gym one morning.

You may divert from the questions asked in the external world, but internally, every question must be answered with full justification. Else, your brain will not find the pursuit reasonable enough to continue. I understood pretty early that this path I chose was going to be tough on me mentally — I'd be seeing people around me working less, enjoying more, and still getting better scores in Academy — Having a secure future. For them, it's all gradual — If they give 20%, they get 20%; give 80%, get 80%. For me, it doesn't matter whether I give 20% or 80% — If I want ISRO, I will have to give 100%. If I give any less, I'll get 0. Competitive exams are Games of Binary. You are either selected in ISRO or you are not. There's no gray area in between. Hence the risk.

To deal with self-doubts, I relied on a mentality guided by simple questions. I never asked myself complicated questions like:

"What am I capable of doing?",

"What others with similar circumstances were able to do in the past?",

"What is pragmatic?" or

"What is possible?"

Instead, I asked simple questions like:

"What do I want to do?" and for that,

"Which direction should I move in?" and

"What is the next action that I have to take?"

Another aspect of my life that has proven time and time again to negate pressure is fitness. I had caught up with *The Regiment*. I'd wake up at 5:30 am every morning. On Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays, I'd put on my running shoes — Run to the gym, which was 3 Km away — Lift weights for 45 minutes and walk back. Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays were dedicated to Martial Arts.

"What do you want bro? You want the girl, ISRO, and passing through the Academy; all at the same time?" said Ashutosh.

We were having lunch.

“Well, either I’ll get all or none.” I said

“Dude. The world doesn’t work like that. Pick one.” he replied.

“How the fuck do you know, dude? Aren’t you like 26?” I said, laughing as I struggled to keep the chewed rice in my mouth.

“What I know is that getting a girl involves time. You only have so much of it. Now look, I’ve been talking to Vaishnavi, and she thinks that Simar might like you. But it’s not gonna work with you spending 5 hours a day in Library. When will you spend time with her so that you two can get to know each other?”

Everything he said after “... *Simar might like you.*” bounced off my head like sun rays off his shiny head.

“Hey, Bald Motherfucker! Why didn’t you tell me that before?!”

By the way, “*Bald Motherfucker*” was the nickname Raju honored Ashu with. Everybody respected the nomenclature, including Ashu.

Ashu said,

“I found out last evening. You gotta be patient, bro... Focus on Academy and Simar this year. She is serious about her career in NEA. Why would she care about you if you are so focused on leaving it?”

That evening, back at #804, walls were by now populated with taped A-4 sheets with Mechanical Engineering formulas, quotes by my idols, and few I thought of myself. Meanwhile, Dibya started texting me like crazy. From “good morning” to “goodnight” to “let’s hang out sometime”. She was working at TCS, and it had been 2 years since we were in the same city. Our talks escalated from messages to voice calls to video calls to her talking about her problems. The girl was in the good old corporate life shit cycle. I was sure about not starting anything with her but was spellbound by the magic in her voice. The leash was in her hand.

“... I’m all fed up with this job Aswiin.” she said on a phone call.

She could never pronounce “sh”. That cute North-Eastern accent — All those memories — The fact that I was not getting any sex — And above all, that I was lonely as fuck — Kept me talking to her. Before I knew it, I was spending at least an hour talking to her daily. She was persistent and knew all my weaknesses —

Clearly indicating that she wanted to start it again. And then all of a sudden, on a Thursday, she texted,

“Hi Ashwin, let’s meet up! I’m in Santacruz.”.

24th August 2017, 7:00 pm | CCD, Santacruz, Mumbai

She probably chose CCD as it was our favorite place back in college. She was still as beautiful as she was 2 years ago. To my disappointment, she didn’t gain weight. That smile still had a slight angle towards the left, brimming with that weird mystical confidence saying, “*I know how beautiful I am*”. Her strong eye contact still had the ability to make me nervous. She had one strand of hair that fell on her right cheek just as I liked it. As always, she was chewing gum. I often joked that maybe she started chewing at the age of 8 and decided never to spit it out. After a little bit of chit-chat, she got to business,

“My parents are arranging my marriage.” she said

That day I realized how the talk of marriage can turn the prettiest girl ugly. She indirectly made it clear to me that I should give her some commitment.

“I believe it’s never going to work out between us. I’ll never forget that you left me when I needed you. Also, you should know that I like another girl now.”

It would have been easy for me to keep her hooked, but playing it safe is a killer of confidence — It is an addiction. If you give in, your mind naturally chooses the path with lesser resistance instead of the correct one. She never texted me again. Neither did I. Her new number now entered the block list.

I chased Simar like I chased ISRO, playing it wild and making no attempts to cover it. Genuine efforts can never remain a secret. I tried to ask Simar out for coffee or just a walk multiple times, but she always found some excuse or the other. I was starting to accept that she might not be interested after all. But then again, the way she looked at me clearly said otherwise. Or maybe I wanted to believe that. I even considered that she might be in a long-distance relationship, but her Facebook relationship status said ‘single’. Moreover, if so, why wouldn’t she tell me that or just stop responding to my texts when I am clearly hitting on her? I did not know. Only one way to find out.

26th August 2017, 5:00pm | STH

“Hey, it’s Saturday, weather is good, would you like to go out? There’s a good coffee place nearby.” I texted her after a few text exchanges.

After about two minutes of typing, she replied,

“No, I’m busy.”

Typing... DING!

“Exams are getting closer.”

“Come on, we all have been studying a lot. It’ll be refreshing.” I replied

“See, it takes time for me to get close to someone.”

Typing... DING!

“Maybe some other day.”

“How can you know more about me if you always turn me down whenever I ask you out? I guess the only way for me to get close to you is by spending all the off-class hours with you and your entourage — Going out for meaningless dinners every Friday — Organizing birthday parties for full-grown ass adults, and performing better than ten other guys who are also doing the same. What about the real character of straightforwardness I’m showing in which none of us wastes our time? You go out with me — I treat you well — We get to know each other — If you like me and I find you as good as I expected, we do it again — Rest of the time, we focus on our careers and passions. No wonder there’s an old saying: Career and Relationships don’t go hand in hand.” I thought and responded,

“You can just say it if you don’t want to. Why play games? I’m not some third-class roadside Romeo.”

The only way that it was going to work was if she turned out to be a super cool chick who doesn’t want a bullshit Swayamvar for her. There was a one-in-a-million chance, but I had to try since it was possible. Now that I realized that it wasn’t, I was done running after her.

That night around 10:00 pm, I was having dinner with Arun, Ashu, Raju, Chandan, and Sumit when I saw a text message from Simar,

“Hey! Meet me near the bridge.”

“Go as fast as possible bro.” said Raju, sitting beside me.

It’s a shame that one message from her made me forget all those wise realizations I had less than five hours ago. I aborted my dinner mid-way and left the mess in a rush. My quivering feet made hasty steps. I called the elevator but couldn’t wait for it — It was taking too long, or so it seemed — I ran for the stairs — I swear to God, I would have jumped off the 5th-floor balcony if there were no stairs.

When I reached the moonlit bridge near the STH, she was standing there looking as beautiful as ever — Like one of those Japanese oil paintings, she was gazing at the horizon — It seemed like the wind was blowing only to give air to her hair. 100 meters from her, I took deep breaths and acted to walk casually. I gave her a wave — She gave a smile back — Every step towards her felt like a step away from my miseries. As I stood before her, the earth seemed to swing like a cradle. Her presence with that ambience was a trip. To top it all, she started to speak,

“Sorry, I was a little rude earlier...” she said.

Lilies bloomed within me, which induced an uncontrollable smile melting away all my anger against her. If I was smart, I would have kept quiet and let her finish her sentence. But I was not,

“It’s alright.” I said,

“... But...” she said, which kicked my smile to oblivion. She continued,

“... here’s the thing: I’m here to work hard, to get my final posting in Mumbai. Nothing can happen between us. It’s just one year, so stay Normal. That’s all that I had to say. Stop trying.”

Well, I kept quiet this time. My brain started to analyze the new-found set of information:

1. She knows I was trying to get into a relationship with her (Now Confirmed).
2. She doesn’t have a boyfriend (Or she would have told me).
3. She is dumb enough to think that being with me will make her work any less.
4. She makes her relationship decisions based on mathematical career calculations.

All I needed to know. I instantly took a 180 and walked away without saying a word. The excitement-borne shiver was now replaced with an anger-conducted tremble. I started talking to myself... again,

“I’m here to work hard?! What the fuck do you think I’m doing here? Not just you; nobody on this fucking planet is more dedicated and passionate about their goals than me. You can be equal, but NOT MORE! I thought you were a shy girl, so I initiated. But you turned out to be more stupid than shy. Every now and then, life offers you an opportunity that is better than what you imagined in your sweetest dreams. The question is whether you are smart enough to even realize it’s being handed over to you? Whatever... I’ll do what I want to do with or without you, and let’s see how hard you work. You don’t care, so I don’t care. You soon will, but I still won’t.”

I was happy that I used the freedom of Choices — The only way to truly find out. But,

“If you want the liberty of choices, be ready for the responsibility of consequences that comes with it.”

Next, I drenched myself back with ISRO preparation over the weekend and found out more about the meaning of Consequences Monday morning.

28th August 2017, 9:45 am | SCAR Academy

As I entered the *Engineering Mathematics* class, I was the focus of attention but for all the wrong reasons.

“What the hell were you thinking, dude?!” exclaimed a boy in the front row.

I stared in confusion at him. Before I could ask him,

“What the hell are you talking about?”

The guy next to him asked,

“Did you fucking propose to Simar, bro?!”

“I heard that she said NO. Is it true?” asked the boy sitting behind them.

“Tough luck, man... You should have waited.” chuckled the guy beside him.

I walked away thinking hard of what to say to them, harder about what they were talking about, but hardest about WHO THE FUCK ARE THESE DUM-DUMS? In that class, I had at least 10 guys who I didn’t know existed, asking me what happened at “The Bridge”. Now wait a second; you’ve read the full story so far. Let me confirm right away that this is not one of those where I have memory issues,

causing me to over time rediscover the stuff that I did myself. With that out of the way, you might agree that I've done a lot of stupid shit so far, but that one atrocity that even I was smart enough to keep away from was: Proposing to a girl I am not even dating!!

"Psss... Don't worry bro. I know that you didn't actually propose to her... You umm... just... I mean... She just told you to.... umm... to stay the hell away from her... kinda." said Arun, who came to the last bench just to talk to me.

"Kinda?! Who the fuck told you that?" I asked, wondering how Arun knew a little bit more accurate of a story.

"Sumit told me." he said.

When I asked Sumit, he said Raju told him — Raju said, Ashu — Ashu said, Vaishnavi, and guess who could have told Vaishnavi?

"God damn that bitch!" I screened in my head.

But she didn't owe me anything, and I didn't believe in using excuses while ingesting the bitter medicine of Consequences. I went from that hot shot who got her number in 5 minutes to the first to get rejected by her. Overnight, she ramped up her social credits and plummeted mine. Gotta applaud the hustle.

That evening after the classes, at 5:00 pm, I entered the STH library. I was the first to be in there, as usual. Simar unusually entered 5 minutes later and sat 4 feet away from me. After 10 minutes of awkward silence between us, Vaishnavi entered and sat beside Simar. I was trying to not give a fuck, but her proximity would automatically cause my heart to pound — My eyes still craved just one glimpse of her. I knew it was my fault, and it was my responsibility to get her the fuck out of my head. But how to wipe her off when she doesn't want to be gone?

Ding!

"Hey, are you angry with me?" She texted me.

Firstly: Fuck her for texting a person sitting 4 feet away.

Secondly: Yes, but I can't tell you that cuz then you win!

"No." I replied and walked out of the library.

She messaged me frequently for the next couple of weeks, trying to start a casual conversation, Like, *"How are you?"*, *"Health Physics notes."* etc. But it was my turn

to give cold replies.

Firmly believing in the *Out of Sight - Out of Mind* Philosophy, I avoided going to STH Library on the 6th floor and started going to the Central Library on the 4th floor — That's where I first met the JRFs. Girls were allotted hostels on the 5th floor and JRFs on the 4th Floor. JRF stands for Junior Research Fellowship, and this is what you need to know about the program:

1. They are basically in a Ph.D. program funded by NEA.
2. They had the same coursework as us Trainee Scientists (TSs), which they have to cover in the first year.
3. And so they would sit in the same classes as us.
4. They would get a monthly stipend of Rs 25,000 without any Bond amount.
5. They did not have competitive rankings unlike TSs, but had to pass all courses, else, their stipend would be on hold.
6. They had 5 years of secured funding.
7. They had appeared in the exact same competitive exams like GATE, ISRO, ESI as TSs had before entering NEA. It's just that we cracked the SCAR screening process, and they didn't.
8. Most JRFs never wanted to do a Ph.D. but were in this position because of unemployment.
9. They had neither secured job positions in NEA nor any career prospects outside NEA once they complete Ph.D.
10. The above two points pushed almost all the Engineers in the program to prepare for the competitive exams again and leave NEA as soon as they crack any of the

As you can see, JRFs and TSs had differences. But considering a TS who had given up on the Academy rankings and planned to leave NEA within a year, it would be a different picture. There were more similarities between me and JRFs than between me and other TSs.

1st September 2017 | Central Library, SCAR

I was sitting with Ankit, a JRF who joined NEA in August 2017 as well. He was a 2016 graduate from Delhi University — Gold medalist — Spent a year at Delhi

coachings, same as me — GATE 2017 AIR-1875 — Didn't qualify ESE, SCAR and ISRO — This competition is ruthless! Cleared the SCAR JRF screening interview, and here he was.

"I got into this thinking that it is the cheapest and quickest way to build the best career in Engineering." He said.

Ankit was a tall, well-built, and hyper-athletic dude from Haryana — A pure farm boy — Apart from his Academic medals, he had about a hundred gold medals in track & field — A straight up winner — But then he banged against the wall of GATE.

"We all did. And you know what? It might just be... It's just that we are not the only ones to know about this. Hence the brutal competition."

"True... We humans are so optimistic... We just look at what we can get and go for it. Completely neglecting what we gotta give." He said.

Ankit left the library at 11:00 pm. An hour later, the librarian pushed me out for some reason so ridiculous that I don't even remember well. But it was something along the lines of "... *Library closing time...*".

As I walked out of the library, I passed by Simar. Your boy with tough nuts didn't even look at her.

"*Then how do you know Ashwin, that it was her?*" you would ask.

"*It's cuz of ya' boy's Ninja Peripheral Vision, son!*" I would say.

And also because two minutes later,

DING!... DING!... DING!

Only one person who texts like that and is yet to be blocked.

3 messages from Simar:

"Oh my God!"

"How much will you study?"

"You'll become the topper of the Academy like this."

After two minutes of thinking on whether to reply or not, my illogical side took charge of the matter,

“Heeeyy mannn... Listen... You are so self-obsessed. Have you ever considered how everything you’ve been brewing in your lonely mind might be WRONG? It’s not her fault. It was your choice, your decision, and your actions. Why are you making it awkward for her? You know how rumors work. Maybe she didn’t even start it. She is a good girl who cares for you just like she would care for any other person. She understands that you had feelings for her and must know it is painful to endure this rejection. So she is trying hard to make sure that you are ok. Be better than what you are. Be bigger than yourself and respond in a NORMAL way.”

“I’m not studying for Academy. I’m preparing for ISRO.” I replied after 2 minutes of typing.

“You don’t want to stay here at SCAR?” She replied instantly.

“No.” I replied quicker.

She kept on typing for horrendously long — I thought she was writing a message as big as this chapter — Tossed my phone on the bed and went to wash my face. When I returned, her text said,

“Ok. All the best! Goodnight.”

Her frequent texts found an abrupt end that night. It was easier to get over her after that.

16th September 2017, 8:00 pm | STH Mess

I was having dinner with Arun, Sumit, Ashu, Chandan and Raju. The food was horrible. I could slowly but surely get what Faiz was talking about. On the bright side, I had good company — Cheerful conversation — Laughing about events from our Delhi days. Dinner with the boys was a good break after a day of continuous grind — Made me forget about numericals for 30 minutes. But then I heard something that would launch me with the escape velocity, propelled through the stratosphere. My jaws couldn’t give a flying fuck about the food it was assigned to chew once Sumit said,

“ISRO released a new notificat...”

“When is the Exam?” I asked quicker than a thunderbolt as I dropped a couple of half-chewed rice grains off my mouth.

“December... It’s surprising that there’s... a second notification in the same ye.....”

I left the plate where it was — Chewing the remaining food in my mouth, I blitzed out of the mess. I needed internet. On the 8th floor, near the Elevator (My usual asylum), I opened the good old <https://www.isro.gov.in/careers>. It was true, 40 seats for Mechanical — Scientist post — No reservation quotas — Not even handicapped quota — Clean — Examination Date: 22nd December 2017. Nobody on Earth could have swabbed the smile off my face that night. I was not in the same dimension anymore — Exhilarated, as if I had already become an ISRO scientist. This was all I needed — An opportunity — An opportunity gives the control in my hands. Never in the 11 years history of ICRB has it ever released two notifications in the same year. This confirmed that I was going to leave SCAR even before completion of Academy. I rushed to STH Library and filled out the application within an hour — Application fee: Rs 100. Right when I clicked on the ‘Submit’ as if right on cue, Simar came and sat in front of a computer right of me. Just before I got up to leave, I took a good look at her eyes for the first time since *The Bridge*. I wanted to show the steadiness in mine — I wanted to see her’s roll down.

Back at #804, I made a proper plan — Spoke while I planned — Discussed the strategy with myself — Recorded what I spoke. There were two voices — Same sound but completely different characters — Both in perfect synchronization — The Candidate and the Coach.

“They are going to call us *Double Scientist*.” I said while writing the same on a Chart paper stuck on the wall.

“The boy who was considered smart enough by both India’s Nuclear Program and Space Program.” I said into the microphone of my earphones connected to my phone with the voice recorder app running.

I had 100 days left. Since now I had lesser time, contrary to my original plan,

“Everything had to be tightened further!” I said.

—*Knock Knock*—

I opened the door — It was Mahinder,

“Hey, man! ISRO released its vacancy.” I shouted in excitement with a broad smile on my face.

“Yeah bro... I heard. Couple of other boys told me. I came here to tell you just in case... You know.” he said as he walked past me and jumped on the bed — Rested his head on my pillow and started scrolling through Facebook.

“Nah dude, I was just creating a plan for it.” I responded while putting the number of days needed against subjects on the Chart.

“Damn! With chart paper and all? It’s not a war dude. Just an exam.”

I didn’t respond to it, just placed his words in the waitlist queue and continued to calculate the time my weak subjects would take.

“Yeah yeah... I can’t function without a plan.” I said as the pencil scratched against the white canvas.

“You know I came here knocking 10 minutes ago as well. You didn’t respond... Heard you talking to someone on call.” he said as his focus towards Facebook paralleled mine towards the chart.

“Yeah, bro. It’s something I often do.”

“What? Talk over the phone? Yeah... It’s 2017, most of us have started doing that. If only you would socialize with other people, you’d know.”

“Look who the fuck is pestering me about being social... Mr. Earphones!”

He giggled. I placed the pencil in my pocket and explained that I had developed this habit of speaking in English as if I was talking to someone or a crowd. This was a regular practice to enhance my communication skills. In my second year of college, I realized the importance of Spoken English in India, as all the job interviews were in English. Since my mother tongue is Hindi, I felt the need to work on it. I used to record every such talk, which usually lasted from at least half an hour to as long as 2 hours. I recorded it so that I could listen to them later and find out my mistakes — Work upon them to improve. I called it the *D.M.I.R.*, short for *Do-Monitor-Improve-Repeat*.

“Damn, bro... That’s intense.” he said while scrolling through YouTube now.

What I did not tell him was that my spoken English had reached an above-decent level 2 years ago itself. I continued the process because it helped me to clear my mind. Thoughts in your head are a mixture of chemicals — A jumbled mess. To have it structured out, you either need to speak out or write them down. A single

trick to sort out my mind, the most powerful weapon — And to enhance my communication skills, the most essential tool. I had fallen in love with the process. Why stop if I know it works? If this is how much I have improved using it for 4 years, I would like to see how much I can grow in 40 years — The beauty of developing your own path from scratch is that you can be as good as you want to — Go as far as you wish. I was here before you found it interesting, and I will be here after you are tired and gone. I will put ten bricks a day and will do that for decades. You will call me talent, and I will call you unaware. Watch me pulverize all your heroes born with talent gifted by your Gods. Watch me make your Extraordinary look Ordinary.

Chapter 4

What Engineers do Best

20th September 2017, 12:05 pm | SCAR Academy

“...A nuclear power plant produces Energy measured in Megawatts! The only place humans generate more is at the Rocket nozzle throat, where it’s measured in Gigawatts.” Explained Dr. Suresh P.S., the professor of Reactor Engineering.

There was silence in the class — Some sleeping — Some thinking — Some listening — You could listen to the faint voice of the professor in the neighboring class, as Dr. Suresh wrote equations on the green board. He then turned on the projector and displayed the Mushroom cloud of an Atom bomb test. Dr. Suresh was one of those rare scientists at SCAR who actually knew how to teach. He was a tall man in his mid-40s with long curly hair and teeth of unreal whiteness — He would make sure that you see them 90% of the time you see him — It’s almost like he was a failed model who never gave up auditioning for *Colgate*. He was a very successful Engineer though. His class didn’t feel like a lecture but a discussion. He used to talk about such practical applications of Nuclear Science & Engineering that I couldn’t help but ask him questions. Chandan wouldn’t like my curiosity disturbing his nap time, so I’d sit away from him during the RE classes.

Today’s class was on the basic concept of Dimensional Analysis, which we Mechanical Engineers study in our second year of Undergraduation. But Suresh would never tell you something you already knew. He instead explained how Dr. GI Taylor, a British physicist, used simple Dimensional Analysis to figure out the amount of Plutonium used in the Trinity test utilizing just a picture of the blast published in the newspaper. GI Taylor had worked on Ballistic Research during World War I — Was brought within the outer circle of the *Manhattan Project* to study the wave propagation and Implosion mechanism of the Atom Bomb in

1941. For reasons quite obvious, he had concerns about the bomb that was being developed itself and was pushed aside from the program by 1943.

"I wonder what it would be like in the early 1940s... What would be going on in the minds of the scientists working on something knowing that it could put a full stop to Humanity. No wonder Oppenheimer quoted Bhagavad Gita when he saw this power in full action. Now, I am become Death, the destroyer of worlds... God damn, that's a scary line... But fortunately, those fears never turned into reality... Those scientists would have had a sigh of relief that they were wrong... Or were they?... With Russia having 6,500 nuclear weapons, the USA holding 6,185, and over 1000 by China, France, United Kingdom, India, Pakistan, Israel and North-Korea combined... And that's only what we know of... Maybe it's only a matter of time..." I was lost in my thoughts when I was woken up by Dr. Suresh,

"Alright, so let's see what variables are important for us... Obviously, the radius... that's what he got from the footage. What else?"

"Pressure and density." said Sumit.

"Correct, so we got three. What else?" He said as he looked towards me.

"There will be two of those."

"Pardon me?" He said, pointing at me with a chalk in his hand.

"Inside and outside the explosion... different P and rho."

"Perfect! So five... I am gonna tell you, there are seven... So, what else?" He said, expecting an answer from me.

The brightness of his teeth blinded me for a second, but his energy reminded me of $E=mc^2$ — Which reminded me of Einstein — In turn, reminded me of his fascination towards the ultimate independent variable,

"Time." I said.

"Great!..." He said with that wide smile of his as he chalked 't' on the green board.

He then turned and said,

"But you all are missing one essential parameter... Why would Dr. Taylor go out of his way to do all this? What else matters?"

"The amount of fuel... Plutonium." I said.

“Plutonium or Uranium?” He asked immediately as he felt his thick and well-cherished mustache.

“Plutonium... Trinity test had the same design as the *Fat Man* dropped on Nagasaki.”

“Good job, kid... Yes, so in other words, our seventh variable is Energy. That is what this gentleman was trying to find. Now let’s see what he did.”

He then went out to derive the energy relation in ten short minutes. The total yield came out to be about 20 Kilotons of TNT. This was in 1945 — If you had a kid that year, before he or she would have reached high school, the Russians had developed the *Tsar Bomba*, which produced an explosion equivalent to 50 MEGAtons of TNT! Humans... these motherfuckers would have created a Sun if they could... and someday, if they don’t obliterate themselves first, they would.

1st Midterms: 2th Sept - 6th Oct 2017

1.	25 th Sept	Engineering Mathematics
2.	27 th Sept	Finite Element Method (FEM)
3.	29 th Sept	Pipe Design
4.	2 nd Oct	Reactor Physics
5.	4 th Oct	Reactor Engineering - I
6.	6 th Oct	Health Physics

26th September 2017, 9:00 pm | STH

I ripped through the first paper since its syllabus superimposed a part of GATE, but the second paper was a mountain. Here’s something people need to know about the difference between Bachelors’s and Master’s courses: There’s a gigantic gap in the level of complications. After going through the entire lecture series on FEM by *MIT*, reading half of the book by *J.N. Reddy*, and Investing 2 full days, when I picked the previous year’s questions (PYQs), I couldn’t solve even a single numerical. 12 hours before the exam, with that intense fear of failing in this exam, I knocked Mahinder’s door. He was sitting on a carpet of printouts of slides used

by faculties to teach us — Shirtless in his boxers — A thin towel tied around his forehead — Biting his nails — Fiercely turning pages of the same book I had given up on.

“Were you able to solve PYQs, bro?” I asked.

“Nope... I am still trying to understand concepts.”

When I showed him a few PYQs, he went into shock and recovered only with a smack on his head. He said,

“Bro... I’m going to fail.”

“No, you are not! We still can turn the table.”

“What can we do? We are fucked!”

“We do what Engineers do best.”

24th November 2013, 9:00 pm | Academic Block, AIT, Sikkim

Amongst the mountains of North-East, the winter was brutally cold, the girls were brutally pretty, and I was brutally single. That Sunday morning, I woke up at 5:25 a.m. — After a run followed by a clean & lean breakfast, I reached the library at 8:30 a.m. As always, I was the first to reach the library, and as always, the librarian was late. She saw me sitting on the stairs waiting with my books on my lap — I looked up and then at my watch — 8:40. My gesture probably sounded to her as,

“Do your job.”

She rolled her eyes in annoyance, and her expression sounded to me as,

“Get a life.”

As soon as she opened half the door, I got in like mosquitos get in your room the moment you make the mistake of opening a window at 5:00 pm. That day, first I revised all my class notes — Then all of my self-made notes that I had made by going through 2-3 different books — Then I practiced writing the answers to all the previous year’s questions multiple times till it could be tasted in my blood. It was Theory of Machine (TOM) semester exam the next day. I was in an intense race to become the topper of Mechanical Engineering. I wanted that Gold medal currently held by Reet Viraj Bhandari, a boy who had been a topper since.....well

since he had been giving exams. State topper in 10th Boards, state topper in 12th boards, and AIR under 4000 in AIEEE — I heard he got sick before that exam but was still way better than my rank of 3,75,000 — The only two reasons that he was not in some NIT was because AIT gave him a 100% scholarship and was close to his hometown. I wanted that scholarship. My plan was to surpass him and then write a letter to the HOD for a scholarship. From scoring 65% in PCM in 12th Board, I climbed to a CGPA of 9.42 in the first semester of college. Reet had 10 that semester. I was section B topper, while Reet was section E Topper, Mechanical Engineering Gold Medalist, and Over All Gold Medalist of our batch. Second Semester, I climbed to 9.78, Reet had 10 again. I was then ranked 5 and aimed for a 10 that semester.

As I walked out of the library onto the main road — Couples, boy gangs and girl groups were sitting on either side — I could feel them all looking at me.

“What are they thinking?”

“Am I too skinny?”

“Is my dark skin the reason they don’t talk to me?”

“Why is she laughing? Is my pant’s zip open?”

I would think, as I found the attention suffocating me — I would walk at a speed a little lower than running to get out of the spotlight ASAP.

“Hey, Topper!! Wait a second.” shouted Akash from behind.

A 19-year-old me slowed down, turned back and replied,

“Yeah bro, what’s up?”

“Full-day library, huh? You completed the Gears chapter?” he asked.

“Yeah man, how about you?” I replied while I continued to walk at the same pace.

He started walking fast as well to catch up with me,

“Man, we are not able to understand anything... All these adindum, didendum, peach.... It’s all messed up man. Will fail tomorrow for sure.” he said with panic on his face.

“Bro... Just say it.” I shrugged my shoulders.

“Fuck yeah dude! My room. Boys are waiting.”

“Tell them that they are buying me coffee... It’s going to be a long night.”

With that *Eureka* face, he exclaimed,

“Thanks Topper! We’ll get you one every 15 minutes, don’t you worry!” he said as he placed his arm over my shoulder and walked along.

At Akash’s hostel room, when my lecture started at 9:30 p.m., there were 5 boys — The audience rose to 15 by 12:00 a.m., 30 by 1:00 a.m., and dropped to 10 by 2:00 a.m.

At 3:30 a.m., with my morally satisfied heart pumping caffeine-rich blood, I entered my room. My roommate was already asleep. I took my blanket out of my cupboard stealthfully and was about to sleep when I heard a *Knock-Knock* with a whisper from outside,

“Ashwin!”

It was Ravi — He lived in the room right in front of ours. You know those kinds of boys who have tried all the drugs on the face of the planet and have spent more of their time in college high than not? The kind who takes *Dota* more seriously than *General Patton* took WWII? The kind who wants to go to class but unfortunately finds some left-out weed from last night and is now too paranoid to climb stairs? Ravi is that kind of guy. I gently, avoiding all the high-pitched sounds, opened the door.

“Bro, I was waiting for you... Where the hell were you all night?! I searched for you everywhere.” He whispered in fury.

Now, if someone was really going to fail the exam, it wasn’t Akash or any other 7-8 pointers I just taught; it was Ravi, who would score less than 10 marks if I did nothing. Moreover, he was in a position where he’d get a *Year-Back* because of it — I walked out into the corridor, gently shutting the door behind me, and whispered,

“Sorry, bro. My phone died.”

For the next 3 hours, I explained to him all the answers to the past 5 year’s questions and gave him my notes, which he said he’d mug up the important marked parts by 9:00 am in the morning. I had a good beauty sleep till 8:00 a.m. and then went for the exam.

Summary of the 3rd semester: I got 100/100 in TOM but fell short in the subject of Fluid Mechanics. I climbed to a CGPA of 9.89 and became the topper of Section A. Reet had 10 again, was the topper of Section B, Gold medalist of Mechanical Engineering, and Over-All Gold Medalist of the batch. I was now ranked 3.

26th September 2017, 9:10 pm | STH, SCAR

“Hey guys!” Sumit said as we entered his room.

Mahi and I had agreed to go from door to door like salesmen. Sumit was the first option, as he was the only one who never took a nap in the class. On top of absorbing information like a sponge in class, he had already studied FEM back in undergrad as an elective. Lying calm as a saint on his bed in a red t-shirt and blue capris — Back resting against the wall — With a thick pair of glasses on, he was revising his notes.

“Bro, have you solved the PYQs?” Mahi asked.

“No. I don’t need to. I’ll directly solve them in the exam tomorrow.” Sumit replied without taking his eyes off his notes.

Highly impressed by his preparation, I requested,

“OK, man... would you please take a look at a few of these PYQs and explain some of these to us real quick? We are in a sloppy mess.”

Sumit casually turned a page of his notebook, read a couple of lines as the room sunk in silence and then he said,

“Sure.”

Mahi went ahead with a smile and said,

“Alright bro, this is a question from last yea...”

“Of course, you don’t expect me to explain it right now. Do you?” Sumit scoffed and finally looked at us.

Our bad. We might have misled him into thinking that we came here to get an appointment. He continued,

“... It’s already around 11. I need to revise this and go to sleep by 12. You can come back tomorrow morning around 6... no, no... I have to do Yoga as well... 7... Come at 7. I’ll explain.” he said and redirected his attention toward his notebook.

Mahi stared at him with wild eyes and a smile, exposing his bloodthirsty canines. I placed my palm on his shoulder, turned him around, and walked him out. On our way back, Mahi overflowing with wrath, said,

“These fucking rich kids! If he grew up in my village, he would have crutches by the time he was 14.”

I was baffled too, but calming Mahi down, I said,

“Whatever, man. The dude wants to be the topper. Let him have it. There are at least 20 other rooms we haven’t tried yet.”

Next, we went to Adil’s room — Kept knocking on his door for 5 minutes straight — No answers. This was absurd as we had heard some *Telugu* music playing which abruptly stopped after the first knock. On the 8th floor, we tried Raju’s, Arun’s, Ashu’s, and Kabir’s rooms. All their doors were unlocked, but the rooms were empty. Mahi and I wondered if they had some clandestine meeting we were not invited to. Then we went to neighboring Kunal’s room, and there they all were — All five. Kunal was on a chair with his notebook on the table — Kabir and Raju were sitting on the floor, rigorously solving numericals — Arun and Ashu were sitting on the bed going through some books and printouts, respectively. All of them except Arun were operating a *Casio* calculator. Arun had earphones on and was surrounded by 3 books on FEM — Flipping through the pages while also talking to someone on the phone at a frequency that maybe only dogs could sense. Others were not only solving PYQs but also competing on who could do it faster. They had already finished the last two year’s questions and aimed for five. With tenacious boys working relentlessly, the only sounds you could register in that room were that of turning pages, calculator button clicks and scratching pens.

I carefully went close to Raju, who was dedicated to get a solution faster than Kabir. I gently poked my forefinger on his back twice.

“Sup bro? Why so serious?” Raju said as he took a quick look at me and continued to violently drag that pen through the paper.

Trying not to disturb anyone in the room, in a whispery tone, I said,

“Man, me and Mahi are going to fail in this paper. We are unable to solve even a single PYQ.”

Raju dropped his calculator, and before it hit the floor, he grabbed me by my hair — looked straight into my eyes, and shouted,

“ARE YOU FUCKING NUTS?! IN THIS BITCH ASS PAPER?!?! I know Mahi’s brain is shoved deep in his ass, but you! I thought you were gonna fly off rockets and shit... This paper is child’s play! It’s so easy that even Dumbass Kabir is getting the answers right... sometimes.” Raju passed a satirical kiss gesture with a wink toward Kabir as he completed his sentence.

Cringing in the pain of my hair being uprooted off my skull — Sitting on my knees, I asked,

“So, which books did you guys follow?”

Raju finally decided to let go of my hair and said,

“Bro, books are for pussys. Kunal solved 2 types of questions based on what he studied back in college; respected *Bald Motherfucker* solved two more based on what he listened to in class when he was not sleeping. Whatever he missed, Kabir reconstructed from his notes. I solved one type of question as Dr. Pandu *Gandu* gave the exact solution in the last class when everyone else was sleeping... Except for you, cuz you are always on the last bench, busy solving crosswords and shit. These 5 types of questions repeat every year with different data. So once you understand how to solve them, it’s all about the accuracy and speed with which you operate the Calci to get the answers correctly. That’s what we are practicing right now...”

A perfect analysis of the problem statement — Team effort to find a solution — Execution in harmony.

Raju continued and said,

“... And yeah, there are 20 marks theory which is also mostly repeated. Arun is right now searching for the answers in books while he simultaneously talks to his BITCH.” he looks at Arun and chuckles.

Arun looked at him with an intent to kill till Raju apologized with his wide smile showcasing those 32s. Knowing that Mahi and I were in no state to contribute to their team effort and doubtful that they would be willing to help us out, I said,

“So bro... Umm... can you please spare some time to help us?”

“Can I help you?” Raju replied with a serious look on his face — Paused for a few seconds and then broke into laughter, saying,

“Bro, yo ma homie! I’d suck a dick for you if I had to. No seriously... Pick anyone in this room right now except for Kabir and I’ll blow him right now for you...”

“Of course you will. But don’t pretend you’d do it for him.” said Ashu while devouring that calculator with numbers. Raju slapped his shimmering head and continued,

“Look, man. It’s simple. Sit the fuck down, and you’ll get it by 12. Practice by 2, Jerk off by 2:10, and go to sleep like a fucking Emperor! You’ll be kicking ass in FEM tomorrow.”

Raju had an AIR-155 in GATE 2017 and was on the waitlist of ONGC. Though he would always say he was considering continuing his career at NEA even if he got ONGC, we all knew that was bullshit. Raju hated research and loved money. We knew that if he got a call letter from ONGC, we would just hear a *Poof*, and he would disappear into the ether — Forever a history for SCAR. Arun was a temporary guest as well. His Engineering Services Interview was lined up right after the midterms. On a much sadder note, Simar was AIR-25 in GATE 2017 Physics discipline and was on the waiting list for ONGC as well. She missed it just by 0.03 marks, which meant she was probably the first on the waitlist. It was sad, not because I didn’t want her to leave but because I wanted to leave first. But looking at the graveyard of my history with fortune, I was convinced she would get that call even if it meant a person had to die to vacate a seat for her.

Raju really did teach me and Mahi FEM in the next 2 hours — To the point that we became pros at all of those 5 types of questions. Arun gave us 5 pages of theory that we had to mug up. I got around 4 hours of sleep and sliced through the exam like a *Ninjato* would through noodles. FEM gave me a playbook to pass Academy exams investing the minimum amount of time, which I followed for all the subsequent exams. Health Physics and Reactor physics were taught to me one night before the exams by Ganesh, a humble guy from Kerala — An inch taller than me and more than double my weight. Although looking at him, you’d expect him to be a heavy-weight combat sports athlete, he had spent the past couple of years working at Vikram Sarabhai Space Center (VSSC) as a JRF. VSSC, located at

Trivandrum, is the primary research center of the Indian Space Program. This was the reason I spent a lot of time talking to him. He told me a lot about ISRO and life over there — About regular sounding rocket launches from Thumba Equatorial Rocket Launching Station (TERLS) and the dedication of ISRO scientists during the Mars Orbital Mission and the Chandrayaan. He shared how he witnessed the scientists at ISRO working day and night to make those missions happen. Often Sumit would join us in such discussions and end up throwing down more information about Rocketry than Ganesh. Sumit had read dozens of books on ISRO: *Wings of Fire* on Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam, *History of ISRO* on R.Aravamudan and *India's Rise as Space Power* By Padma Vibhushan Awardee Dr. U.R. Rao, to name a few.

“When Elon Musk was asked how he is so knowledgeable, he said that it’s because he has always been reading books.” Sumit would often say. Needless to say, he had read a dozen books on Elon Musk as well.

Ganesh was in the Electrical Engineering (EE) department. Almost every branch of Engineering and Sciences had interdisciplinary subjects, and EE TSs had courses like SOM to facilitate their understanding of materials used in reactor cores. TSs from disciplines other than Mechanical Engineering often came to me for such subjects. But unlike others, Ganesh would ask questions to learn instead of questions that would just help them to write good answers in exams. For example, most would ask:

- What’s the definition of dislocation?
- What’s the derivation of the stress equation?
- How to solve a particular numerical?

Ganesh would ask all that too, but he’d also ask:

- What are dislocations?
- How does it make materials both stronger and prone to failure?
- What are its real-world applications?

And then, before you know it, we would be talking about superalloys? What are ceramics? What’s an ablative material? Their applications in launch vehicles and what he knows about their use in ISRO.

20th October 2017, 5:00 pm | STH

The Engineering Services 2017 result just got published. Arun secured AIR-8. This extraordinary performance was pretty much expected by all. Much more enthralling news was that Kailash secured AIR-11. Days of unemployment were finally over for him. That night, I called him to congratulate, but he was way too drunk to talk. Meanwhile, the boys planned a celebration party for Arun. Raju brought beer crates, Keshav held one *Johnnie Walker* in each hand, and Kabir brought food. Considering my past experience and achievements, I was assigned the honorable duty of scoring weed by 9. Two hours later, I reached back the SCAR main gate where, as always, I found 5-10 CISF officers responsible for guarding and protecting the Government's intellectual property. I showed my ID, and that's all it took. I walked in with Marijuana both in my pocket and my bloodstream. The 8th floor at STH looked like one of those Bollywood item song sets with unshaved drunk boys in their boxers, cheering like a bunch of degenerates. The item girl was replaced by topless Raju, and by the looks of his energetic movements, it didn't seem like his shorts would hold for long either. Dancing with his hands up and his eyes closed, forget alcohol, to hell with weed, it looked like the dude was on Acid. When Arun saw me, he impatiently snatched the weed packet — Entered his room and started crushing them like a gentleman. Chandan, Ganesh, and Sumit stood on the sides like you would beside your father at a wedding of your distant relative — Waiting to eat and leave.

"C'mon guys, let's sit down and talk." said Ashu with a slurry voice.

The boys formed a circle and sat on the corridor floor.

"Bro, the first day I got here, out of all the girls, I found Vaishnavi to be the most beautiful. I'm glad that you got her... Do you love her?" asked Keshav.

Ashu took a sip of beer — A lousy attempt to hide his smile.

"But who is going to land Simar?" asked Kunal.

"It's ma bro. Who else?" Mahi said, raising his bottle.

"Naah... he got balls, but that's not how you get a girl... especially when she's so damn hot." said Ashu.

"But I've seen her checking Ashwin out. I've already considered her as my *Bhabhi*." said Kabir.

You do, people watch, and then they talk. If this is what they were saying in front of me, I wonder what they have been behind me while I was busy studying.

“I think the future ISRO chairman is getting close too.” said Kunal.

To clarify, I was not being referred here. Looking at the talents, ambitions and spectacular academic records, Sumit unanimously got the title of “*Future ISRO Chairman*”.

“Come on!! That Nerd?!” Mahi exclaimed.

“Well, where do you think he is now? I went to the water cooler half an hour ago and saw Sumit and Chandan getting into the Library.” said Keshav.

“I know Vaishnavi is in Library... that means Simar is there too.” said Ashu

“Chandan is also trying his best to get closer. After all, they have a lot in common, singers, artists, Chandan likes to be behind the camera, and Simar loves to be in front of one. Soon, they won’t need a *Nikon* to be in between them... The only problem is, just like me, he is terrible at talking to girls. Ashwin can do in 5 minutes what Chandan can’t do even in 5 hours. This player took her number in one go! Whooooo!! You gotta teach me, bro!!” exclaimed Kabir as he emptied another bottle.

It was interesting to listen to what the audience had to say. I was also assured that I was not alone in this. It’s just that others were playing it incognito.

“Count me out, guys. I’m not in it anymore. This girl needs me to do a lot of shit that doesn’t make sense, nor do I have the time for it. But God damn, the shit the boys are ready to do is *sen-fucking-sational*! How can you listen to their girly talks for even 10 minutes? Last time I tried, my ears started to bleed. It’s always about some normal shit someone did that will leave them all *ROLFing*. Once, in the library, Simar, Vaishnavi and Poornima laughed for an hour about Kavita losing her loofah... After 10 minutes, I realized: *Oh, this itself is the fucking joke!* — And that they would keep telling it to everyone who enters the library and will continue laughing like psychopaths! There’s never a point! Don’t you wanna kill yourself listening to them!?”

Ashu chuckled with his eyebrows raised and said,

“Chill, bro! You are tripping. That’s the price we all pay for pussy.”

Still frustrated, I immediately shouted,

“Go to a whore house. You’ll pay lesser!!”

Ashu laughed while trying to see if any drop was left in that bottle.

Arun stood up — Picked up his guitar — Placed the strap behind his neck and arm — Finding it difficult to completely open his eyes, he said,

“Whether you accept it or not, Ashwin, this is the bitter truth you must swallow. If you like a girl who is 23 already, she is not as novice as she was 5 years ago. These girls have already made the mistake of falling for the bold and rash within a week. They have learned from it. They have 3 years before their family starts pressuring for marriage. They cannot afford to get into an unstable relationship at this point in their life. Which is why you need to make her feel comfortable, for that you have to spend a lot of ‘*I just wanna be your friend*’ time till she enjoys hanging out with you...” Arun gave the last statement with a stroke across the strings.

He wanted to continue, but Raju mimicked Arun’s deep, monk-like voice and interrupted,

“... till she shares her secrets, tells you about her boyfriend, and then you patiently, like a hawk, wait till she fights with him. If you’re as smart as *Bald Motherfucker*, you yourself will become the reason for that fight. And when that happens, you give her emotional support. Then support her in sleeping at night, then support her in blocking that dumb ass, then support her every now and then when she says, ‘*I miss him*’. But don’t you fucking let her call him back! Support her to the point she believes that her Ex’s only purpose was to bring her to you. Do it all while pretending you only do it because you care for her. Then there will be a time when her Ex is completely out of her life, and she needs a new boyfriend... Cuz she has had at least one since she was fucking 14. And when you reach this point, she herself will want you to be her boyfriend. There you go, she gets the close support, and you get a girlfriend. Congratulations!”

A lot of things changed post that night. Arun resigned to join Engineering Services, and Raju resigned to join ONGC. SCAR was never the same again for me. Moreover, the dynamics started to change post midterm results. While everyone, including me, was sure I would be the last in the rankings, I wasn’t. I scored the highest marks in FEM and Mathematics, scoring 81/100 and 95/100, respectively.

Sumit scored 60/100 in FEM, but he had that promising look in his eyes, which said,

"I know what I have to do now."

Of course, he scored much better in other subjects and ended up in second position in Mechanical rankings. I was the 9th with Ashu right behind me, followed by Nishant, who never talked to anyone and was supposedly preparing for the Civil Services Examination. I learned about his silent existence on the day the ranks were published — Sign of a true UPSC aspirant. Chandan was at the tail end with 12th position. This marked the beginning of him distancing himself from me. He gravitated more towards the cult, and his foul mouth pretty quickly got a spell-check as good as the swipe keyboard in *iPhones*. I skipped more and more classes as the ISRO exam was closing in, and in the classes I did decide to attend, he wasn't beside me anymore. My negligence towards semester exams assured everyone they didn't need to worry about being the last ranker. But now, they started to suspect that maybe in all those hours in the library and when I wasn't going out with them, I was actually studying for Academy exams instead of ISRO. I swore to God I wasn't, but nobody believed me other than Mahi. Why did he trust me, you ask? Well, for one, he was lying around in my room most of the time, and for second, arguably more importantly: He... was... Wait for it... Rank 1. This was more surprising to both of us than the fact that I wasn't last. Only we knew that none of us ever studied for Academy exams other than the night before. Nobody believed us, and Mahi was ostracized. The boys analyzed the first midterms and concluded:

- Class teachings were mostly useless in scoring marks other than when the faculty talks about a question that can '*Potentially*' be asked in exams.
- '*Potentially*' always meant that the question was most '*Definitely*' going to appear in the exam.
- Solving PYQs was essential.
- Forming groups of 4-5 was vital.
- Stop teaching Mahi. Otherwise, he would certainly end up getting the gold.

The darkness I saw amongst my batchmates post that night made me consider the last two months to be sunny and rainbow high school friendship. They could no longer look at the few above them in rankings without thinking they had to outscore them. They could no longer look at the few below them without

considering they were running with a target on their back. The only bright side was that I had to bear this hostility just for a few more months. Joining should be by February, as ISRO would most likely conduct the interviews by January. Speaking of which, Ashutosh decided to not appear for the ISRO interview.

A moment of silence for that dumb motherfucker. Hand a cell phone to a monkey, and he'll scratch his bum with it. He gave a million reasons why SCAR was better — Better postings, faster promotions, and *bla-bla-bla*, but everybody knew the truth. He and Vaishnavi were getting close, and she must have been pretty convincing. Rumor had it that Vaishnavi was already in a 5 year-long relationship but decided to dump the guy a couple of weeks before Ashu's ISRO interview date. Raju told me how the poor guy tried everything to reach her day and night. The former couple prepared for the same exams — She made it, and he didn't. She came to Mumbai, and he was left at Asansol. It must have felt to him like a blind man lost in the desert, and all of a sudden, fire started to rain down. For Vaishnavi, what could be better than to have a life partner in the same Government Organization as her? Just look at the financial stability that double income brings. With a single bullet, she murdered the ambitions of one and self-confidence of another while she secured her future. World works in a brutally practical fashion, and how much people care about this "SAFETY" is astonishing, to say the least.

For old time's sake, I sat him down a couple of days before the interview and tried to knock some sense into him — Told him that two months of knowing a girl is not sufficient to drop an opportunity like ISRO. But of course, he didn't listen — He was decided. No logic is sharp enough to penetrate the shield of ignorance enchanted by a girl. I wasn't the only one to talk to him, though. A couple of other boys like Kabir, Keshav and Kunal, the K3 as we called, who were now a lot closer to him than me, also talked to him before he made his decision. The only difference: They all convinced him to skip the interview.

"I'm working to get placed in Mumbai now." he said to me.

Rohit decided not to appear in ISRO exam — Said that he had lost touch from Competitive exam preparation because of the Academy exams and that appearing in this exam would only demotivate him from giving a solid attempt in future. In other news, away from this bullshit, ISRO preponed its exam to 17th December — Looked like they were in desperate need of new scientists, and why wouldn't they be? They had recently made the world record for launching 104 satellites using a

single Rocket. Their PSLV rockets were robust, with an outstanding over 99% reliability. ISRO had SpaceX quiver in their boots — Providing deliveries at 40% of their cost in the small satellite market. The Indian Government was putting everything behind ISRO, and the Organization was hoisting India's flag at an International stage. ISRO climbed to one of the top 5 Space Programs in the world.

9th November 2017, 9:00 pm | #804, STH, SCAR

“Thanks a lot dude... *You know...* It was all Greek and Latin before you made it look like middle school science.” said Ganesh as he got up with an exhale of relief.

“You got it! And don't worry, I'll show Himanshu the middle finger if he comes to me... So that you get to the gold spot!”

It was our first quarter, finals. I had just spent 3 hours teaching Ganesh basic Solid Mechanics and Material Science Phase Diagrams, as we had a common paper the next morning. About a week ago, Ganesh did the same for me and taught me Reactor Physics.

“No man... Don't do that... That's not fair... *You know...* Just teach him everything wrong.” He said with a straight face as he placed his specs back in its case.

I laughed with a pat on his left shoulder which felt like a mattress. I said,

“Fuck yeah, bro... Hey, which department are you interested in being placed in?”

“F-BRD... *You know.*”

“You mean S-BRD, right?”

“No, no... F-BRD, the one at Vishvenpuram... *You know...* It's down south in Ta..”

“I know where it is, bro! Why the fuck would you want to go there?”

“*You know...* Closer to my home, and I really think it's at more of a forefront of research compared to Mumbai... *You know...*”

“I know... But the problem is that everyone down there wants to leave that place. Everyone is working just for a transfer. You'll never get anything done in such an

environment. I think that's the reason they have made zero significant progress in 30 years."

"Well... Most, not everyone... And I think we are the ones who can change that. Don't you agree?" he said as he collected his books and notebooks.

"Hell No! I do not. Your life is too short to change anything; your career is even shorter." I responded as I tossed him his pen — He missed the catch — What a loser.

"*Ayyo...* Why would you throw *Vidya*?" He said — picked up the pen — Quickly touched his forehead and chin 3 times with it as if God would walk down and chop his head off if he didn't.

"I would never throw *Vidya*, bro... I respect women way too much to do that."

"*You know...* Ah... Nevermind..." He said — Walked to the door and, standing there before he left, dropped some profound wisdom which, as always, came with a question rather than an answer,

"It's too short to change yourself to fit into the world as well. It might just be long enough to try. Would you rather spend your life adjusting to the world or spend it making the world adjust to you?"

17th December 2017, 12:00 p.m. | Hansraj College of Engineering, Navi Mumbai

Me, Sumit and Adil were waiting outside the college's main entrance under the sun with our ICRB admit cards in our hands. Sumit was talking about the various rockets of ISRO and some complicated orbital mechanics,

"... so how the laws of motion work on earth is not the way it works in space where the magnitude and size of celestial bodies are so huge that it influences tiny objects like spacecrafts..."

He drew two circles on the back of his admit card — Wrote 'Earth' on the larger, 'Moon' on the smaller, and asked,

"What trajectory are you going to follow to reach Moon if launched from Earth?"

With a precarious amount of confidence, I took the pen to draw a straight line, but Adil interrupted. In his southern accent, he said,

“It’ll have to orbit Earth a couple of times, raising the orbit at the perigees by firing LAM engines. It’ll raise its orbit *la-la-la-la-* Hohmann Transfer *la-la-la-la-* Apollo Mission *la-la-la-la-* similarly when it reaches the moon it’ll have to fire the engines at apogee to reduce the orbit *la-la-la-la-*”.

I smiled, nodded and acted as if I was going to say exactly the same.

“Correct! But the term ‘gee’ is only used for Earth. The general terms are *apoapsis* and *periapsis*. For the Moon, it’s *perilune* and *apolune*.”

“How can I expect myself to get selected in ISRO with this stupid brain of mine?” I started to question myself.

They kept on blabbing stuff about the *ISS*, the *Saturn V* — Meanwhile, interesting as it might sound, I restrained myself from asking any *What’s*, *Why’s* or *Who’s* to seize what little confidence I was left with. I pretended to revise my notes while those two continued their chat. I was looking at my notes but was reading nothing. The dark side of me started mumbling,

“You are never going to beat them. They are a lifetime ahead of you. They started studying hard when they were 2 years old. You started when you were 18. They graduated from IITs and NITs. Where the fuck did you graduate from? What were you thinking? That you can undo in 6 years the mistakes you’ve made for 18? And you say I am the illogical one?! That’s funny! You should get back and try to save whatever you’ve in Academy because Ashu, Nishant and Chandan are coming for it. There are certain men who were born to walk in light. They don’t try. They just are. Like Arun, like Sumit, and then, there are few cursed like you who....”

“DON’T YOU Fucking Listen to him!” interrupted the logical side with his ice-cold eyes and rock-solid stare. He continued,

“We can’t always control the outcome, but we 100% of the time can control our input. No exceptions. These two boys, talented as they are, do not affect what you do. The world will try its best, till the last moment, to wash away everything you’ve done. The closer you get — The harder it tries. The inertia of this Universe wants you to stay exactly where you are. To break it, all you need to do is your best.”

“They have opened the gate. Let’s go!” said Adil.

We got through the bottleneck main entrance gate — Getting churned by our competition — That gate, that struggle and that physical push — Whether it’s

Government Job Exams or 7:30 am when the gate of Delhi coaching institutes opens — Office hours at Delhi Metro or Mumbai Local — For sleeper class trains in Bihar or the Rs 9 hour-long standing bus ride in Kolkata — Always gave the physical reflection of the struggle, the fight and the competition to survive — To make a name — We compete to get out of this competition.

“What happened, bro? You seem lost.” said Sumit with his hand on my shoulder.

“Nothing, man. We’ll meet after the exam... All the Best.” I said with a thumbs up.

“You too. Do your best.” he responded with a smile.

“I will... I surely will.” I said as I walked toward my allotted exam hall.

Following was the classic pattern of the ISRO-ICRB written exam:

- Total no. of questions: 80
- Marks awarded for every correct answer: + 3
- Marks awarded for every wrong answer: -1
- Marks awarded for every unattempted question: 0
- Time allotted: 90 minutes
- Expected Cut-off for 40 seats: 140

Exactly at 2:00 p.m, we were allowed to open the seal of the question paper. The 3 questions on the first page were surprisingly difficult. ICRB exams had taken place 12 times — One I had appeared in — I had never seen questions like these. Assuming I got a crooked set with difficult questions piled in the beginning, I turned the page. Among the questions in the first 2 pages, 6 out of the 8 were unsolvable. Sweating in December, I turned a couple of more pages — Sliced through a couple of SOM questions — Then got a speed bump again. There were plenty of *Material Science* and graphical questions, the likes of which weren’t even seen in ESE Prelims. On top of that, some barbaric, never seen before questions from *Operational Research*, *Production*, and even application-based questions were present. In the first 20 minutes, I had reached the 40th question, out of which I was able to solve just 19. I still did not know the trajectory to the moon, but it felt like my brain just got launched straight to its menacing silence.

By the time I went through the entire question paper, I had solved 14 more. I checked the clock; it was 2:45 p.m. Now that’s an anomaly. If there was one thing I

knew about ISRO exams: It never gives the luxury of extra time — You always miss a few questions at the end. This could mean only one thing: ICRB had done something that we had never seen before — It had changed its pattern. Sometimes, never happened before events happen when you are right in the middle of it — That's when you least expect it. Say you are a Nuclear Engineer working at a power plant for the past two years — Same routine work day after day — But imagine if it is 1:23 a.m., April 26th, 1986, and the plant you work at is *Chernobyl*. That is why you should always,

“Expect the Unexpected.”

ISRO had made a paper never seen before — Thus, the cut-off would be something never seen before. The number of questions needed to be solved would drop. Judging by the difficulty level, I analyzed that it'd be less than 60. Experience that I had gained after dozens of exams said that when the paper is difficult, quality is much more important than quantity. Each question will take longer, and the value of each question will rise. Basic Strategy in such papers:

- Scan the question paper well for all solvable questions.
- Don't panic, seeing impossible-to-solve questions.
- Keep calm and solve the solvable questions with utmost accuracy.

Now people who understood this earlier would adapt faster. People with *No Preconceived Notions* would have caught it the fastest. In the next 20 minutes, I brushed through the paper for my actual *Wave-1*. I carefully searched for questions that only appeared difficult but actually weren't — Reached the 80th question for the second time at 3:10 p.m. and solved 15 more questions. In the last 20 minutes (*Wave-2*), I was able to solve 7 more until the bell rang, and the invigilator was there to collect the OMR sheet.

I took a local train from the closest station back to the Academy along with Sumit and Adil, who were able to attempt only 41 and 35 questions, respectively.

“No shit, next time, study Newton's Laws before Kepler's Laws for Engineering-based exams in this Country.” I said in my head.

Relaxed that this fight was finally over, I could now go to the SCAR classes like a normal Trainee — Make fun of professors — chat with others in breaks — Sleep in the class like others, and basically live without constantly burning out my brain.

It was a long-awaited and well-deserved sigh of relief. Just five months of struggle and I cleverly, both skipped the SCAR Academy competition and yet made a better career for myself. As I knew that my rushed preparation had covered the syllabus and pattern of other competitive exams as well, I thought it would be best to appear in GATE & ESE 2018 as well. I wanted to churn the maximum out of the level of preparation I had achieved. I had sufficient faith that I would do fantastic even if I walked in casually in these exams. *Top Coaching Institute* (TCI) in those years provided a prize of Rs. 1,00,000 to Rank 1, 2 & 3 of GATE. This would help me pay the bond to SCAR and to stay up to date for the upcoming ISRO interview.

I chose this ISRO fight. Nobody pushed me for it or influenced me. I didn't have to fight, but I did. And that night, the job was done. I came out victorious. For ISRO, interview was the easy part as I already had the experience & confidence of cracking SCAR interview. So everything was actually ahead of schedule. Apart from messing up with the '*Simar Situation*', this was exactly my plan. But we humans are not the only ones with the consciousness to plan — You choose some fights, and some fights choose you.

Chapter 5

When That Door Shuts

12th January 2018, 7:30 pm | Central Library, SCAR

I appeared in the ESE 2018 Prelims last weekend. It was a good warm-up for the upcoming GATE exam. The library was quiet and peaceful on the weekends. I would churn the advantage out of such moments to get 3-4 hours of quality studies. After finishing a mock test on Fluid Mechanics, when I turned off the Airplane mode of my phone, I saw,

“Bro, the ISRO result is out. You got in?”, a message from Raju.

He even attached the *result.pdf* file, which jolted waves of uncomfortable surges in my heart rate. I didn't remember my roll number but opened the file to check the cut-off. ICRB's published answer keys to two of the questions were challenged for being wrong. I would score between 112 and 120 based on what they choose to do with those two questions. With my sweaty fingers, I scrolled down,

Selected...

Selected...

Selected...

I wiped the phone screen on my pants to clear the sweat which was making the touch screen ineffective and continued to scroll,

135... Selected...

125... Selected...

120... Selected...

119... Not-Selected.

My heart started pounding hard enough on my chest to convince me it could break out at any moment. My shivering hands were no longer reliable — Yet somehow

managed to place the laptop back in my bag — Being ruthless on my trembling feet, I ran back to #804.

I locked the door of my room and took out my question paper as it had my roll number on the front page — Selected search and typed my roll number — Digit by digit,

22..... 37 matches

01..... 13 matches

02..... 2 matches

422..... 1 match

My eyes slowly swept from left to right,

435. ——— 220102422 ——— 116 ——— Not Selected

My entire body felt the Siberian cold. Control over my limbs was now lost. From the audience seat, my eyes watched my hands tearing the question paper in half. My brain was trying hard to figure out,

“What’s going on?... Who gave you that order?”

Before my hands could answer, the ball of my right foot had already hit the door full-blast. There must have been a big *BANG* of collision, but my ears couldn’t register any — All I heard was the terrifying scream of silence. I couldn’t feel any pain in my foot, but the moment it touched the floor, it buckled like a sheet of paper. With the Center of Gravity of my body now having a balance crisis, I fell with the floor slapping my right cheek — The impact of which I could not feel either. But, there was one uncharted anguish that was prevalent all along — It was my heart which was hurting so bad that I was wailing miserably — The screams of which I couldn’t hear. My bewildered mind, still trying to solve the loss of controls, got some signal from my right cheek and immediately started to analyze,

“Why the fuck is it moist?” It asked with curiosity.

“Was there water on the floor? Did I pee when I saw the result? Shit... That’s gotta be the most humiliating failure in the history of exams.” It responded to itself.

No, I didn’t piss my pants — Thankfully. It took a few seconds for me to realize that I was crying. Not just tears rolling down — Howling crying!! I got the howling part when the signals from ears restarted its delivery services. I didn’t even remember the last time I cried, let alone this badly. Maybe it was back when I was 6, and my uncle

whooped my ass for demanding too many sweets — Most certainly long enough to forget what it was like to cry.

“Mr. Tough Boy, for every failure, has a motivational quote pulled straight out of Naruto. Well, what are you going to say now? I’ll try again? — You’ve already tried again and again and again. Failed twice in GATE, once in ESE, and twice in ISRO now. ‘I’ll work harder’? — You have been up-rating for the last 6 years: Increasing hours, increasing efficiency, using every trick in and not in the book. All just to crack this one fucking exam. I think you got SCAR by sheer luck, and instead of accepting what good you were handed over, your head got bigger. You oblivious fool! You fucked up by listening to too many YouTubers screaming, FOLLOW YOUR DREAM!!... Well, what now? After risking so much, sacrificing everything, and giving your best, you are still not good enough!! What are you going to do now? Simar was smart. She sensed a loser from a mile away.”

I was on the floor against my belly, and right cheek still squished against the floor, while all these statements by the *Dark Prince* made a lot of sense. I did not know if I even had the strength to get up, forget trying again for ISRO. In this tiny dark room, where I face the question of,

“Was I able to do what I wanted to do?”

I had no creative rights to fabricate some blame or excuse. From an external source of truth, the answer strikes plain and brutal — With an arrow tipped with NO — Moving at lightning speed — Tearing through everything in its way, targeting the boy who asked for it — Unlike the boy, it never misses its mark. Effortlessly, it cuts a neat slit on my chest covered with human skin, which has been softened too much since the 20th-century wars & massacres. With no mercy for the pain it brings to the victim, it punctured my heart till it found an exit through my back with its metal drenched in my blood of failure. If you think your parents are tough on you, if you believe your ex was heartless, if you think your enemies are cruel, wait till you receive the decisions of life. It wastes no time in explanations and gives its decisions with no obligation to justify.

When you fail, you are all alone. When that door shuts, you are all alone. There are no friends around you to help you drink your fuck-ups along with alcohol. You don’t have a lover’s shoulder to cry on while you victimize yourself. You took the decision, so you face the consequences. You are the architect of your tribulations. You are the culprit, and you are the victim. In this empty and isolated room, there’s no one to hear you blame others or the situations for what happened to you. In this room, you can’t hide from the things you did and the things you didn’t. This room of solitude is

ruthless but honest. When that door shuts, the blindfold so dear to men called Excuses jumps out of the window. Here, the pain you face is not limited by how much you can take but is guided by what you deserve. What you do with that pain is up to you.

So I did what I could. I pressed the floor with my right palm,

“What are your options? You are writing your story today. What do you want the readers to read? I thought you were tougher than this.... What good do you expect to come out of staying down here? Trying again may not work, but staying down here definitely won’t. If you want it, no one is going to hand it over to you. This competition is way too brutal for you to be expecting anything to come easy.”

I pressed my right knee on the floor and said,

“Four fucking marks. One bloody question.”

“People on the borderline will always be slaves to luck. People who decide their own destiny hold control of their life firm in their grips. If you want it, nobody is going to hand it over to you. If you want it, you’ll have to SNATCH IT AWAY! Get up pussy! Leave the crying for the bitches. Stand on your feet and tell me what you can do now?”

As those voices spoke, I found myself back in the dimension of matter. I now stood on my feet in front of my study table — Holding the two parts of the question paper in my hands.

“Hey, fucker! I asked you a question!! WHAT ARE YOU GOING TO DO?”

“I’m going to take what’s mine...” I mumbled.

“Bitch, I didn’t hear you. WHAT THE FUCKK ARE YOU GOING TO DO?!”

“I’m GOING TO RIP IT OUT!! It is mine!! I’ll SNATCH away what’s mine.” I shouted out loud.

I looked at the mirror hanging on the wall behind my study table and wiped the last reminiscence of tears — Pushed off the table — Stared at myself for about 30 seconds, and said,

“At least you are hot.” to myself... in a room... with only two ears... both of which... belonged to me.

Meanwhile, as I flattered myself in a *soon-to-be-serial-killer* fashion, I heard the boys cheering outside. I wiped my eyes again to remove any signs of crying — Buttoned back my shirt — Opened the door and walked out with my right leg still limping.

Analyzing based on this massively shitty weekend initiation, I thought it could only go south from here on and that the cheering was probably because Sumit made it through.

When I walked out into the lobby, I saw Ashu, Kunal, Kabir, and Rohit, each having one of Mahi's limbs in their hand and one of their foot up his ass. I witnessed the crime of manslaughter, which had no punishment by law if you did it on the victim's Birthday. When they got tired of inhumanely breaking Mahi's ass for being born on this day, they dropped him on the ground. I picked him up and said,

"Happy Birthday!" with a hug.

"Result?" he asked.

I shook my head with a smile. Everyone got the answer.

"No problem, bro!! GATE is there!! And ISRO will again be there next year. There's always IISc." Mahi said.

"Yeah, bro. No issues. I will find some way or the other." I responded with an imperfect mask of a smile.

Sumit, with 101 marks, and Adil, with 94, didn't qualify either. Adil was shaken but aimed to score well in GATE 2018. He was confident about qualifying ESE 2018 prelims, and GATE would be a means to better prepare for ESE 2018 Mains which would be in June. Rohit, after seeing the ICRB question paper and cut-off, regretted not appearing — He then resolved to appear in GATE 2018 too. Sumit, on the other hand, had always been decided about not appearing in GATE and was unbroken towards his ISRO ambitions — Say what you will about him, the kid was a one-track mind. His passion for Space Science and Engineering had its roots dug much deeper than even that of mine and so he said that he'll try again — Which was pretty inspirational. Looking at his stoic expressions that night, I bet he didn't cry in his room for an hour.

For me, with ISRO lost again for at least a year and my Academy position sinking deeper into the gutters every day, GATE was the only hope. *HAL*, *BHEL*, *ONGC*, *IOCL*, *HPCL*, anything would be better than a *Botommer* posting in NEA. I was in Survival mode. I needed to get out of NEA, get another job, and fund my third attempt at ISRO. Obviously, a good option through GATE would be *IISc*, Bangalore. It has an ISRO cell within the campus — The then-current and most of the former chairmen of ISRO were all alumni of *IISc* — It opens the route to get into ISRO through M.Tech. Or, who knows? Maybe an even better career in rocketry at *SpaceX*

or *NASA* as I could go for top universities in the world like *MIT* or *CalTech* for a Ph.D. With all this in mind, I recalculated to correct my trajectory — New plan — New Chart Paper — Aiming to get a rank under 100 in GATE 2018. My direction was clear now:

Barely pass the semester exams — By hook or crook — Invest all my time on GATE.

It was a gamble with my academy position on the line — My current career for a career I wanted. You are more likely to take risks when you are losing the war. With this decision to escalate further, I had no doubts that soon 12th position would be my throne.

After the first midterms, nobody gave a flying fuck about learning. Learning didn't help perform better in Academy exams — Learning thus became secondary. As trainees discovered more ways of enjoying the Mumbai lifestyle, it was shoved to tertiary by the 1st Finals. By the 2nd Finals, it was tossed to the *Arabian Sea* with a rock tied to its ankle. Placement was all they cared about. When Relative Performance walks in the door, it murders Skill Development in cold blood. They took the path of rot process, professor ass-licking, and dirty politics. Meanwhile, I bunked all the subsequent classes — Walked into a crowded class — Punched in my attendance with biometric thumb impression — Walked out — Walked into an empty class — Placed two chairs facing each other and with my ass on one and my heels on other, I kept my notebooks on the plank over my lap like a gentleman and studied for an hour. This cycle would repeat for every class.

A week of this raised eyebrows in the administration. The Academy head, Dr. Sudha Goswami, sent her finest to make things difficult for me: Kantharaj Gowardhan Balamurugan, *KGB* for short — HR department's loyal pet #1. His dedication and loyalty were clear from him being on his toes throughout the day, scanning for *bunkers* like me, and bringing justice. Justice included,

1. Deduction of a full-day stipend,
2. A written application of apology.

Bala was assigned the work according to his talents. He would just glance at a class of 70 and know exactly who was missing. Most of the time, he even knew exactly where who could be found — Lovers in canteen looking into each other's eyes, sipping coffee — Lazy fucks, sleeping in the SCAR Library newspaper section — And exam aspirants in vacant classrooms. Evading him was tricky initially, but I figured out his

pattern pretty soon. You just had to keep spots on rotation. We used to have lunch breaks from 12:30 to 2:00 p.m. Get to the mess too early or too late, and Bala would spot you away from the herd. Now he knows that you bunked the class. Classes sometimes lasted longer than scheduled and sometimes shorter. That's where Mahi comes into the picture. He always knew exactly where I was; right after the class, he'd rush to tell me it was time to bounce.

10th April 2014, 3:00 pm | HOD's Office, AIT, Sikkim

I knocked on a door with a board that said

*Dr. A.K. Thakur,
H.O.D.
Mechanical Engineering*

"Sir, please may I come in?" I asked.

"Yes, come in Taksh." said Thakur.

I walked in and stood on the side with my palms on my back, one over the other. H.O.D. continued explaining to Shankar why he could not escape *Year-Back* as he lacked the credits.

"Sir... Sir, please... I'll clear my backs this year, and I promise there will be no more." said Sankar, my classmate, one of Ravi's closest friends — On the brink of crying.

"That's what you said last year." said a poise Thakur.

"Please, sir... I had health issues this year."

Thakur lowered his specs on his nose, looked at Shankar, who was standing right in front of him, and said,

"Son, I was the hostel warden for 10 years. I am fully aware of your health issues. Now, either you'll walk out quickly and quietly, or you'll walk with me to your room."

A few tear drops departed his eyes as he turned back, took a look at me, and walked past me towards the door I just walked in through. I heard the door shut, and the next second, HOD said,

"I got to talk to the dean again."

“Sir.” I said with my eyes focused on his desk, which had a bunch of papers with his signature.

Behind me, his assistant continued to type rigorously. Thakur asked,

“What was your Senior Secondary percentage?”

“75.5% sir.”

“PCM?”

“65%, sir.”

“See... that’s the problem. We do not give scholarships to anyone with a percentage below 90.”

“But... but sir... I am ranked 3 in the Department. Everyone under 10 has a scholarship except for me.”

He sighed — Took off his glasses — Placed them on the desk where my eyes were fixated, and said,

“I know, son... But this is what the Dean told me, and you know that scholarships come from the University, not the Department.”

I went silent. In the past 3 months, I had made dozens of circles in this office. Every time he would say,

“I am going to talk to the Dean.” or,

“I am waiting for the Dean’s response.”

This was something that I had been working on for 2 years, ever since I heard rumors that University provides scholarships for excellent performance in academics.

“Ae *Chottu!*” Shouted Thakur.

The assistant behind me stopped typing immediately and said,

“Yes, sir.”

“Get this boy some of those sweets.”

The assistant got up — Picked a box of sweets — Turned around — Picked the lid up, placed it below the box, and offered me sweets from a box filled with 4 columns of orange *Motichur Laddus*.

“Have it, son.” Thakur said as he pointed his fingers toward the box.

With a shivering hand, I picked one *Laddu*. Thakur, looking at the Assistant said,
“Look at this one, *Chottu*. The boy who did not know what an IC engine was less than 2 years ago is now in 3rd position of Mechanical Engineering batch. The boy has worked hard. Wouldn't you agree?”

“Certainly, sir.” said the Assistant.

I stood there with my eyes locked at his desk and a *Laddu* in my sweaty right hand. Thakur continued,

“Keep it up, son.” he said with a rare mellow in his voice.

“Thank you, sir.” I said, turned around and walked out.

I tossed that *Laddu* in the closest trash can I could find. That's when I walked away from a race to become the Gold Medalist and decided to prepare for GATE. 9.89 was my highest GPA ever, and it started to decline after that — Lowest being 9.00 in the 7th semester.

18th January 2018, 6:00 pm | #804, STH, SCAR, Mumbai

I placed my hands on the arm support provided in that cheap plastic chair that I was sitting on — Grabbed the right handle — Lifted my ass off the seat, and swung the chair across the room as if it was a tennis ball — It slammed on the wall left of me and fell on my bed.

Mahi came rushing into my room,

“Dude! What the fuck was that?!... The hell?” he shouted in confusion.

“Hey, man... How are you doing?” I said, panting.

“Good. How bad are you doing?”

“Extremely.” Still panting.

“Did you fucking throw it?”

“Nah, man... It flew on its own.” trying to breathe deeply.

“Dude, you broke one of its legs!”

“Bullshit! It was like that when I got it.”

“Academy is going to charge you for that.”

“What are they going to charge for that shitty chair? 50 Rupees?”

“Not for the chair, bro. That’s probably cheaper. But there’s a giant dent on the wall!”

“It was like that when I got it too.”

Mahi took a sigh, scratched his right eyebrow, and left the room.

As the GATE exam was getting closer, I needed to give complete 3-hour Mock Tests to tune my mind for the real thing. Second half on Thursdays would be some bullshit colloquium where some guest speaker would talk about something you’d never understand — Either because they sucked at speaking or because they sucked at realizing that we haven’t spent 30 years in the Nuclear domain. Either way, it was a waste of my time. So that day, I decided to walk back to my hostel and give a Mock, which started at 3:00 pm. To get a rank under 100 in GATE, I needed to be good enough to score at least 85 in these Mock tests. 3 hours and 61 questions later, I scored 75/100 with 3 silly mistakes. The next morning, I learned that Bala had found out about my half-day absence and reported it to Sudha, who then made me write an apology letter and deducted a full-day stipend.

2nd Finals: 22nd Jan - 2nd Feb 2018

1.	22 nd Jan	Reactor Engineering-II
2.	24 th Jan	Manufacturing Processes
3.	25 th Jan	Structural Integrity
4.	29 th Jan	Material Science
5.	31 st Jan	Advanced Heat Transfer
6.	2 nd Feb	Computational Fluid Dynamics (CFD)-I
7.	3rd Feb	GATE 2018

For Academy exams, I was primarily relying on my analysis:

1. A minimum of 40% and a maximum of 100% of the questions will be a repetition of the PYQs.
2. Cheating from the fellow TSs in the exam hall was next to impossible for 4 reasons

- a. Exam halls are under camera surveillance.
- b. Cheating as a government employee is a criminal offense.
- c. Three invigilators per 20 examinees.
- d. TSs were sly motherfuckers and competitive as fuck.

My Strategy to pass:

I. Data Collection

1. **T -17 Hrs:** Stop GATE Preparation. Go through the past 5 year's question paper and pick all repeating questions. This would give you 15-20 questions (securing 100 marks, depending on faculty).
2. **T -16 Hrs:** Start going door to door, asking other trainees for the answers.

Note:

- ❖ You cannot expect all the answers from a single person as the trajectory everyone's preparation is different, and not even the toppers will know everything.
- ❖ Not everyone will be welcoming.

Law of Probability (LOP):

If you go to 10 doors for help on the night before the examination,

- 7/10 will show you a *virtual* middle finger by saying either of the following:

"Bro, I have not studied anything."

Translation: *"I don't have time for this shit."*

"Come after 2 hours."

Translation: *"I never want to see your face again."*

"I'm going to fail, bro. Please understand."

Translation: *"I will fail at scoring more than Sumit."*

We call this fraction: 'Majority'

- 1/10 will show a *literal* middle finger.

We call this fraction: '*Smart*'

- 2/10 will somehow or the other help you out. Because their preparation might be going well, or they are in a good mood, or it works as their revision, or they believe in *Jesus* or in *Karma* or in fucking *Kala Jadu* — You never know why, but LOP still works. true.

We call this fraction: '*Useful*'

Note:

- ❖ Tolerance for each fraction: ± 1
- ❖ *Useful* ones may change faces from exam to exam.
- ❖ Humans will betray, but mathematics won't. So don't give up until you are knocked on the last door.

II. Data absorption

1. **T -9 Hrs:** For everyone else, it's bedtime. For you, it's time to mug up all that you have collected.

Memory Palace Technique (MPT):

- I learned this technique during my 7th semester in college when Akash was trying to explain how some super genius detective in some TV show uses it to remember stuff. Amidst the simultaneous burden of GATE preparation and Semester exams, it was the perfect solution.
- I researched the method thoroughly — It was originally called the *Loci* Method and could be dated back to the Ancient Roman & Greek Civilizations — 2000 years later, college students would use it to pass semester exams.
- The technique connects your *Surface Memory* to *Core Memories* by making weird and memorable stories about physical pathways or real-life events.
- I was shocked to see high scores in semester exams by studying just 24 hours before the exams.
- The method helps you memorize giant paragraphs and extensive derivations line by line, which is what college exams are all about.

Limitation:

- My brain was limited to 10-12 memory palaces — One per question.
 - Make too many, and the stories will start intersecting — You won't be able to find the key, i.e., Start/Opening-Thread/Entrance to a particular memory palace
 - From experience, I had found that 2 out of 10 memory palaces would betray
- This meant that, in the worst-case scenario, it would bring my marks below 50 — the final nail in the coffin was the chits.

Chits:

- It was an unfair world, and I aimed to be an ISRO scientist, not a saint.
- The same memory pathways were written on small pieces of paper.
- Use micro handwriting.
- Tuck only one in one pocket — One answer in one chit, so you know where is what

In the end, the strategy worked fine for all exams but one.

2nd February 2018, 9:45 am | SCAR Academy

I was in the exam hall — Last bench. Simar entered 5 minutes later and started searching for her seat. With each mismatch, she was one step closer until she found her roll number written on the desk right in front of mine,

"Fuck my Luck!" I screamed in my head while I pretended to be busy studying the wood of my desk.

Five minutes later, the king of nerds walked into the class smiling at Simar. She smiled back and gave him a wave... A good one.

"Good luck!" Sumit wished her.

"Oh yeah! Good luck, you fucking geek! Who says that beyond the age of 5!?"

"Same to you, Suumiiiiittt!" she replied with a thumbs up and a smile... A bloody good one.

All of a sudden, those two started having a conversation. It was all whispery — I guessed they were talking about,

“Top 10 vegetarian starters.” or their good old,

“Hey, you see Ashwin sitting right there? Let’s pretend we don’t see him and try our best to make him jealous.”

For the next hour, during the exam, every time Simar asked Sumit for a pencil, I wanted her to pass it to me after use just so that I could stab Sumit with it in the fucking neck — Straight up, *John Wick* style. The dark one started posing some reasonable questions,

“You’ve written enough... The torture is too much. Why are you still sitting here?”

“How many marks have you answered?” the reasonable one asked.

“55, but I am feeling confident about them. Let’s get out of here. It burns real bad witnessing young kindergarten love among grown-ass adults.”, responded the dark side.

“No, dude. It’s not safe yet. You can at least answer 20 marks more.”, the reasonable side wanted me to reconsider.

That’s when Sumit turned back towards Simar and asked for an eraser — She passed it to him, but OOPS!! — the prodigal son couldn’t grab it — The eraser fell on the floor — Bounced a couple of times — Both broke into laughter.

You see? The eraser fell!! Isn’t that hilarious? Didn’t get it? Me neither.

“Now, do you agree that we should walk out?” the unreasonable side asked for reconsideration with a palm on his face.

“Yup! It’s not worth it. Let’s get the fuck out of here before we get a brain hemorrhage.” the reasonable side replied immediately.

I Slapped my paper on Bala’s chest — Dusted my shoulder, and said to myself,

“GATE better fucking work out.”

3rd Feb 2018, 7:00 a.m. | St. Anthony’s Technical University, Chembur, Mumbai

Early that morning, amongst the hustle of Mumbai, I got into a Local train. Ganesh was picking up his sister at the airport, so he clubbed with me. You are never getting a seat in the morning rush hours. Ganesh and I oscillated — Resonating at compound frequency of the bogie — With the fulcrums at our toes.

“So? Rank 1 now, huh!” I said.

“Yeah, but gotta maintain it, *you know*... Every night, I feel like Himanshu is breathing down my neck... He wakes me up early in the morning, *you know*... There’s a target on my back.”

“Damn, bro... For a second, I thought you were sleeping with him.”

“Shut up, dude... What about you?... If you take the Academy seriously after today, you can easily knock 5 people ahead of you.”

“I know... Them bitches never got to see what happens if someone like me steps a foot in. I mean... Look what Dipesh could do with his work ethic.”

“Don’t even get me started on that... *You know*... You and Dipesh are polar opposites!”

“How is that? I work pretty hard too... It’s just in another direction.”

“I am not questioning that... You probably work harder than him, *you know*... He, at least, goes every night to the canteen to enjoy his *Rasogulla* and takes walks with his friends on weekends... I am saying he is an obedient, good kid... an ideal student... I never see that happening with you... Dipesh and You are the specimens of DOs and DON’Ts at SCAR Academy, respectively... You know.”

“I disagree with the ‘respectively’ part.” I said.

We bifurcated our ways at my station. The exam center was a huge complex — Well built — Well organized — Thousands of young graduates standing in queues with their admit cards in hand — Hoping today to be the day their lives changed. Some were chanting their holy prayers, some were revising their notes, and some running through books. GATE 2018 started exactly at 9:00 a.m. IST all across the country.

Pattern:

- 65 questions
- 180 minutes.
- +2 and -0.66 for 35 questions
- +1 and -0.33 for 30 questions
- Attempt needed: 60+

My strategy:

1. **Wave-1:** Lasts around 30–40 minutes. Solve the easiest questions in this. Then, move to Aptitude & English questions (Total: 10) in the *Non-Tech Break* (10-15 minutes) to give me mental fluctuation. If you find a question too complicated, or too consuming, or if there's a solution you are unsure of, leave it for the next wave (*Marked-for-Review*). This would gather me confidence to blast through the known but calculation-intensive questions prone to mistakes in Wave-2.
2. **Wave-2:** last the longest (About 90 minutes). The *Marked-for-Review* and *Pron Mistake* questions will be solved here.
3. With around 40 minutes on the clock, I would exterminate the questions that no one has ever seen before in the **Topper's Wave** and still have some time to revise and confirm my answers. This would create the difference and land me straight at Rank 100.

"Everybody has a Plan until they get Punched in the Mouth."

- Mike Tyson

A few aptitude questions stumbled me — A few questions staggered me in the *Wave-2* — *Topper's Wave* got less than 10 minutes which meant that my revision plans took a hike — I could solve only 2 anomalous questions and couldn't give a second attempt to 5 questions which were marked for review. At 12:00 p.m. IST, 59 attempted questions were lodged in the history books — Not much different from my 2017 attempt.

I was experienced enough to know that GATE 2018 was not my ticket out of the swamp I was in. I would have analyzed my mistakes in that exam to work on my weakness, but why would I? Nothing was coming up, and I began considering giving up on competitive exams altogether. For the first time, it was a dead end. It was clear now that even if you give your 100% and risk it all, it still might not be sufficient to change your destiny. At least I had seen the monarchy of fate in first person and would never regret not questioning it. I could not sleep that night — 8:00 a.m. I smoked some weed in hopes that it would help me sleep. But instead, it played the compilation tape of the most horrifying possible words at this moment,

"Hyper Skill is a twin to talent...", "... either I'll get all or none", "... It's impossible along with Academy burden.", "Maybe they didn't prepare that seriously."

Each of these kicked my brain and body like a *Muay Thai* Professional would kick a banana tree — Each one sounded like the sound of a giant gong — Each louder than the last,

“I will snatch it...”, “I’ll do what I want to do with or without you...”, “The world doesn’t work like that. Pick one.”, “If you want the liberty of choices, be ready for the responsibility of consequences...”

All those ideas which convinced me that I took a path better than others now made me feel like I had scammed myself.

“How foolish am I? Did I swindle myself into believing that I could change my life?!” I asked myself.

Mechanical Engineering Rankings at the End of 2 Quarters:

1. Sumit Timewala
2. Adil Khan
3. Ashutosh Rana
4. Kunal Kapoor
5. Kabir Ram
6. Rohit Kerketta
7. Mahinder Pratap
8. Gyan Kumar
9. Nishant Sharma

10. Varun Jaiswal
11. Chandan Sahu
12. Ashwin Taksh

Drowning in a colloidal black solution of negativity and misery, I tore every chart paper stuck on my wall, every self-written quote and array of formulas wherever my eyes could see. For the next 4 days, I walked the streets of SCAR like a ghost — Like a man searching for his lover in a graveyard. My walk no longer had the flick of an ego I wore so proudly just a month ago, nor did my eyes had that shine of vision. All that was replaced by a shudder of failure and hopelessness carried by the carcass of a boy who once believed he could do anything. Death of an ambition is the death of a man. The diet was off, the routine was scrapped, and *The Regiment* was in a junkyard. If all of that brought me to this, what was the point of it all? It was painful to see anyone having a good time. I felt wronged and had reached a point where everything hurt me. There used to be moments in the middle of a sunny day when everyone around me was cheerful, and I suddenly had an urge to cry out of nowhere. I would

run for an empty place and let out those tears which had rediscovered me and were now unstoppable.

8th February 2018, 6:30 pm | The Bridge, SCAR

As I was walking with no destination, I saw Simar and Sumit walking right in my direction — Laughing about something I'm sure was not funny at all — On *the bridge* where Simar had told me 5 months ago,

"...I'm here to work hard..." and, *"...nothing can happen between us..."*

As they came closer, Sumit pretended as if he couldn't see me, but Simar looked straight into my eyes — With the same steadiness that I had looked into hers the day I submitted my ISRO application in September — Just before I was about to roll my eyes down in surrender,

"Don't you fucking look down! You did what you wanted to. You walked the walk, and that is a lot more than what these two ever did. To Realize your worth, you don't need the attestation of GATE, you don't need the Judgment of ISRO, and you definitely don't need the approval of Simar!"

I might have lost every battle I fought, but I had won the respect of myself for me, which meant that the war must go on. I glared into her eyes till she looked away and continued to chuckle with Sumit. Both of them walked past me. They might have forgotten that moment in an hour, but for me, that day, seeing those two together at *the bridge* brought my feet back.

"You still got it, you fucker!" that voice laughed hard and continued,

"This is what you are to your bloody core! You fight; that's what you do. You fight as long as you exist. You will find something or the other to fight for. We are back in business motherfuckers! Whoooo!! Watch out!"

When I reached back to #804, Mahi was already there, sitting on my bed with my bong in his hand. The apprehension on his face was unmistakable as he said,

"What's going on, bro? You don't go to classes anymore, I haven't seen you in mess, and I heard you talking to yourself last night at 2:00 a.m... You have terrible dark circles under your eyes, and you left weed out in the open in a room that's unlocked! Do you know what'll happen if *KGB* finds this?"

Understanding his concerns, I said with a smile,

“You know I practice speaking sometimes, and bro, when the fuck have I ever attended classes?” I chuckled.

“Yeah, but at fucking 2:00 a.m.?!? Also, you don’t punch in anymore. Sudha was saying that she would deduct a week of your stipend. Bala was looking for you. He asked everyone about your whereabouts. When he came to me, even I didn’t know. I told him that you are sick. I knew he would barge into your room to find you, and guess what condition you left it in? This can not only get you thrown out but straight into jail!”

“Thanks, man. But they can keep their stupid stipend. Doesn’t look like I’m gonna need it anymore.” I replied with a sigh.

“Ashwin... GATE is a gamble. We all know that. Let it go. There are other exams coming up.”

“Like what? SCAR? Maybe I should appear again and restart the Academy in August.”

“I heard BIS is organizing an exam.”

“What the fuck is that?”

“Bureau of Indian Standards. It’s a scientist post as well.”

“See, bro... we both know that SCAR is better than any ‘*What the fuck is that?*’. So I’m not appearing in any random exams just for the sake of a job.”

“Bro, it’s pretty obvious that if you stay here, you’ll go down south in August. ‘*What the fuck is that?*’ is better than that. Posting is in Delhi. Give it a try. If not, I believe you can still beat Chandan and Nishant to save your posting.”

“Well, I have no interest in participation certificates. And don’t worry, I’ll find a way out... I’m considering putting forward my Resignation from NEA. Sooner better than later. The longer I stay, larger the bond payback amount.”

“The fuck?! And do what?”

“Don’t know, bro. I’m still figuring it out.”

“You crazy fuck! There are about 20 missed calls from your mother! Fucking talk to her! She must be terrified. Maybe she can knock some sense into you.” he said anxiously.

I took the bong off his hand and threw the water in the sink.

“I will, bro... I will... I’m making coffee, you want?”

He didn’t say anything.

“Hey dude, stop worrying... I’ll be in class tomorrow. Not only to punch in but also attend like the good student I am... Look, I was just a little fucked up, that’s all. We’ve all been there. But I’m back.”

“Ok. Make it strong. No sugar. And hide the weed.” He said as he took my packet of weed out of his pocket and tossed it to me.

I grabbed it — Walked to the washroom — Flushed it down the toilet, and said,

“Shit’s not good when your life sucks. Makes it worse.”

The next day I restarted *The Regiment* to clear the fog in my brain. I decided to go back to the Academy only to find that Sudha was having a meltdown because of me. I was chewed off with an hour-long lecture, which was very well justified. She said something along the lines of,

“You can get restigated... *la-la-la-la*- You are ruining your career *la-la-la-la*-.”

Which I responded with appropriate placements of, “Hmmm.... No... oh... ok.” while I wondered how she’d react when I dropped the resignation letter as soon as I figured out how to survive without this job.

10th February 2018, 9:30 am | STH Mess, SCAR

That morning, I woke up at 5:30 am with a single aim: To find what to do with my life. After returning from the gym and post breakfast in solitude, I was walking out of the mess when Chandan passed by me.

“Hey bro, you filled out the ISRO form?” Chandan asked from behind.

I turned around and said,

“Yeah, dude. The exam was a month ago.” I said casually.

“Yeah. No shit. I’m talking about the latest notification.”

“Huh?”

“You don’t know? It came out yesterday evening. 40 seats.”

“Bro, that was the September notification. You must be tripping.”

“No, you moron! The exam is in April 2-0-1-8. Sumit told me. He...”

The rest of what he said was entirely ignored by my eardrums. I watched his mouth move, but with my pupil dilated and goosebumps invading my nervous system, the only words I heard were,

“And all of it might still be possible.”

I turned and ran towards the 8th-floor lift. Climbing up the stairs, I said,

“Fuck yeah! This is all we needed!! This exam is made for us.” in an empty staircase... to the stairs, the wall on my right and of course the staircase handle on my left... All three of them combined had zero ears.

The examination was on April 22nd, 2018. Until then, there was no time to quit NEA and worry about survival. Possessed, I immediately started to analyze my GATE 2018 attempt. That night after preparing my plan, I slept like a baby. The next day when I reached class, I got another big news: The rest of our training was going to be in FBRC Vishvenpuram, home of the second phase reactors of NEA — Supposedly the future of Nuclear Power in India.

Chapter 6

You Do Get a Replay in Life

11th March 2018, 7:44 a.m. | FBRC Vishvenpuram, Tamil Nadu

“Man! This place sucks! I’d hate it if I get posted here...” said a frustrated Mahi as we walked towards our new hostel. He continued to vent with his non-stop rant that begun at the Chennai Train Station early that morning,

“... It’s a 100 fucking kilometers from the closest major city, no *Domino’s*, no *KFC*, no *PVR*, and no fucking North Indian Food!! Nobody understands Hindi or even much of English, and I can’t understand shit written on the street signs and buses.”

Tamil Nadu is a rare state of India — Located on the South-East coast of the Peninsula, it is 100% self-sufficient and populates a proud *Tamil* crowd who loves their language more than anything. If you want to test it, Walk into a random grocery store in Tamil Nadu and say,

“It is fair that Hindi is India’s official language and Tamil is not.”

You’ll either end up retreating or end up dying. So naturally, Tamil Nadu is a state which speaks and understands the least *Hindi*. All the road signs and banners had Tamil Texts. Even the destination tags on buses were in Tamil, so you’ll never know whether a bus will take you toward or farther from your destination. In such a case, you can always ask the Tamil dude next to you about where it’s going. You can ask in *English* and get to your destination, or you can ask in *Hindi* and probably end up catching the bus moving in the opposite direction. Tamilians, in general, love *Tamil*, tolerate *English* and hate *Hindi*. It’s funny how you can travel 6700 km North-West to London — A different country — A different continent and understand the language, but if you travel 2200 km South in India, the language would be alien.

I couldn't care less however, neither about the state nor about Mahi's bitch *KFC* problems. What I had in my head was a constant marination of planning and strategy of how I was going to crack ISRO — Mistakes I made in the past, what I learned from them, and how to make sure that they don't repeat. The temperature in south was higher, the climate was more humid, and the facilities dialed down severely compared to Mumbai. Adjusting there would definitely be a hurdle in my way to ISRO, but it was not like my situation was very supportive of my preparation prior to this.

16th March 2018, 5:15 p.m.| FBRC Trainees Hostel (FTH)

To save myself from the jolt, I assumed my rank in GATE 2018 would be beyond 3000. When I saw the actual result, my AIR was 2160. It was still worse than last year's, but I had come to an agreement that this exam sucked at judging improvements. I closed the lid of my laptop and walked to the mess. Since Visveshpuram, unlike Mumbai, had no shortage of space, our new trainee's hostel mess was more spacious — It had two options: You could either sit inside in one out of the two halls, or you could sit outside and enjoy the scenic beauty just 200 meters from the *Bay of Bengal*. The halls and the patio had two tables each — Each table surrounded by 12 chairs. I chose to sit outside whenever the place was isolated. Every sip of that coffee, though it still was majorly composed of sugar, water and brown color, tasted better under the sky until,

"So, bro!! Did you top in GATE? Heard the results are out." asked Kunal as he passed by me.

"Nah man." I said as I took a sip.

"So what's your rank? Single digit?" he asked as he took a seat in front of me (For the first time in 8 months).

"2160." I said and took another sip.

"Rank 60! Congrats, man!" he said

"Thanks, man... But my rank is Two Thousand One Hundred and Sixty." I said.

"Get out of here, dude!! Stop kidding." he laughed only to get none in return.

I took the last sip, exhaled, and said,

“Score 735. Marks 71. Gotta go, dude. See you. Nice chatting.” I said — Knocked the steel cup on the table and got up to leave.

As I got up, I turned straight into Rohit, walking with a giant smile. He hard-braked and asked with excitement,

“Ashwin *Bhai*!! Under 100 or under 10?”

“Under 10,000 *bhai*. AIR 2160.” I answered with a smile.

Simar passed by, along with Vaishnavi looking straight at me. They stopped and stood behind Kunal beside the plants.

“What?! How’s that possible *bhai*?” asked Rohit in an unjustified shock.

“Dude, I said 2160. Not *Minus* 60. It’s entirely fucking possible.” I said, maintaining my smile.

“So... What are you going to do now, man?” asked Ashu from behind while both the girls stood there still.

What I was going to do was smash their faces on the God Damn pavement for ruining that perfect coffee under the blue sky. But Instead, I said,

“Will see.” and walked away from the media.

They all must have seen me ramping even further since January. GATE was a more popular exam anyway, hence more eyes. I don’t know if one year of Government job made them forget about the reality of these exams or if they were just trying to fuck with me. When I saw the result, my first thought was,

“When they ask my rank, I’ll simply lie about it. Say AIR 600 or so. They’d never find out, and it’ll save me the humiliation.” But then I thought,

“If they hold the power to humiliate me without even stepping into the ring, then I have a bigger problem to worry about. What I did was my decision, and win or lose, I will wear the result with pride. Let the world react the way it is designed to — If for nothing, I’ll learn to react to reality.”

I later discovered that Rohit and Adil didn’t even qualify GATE 2018. There were a couple of others in Academy who had appeared and performed horribly, but all of them did so in secrecy. That same day, Adil gave up on his ESE ambitions, and Rohit gave up on his ISRO ambitions. It was like a highly contagious viral

infection spreading all around me, causing people to crush their dreams and throw them in a can.

Safety is a bribe you take in exchange for the freedom of choice. The general mentality goes,

“Let’s keep the job I have now. Who knows if I’m going to get a better one?”

It gets worse when they choose their partners in a similar way. People compromise to stay safe, and in doing so, they sell their souls wrapped in their ambitions — Turning into those bots that do what they are told to — To keep their miserable existence ‘Safe’. When they witness their life tumble, they compromise some more, as that’s what they are trained to do. Lost in this maze, thinking they are on the right path and unaware of the strings controlling every step they take — One day, they would wake up with their hair gone, their tummy out, a shitty bickering relationship with cheating a partner, and with a bottle in their hand they would wonder,

“Why did it happen to me? I did everything right!”

No, sir! You just did everything you were told to do. You lost your identity, and after 35 years, that same cycle has happily replaced you with fresh 22-year-olds — It’ll try its best to make good bots out of them as well — Using the same piece of cheese they call ‘Bait’ and you call ‘Safety’. It’s funny how Consequences follow both by taking and avoiding choices.

Meanwhile, taking a look at my consequences: I had Rs 70,000 in my bank account and had accumulated Rs 2,50,000 of bond amount so far — Was at the bottom of the Academy — I had been repeatedly rejected by every girl I liked, and every job I wanted — Not one person close to me. Broke, single, unemployed, and alone. But why is it then that I felt more in control than ever? I thought Control marches on the drum beats of Power. Maybe I had been thinking wrong. I was already a loser in everyone’s eyes, and thus, for the first time, I had no burden to impress anyone. All I knew was that *“It is Possible”* — For me to become an ISRO scientist — For everyone to be wrong and for me to be correct. We underestimate events with low probability too much. We should not — For *it is possible* for it to occur, and as low as the chances might be, once it does, its probability shoots to 1. If you are trying to do something that the world brands insane for even considering, you are operating in undiscovered territories. This is the domain that

makes the heroes you look up to — What turns humans with the same flesh and blood as you into what you see as Gods. This is the domain that changes lives from slums to royalty — Turns midgets into giants — Outcasts into leaders. This is what the world works on, and they are the ones who made the world around you.

It was only here that I realized that the chains to impress Simar and to prove myself to my colleagues were something that I was still subconsciously tied to. Invisible layers of shackles, camouflaged brilliantly to make us believe down to our core that they don't exist.

“The perfect slavery is where the slaves believe they are free.”

GATE result injured me, but I was experienced enough to know that it could all be turned into a net positive. I also knew that I was not the only one to experience the bitter medicine of GATE. This happens to tens of thousands every year. The only difference, they did not have my perspective. And so I picked up my cell phone and changed it. I recorded my strategy for SCAR 2017 and uploaded it on Youtube.

The layout of the Trainees Hostel at Vishvenpura was different. Unlike Santacruz, where all trainees were placed in the same building in individual rooms, here we were provided with single floored 2BHK government quarters to be occupied in pairs. Basically, it was employee housing, and we were supposed to pretend it was a hostel. Naturally, me and Mahi paired up. We were assigned Quarter #59. The boy's side of the quarters was separated from the girl's side by the FTH mess and library in between. Vishvenpura was crazy hot, and even in March, my room used to get so heated that I would wake up every morning with my mattress soaked in my sweat. Kind of like Delhi summers aided with extreme humidity. But no matter how bad the situation gets, you can always find a way out — No matter how good it gets, you can always find an excuse to not do your best. The heat helped me wake up early and embark on that day's respective workout. The fear of losing again lit a fire up my ass so hard that I would be running by 6:00 am. Getting introduced to the basics of *Rocket Propulsion* for the first time. Every morning, to save 10 minutes of my time, I would use a shortcut by jumping off a fence. The problem was that the shortcut was through the Girl's hostel, guarded by a middle-aged man sleeping on a chair right in front of the mess. Rule was that boys cannot go past the mess into the girl's region.

“Stupid rule.” You would say.

That's what I would say every morning — Sprint and jump off the fence. Why should girls get to use the shortcut and not me? Right?

The landing, if not done correctly, would wake the guard up, who then would shout something in *Tamil*. Being the optimistic lad I am, I would assume that he was shouting,

“Wow! What a jump!! You look so handsome *tambi*. I bet Simar wakes up every morning and waits by the window to see you!”

By 8:00 am, when everyone else would be snoozing their alarms, I had already spent an hour sweating, had my self-made breakfast (oatmeal + coffee + bananas), and would be revising my notes.

3rd Midterms: 2nd - 20th April 2018

1.	31st March	SCAR 2018 - Written Test
2.	2 nd April	Seismic Design
3.	4 th April	Pressure Vessel Design
4.	9 th April	Sodium Technology
5.	11 th April	Fast Breeder Reactor Design
6.	16 th April	Computational Fluid Dynamics (CFD)- II
7.	18 th April	Automation & Controls
8.	20 th April	Vivas
9.	22nd April	ISRO-ICRB 2018

I had applied for the SCAR 2018 written test to warm me up for the ISRO exam. To my surprise, my YouTube video had thrusted to 15,000 views so far. It was a new world I was getting introduced to — The online one — Where people from thousands of miles away can see you and get your ideas. The comments of praise and requests for further videos were overwhelming. It was the first time someone working in a Government Organization shared pure information about how others could get in too. I would have never imagined that years of rehearsing my speaking skills could be used to talk to thousands over the Internet.

31st March 2018 | Shiksha College of Technology, Chennai | SCAR 2018 written test

I took a bus from Vishvenpuram bus stand for Chennai, got off at *Madhya Kailash* bus stop, and took an auto to the exam center. Even though thousands watched me over the internet to prepare for the same exam, surprisingly, none recognized me. Thankfully, the Internet, at least till that point, was just a tiny subset of the real world. I also knew at least one scientist from SCAR would be in the examination hall as an invigilator. To my favor, I skipped most of the classes — Those I attended because of the unavailability of empty classrooms; I did so with my head buried deep in my notes like a God Damn ostrich. So the probability of a SCAR scientist who could identify me being the invigilator was extremely low. And then he entered the hall — Around 6 feet tall — Curly hair and happier than I would be after fucking *Gigi Hadid* — His teeth whiter than God's halo. It was Dr. Suresh P.S., wearing the badge of SCAR above his chest pocket, smiling at every student while distributing the rough sheets.

"No matter how low the probability, until and unless it's an impossible event, there's always a chance of occurrence, and when it does, its probability shoots to 1." I gulped as I cursed my own principle.

As he looked in my direction, his eyebrows sank closer. He kept walking, distributing the sheets, and as he moved closer, I intentionally dropped my pen and leaned down when it was his turn to pass the sheet on my desk. I heard him saying, "All the best, son."

Sharp at 10:00 am, the exam started, and my mind dove into the dimension of Mechanical Engineering. Back arched straight — Shoulders wide — Ass planted on the chair — Eyes ruthlessly paying attention to every pixel on the computer screen. My mind constantly scanned thousands of concepts residing in my brain. It selectively screened the ones applicable to the questions one by one. In the first wave, by the first 20 questions, I had judged that the question paper was easier than usual. Cut-off would rise, and so would the required attempts. Following was the classic pattern of SCAR online exam:

- Total no. of questions: 100
- Marks awarded for every correct answer: + 3
- Marks awarded for every wrong answer: -1

- Marks awarded for every unattempted question: 0
- Time allotted: 120 minutes
- Usual Cut-off: 100-120 out of 300

My SACR 2017 attempt:

- Attempted questions: 50
- Score: 120
- Cut off: 111.

My SCAR 2018 on-spot analysis:

- Required attempt: 60
- Expected cut-off: 150

I took another look at Suresh. Motherfucker was still smiling. His happiness almost fucks with you. You are bound to question,

“Am I living my life wrong? Why can’t I be that happy? What handjob techniques does his wife use every morning?”

If the kind of question paper I saw that day appeared in 2017, I wouldn’t even be in SCAR. But,

“Man never crosses the same river twice. For It is not the same river, he is not the same man.”

— Heraclitus

I knew the demand for speed and accuracy would be much higher for ISRO. So that’s what I had majorly focused on since April 2018 — Solving questions rigorously — At least 300 a day. The more you do it, the better you get at it. I was ready with speed along with accuracy, and that day, for the first time, I played offensive — On the front foot. By the end of those 120 minutes, I could attempt 62 questions, making me dead sure that I made it.

3:00 pm, at *Madhya Kailash* Bus Stand, I got on a crooked bus — The windows were rusty, and the seats were bare metal. For the next 3 hours, my skinny ass with no natural cushion bounced on that steel seat with no artificial cushion. If a Harder metal hits against a softer metal, the dent will always be on the softer one. This is

what I learned that day when I got off at the Vishvenpuram Bus stand. Along the way, while getting a forced physiotherapy, sitting next to a sweaty old man, a few questions came across my mind, and the answers were pivotal,

“What was different with this exam? I never got this kind of feeling after the past ISRO, ESE or GATE exams. Why now? Why did I play offensive now?”

I wanted to answer these questions because I wanted it to be repeated in the upcoming ISRO Exam. I realized that up until GATE 2018, I was always playing it safe — I had never completely let go of the Academy. Somewhere in the back of my mind, I considered that once GATE was done, I could return and improve my ranking in the March exams. It was only after the GATE 2018 exam that I had to make a decision: Either SCAR or ISRO. That choice made all the difference. I had reached a point of “FUCK IT”.

“If you choose to take a risk, do it properly — If you are letting it go, leave it completely — You can not half-ass Risk.”

With my decision to go for ISRO the third time — Despite the Academy rankings — Despite the failures in past exams — I had crossed the Rubicon. Now, for the first time, it felt like I was not rowing against the tide. Most people choose not to fight at all for what they want — The few that do, do so with one hand tied in their back with what they need and one foot touching the exit with a Plan B — Fewer have the guts to completely let go. Those are the ones who become free enough to utilize their full-potential — Anything less is not good enough.

It is essential to understand that you cannot control what will happen next — Life is uncertain. You don't become safer by controlling what happens to you but by learning how to deal with what happens to you. We are in the midst of a whirlwind, and the path for you to reach where you want to be is not only undefined, it doesn't exist. When you let go, you plunge yourself into the world of uncertainty — The only way you learn to deal with randomness.

“In all this randomness, the genius is the one who embraces it.”

Most people do one of the two:

1. Deny randomness and pretend that events occur in a predictable, steady stream guided by destiny. Or,

2. Accept the randomness and curl up for the rest of their lives from a Wave never passes.

The best you can do is learn to ride it. Expect the unexpected and face it. Either you'll deal with it or get better at dealing with situations that life throws at you.

With these infant ideas solidifying my faith in my path, I returned to NEA soil for the first time a winner. But the job was not done yet. A day later, on 2nd April, the midterms returned and brought with them, as expected, ruthlessly sleepless nights.

15th April 2018 | FTH, Vishvenpuram

The day before the CFD-II exam. Just passing wasn't going to do it for this one. I needed 80/100. Remember CFD-I? Yeah, I regretted walking out when I found out my score: 20/100. Every year the Academy calls a professor from IIT Madras to teach CFD. The previous one retired last year, and there was a delay in Government paperwork to assign a new faculty. Because of all the delay, CFD superimposed both 2nd & 3rd quarters. Mahi explained that CFD had its midterms in the 2nd quarter and will be having its finals in the 3rd quarter midterms. Point is, I still had a shot at passing CFD by getting an 80. Computational Fluid Dynamics was actually my area of interest and specialization. In my final semester of B.Tech, I even published a paper on 6-Cylinder Internal Combustion engines where the temperature and flow study calculations were done using CFD. The problem was that I had skipped every class here in the Academy. So, for the first time, I dedicated an entire day to an Academy exam. I started studying early that morning only to find out that everything seemed Greek to me. 2 years had made me rusty, and the professor had used his own notations, which made it impossible for me to understand what he taught via his presentation slides alone. This had gone way past the level I could handle. By 12:00 pm, I had understood that I needed help. So I decided to go out hunting — By 3:00 p.m., I conceded that not only me but even the toppers could not comprehend what the hell was taught and what would be asked. A new faculty was always terrible news as it squanders all PYQs. By 5:00 p.m., I began to consider the reality that I might not be able to pass after all. By 8:00 p.m., I had made two more circuits across every Chemical Engineer & Mechanical Engineer in my batch. I ended up getting a few hints about what questions were expected based on a few legit nerds who noted down every breath

that old hag took in class. Everyone was studying books this time. Many trainees figured out the questions but didn't know the exact answer, so they worked in groups to understand the subject using 5-10 different books — This was the closest the Academy had ever come to actual learning. By 12:00 am, I had gathered probable questions worth 150 marks along with their solutions. In my head though, I was still at absolute zilch, and so I still needed to go through the data I had collected.

Boycotted Mahi, sadly, didn't have this option. They believed that keeping him in any group was like nurturing a parasite around, which would inevitably devour the host itself. It was appalling to see Mahi with his hair tied back — Sitting on the floor with 5 books scattered around him — Surrounded by dozens of Xerox sheets — Trying to just pass the exam. I gave all those 150 marks to him. Out of which he had already figured out 100.

“I knew those fuckers would never help me out. So I paid attention in class.” He said and gave me 50 more marks that he had gathered from Varun, Nishant & Rohit.

“Those three don't gel with any other trainees as well... ever since the Nishant thing.” he said.

“What thing?” I asked.

So far, I thought I held the position of *Daring-Dumb Champion* of the Academy because I asked Simar out on a date the first time I talked to her. But this story that Mahi told me relinquished my *Title*. Nishant, on the second day of Academy — Walks into the girls' wing — All suited up — With a rose tucked in his jacket — Saturated in perfume — Kicks open Simar's door like *James Bond* — Finds Simar sitting with 4 other girls — Who probably were gossiping about my colossal dick — And asked them all out for a motherfucking *Gol Gappa* party — Stating that it's his birthday. Poor girls couldn't refuse for 3 reasons:

1. It was his birthday.
2. Nishant was all dressed up.
3. Girls can never say no to *Gol Gappas*.

Nishant spent Rs 200 with him in a Rs 2000 suit, and the girls munching *Gol Gappas* in their pajamas for 30 minutes without saying a word.

“What. The. Fuck?” was my immediate reaction. I felt fortunate as I realized that life could be much worse than just failing in CFD.

“What the fuck is right bro...” said Mahi as he continued,

“... But the problem is that the girls talked of it with Ashu and Sumit when they formed their cozy little cult. Those two chumps talked of it with K-3. In the last week of September, when you were lost in books, their group straight-up roasted Nishant publicly on the bus. Nishant never talked to neither the girls nor the boys after that day. Rohit and Varun decided to keep their distance from these assholes as well.”

So it wasn't UPSC. This was the reason for Nishant's Isolation. It pissed me off. Nishant at least took a step toward friendship, whatever the reasons might be. Matter of fact, I feel that I still retain the *Title*. He at least started with socializing. According to my cartoon imagination, I was probably planning to be in bed with Simar that very night. There's no doubt that Nishant should have done better, but making fun of him publicly is just cruel. What he did was still better than the pathetic politics that Ashu and Sumit had been playing for the past 8 months. Nishant, Rohit and Varun agreed, so they did not obey the sanctions on Mahi by the superpowers. Actually, they came up with a few solutions that even Sumit, Kabir and Ashu couldn't. However, there were also some topics that these four hadn't covered that the other squads had. I now had 200 marks worth of material, using which it was perfectly possible to get 80. It was time to use the *Memory Palace* for the next 2 hours — Go to sleep for 1.5 hours — Revise till I enter the exam hall at 10:00 am and secure my Stipend & Degree.

But only God's favorites get sleep a day before college exams. At 2:00 a.m., I found myself still at the mid-course. By 6:00 a.m., I had memorized around 170 marks, but now my head was spinning like a *BeyBlade* with unsymmetric weight distribution. So I decided to take a walk. With *Mariana Bo* playing in my earphones, I somehow guided my legs to move in a straight path. Just behind our quarters was a *Kendriya Vidyalaya* Playground, on the right side of which was a 20-foot tall wall, and on its other side was the *Bay of Bengal*. I walked towards the wall — A couple of stray dogs followed me — I Climbed the stairs to reach the top of the walls — A strong wind blew my hair over my eyes — I felt the humidity both in my hands and my hair as I plowed my hair back to take a good look at the view. Fisherman boats on the right — The dome of the Vishvenpuram Fast Breeder

Reactor (VFBR) far on my left — The vast horizon right in front of me reminded me of how small I was. I climbed down towards the beach — Took my slippers in my hands — My feet felt the fine beach sand and the welcoming warmth. The beach has an inherent property to wipe away the bullshit from your life. As my eyes gazed at the glittery surface of Earth, I forgot about all the mess in my life and plunged myself into a thought bubble,

“However bad it gets, we’ll find a way out. We’ll deal with it. I’m looking at another world with Billions of lives. Would I ever care about what happens in the life of any particular one of them? Most certainly, none of them will care about whether I turn out to be a disastrous failure or a skyrocketing success. What’s the worst that can happen? If I fail at ISRO for the third time and SCAR throws me out — I’ll deal with it. Maybe I’ll find another way to study Rocket Engines. Maybe I’ll try a new career. Maybe I’ll try to become a Barista... Why not?... Coffee is such a mysterious drink... about 2 years down the line of me, working as a Barista, my father would still be asking me to crack the Engineering Services Exam. I’ll ignore his world-taught wisdom just like I rightfully do today. Who knows... Maybe I’ll try to become the best Barista in this world... Maybe I’ll even fail at that.... But you know what? None of those sharks in the Bay of Bengal would ever give a shit. If I took a dive now, the sharks would eat me up, no matter if I am a Scientist or a Barista. Nobody remembers the second man on the Moon? Failures are not remembered? Failures are ignored? Losers don’t matter? Well, this has a bright side: If you fail, people will forget about you pretty quick — That means they’ll forget about your failure too. I wonder why people are so afraid to fail then? I wonder why then, they are so afraid to go for what they really want? You are literally getting Millions of free opportunities to fail. Life is like a video game after all — You do get a Replay Button in Life. You can fail in a hundred attempts at it, and it was never lodged in the history books — You only have to win once, and that will be recognized — Pretty fair if you ask me.”

After a month of living 500 meters away from the East Coast, I saw the sunrise for the first time. Its beauty reminded me of my mother’s oil paintings. It’s outstanding that most people live the majority of their lives without taking a second to look around and admire the beauty. It gave me hope that someday the Sun would rise in my life as well. Those 15 minutes of staring at the horizon did more for me than an 8 hours of sound sleep could ever have.

At 6:20 a.m., I decided to return to my CFD preparation. Till now, although I always carried chits, I had never used them. Despite its limitations, my Memory

Palaces stood firm to get me 50 marks. But this time, 80 was the requirement. Instead of getting back inside, I climbed on the roof of #59 to create the last few memory palaces. The advantage was that not only I had never made a palace there, but I had never even been there. When I got to the top, I found that my roof was connected to Nishant & Rohit's roof, which was connected to the following and similarly all the way till Ganesh's roof — A total of 4 quarters. For the next 2 hours, I made memory palaces, walking from my roof to Ganesh's and back again.

At 8:30, I returned back down, Mahi was awake, and as he saw me entering through the back door, he asked,

“Full night again?”

“Yup.”

“How do you manage, bro? I tried with just 4 hours of sleep one night and felt like I was gonna puke.”

“Practice. All prepared?”

“Naah, man... but I scored 92 on the first paper, so it's fine. You sir, on the other hand, have a tough day ahead. I'll make some coffee for you.”

As he entered the kitchen, I entered my room and made 9 chits. Two back pockets in my jeans, two side pockets, two in the ankle jeans folds, one on my chest pocket, and two in the folded sleeves of my shirt. Each chit consisted of 5-10 marks. I drank a cup of coffee and left for the mess. When I reached there, I saw *Chole-Poori* bathed in refined oil being served. Sleep for 9 hours like a prince — Eat *Chole-Poori*, and you'll instantly feel sleepy again. For someone who had not slept in 27 hours, it was poison. And so, with an empty stomach and pocket full of chits, I took the bus to Academy.

As usual, at the entry gate of FBRC, we got off the bus to get ourselves security scanned for any flash drives, CDs, DVDs, Floppys, sharp tools, knives, guns, atom bombs, black holes, or anything that could potentially destroy the research center and compromise National Security. I'll never forget that straight path to the entry gate of FBRC — Well guarded by CISF — Dogs sniffing the bus that we came in — Us passing through the metal detectors — Our bags being scanned layer by layer — Me struggling to keep my eyes off Simar's ass — And finally on the other side of the gate boarding the bu... *BEEP! BEEP! BEEP!* The scanner made a noise a few seconds after I passed the metal detector.

“Who the fuck is dumb enough to bring electronic stuff in their bag?! That too on the exam day!... When we can’t afford delays!!” frustrated I thought.

“Hey, we need to check that.” a female CISF personnel pointed at my bag as I attempted to pick it up.

“Naah... It was one of the bags behind mine.” I said

“We need to check them all.”

One by one, all bags were scanned again. And after a couple of minutes, looking at me, she said,

“It looks like there’s a laptop charger in your bag. You’ll need to submit it.”

“Fuuuck! I forgot to take it out after I returned from the library last night!!” I screamed and murdered myself multiple times in my head.

I went to the library last night to download my own Paper. After I returned to my room, I took out the laptop but left the charger there.

“Hurry up, Ashwin!! We can’t afford delays on the exam day!” shouted Rohit.

Everyone else stared at me but was not surprised at all that I would be the one pulling off shit like this on the day of exam.

“Fine, keep it with you. I’ll take it while returning.” I told her.

“You’ll have to submit it at the counter and get a receipt.” she replied, pointing towards the office with a poker face.

Understanding that time was limited and that it was useless explaining to these dummies that you can’t use a laptop charger to leak classified information about India’s Nuclear Program, I ran straight toward the counter. Standing in the queue, I saw two gentlemen in white *lungis* and white shirts — Angel level — Probably stolen from a *Nirma Washing Powder* advertisement set. I requested them to let me go first, explaining that I had an exam starting in less than 15 minutes — One of them responded with a gesture of straightening out all five fingers, bringing them close to his face, and oscillating that wrist multiple times with a noise of,

“ILLA ILLA maiii HURRRY.”

His friend remained expressionless, frozen like his ice-cold heart. What he said basically meant “No” in Tamil language, and what he did with his hand meant, “I

don't give a fuck" in universal language. I had a tormenting time seeing the Tamil guy explain to a Bihari CISF why he needed a pass for his 20th-century cell phone. By the time it was my turn, it was already 10:05 a.m., and then the CISF guy made me fill out a dozen forms before he could keep my charger in his custody.

"Keep it up, *bhaiya*! You guys are doing a good job protecting our country's National Securities!" I said before leaving.

For a second, I felt like I should have thrown that charger in trash instead of submitting, but then I acknowledged I was trying to save Rs 4,38,000. When I got past the security check again, it was 10:30 a.m., so our bus had obviously left.

"They waited for some time." said the CISF lady with nil emotions or expressions in her voice or face.

I waited beside the road with my thumb pointed for a lift. After 10 more minutes, I found a guy on motorcycle ready to help. But since he had to take a turn for work, I had to run about a kilometer. It was the only exam where I needed a complete 3 hours. I entered the exam hall at 11:05 a.m. — Panting — Drenched in sweat. Bala came running towards me with an answer sheet in his hand. At that moment, I was more concerned about his eyeballs popping out of his sockets than my failing in CFD. After all, the Academy will need to justify to NEA why a particular TS failed. I took my seat, and after taking a few deep breaths, I initiated the analysis:

Problem Statement: As I read the questions, I quickly understood that it was a paper that would make even Sumit tremble. I took a look at other toppers: Kunal was biting his nails, Ashu was polishing his bald head with his fingers, and Adil looked like he was just 2 thoughts away from finding the true meaning of life.

Desired Output: Minimum 80 marks, which meant a minimum of 90 marks attempt.

Resources:

- 100 minutes.
- At least 6 useful memory palaces intact in my head — Worth 70 marks.
- 2 Chits intact in my pockets and useful — Worth 20 marks
- Mahi sitting 6 feet away — His writing was visible — He wouldn't try to hide from me.

Now it was time for the ink to paint the fabric. As I proceeded through the questions, I realized that though they were twisted, they were actually asking things similar to what I had studied. It just demanded a little *High-Level Language* to *Low-Level Language* Compilation. My writing speed was limited only by the heat generated during the process and the sheer strength of the answer sheets. In the next hour, I had taken 6 supplementary sheets. Everyone stared at me as if I was sleeping with their girlfriends — Including forever single dudes — Including straight girls.

By 12:30 pm, I was done with 6 questions worth 70 marks — Each answer explained in neat and clean handwriting — Explaining each answer in at least one and a half to two pages — Taking care of time boundations. In the next 10 minutes, I got 10 more marks on a question straight out of my Bore Distortion project. But it was still not safe. I needed at least 10 more marks. There was one question, the answer to which I had studied and formed a Memory Palace for — But I was not able to get the starting point to it. Without the key, you basically cannot access the points attached to it. What I did remember was its chit's location. Left back pocket of my jeans. I needed to go through it just for 10 seconds, but it was impossible in there with 3 invigilators and 5 CCTV cameras. The only way was to go to the washroom and open it.

Ankit once faced a similar situation firsthand. One day, I was sitting with 5-8 other JRFs at the Central Library — All preparing for competitive exams — Somewhere hours in, saturated with running our brains across numericals, we broke into gossip. That's when Ankit shared his story of cheating. In the middle of FEM exam, Ankit went to the washroom to open a chit. What he didn't know was that Bala followed him stealthily. Ankit got caught red-handed, reading from his chit in the urinal. The following happened post that in sequence:

1. Bala searched all his pockets.
2. 5 more chits came out.
3. Took those chits as proof.
4. Gave him an A4 sheet and a pen to write down precisely what he did, accep plagiarism. Which can be punished as severely as permanent suspension from and every government service.
5. The Academy then canceled his answer sheet. He'll have to clear FEM next year

Choosing between different shades of gray and doubting the very steps I was about to take, I walked to the desk where you had to write your name, out and in time in a register to use the restroom. Bala was standing right there — He looked at the clock — It was 12:50 p.m.

“Can’t you hold it for 10 more minutes?” he asked with his eyes trying to read mine.

“No, sir. I’ve been holding it for the last 30 minutes. I think I drank too much water during the exam to cool down from all that running.” I said with a straight face.

As I walked out, it struck me that I didn’t carry a bottle of water with me. Expecting that our beloved Bala was not really a KGB agent, I assumed that he didn’t notice. As I entered the empty washroom and stood in front of the corner urinal with my hands shaking and half of my mind saying,

“KGB can walk in anytime.”

I placed my left hand in my left back pocket and pulled the chit out. With my hands vibrating at a frequency greater than that of the Ultrasonic Machining tool, I read the first three lines. In my head, I exclaimed,

“Oh!! How can I forget that?!? Obviously, it’s the purple Alien chick!!”

I closed the chit in a hurry, placed it back in my pocket, and walked out of the restroom.

At the Exam hall door, I saw Bala walking out towards me. We made eye contact with both of us, trying to understand what the other person was thinking. I smiled, brisk-walked, and said,

“Where are you going, sir? Just 7 minutes left. You gotta collect the papers on time. I don’t want my competition to get a time advantage... Is it ok if I put the in-time after the exam?” and walked past him.

“S-sure..” I heard him say confused, from the rear.

I wrote the answer to the last question while others were somehow killing time by tying the papers in their own creative ways. At 1:00, I slapped the paper amongst many others, jotted in time as 12:53, blended amongst the crowd, and ASAP got to a place far away from the Academy where I couldn’t be searched.

Chapter 7

Embrace the Chaos

20th April 2018 | NEA Township, Vishvenpuram

At 6 p.m., after a quick nap, I walked to the mess for a cup of coffee. The day marked the end of another midterm. So, as expected, the mess had an ambience of Celebration. I took some fake coffee in a disposable cup and went for a walk. Vishvenpuram was a beautiful place to get clean air and crisp natural beauty. I knew that two days before the ISRO exam, studying was not going to help much. It was more about getting my mind to a peaceful state and calming the blizzard down so that my brain could work in the most efficient manner. While visualizing that my coffee was a product of *Arabica* beans straight from Brazil pressure fed by a dual boiler espresso machine costlier than a car, I got an incoming call from my father,

“How was the exam?”, the first line he says.

“It was good. I’ll pass.” I responded in a chill manner and giggled.

“What!? What will passing give you?” he responded with a stern voice.

By now, I was used to him giving me shit for not doing what he wants — I responded calmly while I took another sip of that tranquilizing coffee dissolved with the essence of greenery around me — Those beams of sunset induced gold plating to the leaves — I said,

“It’ll give me a job and a degree, Dad.”

His voice raised along with his astronomically surging anger as he said,

“Mumbai placement goes to the toppers! What is your rank now?”

A couple of sparrows passed by me as I took another sip and said,

“Oh, I am the topper.”

His tone geared from harsh to mellow as he said,

“Really, *beta*?!?”

I responded, mimicking his mellow tone,

“Yes, Daddy... from the bottom, though.”

Which, for obvious reasons, must have tossed his bloodstream straight to film boiling states. With his fury apparent in his voice, he said,

“Are you out of your mind?!?! What the hell are you doing over there?!”

With a newfound elevated level of calmness further reinforced by the coffee-nature combo, I said,

“I’m studying day & night.”

Probably more annoyed by my nonchalant attitude than by my results, he said,

“Yeah, I can see how much you are studying. You need to change your company, spend more time with the toppers, and make it up in the remaining exams. At least get a placement in Hyderabad. Ronit uncle was saying that Hyderabad is good too. He has been promoted to Technical Officer recently. Next time you go to Mumbai, you must meet him.”

I wanted to tell him that I was preparing for the ISRO exam again, but I didn’t to avoid some of his ear beating and profound advice. A few months ago, I made the mistake of telling him about the December exam. The whole experience was brutal as the amount of time he asked me, “*How’s your ISRO preparation going?*” and “*Will you be able to crack it?*” could only be surpassed by the number of times he asked, “*Will you get SCAR, Mumbai Placement?*”. I don’t know what goes on in a parent’s head, but them giving advice in fields they have no experience in whatsoever is preposterous. My father had worked in Coal India Limited (CIL) for the past 30 years, and he would consider his life successful only if both his kids got Government jobs as well. My brother, who was 6 years older than me, never made it but me getting into an organization like SCAR did sufficient for both of us. The only thing that would further please him would be me cracking the UPSC ESE, or better yet, Civil Services Exam. ISRO would be great too, as it was more

prestigious as compared to SCAR. It would be a big deal for the neighbors back home, and my dad would get some street creds. Even after hiding information, I was used to getting chewed off like this once a week. I guess he deserved that much for providing me with basic education — So I dealt with it by messing with him while he messed with me. I guess I deserved that much for not being a crackhead.

“Listen to me carefully. Whatever you are wasting your time in, you need to cut it out and focus on your classes.” said pops.

I was walking this footpath with trees on both sides. It was a path I used all the time to get groceries. Say what you will about Vishvenpuram; it is a scenic masterpiece — Here, nature plays its own orchestra which calms you down. I replied with the same composure,

“I know what I’m doing. Dad, I always end up doing what I said I will, don’t I? I told you that I’ll get into IIT Bombay and I did. I told you I’ll crack SCAR and I did, didn’t I?”

My father raised his tone further now, got all heated up, and said,

“You said a lot of things. You said you’ll get into ISRO, didn’t you? You failed at it, didn’t you? Twice! Am I correct?”

I stopped walking — Street chatter faded out — The serene music of nature morphed into a perilous silence of doom — The setting sun lost its light in an instant — The bright beauty of greenery smoothly transitioned into a pitch dark, eerie space as the words *“You said you’ll get into ISRO, didn’t you?”* rang in my head six more times. With all the calmness and tranquility now annihilated, my mind sunk into hellish agony where I was blind of reasons and thirsty for blood. Pupil dilated — Fist clenched — Nails plunged in my sweaty palms — Heavy breaths — Veins ready to pop. I was woken up back to where I was by my father saying, “Did you?!?”.

Oh, you don’t wanna be the person who knows where it hurts, where the wound is fresh, and you definitely don’t want to sprinkle salt on it, especially if that wound is mine. I heard him saying, “DID YOU?!” one more time, and I made sure that he never dared to say that ever again,

“Yes, I failed! But who said it’s over?...” Possessed by the devil, now my voice had that forbidden concoction of woe and fury as I continued,

“... I told you I'll get into IIT Bombay! I failed in GATE 16, but did I stop? NO! When I graduated, I had a job offer, which you advised me to take. I didn't. Because I believed in myself! If I know what I can do, why would I settle for anything less than what I want? I didn't join that job and went out to prepare again. I worked the hardest for one more year but still failed again in 17. Didn't give up. I went into the IIT Bombay Interview room and beat people with ranks half of mine!...” In the middle of the street — On the top of my lungs — Without moving an inch — Drunk with ego and sunk in vanity — Refusing to look from a different perspective — I continued,

“... I had only one job interview, happened to be the most difficult job interview in the country. Not once you said that, *son, you can do it*. But guess what? I never needed you to! I went in there and did something that you never imagined I could! You are a Mechanical Engineer too, aren't you? Graduated from BIT Sindri! I couldn't get admitted there. You were always disappointed that I couldn't get into an A-league college like you or one of your colleague's sons. I had to settle with a third-tier college, but you were from a top-class college with top education, so tell me, why didn't you crack SCAR? Why didn't you crack ISRO? I know these organizations were sure as hell recruiting in the 80s. I, after facing consequent failures, went out and cracked SCAR. Do you know everyone in my batch has been toppers their entire life? They are from top colleges like IITs, NITs and DU. They are all smarter than me, but none decided to put ISRO above the Academy. I did! Why? Because I'm dumb? If this is dumb, then I don't wanna be smart. I failed the GATE exam thrice and ISRO twice. I'm still going at it. IF I'M NOT TIRED OF TRYING AGAIN AND AGAIN, THEN WHY ARE YOU?!?...”

My father listened to it with a pin-drop-silence as I made violent attempts to change him. I exhaled, and now with the amplitude lowered, I continued,

“... Sometimes you should respect the struggle more than the achievements. Humans are smart to create an exam to judge capabilities but not smart enough to measure efforts. Why? Because it gets too difficult to look at people with the perspective of where they started. It's too complex and confusing. Tell me, 53 in math, 61 in Physics in 2012 to Bronze Medalist in 2016 to Nuclear Scientist at Science Center for Atomic Research in 2017. Haven't I done enough to earn your confidence?”

To this long rant, my father responded with,

“Are you on drugs? Or are you watching too many movies these days? These dialogues don’t work in real life. Those IITians are doing what they are doing for a reason. Follow them. They understand what can and can’t be done outside fiction.”

I hopelessly sighed and replied,

“I would have listened to you if you were doing what I wanted to do or even if you were doing what you wanted to do.” and ended the call.

When I returned to #59, I found that SCAR 2018 results had been published.

- Cut Off: 152
- My Score: 162

That night, Raju and Arun surprised us all by giving a visit at Vishvenpuram. I was having dinner with them when Sumit waked to our table and said to me,

“Hey, bro... How are you?” holding two bottles of water — Purple and metalling.

“Good.” I replied as I dipped a piece of chapati into *Mutter Paneer* curry.

“Umm... You’re appearing in ISRO tomorrow, right?”

“Yeah.”

“What’s your center?”

“Sathyabama. Yours?”

“Same. What time will you leave?”

“5:00 pm... Saturday.”

“Oh... wh... I’ll be leaving Sunday morning... um... We can... You know, return together.”

“Sure.”

“Cool man... umm... See you Sunday.”

As Sumit walked away, Raju said,

“Whoa... I sense tension. What’s wrong?”

“Shut up, dude.” said Arun.

Next day at 5:00 p.m., I took a bus at Vishvenpuram Bus stand and left for Chennai. As expected, I could not get a seat, and after a two-hour shaky ride on my feet, I checked into my pre-booked hotel room. The room was air-conditioned — Felt good for a change. Now the final step was to get a sound sleep so I could be in perfect shape to slay 80 questions the next day. Exam was 4:00 pm to 5:30 pm the next day. Everything had to be perfect. The dinner had to be light for a sound sleep. Sleep had to be between 6 to 7 hours. Breakfast and lunch the next day had to be optimum — No more, no less.

I was responsible for bringing myself to the exam hall at peak performance. Every sacrifice I had ever made, all the words that ever left my mouth, had to be backed. I had taken enough risks for my goal to take any with my goal. All those rejections that felt like daggers thrust into my gut had to be brought to justice. All those eyes watching me confidently, expecting me to fail, must be lowered. If I failed after a year long & nasty fight, they'd win without even fighting. I've lost a lot along this path; the only thing I've earned is this moment of opportunity. At this moment, I was not living in the past thinking of what I could have done, nor was I living in the future thinking of what I could do — I was right there in full flesh and blood. I felt the control of my life clutched within my fists — I felt the future's dependence on my actions — I felt life.

22nd April 2018, 3:30 pm | Sathyabama University, Chennai

That day, I gave ISRO its last chance. I had done everything I could. This time I couldn't have failed in proving myself — Only ISRO could fail in judging me. And if it did, I would go ahead to find other ways to build rockets. It was my final march towards a battlefield that had made few lives and destroyed many. The war that portrays the mirage of glory and attracts young, hungry, ambitious and unemployed. It reminded me of 4th February 2016, the first time I made the walk. I was sweaty that day as I am today. My heart was throbbing as it is pounding today. Ironically, I thought it would be the last time that day as I am today. Back then, I never imagined that a game I expected to be a means to get what I wanted in 6 months would keep me its gladiator for 3 years. I still don't know whether I played the game or the game played me. Three years ago, I wanted to become the topper; for them to take my interviews; my posters to be in the streets of Delhi coaching hubs. I'll be an ISRO scientist and will proudly say that I make rockets

for a living. Now, when all the exquisite ideas and lust for eminence have faded away, all that bullshit settles at the bottom of the pool. Time and trouble are excellent filters to screen out wannabes. It's also a good litmus test to see what you really are in for. Three years of endless sacrifices — Sacrificing weekends, relationships, festivals, and trips with the reasonable ones. For a goal that seems less and less possible the more you run towards it — Closer you reach, the farther it seems. But, *You Want It* and *It's Possible*. To psychos like us, somehow, that outweighs all the rational reasons on the other side.

I did not want to be 80 someday — Looking back as a retired Scientist of NEA — Seeing Indian *Gaganauts* landing on Mars — Thinking I could've made rockets for a living — Regretting not that I didn't, but that I didn't try — Not giving everything I had. The vision haunted me: Sitting alone on a couch — A live telecast of a rocket launch pops up, and the countdown goes: 5 — 4 — 3 — 2 — 1 — “*Ashwin, did you give everything you had?*” — *And, lift off!*

I hated eating oats every morning — I hated sleeping for just 6 hours a night, and I bloody hated pulling an all-nighter a day before the Academy exams — I hated sacrificing comfort — I hated not having sex — I hated not having delicious meals — But boy would I hate being 80 with NO as an answer.

I walked inside the exam hall and started searching for my allocated seat. It looked like a typical Government college classroom — High ceiling — Old and rusty fans — Lack of light in the classroom. Thanks to the Sun for its nuclear fusions and the giant windows there, else it would have been difficult to even read. No matter what you do — How healthy you eat — The complete breathing techniques you follow — How sound of a sleep you had last night: Your eyes will burn just before the exam, palms will be sweaty, and blood pressure would be meteoric. It's your brain preparing to release adrenaline — It's up to you whether you ride the tide or let it drown you. I closed my eyes, put my head down, and calmed myself by deep breaths. Same old regiment: Visualizing the 90 minutes of exam — How it could go — How I'll move in waves — How I would react to hurdles.

At 3:55 sharp, a lady in her mid-40s walked in with the question paper bundle — Wearing a *saree* — Around 5'3” tall — Boy Cut curly set of hair. My eyes adjusted their focus immediately to something that was pinned to her saree towards her left chest — The signature vertical card — White in color with her picture at the center — Hanging by a circular plate around 1.5 cm diameter, stuck with a logo that I

could even recognize a silhouette of — It was the ISRO logo — The majestic combination of Orange and Blue. I couldn't take my eyes off it. It's almost like it had me under some spell — I wanted to hold that badge — Touch it — Whip my thumb around it. I had done it a million times in my dreams — Grabbing it tight by my hands.

I hooked myself out from my dream to reality, for the dream still had to be brought to reality — I checked if some saliva was dripping from my mouth — None — So proud of myself — But then I realized that a couple of boys were staring at me. God damn it, I looked at that badge long enough for the lady to notice. They must have thought I was focused on what was behind the badge. My fantasies, from their perspective, must have appeared pretty disturbing. At 4:00 p.m. exactly, she slapped the question paper on my desk — It was time to go. I kept 3 things in mind:

1. Play on my front foot, aggressive and bold.
2. Even a single mistake could drown me.
 - I got 116 in December when the cut-off was 120. Short of 4 marks. The worst was that I had committed a mistake in a question I knew exactly how to solve. Silly Mistake: -3, -1 is all it took to have an L. One mistake is all it takes.
3. Sumit was in another room giving the same paper.
 - If there's even a single question that brings me below the cut-off, and he clears won't ever be able to face myself.

If, after all this, someone who didn't risk it all is the one to get it all, my whole philosophy collapses on itself — Establishing that no one can intentionally get what one wants. With every question I attempted, I reminded myself that Sumit could get it right, so I better not make a mistake.

The first 20 questions in the *1st Wave* said out loud that the question paper was easier than usual this time. 60 questions in, I knew that there exists candidates who were going to attempt 80 out of 80 questions. Right in front of me, once again, was an anomaly in ICRB exam history — Second time ever — But a mirror reflection of the first — ISRO had never made an easier question paper. I reminded myself that competition toughness is independent of question paper difficulty level.

My ISRO 2018 on-spot analysis:

- Required attempt: 75
- Expected cut-off: 190

Since the question paper was so easy, it was favorable for someone like Sumit, who had not been preparing as seriously but had a high intellect, to qualify the exam. On the other hand, it made it equally worse for someone who had invested 2 years in preparing and strategizing for a specific exam pattern, and the pattern is not followed. Anomalies Negate all your Strategies. Now you are the same as the one who had done no analysis — Or worse — Welcome to the land of anarchy.

That day, I was neither of those *'someones'*. This paper would have been a problem for me 4 months ago. But since December, I had followed the single rule of predicting the future:

“Expect the Unexpected”

Knowing that if the paper could disrespect pattern and go super difficult, it can very well go super easy. I was aware that I might have to solve a lot of questions fast and accurately — My kryptonite. And so I spent one-third of my time practicing relentlessly on this specific kind of question — The prime reason I cracked SCAR 2018. The other two-thirds were distributed equally amongst moderate and difficult questions — Ready for all — After all, I had crossed the rubicon, I had no options — The *Beauty in Simplicity of Adversity* — And so I had to throw everything at it, including the kitchen sink and if need be, the damn kitchen itself.

My head had its veins popping — Forehead wrinkled — Concentrating hard at each and every question. Palms sweaty — Back arched — Shoulder wide — Deep Breaths. I would have even controlled my heartbeat to optimize my performance if I could. With every question I read, with every formula I wrote, with every calculation I did, there was a constant voice in my head,

“If you make a mistake, Sumit wins.”

The 1st Wave went smoothly — I solved 50 questions in 40 minutes. It was time to mark those answers on the OMR sheet.

“1-D... 2-C... 3-A... 4-C...” I used to speak like this in my head while marking the answers to avoid any mistakes in marking.

“... 66-B... 67-D... 68-A...”

— *Turn the page* —

“... 70-D... *Shit!*”

I accidentally marked B instead of D!

“Alright, Ashwin. No worries. It’s just one question. Let’s land so far ahead of the border that this (-4) doesn’t matter.” I said to myself, acknowledging the unidirectional flow of time.

What happened has happened. If I fail because of it, it’s fine, but I should not fail because of what I did after. Our actions, not the life instances, judge where we end up. With a ruptured heart, I continued to attempt questions in the 2nd Wave. In the last 15 minutes, I could even reach the *Topper’s Wave*. This was an easy question paper, but there still were 6 questions I had never seen before. 4 required theoretical knowledge of Material Science and Production, which you either have or you don’t — I didn’t. It took me 5 minutes to solve one of the other two. I tried the last question for a long time, only to find out that I had attempted it in the wrong direction.

“LAST TWO MINUTES!!” the lady announced.

I took a look at her, and on the way back to the question paper, it got pulled again by the same badge.

“Bro, this is no time to fantasize about that badge. Plus, we would really like to go home without a slapped face.” I started talking to myself.

“No-No, wait, you dumbass! Look at that badge carefully. Do you want it? Well, wanting is not good enough. There are 50 other graduates sitting here in this class. Sumit is sitting in some class nearby and, in total, around 2,00,000 Mechanical Engineers across the country. They all ‘want’ it. But there are only 40 seats. You are not alone; everyone wants to get that badge for their own reasons. Your goals can never be unique; actions however, can be. Your actions separate you from the competition. In these final moments, how will you act? Are you OK with an average performance, or are you going to be ruthless about taking what’s yours? So how will you act? What will you do?”

“I WILL SNATCH IT!”

I took another look at the badge — Then looked at the question again. It was a *Gear* question from TOM. It was both easy and difficult at the same time. Difficult because we had never seen such a question in any competitive exam — It was unexpected. Easy because we all had studied this in the third semester of Mechanical Engineering. I looked at the options with a new perspective — A formula clicked — I looked at my watch — We were already in the final minute — Ink to paper demanded time I did not have. So I wrote on the canvas of my brain, which was not limited by 3 dimensions — Placed the formula — Placed the values — Did the mathematics — Marked the answer on the OMR as C — In the middle of the ink painting that bubble, my mind screamed,

“SHIT! You forgot to multiply it by 2!!”

The answer was A — C was just bait. But it was too late. The ink was permanent.

“Time’s Up!! Everyone submit your sheets.” Shouted the invigilator.

“Two mistakes, huh? That’s -8 marks, and that’s only what we know of. In a competition so tough and with the paper so easy, -8 is a death sentence. You truly have no chance.” I thought as I walked towards the lady and submitted my sheet.

“Damn... I fucked it up this time too.” I was in shambles as I leaned to pick up my bag placed near the Black Board.

“Ashwin Taksh!” I heard in a South Indian accent. It was the ISRO scientist with curly hair.

“Yes, ma’am.” I replied as I turned back.

“You need to keep this carbon paper with you. It’s your proof of appearance.” she said.

By now, I had given a dozen exams with the OMR system. I knew exactly what to do with it before submitting it, but that’s how blank I was. With shivering hands, I detached the carbon sheet which was glued to the main sheet, returned her the OMR and walked away thinking,

“It doesn’t matter anyway.”

I felt my internals lament. The control was no longer in my hands — What remained was the grief of mishandling an opportunity. As I walked out, I got so lost in recalculation of the last question in my head that when I took a look

around, it almost seemed like I had teleported from the exam hall on the 2nd floor to the playground where I found myself standing. I took a look at the question paper again and it struck me,

“Oh! I actually did multiply it with 2, but it got canceled by this 2 in the formula!”

It was evening but still pleasantly bright. I ran towards a tree nearby, sat under it, and did the calculation on the back of OMR Proof and *Vallah!* — The answer was ‘C’ indeed! ‘A’ was bait. I had answered 75 questions correctly and 1 question incorrectly.

As I walked towards the main gate to catch a bus back to Vishvenpuram, I saw an incoming call. I was not the kind of person who gets phone calls — Which comes with an instinct of who might be calling — It was Sumit. Before picking, I already knew what was on his mind — He wanted to know how my exam went and honestly, I was dying to know his performance as well. I answered the call and pretended he was not going on long walks with a girl who still hadn’t left my head.

“So Ashwin... me, Simar, Poornima, Raju and Arun were planning to go to Punjabi Dhaba. You know it is Raju & Arun’s last day and all... So, are you coming?”

“Oh... Starting with the small talk, huh? You wanna have this power play? Let’s do it!” I thought and said,

“Don’t know, man. I don’t really do dinners.”

“I know... but Arun and Raju are adamant that you should come... Common man... It’s their last day.” he said.

“Well... He sounded a bit nice. Did I make Sumit an unnecessary evil in my head, vilifying him for no reason?” I thought and said,

“Uh... okay, man... I’m near building 12A. Where are you?”

“I’m in the mess right now.”

Wondering if I saw a mess on my way here from the main gate, I asked,

“Where’s the mess?”

“Near the library, obviously. How was the paper?” he said.

“Are you talking about the FTH mess?” I asked in utter confusion.

“Yeah, bro. I did not appear.” He responded carefreely.

I did not speak for at least 10 seconds — A moment of silence for the death of a dream.

“So... How was your exam?...” he asked again.

I could feel the guilt in his voice. I wondered how Simar must have convinced him to not sit for the exam — There was a pattern to it — I could see it playing out right in front of my eyes by now. For some reason, I did not like it happening even to people I didn’t care about — I did not like it happening to even people I hated.

“Ashwin, you there? Awake?” He chuckled — A sleeping man tried to wake up a wide-awake one.

“Exam went great, dude. I’ll see you guys at *Punjabi Dhaba* then.” I said and ended the call.

There are certain things that you might have heard while someone was describing someone else’s story, which they heard from someone else, who heard from someone else. You hear these rumors of people cremating their careers and passions under the intoxication of an attraction — You don’t even believe that someone can really be that dumb — You think that it’s a fabrication of the Film Industry to add dramatic effects. But when it happens right in front of your eyes, you realize that *Fiction follows Facts as Facts follow Fiction*.

It’s remarkable how we boys forget about everything when the scent of a girl gets us high. I was not much concerned about what happened next with Sumit. For all I cared, he would get his answers in a year. But what I really cared about was that if it could happen to a boy as talented as Sumit, it could happen to anyone.

“What if someday it happens to me? What if I gave up on my dreams? How do I prevent that from ever happening? When it’s happening, and you’re right in the middle of it, the biggest problem is that you won’t even realize you are there until it’s all set and done.” I wondered as I knew that as difficult as it might seem, sooner or later, a girl would pop up in my life as well.

That evening on my way back, standing in a shaky Government bus, I concluded that the way to deal with such a machiavellian trap is by asking myself a simple question:

“Is the influence of the girl changing my ambitions?”

I promised myself that day that the relationship would continue as long as the answer was 'No'.

Chapter 8

What it Takes to Walk Away

3 Hours Later | *Punjabi Dhaba*, 45 Kms from Chennai

On either side of the ECR highway, you'll see nothing but darkness, and amidst that, *Punjabi Dhaba* appears like a Golden crown. Because of the rarity of North-Indian food down South, it attracted both South-Indians and North-Indians irrespective — Which made it both famous and costly. Wearing a navy-blue T-Shirt and mint chinos — Slippers on my feet and straps of my bag over my shoulders, I walked into the restaurant and saw a bunch of 12 cheerful Scientists. Chandan, Poornima, Vaishnavi, Arun, Raju and Kavita were sitting facing my direction — Rashmi, Kunal, Kabir, Ashu, Simar and Sumit had their backs towards the entry door. A cluster of 3 tables was formed to make a single slender one. All the people that I drifted away from were here. That sight reminded me of how wonderful it was with Arun and Raju in it — With the original Chandan — Simar, who was nothing but the most beautiful girl I had ever seen — Sumit as a symbol of intellect who shared my destination and passion. Sometimes you ignore reality just because you want things to fit according to your expectations. Time is persistent with its slaps of reality — Longer you ignore, the harder the slaps — Laws of life are written in stone — You can play fantasy all you want but will learn what it is all about sooner or later — For it is relentless.

“Here comes Ashwin!” Raju shouted.

Followed by Arun,

“Aye... About time bro!! Food is already here. Just join in.”

Since all the seats were occupied, I requested the waiter for an extra chair. He placed it at one of the shorter edges of the table — Right beside Simar.

“Ashwin is head of the family now!!” laughed Kabir.

As I sat down, I had Simar just a foot away from me on my right — Sumit was on her right. On my left were Raju, Arun and Chandan sequentially. I gave everyone a social smile, including Simar, to keep it all *Normal*. However, that eye lock with her still seemed like an eternity and annoyingly demanding to unlock.

“I wonder if it is just me getting goosebumps every time my vision caught sight of her... The only one breathing heavily when she was around, or if it also happens to her? Maybe she’s just better at hiding it.” said my illogical side.

The waiter placed a *Kadhai*-shaped bowl stuffed with *Chicken Butter Masala* decorated with white *Malai* and coriander leaves on top. The essence caused mass production of saliva at a rate higher than *Ford* factories during World War II. Tied by the magic much similar to Simar’s lips, I looked at the bowl and analyzed:

1. 4 chicken pieces.
2. 2 leg pieces.
3. 4 Non-vegetarians: Kabir, Kunal, me and Ashu.
4. No tolerance for hesitation — Time to pounce fast, time to pounce first!

As I moved towards the bowl, Kabir and Ashu hesitated — They lost. Kunal didn’t, but I was a Black Belt — He wasn’t.

“Bitch please, let me show you what lightning hand speed 10,000 repetitions of Oizuki gives you.” I thought with firm eye contact with his glasses, similar to what two fighters would have at *weigh-ins*.

My hand speed warped the 3D space as I grabbed the bigger leg piece. By the time Ashu and Kabir had theirs, my canines had already sunk deep into that perfectly cooked flesh.

“So Chandan... You won’t have chicken?” asked Raju.

I dipped that *Naan* into the silk-like gravy with perfect thickness and let that combo melt in my mouth, along with another bite of chicken.

“Naah... I gave up.”

“Why the fuck?” Asked Ashu — Exactly what I would have asked if my mouth was any good for talking.

“You know... It’s pretty cruel.” Chandan said as he looked at Simar for affirmation.

“The fuck?!” Kabir’s reaction — Would have been my reaction, but I rather chose to take another bite while the food was still warm.

“Whatever, dude... Ashwin, how was your exam?” Raju asked.

I raised my left index finger, signaling him to hold, and chewed faster to clear my mouth. Then I said,

“It was good...” Chewed some more — *“God damn, it’s delicious!”* I thought and said,

“... I’ll make it.” I said as I now placed some *Paneer Tikka Masala* gravy on my plate. My mouth was sucking in food as if there was a negative 1 Bar pressure in my belly.

“Nice!!” said an excited Arun.

“How many questions did you attempt?” asked Sumit with much less excitement.

As I looked at him, my 150-degree vision range automatically covered Simar. I knew that she was not going to say anything. I also knew that she was curiously listening. I always had this weird sense about when she was looking at me or listening to what I was saying.

“75... paper was pretty easy. You should have appeared. You would have made it.” I responded.

“Ehh... What’s done is done.” Raju said.

“Sure is.” I said as I saw a clear regret on Sumit’s face — I took a sip of water — In my head, I said,

“Already? Wait till you see me on the final selection list after the interview. Wait till I wear that badge. Wait till I am a Rocket Scientist, and You are not.”

I wanted to ask him why he didn’t appear. I knew the answer, but I still needed to know what lies he told himself to sleep at night.

“Bro, maybe Interview will be by May end, and by July, you’d have joined ISRO.” said Arun.

I finished the leg piece and said,

“Maybe, bu-” that’s when Simar’s elbow bumped into mine.

She was wearing a peacock blue Salwar kameez with sleeves till a little below her elbow. The fabric of her cloth touching my skin sent tornados tearing through my senses. I took a look at her, and my eyes got caught by those pink lips again, which reminded me of the first time I saw her in that Waiting Room. Her left arm immediately rebounded like she experienced the arc forming as well. As much as I would have liked to bury my emotions for her, it was painful to realize that buried things don’t cease to exist. All it takes is a bit of digging, and it’s all there. ISRO had helped me to replace her, but now, with ISRO out of the way, I was defenseless again.

“Boy, it was a mistake to come to this dinner.” I thought.

But at least now I knew my feelings. Question was,

“What am I going to do about it?”

She lifted her arm to tuck a log of hair hindering her sight behind her ear as she said,

“Sorry, Ashwin.”

That’s all it took for me to forgive it all — Pity. We men are pretty weak. All those tales of our bravery in battles, legendary stories of our victories, strength and motivation are nothing but proofs of our weaknesses.

“No worries.” I said, looking into her eyes.

There was not a person on this planet who wouldn’t recognize that this wasn’t *‘Normal’*. Sumit got up and left in a hurry.

“Where are you going, dude?” asked Raju.

“Wa-wash-washroom... will be back soon.” he responded without looking at Raju.

Sympathizing now with Sumit and respecting the power that this sorcerer wields, I gulped another piece of *Butter Naan* with *Chicken gravy*.

Somehow the thirteen of us stuffed ourselves in a single *Auto-Rikshaw* to save the cost of a second one. One dude on each side of the driver — Four girls in the most comfortable seat and three boys, along with Rashmi, sat at the feet of the four queens. I, Chandan and Raju somehow balanced our asses on the rod separating the driver’s and passenger’s sides. The pain soon became uncomfortable to bear

because of the vibration of the auto, but the East-Coast wind that gushed past my face made up for it. We reached back to our residential quarters by 11:00 p.m.

I had done something that I had been trying to do for 3 years, but that night, all I thought about was Simar,

“What’s this demonic attraction?” I wondered.

I felt I might be at a junction in space and time where the inaction would be regrettable. This is what’s confusing & dangerous about taking control of your life — To what extent do you go? In any situation, you can always act, but are you wise enough to know when you should not? The more I thought, the more that formidable wall built to shield me from Simar collapsed.

I walked out of #59 with a water bottle and sat on the pavement. I took a couple of sips of water. The climate of Vishvenpuram was hot and humid as always, but the breeze at night was something you’ll never experience away from the southern coasts of India. I took my shirt off to feel it better and kept my mint chinos on to avoid sexual misconduct lawsuits. My bare feet touched the coastal sand relocated from the beach — You could hear the sea roaring.

At 12:00 a.m., I said,

“I need to know. Only one way to find out.” and took out my cell phone.

I hadn’t talked to her since September, so I searched for her by name and found her online.

“Hi!” I dropped her a message.

“Hi!” she replied immediately — Faster than I expected — Faster than I could have physically responded to anything.

“Can we talk?” I replied.

“About what?” she asked.

“Have to do this face to face. Can we please meet?” I texted.

“Now?” she replied.

“Yes. In mess.”

“Alright, see you in 5 min.” she replied.

I got up, placed my foot one by one in my *chappals*, and put my shirt back on. I was going to meet a female colleague in a lonely place, that too late at night. Just in case I found myself in the middle of a pickle, I turned on the audio recorder app on my phone. The trembling in my legs had begun — I tried to breathe deeply to counteract. My hands were sweaty again, similar to what I had experienced less than 8 hours ago. To make it all worse, that night's moon was the spookiest I have ever seen — Full — Blood red — As if all the omens indicated not to do this. I entered the mess and dragged a chair with metallic feet to take a seat — All the mess lights were turned off — Hall was lit only by the street lights outside — Entering through the giant windows.

I heard the footsteps and took a look at the entrance door. The interval between the subsequent foot placement sounds kept stretching with every consequent step. Enter Simar Kaur in full flesh and blood. The eye contact felt like I just bathed in cocaine. I struggled to muster sufficient motor controls to get myself up, and when I did, I felt weak standing in front of her as I recognized that she held the leash to my life. I said,

“Thank you for coming, Simar.”

“Yes, Ashwin. Tell me, what do you want to talk about?” she said quite confidently.

“Does she sound like a shy girl who is unable to confess her feelings to you? There's still time, dude. Walk away.” said the bright one in my head.

I did what I felt was not designed for by the Gods.

“Simar... I... I... really... I really like you.” I said with all the courage in my arsenal.

It felt like 10 kgs of weight shredded off my shoulders — A weight I had carried for way too long.

“Ashwin...” she said after a few seconds.

I observed each and every lip movement of hers closely, probably because light travels faster than sound, and relativity was causing every second to seem like a minute.

“... We have already talked about it...” she continued.

“Fucking exactly what I was afraid of!” I thought.

“... only 2 months are remaining. Let's not complicate things. Let's just be normal friends.” she said.

Somehow I knew she would say that before she actually said it, but it was time to pick up every last question in my head and toss it into the trash for good. I asked,

“You think I've not tried? Do you know how hard I have tried every day? But it's just not possible for me. I don't know what it is, but I can't get over it.” I said as I stood weak and helpless 2 feet away from her.

“Ashwin... try to understand. It's not possible.” she said.

“Why not?” I asked immediately — Weak, but relentless.

“It's just 2 months. After that, we don't know where you'll be and where I'll be.”

“That's the dumbest fucking reason I've ever heard, bro.” said the dark one.

“Simar, do you make your life decisions based on place and time? Not based on your feelings? Tell me, what do you want?” I said, looking firmly into her eyes — Knowing that I would scout the Earth for her if need be. If only she says Yes.

“Ashwin... I... I... I can't. You have to understand.” she said, staring at the floor. Looking weaker by the second.

“Why not? Give me the reason.” I said, looking straight at her, hoping for an eye-to-eye truth.

“I can't tell you.” she said as she continued to look at the floor.

“I need to know, Simar. I think I deserve that much.”

“Does it matter? What happens if I tell you?” she said, now looking at me.

I pointed with my right index finger toward the exit door behind her and said,

“I'll step aside and get out of your way.”

She hesitated for a couple of seconds, took a deep breath, looked into my eyes, and said,

“I have been in a serious relationship for the past 3 years.”

The spell finally lifted — Took a step back and sat on the chair behind me — Exhaled — Placed my right ankle on my left knee, leaned back, and looked into her eyes again — It was no longer magical.

“Why didn’t you tell me this before?” I asked.

For the first time, there were no butterflies in my stomach when I spoke to her.

“It’s something that I disclose to only people closest to me. I don’t really know where it is going to go in future, but... um...” she said.

“Fair enough, Simar. Thanks again for coming, and goodnight.” I said with a smile as I got up.

“N-no problem...” she said as I walked past her towards the exit.

After a few steps, I turned back to say one last thing,

“And Simar...”

She turned towards me, and for the first time, I saw her as just another girl or, better yet, just another person. I smiled at her and said,

“... don’t worry. From now on, it’s all normal from my side. You too, please try to be normal. Sorry if I caused you some discomfort.”

As I walked past Chandan & Sumit’s quarter, I saw Sumit talking over a phone call, and that’s when I gave justice to the idea that maybe Sumit and Simar were just great friends. I thought,

“So, she’s just loyal towards her boyfriend, works hard to get placed in Mumbai, and keeps boys like me at a distance. She is a good girl after all. I’m the stupid one here. I guess staying isolated for so long is dangerous for your perception.”

Next, after 3 days of rest, I got back into the regiment. It was time to put the final hammer to the nail. What I absolutely avoided though, was weed. I had come to realize that not consuming Marijuana had definitely helped me in performing better in SCAR & ISRO 2018. Weed prevents you from pushing hard towards anything, or at least that was true for me. And so I decided to keep myself clean at least until the ISRO interview.

Meanwhile, I scored 80/100 in CFD-II. Kunal had the second-highest score of 65. However, my position obviously remained as 12th in Mechanical — Moreover, with an aggregate of 68%, I was at 92nd position in the overall ranking across all disciplines — The only people who scored lower than me were the 28, including

Raju & Arun, who resigned in 1st quarter. Sumit at 1st and Chandan at 11th position of Mechanical discipline had 83% and 78% respectively.

I created a Whatsapp group for all SCAR 2018 Interview candidates who had approached me through social media. Every day more and more people discovered me on YouTube, and the group quickly reached a size of 40. I actively guided them to prepare for SCAR Interview — Guiding the outcasts to do the Impossible. Most of them had beyond 1000 rank in GATE, had not qualified ESE Prelims, and had even Messed up their ISRO exam. I could relate with them and gave them hope, an example, motivation to work hard, and reason to fight for the slimmest chance. I even personally talked to many of them over call — Tailoring their roadmaps individually. Soon, so many popped up that I had to start saving their phone numbers by numbers as names. It started with ‘1’ and within a week, it climbed to ‘300’. A lot of new demands regarding the actual problems students were facing, like *“Revision Strategy”*, *“How to prepare for IIT Bombay if you have poor GATE rank”*, *“How to prepare along with coaching”* started to pop up in the comment section. So I decided to make further videos. I borrowed a tripod and a whiteboard from Rohit and turned on my cell phone camera to start recording. Views multiplied with a snowball effect, and I truly relished the community that was creating itself. Academy exams had just ended, ISRO was under cruise control, I was off of Simar’s hook and was enjoying this newfound popularity online. Interviews completely contrast the written tests, and I was naturally great at it. With the IIT Bombay, Indian Army and SCAR interview feathers on my hat, I had no doubt that I won’t just crack the ISRO interview but would obliterate it. I worked systematically nonetheless, started going through dozens of ISRO interview experiences online, and began formulating my ISRO Interview doctrine.

May 24th 2018, 5:30 pm | 3rd Quarter Finals

Us TSs still did not know what postings NEA would provide, as preparing for an unwrapped gift box for 8 months was apparently customary in SCAR Academy. The Placements could be stuffed with 90% Vishvenpuram and 10% Mumbai like last year — Where everyone apart from the topper got Vishvenpuram — Or it could be 90% Mumbai, Hyderabad and Delhi with 10% Vishvenpuram like the year before. Only two kinds of TSs across all Departments knew exactly where they

would be posted: Toppers like Sumit in Mumbai and the Botommers like me in Vishvenpuram.

It was the evening before the last Academy exam. Everybody knew that whatever the postings may be, by now, rankings were written in stone — Half a paper was not going to change anything. So we had a relaxed atmosphere at STH. It was a beautiful evening, orange sky, outworldly breeze and birds chirping. Adil was explaining to me a numerical when a motorbike with two dudes on it stopped in front of us.

“Are you guys trainees at the Academy?” asked the driver, who wore a helmet.

“Yes.” Responded Adil while I was figuring out why that formula was used in the numerical that we were discussing.

“What are the vacancies this year?” asked the driver again.

“I am sorry. Who are you, and why are you asking this?” asked Adil like a boss as I continued looking at the solution he had just scribbled.

“Sorry, we didn’t introduce ourselves. I am Rajeev, and this is Guddu. We are from the 60th batch of the Academy. We are your seniors.” Said the guy in the rear seat as he got down.

I kept the notebook aside and got up to shake both of their hands, introducing myself. I said,

“Sir, the placement announcement is on June 4th, so we don’t know now. Where are you guys posted?” I said with a smile.

“I am at MPE Chikkalduti” said Rajeev.

I had never heard of that posting but nodded as if my father-in-law worked there.

“And you, sir?” I asked the guy at the front.

“I’m here itself, at FBRC. Giving my friend here a tour of Vishvenpuram...” He said as he took off his helmet and continued,

“... Anyways, just do us a favor. Whenever vacancies come, do let us know. Can you do that, *Hero*?” said Guddu.

Being the optimistic lad I am, I assumed that he was talking to me and said,

“Sure, sir.”

“Alright, give me your number. We will be in touch.” said Rajeev.

He saved my number, I saved his, and both rode into the sunset. Felt good to have contact of a senior.

“Why did you do that?” asked an angry Adil.

“Do what?”

“Let them know more about placements!”

“How would I let them know something that I don’t know myself?”

“You told them the placement dates.”

“Is that a secret?”

“You don’t even know what Chikkalduti is. Do you?... It’s a hell hole! Everyone wants a way out of there. They want to change their own postings. That’s why they asked you for vacancies.”

“How would knowing vacancies help them do that?”

“They just want to know all the vacancies available to graduates. If one of those is favorable to them, they’ll write a letter to the PMO. Vacancies will then change because, based on their seniority, their demands will be considered first. Ultimately we lose a good vacancy and get a shitty one as replacement. You do not understand all this because placements are not important to you. But it is crucial for us!... This is what we have worked for 8 months, man... Don’t screw it up!!”

“Oh... I must have bunked one of those classes where they discussed these.” I chuckled.

“Fuck, man... Nobody here would have entertained them. Because everyone knows what they are trying to do. Just block his number, and don’t you make the mistake of giving them the placement updates at any cost. Okay?”

“Got you, bro. Chill. Let’s get back to this numerical.”

Chapter 9

The Price We Pay

4th June 2018 | NEA Township, Vishvenpuram | The Placement Announcements

The Director, S.K. Chatterjee, was going to announce the vacancies himself. It was an event organized outside the mess with a special dinner. We were asked to arrive at 7 p.m. — Most of the trainees reached there by 6:30. Mahi knocked on my door at 6:40,

“Bro, let’s go... Whoa!! You’re not ready yet?!?! The fucking Director is coming, dude!!”

I was in my shorts with my shirt off — Sitting on a plastic chair — Pen in my hand — ISRO previous Year Interview Questions on my laptop screen — A rough copy miserably abused with solutions, burnt onto them for the last couple of hours. Without turning around and continuing to finish the derivation, I said,

“What’s there to get ready for? Chatterjee ain’t so pretty.”

“Bro, you are sorted... Just be there, though. Bala was looking for you.”

“He has been doing that a lot lately. I think I’m gonna have a word with his wife... About his tendencies to stalk hot young boys.”

“Then why ain’t he ever after me? I’m hot... Just playing the devil’s advocate.” Mahi chuckled, but tension regarding a peril was apparent on his face.

“That you are, sir... But you ain’t his type... Teenage-looking boys with baby-butt cheeks and lesbian haircuts.”

Mahi giggled as he took my deodorant off my wardrobe and sprayed it on himself till there was a visible fog around him.

“There’s a special dinner tonight, right?” I asked as I continued to solve the question.

“Yeah... food is going to be good... well... Better than usual anyway.” Mahi replied, placing the now empty can back in the wardrobe instead of tossing it into the trash can.

“Don’t worry, bro. I’ll be there by 7.”

At 7:15, I reached the venue. The Director was already on the dais and had begun his speech. His wife, along with Sudha and other senior Academy members, were sitting behind him. He was already talking about the same old,

“... Back in my Academy days, I was not only my branch topper but the overall topper. They just asked me where I wanted to be placed, and I chose Vishvenpuram over Kolkata, my hometown. Young Scientists should choose placement based on interest, not location...” He said with pride, which almost brought tears to both his and his wife’s eyes — Even though he had said the same shit at least a dozen times every year for the past 10 years.

I walked in, and everyone, who was also with moist eyes upon listening to the same inspirational story for the 12th fucking time, looked at me as if I was showing my middle finger to their beloved Director. I checked both my hands to confirm. I was not. I sat on an empty chair next to Mahi — Placed my right ankle over my left knee, and leaned back.

In about 10 minutes, I heard the director saying,

“... Among Mechanical Engineers, only one will be at SCAR, Mumbai. One is going to CTRC, Delhi. Two are going to NFRFC, Hyderabad. One is going to NRE. Six are staying at FBRC, Vishvenpuram, and one is going to MPE, Salrutpattinam.”

I had heard all the names except for the last one. I wondered,

“Ok, where is that? It’s not Chikk...kal...kutti... whatever the fuck those guys on bike said... Maybe it is at a good place... maybe near Mumbai, and one of the toppers will take it.”

Meanwhile, everyone turned around and looked at me as if I just died. Soon after the speech was over, I rushed toward Sudha and asked,

“Ma’am, where is Sal... Slaurp... patttinam?”

To which she replied with a big smile,

“It’s Salrutpattinam. It’s a beautiful place in Tamil Nadu, near Kanyakumari...”

My balls froze the moment I heard ‘*Kanyakumari*’. She continued to explain, but my eardrums rejected the rest. I stood among a crowd filled with 65% celebrating their luck and 35% mourning their fate. Amongst the chatter, I felt a pin drop of silence with a single question in my head,

“What am I going to do now?”

My legs autonomously started to walk in the default forward direction — It halted only when my eyes detected an obstruction — It was Rashmi, Keshav and Kunal.

“Bro!!Salrupattinam?!?” Keshav shouted.

“We were worried that Physics would get a spot from there... I lost sleep over it for days, but it’s Mechanical this year. Sorry about that, Ashwin. Hard Luck.” said Rashmi with sympathy in her eyes.

Simar stood beside Sumit, who had his palm over her shoulder, trying to convince her of something. Remember, I said I could always tell whether she was looking at or listening to me? I still had that, but there at that moment, she wasn’t. I could see in her eyes that she wished for all of this to be just a dream.

“No problem *bhai!* It has an Airport... though the flight frequency is low, but...” Rohit said.

His voice faded away as I moved past him nodding my head. I saw a few others looking at me and talking amongst themselves. Chandan gave me that smile that said,

“I have sympathy for you, but I’m happy that your craziness saved my ass.”

Mahi explained that this was the first time ever that recruitment from Salrutpattinam had been from SCAR Academy. Earlier, they used to select fresh graduates from NFRFC Academy, which has a similar one-year program, but the course has an industrial inclination. The NFRFC Academy was closed this year, but a shutdown Academy does not mean a shutdown Plant. Guess where they looked for fresh Engineers?

“Have some food, bro.” said Chandan.

Even in the darkest hours, it’s a sin to reject free food, so I took a plate and tried to get a spoon of rice into my mouth. It was the toughest morsel I ever had to swallow.

"Mahi, you were wrong. Whether the food today would be better or worse than usual depends totally on the placements." I thought as I dumped the plate — Walked to the pavement in front of #59 and called my father.

"I got Kanyakumari as placement." I replied without revolving in a circle.

"What?!?! They have centers there too?" Said my father with surprise in his voice.

"Yes, I also found that out just a few minutes ago. I am going to resign."

"Now now, Ashwin, don't be crazy!! Let's just think about it. Talk to them. They might change the vacancy."

After he suggested a few bullshit solutions, I concluded that he would not be of any help and decided to cut the phone.

For some reason, I got up and began to walk — Fast — As if I was trying to escape from reality. Soon, I found myself walking the same road to the grocery store where I had that arrogant conversation with my father. Each of my own words started to echo in my ears. It's remarkable that even though there was no such sound wave actually present, it felt like my ears were going to burst out. So much so that I, like a madman, pressed shut both my ears with my palms as I brisked.

"These are internal vibrations, and that too on resonating frequencies, kid. Can't be blocked externally. Talking is easy, dealing with the consequences... well... When the going gets tough?" said the mint one.

"Shut the fuck up! I don't need your *Baba Gyan* right now." I shouted.

"Looks like you need it now more than ever." he replied.

It was 9:30 pm, and the streets were empty, but I heard someone shouting from behind,

"... Hey, bro!... Ashwin!... Wait up, man! Where are you going?" It was Ganesh running towards me.

Acknowledging the fact that boys with that kind of weight don't usually run unless they have to, I stopped and said,

"Don't know." — Turned again and continued walking.

He started to walk beside me — I tried to walk faster — He tried to catch up.

"The place Salrutpattinam... it is not that bad, *you know*. I've been there. It's decent." he said as he tried to catch both me and his breath.

“Obviously, it will seem decent to you. So what are you going to choose? Mumbai or Vishvenpuram?” I said, trying hard to restrain my anger.

“... I’m going for SCAR.” he said after a little hesitation.

“Of course you are. See, even people from the south, who speak the language and eat the same food, don’t want to stay here. How can you expect me to like it?” I said it with a smirk of disdain.

He kept his hands over my shoulders, trying to placate as he said,

“I’m not saying it’s great, but it’s not bad either.”

I stopped immediately — Shoved his arms off my shoulders — Turned towards him, and shouted,

“The fuck are you talking about? It is THE worst!! Do you know how I know that? None of the 11 chimps above me will pick it over any other placement. This is the price we pay for going against the grain, for not doing what we are told to do. You know how hard I’ve worked. If I had put even a fraction of that effort into the Academy, I would be sitting with 12 choices right now. This is the price we pay for the risks we take!”

“I know that no one has struggled harder, Ashwin... Although we have more choices, you are the one who really had the guts to choose.”

He fucked it up later though, when he continued,

“There’s research everywhere. You can do great work even in MPE, *you know*. I’m sure...”

This caused a hypergolic explosion in my head,

“It’s a God damn chemical plant! We didn’t even get training for heavy water production. I’ll just be a maintenance guy over there. I’m resigning.”

“What?!?! Are you nuts?!? And do what!?” he asked in panic.

“I’ll find out, but I deserve better than this.” I said.

God knows where I would have walked out to in a city where I was as good as a foreigner, but the boy clutched my wrist — Motherfucker was strong — In my defense, we were in different weight classes.

“The fuck bitch? Let it go!” I turned and shouted.

“Tell me where you are going first.”

“To see your mom!”

“She lives in Kerala.”

“I heard she is worth it.”

“Shut up, bro... You can go all *Forrest Gump* tomorrow morning when you’ve thought it through.” he said as he swiveled me around — He let go of my wrist only when we reached #59. Back in my room, I unbuttoned my shirt, shut the door, and that fine, dreadful silence returned. I could hear the sounds of laughter and joy among other trainees in the corridor. The rich do not stop having lavish lives just because there are people starving around.

13th November 2015, 7:00 pm | Room O-108, Boy’s Hostel, AIT, Sikkim

“Ha papa! I got it... Yes!! I am going out with Akash and others now... Ha *papa ji*” said someone walking through the corridor — Probably on a phone call.

I was lying on the bed with no bedsheet — Alone in the room — Chin dug into the mattress — Staring at my wardrobe. Unbuttoned light blue shirt — Black trousers — Belt unbuckled — A slim gray tie thrown on the floor. On the left side of the room, which was my side, you could see A4 size sheets stuck on the wall with formulas important for GATE exam — On a few in front of my study desk, you could see my weekly, monthly and annual plan along with what subjects are yet to be covered according to the syllabus. Few formulas scribbled on the wall with pencil — Few self-made quotes — Biggest and the most prominent scribbled at the center read: “*Gyanam Paramam Dhyeyam.*”

In a few minutes, I heard my roommate’s voice from the corridor closing in. Soon, he was audible enough to understand what he was saying. He was speaking in his native language of *Nepali*. I had started to learn the language in the first semester itself, so I both understood and spoke *Nepali* well. He was probably talking to his dad on the phone. Euphoric, he giggled as he kicked the door in — Pause for a second, and then I heard him say,

“Hazur hazur... Rati ka call grchu papa... Aee sati, ke bhoyo?” said Arvind, who had been my roommate for the past 2 years.

I looked at him and then buried my face back into that comforting bare mattress. Arvind was a slim guy, about 5'8", and embraced the sport of football like many North-East boys. He was dressed in a neat and tidy white shirt, gray trousers, and well-polished black shoes — Wearing a navy blue tie, a metallic watch, and a pair of specs with a brown frame. He picked my tie from the floor, threw it on my bed and said,

"Aae jatha! What happened, bro?"

1 hour ago | Academic Block | The last Campus Placement

"I was looking for you in the morning... Your phone was switched off... I figured it must be airplane mode." said Akash while clicking his pen.

"Oh yeah, bro... I forget to turn it on when I finish my study sessions... Sorry dude."

"I guess it wouldn't matter... cuz when you are not studying, you are either sleeping or working out." He chuckled.

I laughed it off and asked,

"So why were you looking for me?"

"Needed a tie."

"Oh... I didn't have any either... This one is Ravi's."

"Yo! What a coincidence... I got mine from his roommate... After I checked your room, Arvind suggested checking his... I believe they were not eligible to sit for placements."

"Yeah... They are just happy they are graduating."

"Damn... What are they gonna do after?" Akash asked, confused.

"Nothing... But their fathers will. They'll be fine." I said as I stared at my bruised knuckles.

After a few minutes of silence and him continuing to relentlessly click his pen, he asked,

"Bro, you wanna come to Gangtok with us this weekend?"

"Naah man, you know I can't... GATE is closing in."

“Hmm... I get it... Others told me that it's kind of useless asking you.”

“How come they know me better than you?” I said with a sigh.

“They read all your motivational WhatsApp statuses, I guess.” He chuckled and punched my shoulders.

“I guess it's time you unblock me.” I laughed back.

“Seriously, dude... It's 7th semester... Our college life is almost over... Sikkim is a tourist place for a reason... You, staying here for 3 years, haven't even visited a single spot! At least enjoy the last semester... Your college life was more of library slash workout life in the hills... Have some fun, bro... Some memories.” He said.

“I wish I could... But there's so much guilt whenever I waste even an hour. I feel like I gotta pay the price... My college life was over the day I realized that this college was not gonna give me a decent career... That is why I am working hard... to get master's from a decent college. I will make sure I make time for fun in the next one.”

“That's intense... I am sure you are capable of getting into IITs... However, I am not sure if you are capable of settling.” Said Akash with two pats on my back.

It was the *Infonics Softwares Ltd.* recruitment drive. Annual pay: Rs 3,20,000. I would have never sat in this interview if only I was not still unemployed so deep in the 7th Semester. Before this, I had appeared for the following companies in sequence across the past 3 months:

- *TCS* recruitment

- I qualified both the interview rounds, but *TCS* never released the result never came back to AIT ever again for a campus drive.
- An invigilator caught a WhatsApp group that a few students used to answers on during the aptitude round.
- That round was waived off for me because of my high GPA, but it didn't matter.

- *Dell*

- I couldn't qualify the first round of coding.

- *Wells Fargo*

- I couldn't qualify the first round of aptitude.
- *Capgemini*
 - Qualified Aptitude round.
 - Qualify Group Discussion round.
 - Got rejected in the interview round.

This was the fifth and final campus drive for our batch of graduates.

"Any one of you can get in the moment someone gets out." said a junior who was the placement coordinator.

I was sitting beside Akash on a bench — In front of us were the doors to 2 interview panels. We had cleared the aptitude round that morning, the technical interview round at noon and were waiting for the final HR round for the past 6 hours. Around 200 students of our batch completed this round right in front of us. There was no order — Whoever had better contact with the coordinators got in first. With every other interview, the interviewers were getting less interested and more inclined towards rejection as they got closer to their target number. We knew for a fact that the left panel was occupied by two interviewers who were cheerful and pleasant to the candidates. On the other hand, the right one contained a straight-up asshole rejecting people left and right. Now the question that both of us were thinking, but none asked was: "*Which one of us two was going in the right one?*"

I had decided to get up and walk in if a candidate from the right got out. Keep my ass planted on the seat if the one from left comes out. Mainly because of the following three reasons:

1. I was preparing for GATE for the past year with the aim of IIT Bombay and ultra-confident that I wouldn't need this job.
2. This was Akash's last chance to get a job. And,
3. I was bloody confident that if someone could get selected via the right panel at moment, it was me.

"Bro, I'll go to the Right one." Akash said.

"Hey, hot shot! Don't sweat it... I'll go."

“Dude... He is an arrogant prick.”

“Is that your type when it comes to men? You like those rough ones, huh?”

“Fuck, dude. This is not the time.” Said Akash with a shaky voice as he took a deep breath.

“Bro. It’s all right. Do the math. I have a better resume and better speaking skills. I have a better chance of getting through the right panel... or don’t you agree?”

“Shit, man... can’t we both get in the left one?”

“I guess not. I believe we are the last ones.”

A girl came out from the left door with a smile on her face.

“All the best.” I said as I pointed towards the door with my eyes.

“Thanks, bro. To you as well.” he said as he adjusted his tie and knocked on the left door.

Two minutes later, a boy came out of the right one — He rubbed his eyes, exhaled, and loosened his tie in disappointment. I looked around — The coordinator, with his hand, gestured for me to get in.”

I picked up my file and walked towards the door — Pushed it slightly inwards, knocked and said,

“Sir, please may I come in?”

The interviewer was a bald man in his mid-40s — Angry as if his wife was walking away with half his property, his kids and his kidneys. He threw his pen on the desk, stared at me for 5 seconds and said,

“You want to give the interview from there?”

Confused, I smiled and took careful steps inside as I said,

“No, sir.”

He got busy typing something on the computer — Maybe a mail to his lawyer. I stood there silently, waiting for him to start the interview. After around a minute, he asked,

“You have got a name?”

“Umm... Yes, sir. My name is Ashwin Taksh. I completed my senior secondary in 2012 from...”

“Any hobbies?” He asked without looking at me.

“Yes, sir. I have been a student of Martial Arts for 14 years. I am a Black Belt in Sho..”

“Whoa! We don’t want violent people in our company.”

“I guess assholes are what your company really wants.” I thought.

“Why do you want to join this company?” He asked.

Still standing, with confidence in my voice and fluency in my tongue, I said,

“Sir, Infotech has the record of the best work environment for its employees. It would give me a perfect pedigree to kick start my professional career...”

“You can go now.” he said, with his eyes fixed on the screen — Still typing.

“Thank you, sir.” I said as I turned around and walked out.

That day, a total of 170 students out of the 220 who reached the final round got selected. One out of those 170 was Akash. One out of those 50 was me, another was Arvind.

5th June 2018, 5:00 pm | Quarter #59, FTH, Vishvenpuram

This year’s placement, at least for the Mechanical, was fantastic. 2 from Hyderabad, so Adil and Kabir got what they wanted. Ashu being second, would go for Mumbai. Even Kunal might get a Mumbai placement. Sumit was Rank #1. Based on his interest in Space Technology, I figured he’d choose Cryogenic Technology Research Center, Delhi. That’s what I would have gone for, given the option. They had projects running in collaboration with ISRO for cryogenic rocket engines. There hadn’t been a vacancy from CTRC in 5 years. That lucky bastard.

On the contrary, however, Physics Placements was a bloodbath. Out of nine, eight were from Vishvenpuram. Just one from Mumbai, while the internal competition had been the toughest in Physics. They had both the overall first and second toppers. Poornima was overall second topper behind Dipesh by just 4 marks but was going to stay at Vishvenpuram. Simar was at 3rd spot and would stay here as well. Well, she was right about one thing,

“It’s just 2 months. After that, we don’t know where you’ll be and where I’ll be.”

I was in my boxers, sitting on the chair with my books on the bed, trying to study *Turbulent Flow*, when I felt a hand on my shoulder and heard Mahi's voice,

"Bro? Studying for ISRO?"

"Yeah. What's up?"

He moved some of my books aside — Sat on the bed, and said,

"Nothing, man... Heavy politics regarding who's taking what posting. There was a four-hour-long meeting."

"How dare they not invite me?"

Mahi chuckled and said,

"You are lucky that you are not a part of this."

"I agree... What's there to discuss, though? Sumit is going CTRC; Kabir and Adil are going Hyderabad; Ashu is going Mumbai; Kunal will take his chances with NRE; the Rest 6 of you will stay at Vishvenpuram, and I'll get the hell hole. Simple."

Mahi smiled, scratched his eyebrow, and said,

"If only it was that simple... Word is that Ashu is considering staying here for Vaishnavi. Also, it looks like Simar is convincing Sumit to choose Vishvenpuram."

"Why would Simar want Sumit to stay?" I asked in surprise.

"Laws of Physics point to only one answer, dude." He said.

That's when a buried memory flashed on the curtain — This tiny statement that she blended in — Most likely you didn't pay attention because I, sure as hell, did not. That night in mess, she said,

"I don't really know where it is going to go in future, but..."

Well, as we have it, the *'future'* is now, and where *'it'* went is Out the Fucking Window.

"Wow!" I said in shock.

"The girls from far away are causing turmoil in the entire Mechanical posting. Ashu and Sumit never showed up for the meeting."

"But are these dudes that fucking dumb?"

Mahi moved more of my books — Moved his butt further in — Lifted his legs and crossed them to sit comfortably, and said with a smirk,

“That’s what we don’t know. Those two are probably not sure themselves. Maybe the girls offered them sex. But the point is, if the toppers are going to stay here, it opens up many avenues for the rest of us. There’s even a slight chance that I might get CTRC... If only Rohit takes Vishvenpuram.”

I dropped my pen — Placed my right ankle on my left knee — Leaned forward with my right elbow on my knee, and asked,

“Now, why would he do that? Did you... offer him sex as well?”

“Not yet. But I’ll try.” Mahi laughed.

Mahi further explained that within a day post the announcement of the vacancies, Simar and Sumit got sturdy close. Their casual, friendly walks to the beach converted to hand-in-hand couple walks. Sumit was now in Simar’s WhatsApp DP and Simar in Sumit’s.

The point to be noted was that Simar and Vaishnavi were going to be posted at SCAR, Vishvenpuram. It’s pretty easy to get a transfer from SCAR, Vishvenpuram to SCAR, Mumbai within a few years as it would be an intra-center transfer — Especially easy for girls. On the other hand, the job profile that Ashu and Sumit were being convinced to take was of FBRC, Vishvenpuram. SCAR does research in Uranium and Thorium based reactors, while FBRC does on Plutonium based. In simple words it is next to impossible to get a transfer from FBRC to SCAR and that too for dudes. It was clear as day what the girls were trying to pull, but somehow Mr. Rank *Uno* and Mr. Rank *Tres* of the great and prestigious SCAR Academy had their heads shoved up their asses. I’d have loved to witness the actual conversation where the two girls sat down with Sumit & Ashu, convincing them to choose Vishvenpuram. Surprisingly, I was not invited to that meeting either. Fortunately though, I’ve got a vivid imagination, and in my head, it went a little like this:

Vaishnavi: *Yo, guys! Here’s the deal, you know this year’s vacancies fucked us Physics people brutally in our asses, right?*

Ashu: *Right!*

Simar: *I mean, straight up rammed us!*

Vaishnavi: *You know that Physics was a geek fiesta, right?*

Sumit: *Right!*

Vaishnavi: *We licked every corner of the notes and professors. It was just 9 of us, but we formed 3 different political parties and played a fuck load of games for an entire year. Whoo!*

Simar: *Whoo indeed... But that nerd Dipesh was still able to beat us all. I mean, sure, Poornima is going to play her little games as well with him... showing him the research opportunities at Vishvenpuram, but he is not as dumb as you two, right?*

Ashu: *Right!*

Simar: *So he's probably going to Mumbai, and Poornima will take the best research profile. Lucky for us, we don't give a fuck about research! So, Vaishnavi and I are going to take the remaining two SCAR Vishvenpuram Vacancies.*

Vaishnavi: *Now coming to you numb nuts. You guys know I've been dating Ashu for 9 months now, and even though I regret that he's not nearly as handsome as Ashwin, he's all that I got now that I've gained plenty of weight because of this safe government job. So Ashu baby, I'm gonna have to ask you to take FBRC Vishvenpuram instead of SCAR Mumbai.*

Ashu baby: *But I won't ever be able to get a transfer from FBRC to SCAR in the future while you'll get it easily. (Scratching his bald head)*

Vaishnavi: *Oh, come on, baby... Vishvenpuram is a great place! Why would I ever leave it? I fucking love uthappam every morning, curd rice every noon, and Idli every night! I bloody love it when all the locals talk in a language I would never understand! I would never wanna leave this place. In a few years, we will buy a lovely house here. It would be so awesome to see our kids grow up speaking Tamil! (Vaishnavi turns towards Simar and winks — Simar winks back). So are you in, baby?*

Ashu: *Fuck Yeah!!*

Vaishnavi: *Coolio! Simar babe, it's your turn now. Make me proud.*

Simar: *Sumit, you know we have been very close for almost a year now. You've always done all the dumb stuff I asked for, like playing dumb charade with us, decorating floors with rangoli, and bringing cakes for birthdays on my command like a little bitch. I can keep going on, but you've done a lot to prove your loyalty. I am now confident that you won't leave me and run away to ISRO in future. That is why, recently I've developed feelings for you.*

Sumit: *Oh wow! A girl having feelings for me!? Yay!! When did you first feel so Simar?*

Simar: *4th June 2018, after finding out this year's vacancies, to be precise. So here's the thing, I'm gonna pretend I am trying to get out of my current 3-year-long relationship, dumping his ass for you. But he can't know until I find the "Right Time" to tell him. Because of my golden suggestions, you've already abandoned your dream of getting into ISRO. Can you please also just forget about going to the second closest place for Space Research in this country and stay here at Vishvenpuram? I really like to cry on your shoulders when I argue with my boyfriend.*

—Sumit starts thinking—

—Vaishnavi whispers into Simar's ears: "Oh hell no, girl! He is thinking. This is bad. You gotta give him something, add a baby" —

Simar: *Umm... Can you stay here for me b- ba..um...baby?"*

Sumit: *Fuck Yeah!!*

It might have gone slightly differently, but you get the point. Sumit and Ashu however, were not as dumb as my cartoonish imagination. They were playing their own games. This is where it gets complicated. Here's the easiest way to explain it:

Mechanical Vacancies	Mechanical Ranking
1. CTTC, Delhi	1. Sumit Timewala
2. SCAR, Mumbai	2. Adil Khan
3. NRE, Mumbai/Chennai/Delhi	3. Ashutosh Rana
4. NFRFC, Hyderabad	4. Kunal Kapoor
5. NFRFC, Hyderabad	5. Kabir Ram
6. FBRC, Vishvenpuram	6. Rohit Kerketta
7. FBRC, Vishvenpuram	7. Mahinder Pratap
8. FBRC, Vishvenpuram	8. Gyan Kumar
9. FBRC, Vishvenpuram	9. Nishant Sharma
10. FBRC, Vishvenpuram	10. Varun Jaiswal
11. FBRC, Vishvenpuram	11. Chandan Sahu
12. MPE, Salrutpattinam	12. Ashwin Taksh

Sumit

- Nobody knew what he was going to select. Probably not even Simar.

Adil

- People started to consider that he might not be that fond of going home.
- He was dabbling with the idea that if Sumit didn't take CTRC, he'd pounce.
- He thought that if he opened up about his desires, it might push Sumit to CTRC.

Ashu

- He told Vaishnavi that he would definitely take FBRC.
- But nobody was sure that he was that dumb. Boys were worried that he made promise to Vaishnavi to convince Sumit and Adil while secretly hoping Sumit Adil to leave SCAR or preferably CTRC for him.
- That would break Vaishnavi's heart, but if Sumit takes CTRC and Adil takes SC then Ashu will not lose a girlfriend and will make his peace with FBRC.

Kunal was hoping all three of them to fuck up. Kabir was happy that no matter what happened, he would definitely go home. Mahi and Rohit got greedy and began to dream of what had always been taken by the toppers. Even Nishant was dreaming of Mumbai now.

"Oh! now I understand what you guys discussed for hours." I laughed, slapping Mahi's back

"Yup. By the way, why don't you convince Chandan to consider taking Salrutpattinam? You never know. He might."

"Fuuuuuck that! I'd rather focus my energy on getting the hell out of NEA."

"Ok, dude... By the way, I've booked your seat next to mine."

"What seat?"

"Flight to Mumbai, bro... Placements are at headquarters."

"Oh yeah... Thanks, man."

An issue that had been bothering me was that the ISRO written test results were way too delayed. People started to speculate that ISRO might cancel their written test because this year's paper being too out of pattern. I kept roaming the libraries with my notebook filled with ISRO interview questions, and my head filled with

hopelessness. Nights were mostly sleepless — Alone in a dark room — Staring out of the window, thinking about the price demanded from those unsatisfied with what they are handed over. Nights on which I did fall asleep were filled with nightmares of me posted in some shithole — Simar walking away with Sumit with a sneer — Everyone talking behind my back about what a loser I am and how I could not achieve a single goal I worked for.

6th June 2018, 9:45 am | SCAR Academy, Vishvenpuram

Even though there were no ongoing courses, we still had to go to classes — government servants have to be at work even though there's no work. I was sitting in the class, going through some concepts of *Transient Heat Transfer*, when Mahi came and sat beside me. He said,

“You know Dipesh is going to meet the Director to try and change the vacancies?”

“Why? He's going to Mumbai.”

“But he wants to go to his hometown. To Cyclotron Research Center, Kolkata”

“Is changing vacancies even possible? I mean, S.K. said on 4th that there's no way it'll happen.”

“You want him to announce that everyone who doesn't like their posting can come to me and give me a good old mind fuck?... Lot of shady stuff happens behind the curtains, bro. I'll say you should give it a try as well.”

I talked to Sudha regarding this and found out that Dipesh and I were not the only trainees who wanted to change the vacancies. Simar had secretly come to her to fix a meeting with Director. Poornima had given it a try as well. But in the end, Sudha gave the appointments only to the overall topper and the overall botommer. We were called at 5:00 p.m. at the director's office. Since I had nothing to do in the classrooms and the place was a fish market stinking of politics, I decided to go to the library and strategize my negotiation with the Director.

5:00 p.m. | Director Complex, FBRC

Dipesh and I were waiting outside the Director's office. Dipesh went in first, and before I could take a proper look at the frames of all the legendary SCAR scientists on the walls, he was out with his head low.

“What happened, bro?” I asked.

He replied by sinking his head even lower and walked out, which said it all.

“Ashwin Taksh! You’re next.” announced the assistant.

I walked towards the door, which was made of teak wood with a shiny polish — A silver board said:

*S.K. Chatterjee,
Director, FBRC*

I pushed the door open and said,

“Sir, please may I come in?”

“Yes, Ashwin. Please come in.” He said with a warm enlightened smile.

I walked towards his desk, happy that he seemed in a good mood — Little confused though because Dipesh’s face had me expecting a vile temperament.

“Please sit down Ashwin.” he said in his manly voice.

I sat in that chair which had more cushion than my mattress. With that charismatic smile, he asked,

“So tell me, how can I help you?”

I knew that it was time to show him my confidence, a spark that he had never seen before, compelling him to personally talk to the NEA chairman and say,

“I don’t know what strings you must pull, but I want this boy to work for me at FBRC.”

“Sir, from the day I stepped foot on Vishvenpuram, I was sure I wanted posting at FBRC as this is where the work on the fast breeder reactors is. The future of nuclear power production. Looking at previous year’s vacancies, I was under impression that the last rankers would get Vishvenpuram. Hence, I never participated in the game of being a topper. I rather focused on getting more & more knowledge and learning the concepts well.” I said with confidence — Praying to all the Gods that I did not believe in, that Mr. S.K. over there doesn’t remember the classes in which he was teaching about how he designed and played a pivotal role in establishing the preliminary fast breeder reactors in the 80s and I was sitting in last bench — With my head resting comfortably against the wall — Sleeping — Recharging myself for a 3-hour study session in library post 5 pm — Not even trying to hide the fact that I

was sleeping in the class taken by the Director — Truth be told, for the first 5 classes, I didn't even know that Director himself was taking the class.

“Oh, that's great, Ashwin! I always say even though I was a Gold Medalist, in the past three decades, I have seen all the gold medalists going down the drain. So I am happy that I have some youngsters not caring about rankings...”

He sounded like I just convinced him, and I wondered why Dipesh, with all his achievements, was still kicked out so soon. Then he continued,

“... but as you know, I don't really have any control over the vacancies. People on top decide it. If it was up to me, I would keep all 92 of you in FBRC. We need bright young scientists like you here more than anywhere else in NEA. But the vacancies are sent from above.”

In one shot, he escaped being the villain and told me that the placement will not change. I tried to have a comeback by saying,

“But sir, we weren't even taught about heavy water production. Those courses go on in NFRFC. Won't it be wrong that we are posted over there?”

“I know, but what to do? For people on top, manpower becomes more essential than right and wrong.”

By now, I knew that this dude was playing it smart. There was no fucking way that he was not one of those “*people on top*”. His way was: *Make them like you, and they'll contradict you lesser*. He was the Director of the second biggest research center under NEA, and in the near future, we just might see him as the Director of SCAR or even chairman of NEA. He had enough pull to open a vacancy anywhere he wanted to. But why would he go against the grain for a ‘*nobody*’? So I decided to throw my final card, which would show him personal benefits. I said,

“Sir, I am highly interested in research. I was selected for IIT Bombay the same year I got selected for SCAR. I joined here only because I saw practical research prospects in NEA, but the vacancy in MPE is for a Maintenance profile. Give me a chance at FBRC, sir. You'll not regret it.”

“See Ashwin, MPE is the best place to learn about the career you are in....”

With that, I knew that I had lost the negotiation. He was not going to go against or even question his superiors regarding my case. After all, his superiors decide his next promotion. He continued,

“... You should go there, work for a couple of years, and get experience. Akhil, currently the Director there, is a good friend of mine. If you talk to him the way you talked to me and show him the fire you displayed here, he will certainly consider your case. You’ll come back here, and we’ll work together on many projects on fast breeder reactors”.

“Shit! He’s smart. He knows that I might be planning to bounce.” I thought.

He also knew that even if I followed his guidance and came back to FBRC 3 years later, he was not going to be here to welcome me. By that time, he would probably be in Mumbai directly under the P.M.

He moved his hand forward to shake my hand and said,

“It was nice meeting you, Ashwin. Thank you for coming.”

I got up — Gave him a smile — Shook his hand and said,

“Thank you for taking out your time, sir.”

“Pleasure.” he responded with a smile.

7:00 p.m. | #59, FTH

“... I am not sure if they’ll release the results either. In my attempt, it took just a month to publish it.” said Arun on a call.

“Yeah... what are you doing these days?”

“I was teaching at *Champion’s GATE Inc.* in Delhi, but after the accident, I had to stay with my family mostly... So I started teaching on *Crackify*. Their platform is 100% online.”

“I hear they pay well.”

“Good enough to get by.”

“How much?”

“2k... an hour.”

“When’s Railways joining?” I asked.

“Probably August... Hey, why don’t you apply for IIT Bombay again? Last year’s score is still valid.”

“I have already, but can’t leave even if I get it.”

“Why?”

“Bond, dude.”

“Just pay them off. That’s what I did.”

“How much?” I asked.

“Huh?”

“How much did you pay?”

“Around 60k.” he said

“Well, I gotta pay 400k.”

“Oh, shit!... Yeah... But you must have saved, right?”

“These fuckers deduct 7K every month on the name of their compulsory hostel & mess... Plus they deduct my one-day stipend every time they find out that I bunked a class. Also, preparing for exams ain’t cheap... you know that, bro.”

“Well... If money is what you need. I know what you need to do.”

“All ears.”

“You should start teaching like me. I am pretty close to the people at *Crackify*. They’ll get you started.”

“I’ll do it! Let me know if they get back to you.”

“Get back?! Bro, you’ll get a call from them tomorrow.”

7th June 2018, 7:00 pm | Outside a small shop, NEA Township, Vishvenpura

I used to get my eggs, milk and bread from a small general store about 10 minutes bicycle ride away. The lady who was the shopkeeper didn’t know a word in Hindi or English, but by now knew that I was there for. So the moment she saw me, she smiled and started packing my stuff: 12 eggs, whole wheat brown bread and a 1L milk packet — I took it with one hand, gave her Rs. 104 with another, and walked towards the bicycle I borrowed from Kabir. That’s when I got a vibration on my cell phone. It was Rajeev. The message said,

“Did they announce the vacancies?”

This was his 5th message since 4th June. I had ignored the previous four, but it was there in front of that small thatched roof shop, with my cell phone in my hands displaying Rajeev's message that a paradigm shift occurred and I started to question,

"What if Adil was the one playing games instead of Rajeev. What if Rajeev could give me a way? He is a senior after all... might know something I don't. Anyway, these toppers had done nothing to help me. For all I know, they are all going to go their merry ways in 2 months. If there's slightest chance that Rajeev can show me a way for things to change, I should at least give him a chance to explain. You don't look for Probability of Possibility, just the Possibility of Probability."

For me, it was worth a shot. What's the worst that could happen? Salrutpattinam or Chikkalduti, I was running away either way. And so I replied back,

"Yes."

"Is there any vacancy from the MPE?" he responded immediately.

"Yes."

"Can we talk over call?" he asked.

"I'll call you in 5 minutes." I texted and rode my bike back to #59 — Kept the eggs, milk, and bread in the kitchen — Took off my shirt drenched in sweat — Sat on the stairs of the quarter entry door and called Rajeev. Without any *Hi* or *Hello*, he got to the point,

"Is there a vacancy from Chikkalduti?"

Carefully wondering what his agenda might be, I replied,

"No."

"Then?" he asked

"It's Salrutpattinam." I said

"Holy shit!... That's even worse. Can you give me the contact of the person who is at last rank?"

Now knowing that I most likely am his only contact in the batch and not knowing his intentions, I was confused whether I should cut the call right there.

"Can you?" He sounded edgy.

"Yeah fuck it, worth a shot." I thought and said,

“It’s me.”

I couldn’t say if he coughed or gave an insecure laugh, but he took a pause and back in his monotone, he said,

“You should have told me earlier. This makes things much easier. See, you can change your vacancy... aaa... sign... you’ll have to skip... refuse it.”

There was a network connection issue, and on top of that, his Hindi and English both sucked an equal amount of dicks.

“What? Can’t get you.” I said, raising my voice.

He ended the call — In a few minutes, he texted,

“Someone’s going to call you in few minutes.”

Within 5 minutes, I got a call from an unknown number. In a jolly tone, a male voice with a Bihari accent said,

“Hi, Ashwin! This is Junaid.”

“Hi, sir.”

“You’re the one at last rank?”,

“Yes.” I responded.

“Percentage?”

“68”

“and of the one above you?”

“78”

“Anyone planning to resign?”

“No.”

“Anyone Tamil?”

“No... Two Telugu.”

“Where are they going?”

“There are two vacancies from NFRFC. Both have decent ranks, so they are probably going Hyderabad.”

“In that case, you’ll definitely get Salrutpattinam,” he chuckled.

“Is this my last hope?” I asked myself and jibed with a spark of anger,

“That’s interesting. Tell me more.”

He continued to giggle and said,

“*Arre...* We will... don’t worry. You’ll get another call in 10 minutes. Keep your phone with you. Don’t you miss this one.”

Exactly 9 minutes and 58 seconds later, I got a call from another unknown number,

“Ashwin Taksh... Born 94... Jharkhand... Graduate AIT.. 2016. Correct?” said a male voice, firm as a rock, calm and content.

“Yes, who is this?” I asked.

“Never ask that. You don’t need to know.” he responded with a cocktail of composure and confidence followed by an intense silence.

“Oh, ok... I just wanted to...” before I could speak some garbage to break the awkward silence, I heard a much more cheerful and preferable female voice,

“Hi Ashwin, Junaid told me you’re surely going to Salrutpattinam. We are here to help.”

She sounded like one of those frank girls who becomes head of cultural events, anchoring etc. in college — Effervescent — Playful — I could hear her smile through the shrill in her words.

“So, what is it that you can do to change my placement?” I asked curiously

“We are not going to do anything.” she chuckled.

I could hear that male voice laughing in the background. This started to seem like a prank. Just when I was about to cut the phone, she lassoed me with,

“... but you can do something. Something you don’t know of yet.”

“Do what?”

“I will tell you. But let me first tell you why it needs to be done.”

She then explained that Salrutpattinam was mainly recognized for its recent Police brutality case, which took the lives of a man and his two sons. This sparked the gasoline of already brewing hate against the local police and plunged the town into a full-fledged inferno of riots. The job profile at MPE was a 6 days a week, 8 hours a day plant maintenance in a heavy water production chemical plant with shift

rotations three times a week — What would you expect from a posting rejected by everyone with any other option? Some called MPE a *'Hell Hole'* because of the department's terrible work culture, where highly skilled and well-trained scientists are used as mere manpower. Others called it "*The Graveyard of Scientists*" for it neither lets you take research initiatives nor lets you resign. Filled with the last rankers throughout the history of the Academy, almost every employee in all the remotely situated centers of MPE has applied for a transfer. This makes it impossible for anyone to leave that place until you get some parliamentary-level jack or retirement — Whichever comes first.

There's a third way that has worked for employees as few as the number of successful North Korean defectors: You can pretend to be an absolute lunatic till they believe that you are really psychotic or till you really turn psychotic — Whichever comes first. Since most people have resignation as the only option, MPE did their best to put barricades on that path as well. A Rs 4,38,000 bond amount raised to Rs 5,70,000 just within MPE if you leave before your 3 years of service is completed. Want to prepare for another exam? They won't give you a No Objection Certificate (NOC). What if they found you are preparing anyway? Well, son, early next morning, you'll find out that you got a soul-sucking night shift till your beard turns gray. Did you get a job elsewhere anyway cuz you are too awesome? Don't get excited yet — Wherever you go, they will find you, and when they do, your new pretty company will receive an official letter claiming the illegality based on incomplete resignation from past employment. In which case, your new employer will have no option but to relieve you. Young talents of this country were easily found on depression pills within a couple of years of this mess. Their only fault was that they were last in the ranking list of a super competitive set of bright minds.

"My God! How the fuck did they let it go for 61 motherfucking years?!" I thought and said,

"So, tell me what I can do?"

And then, in her expressive voice, she finally told me,

"On the Placement day, everyone will choose their placements... Other than you... You'll get whatever the hell is left and trust me, this time, what will be left is surely hell! But it's not as simple as they note your placements on a piece of paper. The Government needs you to officially accept the post, so they will need you to sign and confirm that you are accepting the posting. At the end of the placements, they'll come with a paper for your sign, and behind that rough and rude mask, they'll be

praying to their favorite Gods for their life that you sign. When they come to you... and now listen to me carefully... when they come to you, DO - NOT - SIGN."

Immediately after God knows how long, I started laughing.

"Can we really do that?!" I asked.

"Yes. But listen to me carefully, Ashwin. This can bring your job in jeopardy." she said.

"Fuck this job!! I'm walking away anyways."

Sounding confused, she said,

"Really? We expected a bit of hesitation."

"Just Tell me what I need to know." I said.

"Oh... ok... Cool! Now here's the thing, there have been 2 such cases before, but the Agency has tried its best to bury it right where it was born. 2003, NFRFC Academy, Hyderabad campus, the last ranker got MPE Chikkalduti... the boy got so depressed that he started taking sleeping pills after placement announcements. When the moment came for him to sign, he started howling-crying like he had just got a life sentence! The chairman of the placement committee decided to change his placement to NRE with a clandestine meeting. The 2003 yearbook still shows him placed at Chikkalduti, but we know he is currently in Mumbai. 2012, Vishvenpura campus, A guy got MPE, Salrutpattinam. He straight up fainted on the placement day. We still don't know where he got placed, but our sources in MPE confirm that he never joined MPE. Instead, he joined somewhere in NRE. We don't know whether these were staged or these two boys really lost their shit on the placement day, but what's important is that it can be staged."

"*It is Possible.*" I heard — Relieved that I had a fighting chance. I asked,

"How do I go about it?"

"Do you have any acting experience, like drama?" she asked, sounding pretty serious.

"No." I chuckled.

"Then this is going to be your first one. See, looking at your attitude, it doesn't look like you are naturally going to cry or faint on the placement day. What will you do if you get Salrutpattinam?" She asked.

I replied immediately with pride,

“I did pretty well in this year’s ISRO written test. Throughout my Academy period, that’s what I was focusing on. Kinda the reason why I’m at the last position. I’m confident I’ll get through the Interview.”

“Does the Academy know about your ISRO ambitions?” She sounded apprehensive.

“Hell no!”

“They don’t know you’ve been preparing for competitive exams?”

“No.”

“Sure?” She asked again to confirm.

“Dead sure.”

“What if you don’t get through? What if ISRO null & voids the exam?”

“I’ll run away. I’m trying to get a teaching position at *Crackify*. If they give me monthly contracts, I’ll pay the bond when I have sufficient money.”

“What if it doesn’t give you a contract? I heard they are already having funding issues and are cutting down on tutors.”

“I’ll find a way out. Maybe teach in some small coaching institute, start my own course on personality development, become a barista or a delivery boy... but I’ll definitely leave NEA if I get Salrutpattinam.” I said as I got up and walked towards the pavement.

“You see? It is not your likely shot of getting into ISRO or your secondary income. It’s this mentality of, *I’ll find a way*, giving you confidence... You need to hide it at any cost. You cannot play it bold, or they’ll wipe you off like a pest. Understand that these old hags have big egos. If you show them that you are a whiny little kid, changing your placement will satisfy their ego as they’ll think that they used their powers for doing something good — That now they’ll go to heaven or whatever crap they’ve brewed in their heads. If you try to act tough though, the same ego will try to prove itself by proving your lack of power. Plus, the message propagating to the top should read that you did not sign because you were nervous and scared, not that you were trying to make a statement. So act like a scared little kid. Keep your eyes numb and your head low. Point being, you should look depressed.”

— *A sight of my meeting with the Director flashed through my head* —

After a stretched silence from my side, she asked,

“You haven’t yet talked to any senior authorities about placement change, right?”

Thinking that you should never lie to a doctor, a lawyer, or a bunch of strangers who don’t disclose their names but promises to save you for absolutely nothing in return, I said,

“Umm... actually... I did.”

“Who?!” she asked anxiously.

“The Direc...” I said at a low volume, deteriorating as I completed the word.

“Come again?!” she asked loudly.

“The Director.”

“Oh Fucking Hell!... He talked to Chatterjee.” she shouted.

I heard the guy in the background laughing. It was now the girl’s turn to go silent. In a faint voice, I heard them talk,

“I guess...cut it...too risky” she said,

“No... the kid... per... the job. Tell h.. to... depressed... Personality shift... scare them...” he said. And then his voice got clearer before it fainted again as if he moved past the phone,

“.... But they should get the idea that the boy’s gonna die if they don’t do somethi...”.

I could hear her exhale, and then, with a calmer voice, she said,

“See, Ashwin. That is a bit of a problem. But we think... You can make it right.”

I couldn’t have the suspense anymore and asked,

“Who’s that? And what’s your name? Are you guys also employees of NEA?”

“Ashwin, I know it might be difficult trusting anonymous people, but the truth is that for our safety, we can’t really disclose our names. All we can say is that we are a community that goes by the name of *Blitzkrieg*. Started by a handful of tormented employees of MPE. We have seen too many bright minds turned to depressed shells because of the idiotic system of SCAR postings. We work against everything wrong in the system, and it is important for those at the top of the movement to remain anonymous. Know that we have been operating for 6 years. We do many things to go against the system, but the annual Academy placement is our biggest target. Every year, we have tried our best to convince the bottomers to revolt, but to half of them,

their career is too precious to risk based on a telephone call... to rest, who listen to us to some extent, always back out on the placement day and ultimately signs. Later, when they join their postings, they always regret not listening to us. But once you sign, there's nothing we can do. We want you to know though, that it's ultimately your choice as it is your career."

For the first time, trusting someone other than me, I said,

"Ok. I want to do this. Tell me what I should do next?"

I could see her smile in silence. She said,

"Good! Now listen to me very carefully. What you have to do next is..."

Chapter 10

The Rebellion

“... to show them that you are depressed, that you’ve given up, and that something severe can happen if they don’t change your posting. Only under extreme circumstances will they feel the need to change a posting. That too, they won’t do it for you; they’ll do it to save their own asses. If something happens to you because of the placements, everyone from the Chairman to Academy authorities will be on trial. They will be stripped by the media. Do whatever you can to seem like you are a guy that has been shaken by this posting... Like you’ve lost all hope. This is entirely possible for a person with your posting, who has no alternative and is looking at a 35-year-long career in NEA.”

She emphasized strongly that I should keep our conversation confidential. If the word spreads that it’s an act, all of it would be compromised, and they’d not listen to me no matter what I say.

“I suggest you stay away from your friends, even the closest ones. They should also have a feeling that you are depressed. That you have changed. This would spread organic rumors, leading the Academy to take your case seriously. They’ll come to you. You don’t have to do anything.” she said with a surprising level of confidence.

The following day, our batch flew back to Mumbai for placements. I ensured I didn’t talk to anyone — Not even Mahi. We were supposed to stay in our old rooms at the STH. I locked myself in #804 and didn’t get out for things other than early morning gym, early lunch at 12:00 noon, and late dinner at 10:00

p.m. When I was out of my room, earphones would be plugged in — Wouldn't talk to anyone, answer anyone's call, or knocks on my door. I eliminated all the proteins like eggs, peanut butter, and milk from my diet — Focused on cardio in my workouts to lose weight — Slept for less than 3 hours every night to get that pain in my eyes. I lost around 5 kgs in the next 3 days. I took my role seriously.

11th June 2018, 9:00 pm | SCAR, Mumbai

Mahi was so worried that he almost broke my door knocking. I opened the door and said,

"I'm fine, bro. Focusing on the ISRO interview." and winked without a smile as I shut the door.

This was the moment when I was really terrified about the following day. I was figuring out all the possible questions, counter-questions, statements, and threats I would face.

I tried calling and texting the girl for more guidance but got no response, then I texted Rajeev. He told me to text Junaid, who asked me to call him. For a call, one needs to walk 800 meters to the main gate because of the terrible network at STH.

"So? *Maddam* briefed you well?" Junaid asked.

"Yeah, pretty clear, but I don't know what I'm going to do tomorrow." I responded with vivid worry in my voice.

"*Arre...* worry not about what you'll do tomorrow, but what you do NOT do at any cost. Tomorrow they'll do anything they can to make you sign, but no matter what happens, YOU DO NOT SIGN!" He emphasized the last three words strongly.

"I got it. I won't sign... Don't worry about it." I said with a subtle voice.

"*Arre*, you don't know... I'll tell you something that *maddam* didn't. I've researched all the other cases of placement change and all the attempts more than anyone else. First, they'll act as if what you are asking for is impossible, as

if it has never happened before. They'll even try to laugh it off. Meanwhile, in their heads, they'll be thinking: *Shit, what do we do now?!* Then, they will use terror. Most break just because a senior is angry and shouting at them. If that doesn't work, a few might try to privately convince you as if they are on your side. They'll pretend to be a fatherly figure, there to show you the correct direction. As if they are trying to save you from ruining your career. Fake promises of changing your posting once you join. If you still don't sign, they will threaten to spoil your entire career... not just inside but also outside NEA. Meanwhile, they would know that they can't do jack shit. Matter of fact, they are the ones who'd get a thrashing from above. About *Why isn't a boy willing to join MPE?!* I have seen too many bending on the final day, signing, and then being brushed aside by the system. If you sign, it's game over right there. We won't be able to do anything after that. Tomorrow is your opportunity to correct the system. Very rarely do the young get that opportunity."

Junaid had something about him, a tint of rebellion brimming off every word out his mouth. He hated the system more than anyone else and wanted to fuck with it as much as possible.

"Yes, sir. I'll do it. If there's slightest chance of this working out, I'll see it till the end."

"*Arre...* no slight *wight...* it will 100% work. Just do as I say. Also, no one else knows about this, right?"

"No one. I've cut myself off from everyone else that night itself."

"Good!... Tomorrow, when you say that you won't sign, they'll probably tell you to leave the room. To portray that your sign doesn't matter. When that happens, just walk away without saying a word so they believe you truly don't care. When you get out, don't answer any questions from the crowd, and go as far away from the placements as possible so that they can't find you. They know that if anyone else gets the faintest idea that placements may change, they'll be massacred by bottomers. Don't return for half an hour. By then, all the placements would be done, and everyone else would have signed. Act depressed... If you could cry, then believe me, job is done. Remember, OLD HAGS HAVE BIG EGOS!"

When I returned to my room, I made an entire flowchart of all the questions I would face. Every possibility had an answer ready, and all channels had the same outcome: I WILL NOT SIGN. I decided not to sleep that night as well and chose the loosest and lamest pair of clothes I had for Placements so that I look even skinnier.

12th June 2018 | Outside the Green Room, SCAR, Mumbai.

As if the *Cycle of Life* trying to fuck with me, Green Room was located on the first floor of SCB, right beside where I was interviewed for this job. We were made to wait in the same *Waiting Room*. The placement board arrived at 10:00 am sharp, and Bala asked us to stand in the corridor outside the Green Room in a queue — Rank wise — Starting from Sumit — Ending with me.

“Choose your posting from the available options quickly and walk out. They are very busy people so don’t waste their time. Have your choice ready... Ok, Sumit! They are ready. Get in. Quick!” said Bala.

As Sumit walked in, everyone’s heartbeats rose up a notch. He still hadn’t confirmed to the boys of his choice. Honestly, I was scared that he might turn out to be smart enough to choose CTRC. Sumit got out within a minute. Everyone swarmed him like bees,

“What did you take?” they asked curiously.

I was standing at a distance, not looking at him but eavesdropping. Another person standing at an equal distance from him, on the opposite end — Also not looking at him but listening carefully, was Simar. Ironically, extreme contrast emotions whirling within me and Simar brought the exact same smile when Sumit said,

“F-B-R-C”

Which is just a glorified way of saying,

“I am fucking stupid, and I chose a girl over my dreams.”

Nobody dared to ask the question going on in everyone’s heads,

“WHY the fuck!?”

But he answered with his smile, which said,

“What did you guys expect? You should have known that I’m dumb the day I flunked ISRO written test.”

“Of course.” I thought.

Next, Adil entered and got back out even quicker. Still mildly shocking but nothing compared to what Sumit did — He took NFRFC, Hyderabad. Now the situation was as follows: The first two rankers were out of the market, and both SCAR and CTRC were still on the table. If we had the seniors in our audience where the topper took Mumbai faster than *Akshay Kumar* finds things to jump off of, they’d have simply walked out silently — Gone to the black market — Bought some illegal guns — Some ammunition — And mutually blow each other’s brains out — Just to ease the pain.

Next, Ashu got in and also came out within a minute. Kunal asked nervously,

“What did you take?!?”

Ashu answered with a broad smile of the Devil,

“MUMBAI!!”

While Kunal got a full-blown Heart Attack, I said,

“Congrats.” thinking that at least someone over here got the brains.

Even Mahi followed me, giving him a tight handshake, forgetting their past differences, and appreciating his decision. Meanwhile, Vaishnavi, standing right there, was ready to cry rivers. Ashu walks to her and, like a *Bollywood* hero, says,

“I took *Vishvenpuram*, my love!!”

And then — They — Hugged — Like two electromagnets got triggered by the word ‘*Vishvenpuram*’. Their hug even made a *Chapp* sound which resonated with the sound made by mine and Mahi’s palms hitting our respective faces — Triggered by the same keyword.

So, after three toppers were out of the game, both Mumbai & Delhi were still untouched. What would the seniors say about this shit? Nothing! They are dead, remember? Somewhere between the trigger and *Chaps*, Kunal got in — Chose Mumbai and got out. Next, Kabir pushed open the door, picked NFRFC, and got out before the *Hydraulic Door Closer* could shut it. In shock and surprise, Rohit got in with 6th rank and got out with CTRC. Mahi then went in and picked NRE. I was delighted that he landed something better than Vishvenpuram. Subsequently, 4 boys walked in one by one and chose Vishvenpuram vacancies, leaving MPE Salrutpattinam for me. Bala, standing at the door, told the board,

“That’s all we have for Mechanical, sir.” — But was ordered to send the last graduate in. They wanted to see my face, to show a good gesture of respect to their soon-to-be colleague.

“Ashwin Taksh!! Get in.” called Bala.

I pushed open the door and walked in. The Green Room had a huge rectangular table — Around 15-20 senior scientists were sitting along each long side of the table — All Scientist ‘G’ or above — Few were Deputy Directors and Directors. The chairman of the placement committee, Amar Pratap Singh, was sitting at the short side end of the table — The farthest end observed from the entry door I had just walked in through. With a wide smile, he looked at me and asked,

“Ashwin, how are you?”

The act was on.

“Ahh... I... I am fine, sir.” I said with a gloomy tone.

“So, here’s the situation. Of the 12 vacancies, 11 are taken by those who performed better than you in the Academy. Unlike others, you don’t have options. We are left with the vacancy of Moderator Production Entity, which, to be honest, gives you a fantastic career.” He said and never missed a beat in his smiling game, even when he threw that bullshit at the end — Said it out loud with a straight face. Everyone else maintained the monkey shine as well.

There are moments in your life when you know what you do next decides where you go in future. Those moments are obnoxiously threatening, makes your legs tremble, and your internals shiver. At such a junction of life, most people are so afraid of acting wrongly that they don't act at all. At that moment, I decided not to do what was easy but what was necessary. Not only for me but for generations of scientists to come in this country. I did not choose this fight — I did what I was designed to do — This fight happened inherently, and when in fight, I fight.

“You there?... Thought I lost you there. Let's make it quick, Ashwin. Sign here. We want to end the formalities as early as possible.”, said Amar pointing at a clipboard with a list of names and their placements beside them.

I took a deep breath and said something that the Gods didn't write in the scripts,

“Sir, please change my placement.”

Everyone immediately broke into laughter as they sipped tea and chewed biscuits. But there was one man in the room experienced enough to realize where this could go. The chairman dimmed the amplitude of his earlier ultra-wide smile and said,

“See Ashwin, that is not possible. If it was, we would do it. But the vacancies come from the NEA Headquarters, and we have no say in it. So, you'll have to settle with the posting you are left with.”

“Sir, I am already way far away from my home. Staying at Vishvenpura for the past 4 months. Because of the weather and food here itself, I've lost 10 kgs. Now you want me to go further south... that too for plant maintenance work. I... I won't be able to go. We were never even taught about heavy water production. That position has always been reserved for Hyderabad campus graduates, sir.”

All laughter in the room had by now faded. The room was invaded by a pin-drop silence.

— *Slurp* — of an old lady daring to sip her tea for the last time momentarily broke the silence of the room — Then it was quickly engulfed again by its

arms until, with a blunt expression and a strong voice, the Chairman said,

“That’s not for you to decide. You will have to accept what you have been given.”

I replied with courtesy,

“S... sorry sir... I will not accept this posting.”

Now, downright ape shit furious — His eyes wide open as if he just found out that I fucked her daughter last night — While veins on his forehead popped out like one of those *Japanese anime* characters, he slammed his fist on the table hard enough to send shockwaves & ripples across cups of tea placed in front of everyone. He almost got off his seat as he shouted,

“How dare you?! YOU WILL HAVE TO ACCEPT! YOU ARE THE BOTTOMER!! YOU HAVE NO CHOICE!! If you don’t, you will be blacklisted forever in the NEA. Your entire career will be ruined! We won’t even give you a N.O.C. to apply for other jobs!”

“I am sorry, sir. I didn’t join SCAR for this.” I said in a low tone and stood quietly with my vision glued to the floor.

After a few seconds of unsettling silence again, he brought his volume a little lower to pull himself back into the professional domain and said,

“Fine. You don’t want to have a career... So be it. Open a shop somewhere; your Engineering days are over. I will make sure it is. We don’t have time for all of this. You can leave now.”

At this point, I was just surprised how accurate Junaid’s predictions were. I now knew that I could trust the *Blitzkrieg*. And so, I took steps towards the exit door.

“Wait...” Said the chairman.

I turned back and saw him holding the clipboard with a page with the Government’s seal. He continued,

“...You will have to sign here before you go.”

In my head, I went,

“Come on, you fuck! You need me to sign, and you still use the words like ‘have’? I don’t ‘have’ to do shit! I’ll tell you what you have to do: You have to sit down with these fine ladies and gentlemen around the table and decide where to open a new vacancy, for your worst nightmare is now a reality. You have a bottomer who will never sign unless you change the vacancy.” and said in my consistent melancholy tone,

“Sorry, sir. I do not accept this placement, and hence I cannot sign.” and walked out the exit door beside him as I heard the clipboard being tossed on the desk.

The moment I stepped outside, I saw everyone, including Bala wondering what the hell took me longer than the time taken by all 11 combined. Everyone started to ask me the same question in a chorus,

“Ashwin, what happened?”

I stuck to the plan — Without answering anyone, I disappeared from the scene. I went to a place I was very well acquainted with — A place you can never find me if I don’t want to be found — The Library. I went to its deepest corner, at the computer section, where I found JRFs preparing for exams.

“Ashwin, what are you doing here? Placements are today, right?” asked Ankit.

“Yeah, dude... Nothing I am needed for. What are you studying?”

“Heat Transfer... Hey, you knew how to solve this 2016 question, right? Can you explain once again?”

I took a look at my watch. It was 12:00 p.m. I knew some people would be looking for me. I even saw Kabir following me till some point. Probably Bala sent him after me. I knew he was sent in vain. I kicked my legs up and decided to relax for half an hour with the old hustler bunch.

“Sure... It’s the error function one...” I said.

We got back to the same old, ways to prepare for competitive exams coming up, discussing a few of our technical doubts, joking around about the misfortunes we’ve had with exams we had attempted earlier — Talking about

the strategy needed for upcoming exams. At 12:30 p.m. on the dot, I got up to walk back towards the Green Room.

When I returned to the venue, I saw Mahi holding his head with both hands, trying to rip all his hair out. The moment he spotted me, he came running towards me screaming,

“Bro!! What are you doing?! Have you completely lost it?! I thought you had left!! The chairman is so pissed off! This can ruin your entire career.”

Bala had giant sweat stains on his shirt, held the same clipboard, and looked equally petrified. He now brought me to a second room and asked me to sit down. He placed the clipboard on the table and said,

“Ashwin, you need to sign here.”

“Sir, I have already said. If you want me to sign, change the placement.” I responded immediately.

Bala wiped the sweat off his forehead with his handkerchief and said,

“Ashwin, try to understand *yar*. The Chairman is very angry. I have never seen him like this. He has said that if you don’t sign this, you’ll be blacklisted. That will stay with you for the rest of your career in NEA. If you want to leave NEA, he clearly said that we will never provide you an N.O.C. This will end your career Ashwin... before it even begins. Think of me as your elder brother and listen to me for the 12 years of experience I have at NEA.”

N.O.C. stands for No Objection Certificate. You need it from your current employer if you are willing to attend an interview for some other Government job. For me, the second employer would be ISRO. They played it well: If you stay in this organization, your growth would be severely stunted, and if you want to switch to another Government organization, we won’t let you. It was then that I understood why all rebels bent in the last moment.

“Give me the clipboard.” I said.

Bala immediately whipped it in my direction — Fast enough to break the sound barrier. I took the clipboard in my hand and placed it on the table — Turned the pages from first to last.

“Yours is the first name on the first page, Ashwin.” Said Bala.

I turned to the first page, placed the pen over the spot, and took a look at Bala. With gold in his eyes and mouth open, a few drops of saliva were just about to drip.

“Sorry, sir. I won’t sign.” I said and placed the pen back on the table.

“Where the fuck was this brotherly attitude when you repeatedly reported my absence and cost me multiple days of stipend?” I said in my head.

I took a good look at the change in his facial expression. That little shift from expectation towards disappointment and the gold fading away made us brothers even for all his hunting days. I got up and left the room. Mahi rushed to follow me while Bala stood there like a stone — His jaw still hanging. I now knew that everyone except me had signed — So did NEA.

I went and sat on the staircase — Mahi came and sat next to me only to bombard my brains out again with why I needed to sign to save my career. I allowed my silence to ramp up the tension. I had done more than sufficient to bring the spotlight solely on me. Next, the former head of the Academy, Mr. J.S. Mishra, sat me down in a room and said,

“I’m also from Bihar. I completely understand why you don’t want to go down south. But *beta*, unfortunately, you don’t have a choice. Your reaction is correct. What’s happening to you is unfair as well but the consequences of what you are doing will only hurt your career.”

Keeping in mind the act, this time, I played it even better. I myself turned emotional; even my eyes got a little numb. With his experience, I’m sure he had witnessed the last two placement change cases. I was sure he was not on my side. He kept trying to convince me, and I kept acting like a scared kitty who didn’t want to be tossed to the streets. In the end, he gave up and walked away, saying,

“I’m just saying this for your career *beta*. Rest, you decide.”

If there’s one thing I knew, nobody other than me gave a shit about my career. If they did, they would have demanded a change of my placement which, by

the way, I knew was in the hands of not only just the chairman but multiple other scientists sitting right there in the Green Room.

When I got outside that room, I was surrounded by the girls this time. Rashmi and Poornima started asking rapid-fire questions about what the hell I was doing. Maintaining the same grim face. I said,

“See, the placements suck, and I’m not gonna just accept it. They can do whatever they want, but I don’t have much to lose.”

“I wanted to revolt myself, but it wasn’t possible for me as they’d just send me out, and the next person would take what I left. Kudos to you though!” said Poornima.

Simar was standing right there, looking at me but not saying a word — Listening to every word that came out of my mouth. Sumit was standing 2 feet behind her.

Pretty soon, I heard the annoying voice of Bala again. He said,

“Ashwin, chairman sir is calling you back to the Green Room.”

Half expecting them to change the vacancy and half expecting to get chewed off again, I walked into the Green Room for the last time. The room looked a complete 180 from the last time I entered — It stench of fear for rebellion — The anger within the Chairman had made the air thinner. However, this time I was welcomed with respect by everyone apart from the Chairman, who stared at me with the intent to *Cyclops* me to dust. Sudha got off her seat and said with a smile,

“Ashwin, please sit.”

“No, thank you, ma’am.” I said in a low voice with a smile of respect and my hand wave.

“Please get Ashwin a mic.” said the director of F-BRD.

A peon came running with a mic, bumped on top of it twice to check if it was functioning, and handed it over to me. Chairman Amar, with intense determination, controlled his blood pressure with deep breaths and said,

“Ashwin, say what you have to say.”

I stayed quiet for a few seconds. The floor had fine polished mosaic tiles. Then I said,

“Sir, I want the MPE vacancy to change.” I said.

“Vacancies have never been changed in the history of NEA!! IT-IS-IMPOSSIBLE.” the chairman immediately lashed back.

There are moments in your life when you are told that what you want is impossible. In those moments, I want you to remind yourself that the world at that moment is trying its best to convince you that it is impossible. Because only then, after you yourself have accepted, does it really become impossible for you and the world has succeeded in making it impossible. There are moments in your life when everyone tells you that you are wrong — That what you’re trying to achieve is impractical — That the world doesn’t work like this. In those moments, I want you to remind yourself that this is the natural reflex of the world to keep the population in order — Control the Entropy — To keep you in your place. The ones who think they are different, the ones who refuse to accept that this is the way the world works, are a clear-cut threat to the system and must be repaired, quarantined or deleted. If you want to be one of those that bring change, you’ll have to ignore what the world says and believe in what you think is right. Most believe that what the majority says must be correct — Little do they know that the majority’s opinion is also instilled by the minority. Not the Rebellion minority but the Leader minority — The Powerful minority — The minority that holds the majority of wealth & power.

The Rebels and the Leaders are not much different. Both comprise a tiny percentage of the population — Both have their own vision of how the world should grow up to be — Both have principles of how the world should work. It’s just that the Leaders have the power to implement, and the Rebellions have the courage to stand up when the system itself has forgotten about the sense of right and wrong, which were once its very foundation. Everything starts with the right reasons but ends with the wrong values. Those who started it, did it because no one else could have. But unfortunately, the lifespan of humans is

too short, and soon you see the system operating long after its creators are gone. Along the way, when you pass on the administration, the chain of command, and the technology, you somehow fail to pass on the vision and the ethics that the founding fathers started it with. Now, it's just a machine — Lacks the soul. The soul can be reincarnated only by the spirit of the rebels who bring the train back on the rails — Navigating the rocket back to its intended trajectory.

“Sir, if the vacancy can change for the Topper, why can't it change for the Bottomer?” I asked.

Confusion diffused in the room. After a few seconds, with wrinkles up his forehead, Amar said,

“W-what are you talking about?”

“F-BRD had a vacancy under Dr. Velmurugan... But it changed to a vacancy under Dr. Swaminathan. That is the posting that Rank 1 of Mechanical Engineering Chose.” I said.

Last week, Sumit was making circles around F-BRD (FBRC - Bureau of Reactor Design), to change the Scientist under whom he would get posted if he chose Vishvenpuram. All the Vishvenpuram vacancies were in the domain of Structural Design and Automation. Sumit was already compromising with the location and the area of interest. To the least, he wanted to work with Fluid Flows — The closest he could get to his actual area of interest. Chatterjee had a tough time every year explaining to his superiors what was so bad in FBRC that only those with no other choices ended up there. Sumit knew that FBRC would do anything to get a Topper to not only send a good message up top but also to set an example for future batches. On 9th June, he fixed a meeting with Chatterjee. Apparently, leveraging his Gold Medal, he gave an ultimatum to S.K. and said,

“Either change the area I'll be working in, or I'll choose CTRC over FBRC.”

Chatterjee secretly affirmed the deal with a handshake. This was the reason why Sumit was so secretive over the past week. They did their best to keep it in the dark, but the *Blitzkrieg* had contacts deep in F-BRD. I found out that the

information was accurate the moment I walked into the Green Room, where Swaminathan was on the board representing F-BRD instead of Velmurugan. Both Amar and Swaminathan, obviously knew all about it the whole time while they denied the possibility of vacancy changing.

Amar now went quiet — Murmuring diffused amongst the other senior scientists in the room as nobody other than those two knew about this. Many of these scientists weren't experienced enough to know about the 2003 & 2012 cases, so they actually believed that what I was asking for was impossible, until now. I heard the madam from NFRFC whispering to the scientist on her left, "The kid makes sense..."

Some percentage of members of the board already wanted to side with me but were in a dilemma of whether to side with the Leader or the Rebel. After all, the Leader gives them a job, and the Rebel jeopardizes it. The conversation exchange silence was broken by a fat, bald man in his late 50s who I had only seen the shoulder of from behind so far,

"Boy, the MPE vacancy is very good. Don't know who has told you what about it, but Salrutpattinam is a good place..." Meet Mr. Padmanaman, Deputy Director, Moderator Production Entity. Guess he had sunk into depression ever since I mentioned that I won't accept the posting.

"Sir, I... I can't go that... that down south."

"You want some placement in the North? We have centers in Odisha and Rajasthan too. Would you like any of those?"

Would ya look at that! What was impossible was now negotiable. I said,

"Sir, we've not undergone one-year training in Nuclear Science and Engineering to be a maintenance engineer in a heavy water plant. Moreover, we specialized in liquid metal moderated reactors and were never trained for heavy water production. Why did we go through that training then?"

Now Padmanaman went silent, and muttering ramped up further. More of the crowd started to wonder if this kid who looked like a heroin addict was actually right.

“Which department in NEA do you think will give you a satisfying job?” asked Swaminathan.

He was sitting right in front of where I was standing and was listening to me carefully without uttering a word since the beginning of this hassle. I said continuing the depressed act which by now came naturally to me,

“F-BRD department of FBRC, Vishvenpuram, sir. It has research work on plutonium-based reactors. I am interested in working there. Sumit changed his placement, but that doesn't change the requirement. There must still be a vacancy under Dr. S. Velmurugan which requires a Mechanical Engineer. Please give me that.”

Chatter now had reached a point where the board was broken into groups of 3-5, having their own discussions. I knew that the tide had started to turn. Dr. Swaminathan gave it a thought and said,

“I think we can work something...”

Just when I thought I got them, he was violently interrupted by Amar's roar, who shouted,

“Manikandan! You won't make that decision!! Listen...”

Now turning his murderous gaze towards me, he continued,

“... Moderator Production Entity, Salrutpattinam is what you are going to get!! Take it or leave it!” He clicked his finger and pointed towards the same door through which I left the last time.

Understanding that if I pushed him any further, he was going to get a heart attack, I decided to stay quiet — Placed the mic back on the table gently, and turned towards the door — The moment I took a step towards it, he shouts again,

“Before you go, you HAVE to sign here!!”

Surprised by the response from the rest of the board — Disappointed that the placement wasn't ultimately changed — Injured but strong enough to portray vulnerability in my eyes, I turned towards him and said,

“Sir, I do not accept this placement. Hence, I cannot sign.”

I turned around, took deep breaths, and walked out of the door — The chatter of the Green Room faded as the door closed behind me.

That night, precisely at 10:00 p.m., I got a call from an unknown number but knew exactly who it was. She said,

“Good job Ashwin. Now this is what happens next...”

Chapter 11

Rock Bottom

“... Damage is done, but they will stay on your ass for a few more days... still trying to get that signature. Late sign is still better than no sign for them. But as long as you don’t sign, you’ll be in a *Limbo*. They can’t ask for the bond as you didn’t resign, and they can’t force you to join as you didn’t sign.” Stunned by their planning and understanding of loopholes, I said,

“Wow! You broke the system using the system!”

“No honey, you did. We just told you what you did not know.” She said.

“Well, ma’am, I did what I did because I had no choice.”

“Do you know how many conversations I have had in the past years at this moment with the bottomers explaining why they signed? Everyone always has a choice. It’s just that you did not give yourself an option... I’ll tell you what, though... You are a sensation across NEA now.”

“What do you mean?”

“Well, after the placements, what happened next is exactly what we wanted. The news ravaged the Agency like a forest fire. Everyone knows about what you did, and you know what?... Everyone appreciates what you did. They call you: *The Boy Who Did Not Sign*.”

Back in Vishvenpuram on the 14th, I realized what she was talking about. Other trainees told me about how people across NEA were asking,

“Who is this Boy Who Did Not Sign?”

A few knew my name, fewer knew what I looked like, but everyone had heard the term “*The Boy Who Did Not Sign*” and of what had happened on the 12th. Senior scientists admired my bold decision of not signing. They believed it was about time someone stood up against a rusted system and stopped the annual slaughter of careers. After all, I was at Vishvenpuram, the land where many Bottomers had found their final destinations. A lot of them shared their own stories, their own attempts at a rebellion. One such scientist shared a very interesting Idea: The Bottomer should also be offered at least 2 choices — While another shared how she was promised a particular research profile for which she chose FBRC, Vishvenpuram over NFRFC, Hyderabad, but within a couple of months, she was smoothly and silently broomed to a plant for maintenance work. Many such cases started to pop out — Buried stories dug their way to the surface because of an event that wasn’t supposed to happen. The more I learned about them, the more I realized that this was bigger than me. I was hearing all these not from the scientists themselves but through my batchmates, who were constantly approached to know more about the boy. My colleagues also told me that some of these very senior scientists wanted to contact me and offered help. Junaid, however, strictly directed me not to talk to any of them as anyone might be connected to the Academy — Testing whether I was really depressed or just faking it. He told me they needed to understand that I would not join Salrutpattinam at any cost, or they would not change my posting — The act needed to continue.

15th June 2018, 12:00 pm | SCAR Academy, Vishvenpuram

Sudha had sent a message through Bala that she wanted to see me in her office. This was exactly what we wanted. When I reached her office, she welcomed me with a smile and asked me to sit. She took a seat right in front of me and said,

“I’ve gone through your record Ashwin. You had a striking CGPA of 9.57 in undergrad, one of the Toppers of your batch. How come you became the Bottomer here in the Academy with an aggregate of just 68%? What went wrong?”

“Ma’am, my way of studying has always been to learn something in a way you utilize for the rest of your life. When I got into the Academy, unfortunately, I found that the method required to score marks here is to learn something until the next day...”

I tried to summon my most brutal memories — My father — Simar — ISRO failures. All these events that seemed like constant stabs to my guts caused one teardrop to automatically roll,

“.... I never cared about the placements as I saw the previous vacancies where the last one always got Vishvenpuram. I was okay with that. I thought, let's focus on learning things and not participate in this rat race, but I never thought I'd have to pay with my career for it.”

At that moment, I knew that if Junaid was watching me, he would have said,

“Arre... Proud of you!”

I never realized the power of tears until that point. The moment Sudha saw me with wet eyes, her expression transformed. She said,

“Ashwin, please control yourself. It is very important for us to endure tough times... umm...”

It was then that she finally broke out something she was not supposed to,

“... uh... We have actually changed your placement from our side. We are just working to sort out a few things with the Headquarters.”

If only I knew, I would have cried rivers on the 12th itself. For the rest of the conversation, I controlled my laughter while pretending to control my tears. In the end, just before I left her office, she said,

“I'm sure they can make some adjustments... If it's just one graduate.”

All the other TSs checked in and began their projects. To put out a statement that I was not accepting the placement, Junaid suggested that it be better for me to not show up.

“We have checked it from our contacts. Your name has not reached MPE Salrutpattinam's files. They have received only two new names, both from Chemical Engineering. But the deal is only sealed when the Director calls you and gives you in writing about the change of placement. He will need your sign of placement acceptance on that as well. Until then, you'll have to maintain the act.” said Junaid on a call.

On 16th June 2018, at 9:05 pm, my dad called me to confirm that I would not resign. I confirmed that I was definitely going to resign. I was still a boy and

secretly hoped he'd ask me to come back home. He never did. He never called me again.

Two days later, my mother called. She asked,

"How could this happen, Ashwin?! Didn't you study well?"

"All I do here is study day and night." I said.

"That's a lie. I am sure you are having too much fun and wasting time." she said confidently.

It was one of those pains that made you smile.

I kept silent for a few seconds as the world I knew crumbled down right in front of my eyes. I woke up to Reality — It was Dark — It was Scary.

"Since you are so sure, there's nothing left to say." I thought and asked myself,

"Is there nobody who believes in me?"

I took a deep breath and ended the call.

The one thing I was sure of was that I was going to come out of this situation. I was never going to stop until I won. I was relentless, and I would have moved mountains for those who supported me when I needed them the most — Who saw me for what I could become — The way I saw myself. But some people lost that opportunity forever. Those who did not bet on me when I was losing were 'Losers' in its truest form. I added a 'Loser' behind the names of both my parent's contacts in my phonebook before I blocked their numbers.

Carackify never got back to me. ISRO still hadn't released the results. The "Exam Canceled" rumor was now in full swing. If that rumor was to turn out to be true, I'd get back from,

"God Does Not Exist." to *"God Exists and hates my fucking guts."*

It was time for me to consider if ISRO was canceled, and if the revolt did not work either, I would have only one option: *Run away from NEA*. I didn't know if they could really press a bond of Rs 4,38,000 on me because of the *limbo*, but if they did, I'd need some serious cash. I checked my bank account, and even after saving every last penny, I had a net amount of just Rs. 2,00,000. Now, let's look at the bright side: NEA is huge and hence, sluggish. If I just walked away without paying, It'd take them years to catch up. I had the confidence in myself that, given the

time, I would find a way to earn somehow or the other and pay back the bond to get official resignation.

If I did run away, my career in the Government sector would forever have a *Dahaka* behind it. I would be blacklisted by NEA, and even if I did get into ISRO over time, the background check in one year probation period might toss me out. But, from my probation period at NEA, I learned that the Government only checks your history in places you've mentioned while joining. You're not supposed to lie or hide something deliberately — But then again, there were a lot of things that I was not supposed to do but did anyway.

“Life is Not Fair; hence it's Unfair to Play it Fairly”

If I get selected for ISRO, It will take at least 3-4 years for them to find out that I have a history at NEA and that I appeared in ISRO interview without NOC.

Worst case scenario: They toss me out.

Best case scenario: I get a little smacking and a black star which hampers my growth in the organization.

3-4 years was the time I would have to make my exit from ISRO — Lesser if some senior scientist of NEA took it personally and started a hunt. On the bright side, the ISRO dream was still on, and after leaving it, Space organizations across the world would welcome me with open arms as I'd be the *Golden Goose* with work experience in both India's Space and Nuclear Program. But for now, Where do I go? And what do I do?

18th June 2018, 1:00 a.m. | NEA Township, Vishvenpuram

I was at the beach looking at the Moon — Crescent, Red, and Spookie — Inches above the Horizon. There were no artificial lights on the coast which were majorly inhabited by fishermen — The beach sand, the fishing boats, and the Bay of Bengal had a reddish tint. I celebrated the horror of that night like Americans celebrate *Halloween*. But work had to be done, so I took a deep breath and proceeded back to #59. Just 10 minutes of walking drenched my shirt in sweat — I took it off as I entered my room — Shutted the door and looked right — My eyes fell on the mirror — Instantly a sight of 12th January flashed in front of my eyes — A memory of those moist eyes.

“I have done such a spectacular job... of making my life worse with time.” I said.

My hands were skinny — I did not have any body fat — If all the food of this world was somehow wiped away — I would be the first to die — You could see my collar and elbow bones peaking out — I raised my arms and could see my ribs. Bring a medical student, and my body could be used to study human anatomy — On the bright side, 8 packs were ripping. Looking into the mirror, I said,

“At least you are hot... What do I need to do now?”

“What you need to do is get me some fucking coffee, bro!”

“Fuck yeah! Let’s get us a job.”

With a cup of coffee and a cookie, I started to look at my options. On paper, I was a Mechanical Engineer with a GPA of 9.57 — Soon to get a degree in Nuclear Science and Engineering from world-renowned SCAR. So it was time to pitch these qualifications smartly in the open market. I started looking at my options,

1. Youtube

- My channel was booming.
- Last video had gotten 20K views.
- I decided to look into how YouTubers actually make money.

2. Private Sector

- India didn’t have a Space X. Automobile Engineering would be my second choice.
- Websites of these Automobile based companies had a “Careers” page, and I found simple procedures to apply for companies like *Mercedes*, *Bajaj*, *Mahindra* etc.
- I had an Uncle as HR in *Maruti*, and my brother had been an HR in top MNC for the past 4 years.
- I had my 8th-semester internship at *TATA Motors*. My guide there, impressed by my skills, had offered me a job in 2016.

3. Exam Coaching Institutes

- I had qualified GATE thrice and had gotten selected in SCAR & IIT Bombay.
- This would help me get a teaching job in coaching institutes.

I called Arun again. He said,

“Sometimes these people need a little thrashing.”

Next day, Javed became my Point of Contact (POC) with *Crackify* and asked me to make a demo that would be judged by their content team. *Crackify* provided tutors with an app to make lectures where you'd upload slides and speak to explain. The app would merge and sync both in the form of a video the students could watch online for free. I immediately started the process. In a day, my first demo got rejected. They complained about the “Font”, the “Slide's Picture Quality” and “Background Noise”. I sent the second one with significant improvements, but that was rejected as well, stating that “Visual Quality” wasn't up to the mark. I sent 3 more — All rejected — Rotating the same reasons periodically. Giving up was not an option, so I sent 4 more — All rejected. I tried to turn off the fan, close the window and record in my wardrobe. But no matter what I did, they were not satisfied. So I decided to send one every day and majorly focus on other options.

I took a look at how much money my YouTube channel could make. Most people said YouTube was a good source of income. When I really looked into it, I was reminded again why you shouldn't listen to “Most People”. YouTube was the shittiest way to make money in 2018 for a young Channel. You required a minimum of 1000 subscribers and 4000 hours of watch time in the past year to monetize your videos — That's when your videos will show ads, and you'll get a tiny... really tiny portion of the actual money that the advertisers were paying YouTube. After 8 videos, I stood at 500 subscribers and 1500 hours watch hours. With research, I found out that even if I hit the milestones, which would take at least a year looking at the rate, the amount of money generated would be so low that at least for a year more, I'd be earning close to just 20-30 Dollars a month — If I were regular with my content. Payment would be made not before I hit another threshold of \$100 which was then equivalent to Rs 7000 — It would approximately take another 3-4 months. Yeah... like I said, the shittiest way of making money.

Next, I turned my vision toward the internship I did under Mr. Ravish Chaturvedi. We were on pretty good terms as I had made much of his work easier by doing all

his CFD for free — It was pivotal for his promotion interview. When I called him, his response was as expected. Exhilarated, in his classic nasally slurry voice, he said, “Oh! What a pleasant surprise Ashwin! I’m so glad you called. How are things these days?”

For 4 months straight, he harassed me to publish a research paper, appear in GRE and go for MS abroad. He seemed to be obsessed with research. He used to say, “Real Engineers do research. Others are just technicians and managers pretending to be Engineers.”

At the end of my internship, when I had finally fulfilled his wish by publishing a paper, and he had gotten a promotion, in a solitary conversation between *Mentor* and *Disciple*, I asked him,

“Ravish Sir, how many research papers have you published?”

After a little pause, he answered,

“Zero.” And smoothly transitioned the conversation toward a book he had published — A love story. He explained how the main character was none other than him. Who would have guessed? When I asked him,

“Ravish sir, is it your true story?”

After a little pause, he answered,

“No. It is a fictional story.”

I later found out that he had an arranged marriage where his wife’s parents had “gifted” him a Purple *Maruti Swift* on the wedding night. He insisted that I read his book to learn a little about “*Art of Writing*”. When I asked him for a copy, he smoothly transitioned and gave me an Amazon affiliate link instead — Recommending I should buy it. He further asked me to give it a 5-star rating and to add a positive review. He should have written a book about his Big Balls.

For obvious reasons, I told him that I’d do all those and never did. So, to sum it up, the guy preaches research but doesn’t do any — Writes fictional love stories about his fantasies and does horrible marketing — Makes his interns do the heavy lifting and uses the results to get a promotion. Why would I go back to him? You would ask. Well,

1. Gotta applaud the hustle. And,
2. That promotion made him Head of Research & Development of 6 Cylinder Engines at *Tata Motors*. Post which, he did offer me a job as a CAD Engineer declined due to my GATE ambitions.

“Everything is going good, sir. I got into SCAR. My training is almost over.” I said.

“Oh, yeah! I came to know about it last year. Great job, Ashwin! I always knew that you were going to do something great. So, how is Nuclear Research going?” he asked.

“It’s going great, sir! This place is amazing, and the level of work is truly wonderful.”

“Right!? I can only imagine.” Said, Ravish.

“Yes sir... But after being here for one year, I feel like I had much more fun in just those 4 months working with Diesel Engines. I think Automobile Engineering is my true love. I’m planning to get back to that sector once I’m done with my degree.”

“Oh, that’s great, Ashwin. There’s plenty of work in this industry for a talent like you. Matter of fact, I was damn sure that a Government Job could never satisfy a dynamic person such as you, who seeks constant and rapid growth! Being in this industry for this long, I know at least 5 places perfect for your skills... Actually... one is a startup by a very close friend of mine. He is developing his own IC Engines. A brilliant fellow... Based in Bangalore. I think you’ll fit in there perfectly!!”

This was easy. Ravish offered himself! He said he would talk to his friend and get back to me. But I needed more options to secure my career.

Next, I called two relatives: My uncle, Rajat, who worked as HR at *Maruti Suzuki*, and my brother, Abhinav, who was an HR at *Garnier*. When I called them, as expected, they were welcoming. Uncle talked to me just like he used to for as long as I could remember. I had last met him at Ranchi at his son’s wedding. I was recently selected for SCAR then. I remember him saying,

“Proud of you, *beta*. You are the first from our family to plant our flag in the Central Government!”

These two were not Ravish. These were family. I literally grew from a toddler to 6 ft tall in front of their eyes. I decided not to play any games and just tell them the truth — That I was in a bad spot and desperately needed their help. But the moment I disclosed my situation, his tone pivoted to professional — More so than Ravish's. He said,

“Yes, Ashwin. Do one thing... send me a mail at rajtsd237kumar@emp.maruti.com. We will review the current vacancy scenario and get back to you in a day or two.”

Then I called my brother. He first had to be convinced for half an hour that leaving NEA was the right thing to do,

“Father told me that you are ruining your career Ashwin. You can't really think of leaving a Government job. All of us are not fortunate enough to get one.” he said.

“See, *bhaiya*... If ISRO cancels this year's exam, I'll have to find a way to build a... Basically, If I go to Salruttattinam, I'll be stuck there forever. You don't know what it's like there. You'll have to trust me on this one. I can see these things happening, you know that, right?”

“I'll see what I can do.” he said.

Which basically meant,

“I'll talk to Dad and decide.”

22nd June 2018, 8:00 pm | In front of #59

“So uncle, is there a vacancy I can fill?” I asked uncle Rajat.

“No. Nothing for now... But you can look for other companies. There are many companies in the automotive sector.” He said.

“I applied for a dozen but haven't heard back from any of them.”

“Well, you have to work hard for it. You have to build up your resume. Reach out to people and get recommended. It's all about recommendations.”

Well, that's what I was trying to do — Get a recommendation. A senior HR who has worked in *TATA Motors*, *Caterpillar*, and now in *Maruti* — One who has had 30 years of experience in the industry doesn't avoid giving you a recommendation

because he can't but pretty much like the Director, because he doesn't want to. Speaking of which, Ravish stopped picking up my calls or responding to my texts, which was even worse than saying 'No'. Both of them then got a "*Loser*" behind their names in my phonebook.

I was sad, frustrated and angry, but I wasn't broken. However, I had to seem broken — For that, I decided not to sleep at night — Completed a few portions of sleep in the Library whenever my body called for it — walked the early mornings with red eyes — Wore tattered clothes like I had lost all hopes — Stayed away from hair products that I was so fond of and stopped shaving. I knew I was putting my body through extreme cycles and earth-shattering pressure. So, to avoid snapping, I made sure not to miss a beat on my diet & workout. Several senior members of the Academy called me multiple times to check on me, mostly telling me about the bright side of MPE and why I should accept the placement. I maintained the same act, and soon, they went silent. The problem was, so did the *Blitzkrieg*. That's when panic started to seep through the minute cracks in my positivity. The daunting days and haunting nights continued — Days went by acting depressed — Evenings, acting like a confident shark with an answer and a solution for everything in front of people who could get me a job — And nights, preparing for ISRO interview.

28th June 2018, 10:00 pm | Besides Vishvenpuram beach

My brother had been avoiding my calls and texts as well. I was walking on a street lit by a crescent moon and a flickering street bulb — 200 meters to my right, I could see the beach — A silver shine of the moon on the water had a smooth and cyclic wave — In front of me, the same road I was walking on post the placement announcement — Though, in the opposite direction this time — Towards #59. I knew it was when Abhinav and his wife would be done with dinner, and I could get a window to talk to him. So I gave him a call,

"Yes, Ashwin." I heard in a gloomy tone.

"How are you, *bhaiya*?"

"Passing by life. Tell me?"

"Umm... *Bhaiya*, did you look for any spot I could get in?"

"Ashwin... I had a talk with Dad. We don't think you should leave your job."

“I told you, *Bhaiya*, there’s no reason for me to stay here. I would be spoiling my career.”

“You will be spoiling your life if you leave. Private sector has too much workload.”

“I can deal with it. All I need is to be in a good city so that it’s easier for me to prepare for exams.”

“Exams?” he chuckled.

“What’s so funny?”

“I don’t have time to breathe with this job. How the hell would you prepare for exams with a job?”

“Been there before.”

“Oh yeah. When?”

“Right here, in SCAR.” I said as I walked.

“And how did it end up?” He taunted.

I did not know what to say. A wind blew and sent chills across my chest. As I clutched my torso tight in between my arms, he continued,

“See, Ashwin... I can’t do anything here. Join your posting and prepare for exams to get out.”

“If I join, even if I crack a job, they won’t let me go. This is the only time I can resign and leave within a month. They will tie me up for at least 3 years if I join.”

“How do you know?” He asked.

I was now walking on the same path in between the trees — It reminded me of the conversation with my dad the evening before my 3rd ISRO attempt. No birds chirping this time though — No visible greenery — It was dark already when this conversation began. I shouted,

“How the fuck do you know? You know how things work here sitting there in your cozy apartment in Mumbai?”

“Lower your voice! Talk to me with some respect!” he roared back.

I went silent again as my mother’s words bounced in my head,

“Abhinav slapped you the day you were born.” She would often say.

Jealous of a newly born competition — A 6-year-old child is innocent, right? Purest form of humans? We are not nearly as clean and colorful as portrayed in those Romcoms. That first slap on my first day in this world was certainly not the last. He beat me for the next 14 years. What he missed when I was at school, bullies in my class made up for. Then I took Martial Arts seriously, grew taller, and started to hit back. Across the next 10 years, even though I was the younger brother, both of us and our parents knew that I was the wiser one. He started to mend our relationship and would always come to me for advice — On how to deal with his boss — Relationship issues with his girlfriend, who later became his wife, and how he could build a sustainable business so that he could quit his job. He never again dared to raise his voice at me — Until that night. Maybe, he thought that he finally had the upper hand again. Only God knows what he had been brewing in his head for 24 years and how desperately he might be waiting to hurt me again.

“There are no vacancies in my company.” He continued, on the verge of ending the call.

“Are you shitting me right now? You have been an HR in 3 multinational companies, and one in which all your company did was to provide HRs to dozens of companies. You want to say that you can’t look for a single place where I can get employed, given the resume I bring? Come on, dude. Out with it!”

“Even if you get a job here, what will you do? Earn Rs 20,000 a month?”

“It’s not the money that I need. All I need is an opportunity.” I replied instantaneously.

“Listen to me for the experience I have. You need to stay there.”

“Three years ago, when you came to me for help convincing Mom about your love marriage, did I offer you advice, or did I walk straight to the next room to talk to Mom? I don’t need your advice. I need your help. Brother, are you going to help me or not?”

“I cannot... You need to talk to Da..”

“End of discussion. You don’t want to help me because you don’t want to. You don’t need father’s permission to help me. You are a 30-year-old grown-ass man!

You should have started with that and saved me some time.”

“Ashwin, listen to me...”

“Shut up! You have said enough. You did what you wanted to. Now brother, you see what I do.”

He then got a “*Loser*” behind his name as well. I still had not given up on my endeavor to make a good life for myself, but that night, I gave up on humanity.

“Nobody gives you shit for free, not even your family.”

In that street, amongst gray and dry trees, I started running. I heard the stray dogs barking at a distance — A man floundering to walk with a bottle in his hand right in front of me — Wind blew hard, and I saw the leaves give up their struggle as dozens fell on the rugged street. So I ran harder — Pretty soon, I caught the breadths on foot rhythm — I ran faster. From a distance, I saw Simar and Sumit taking a walk — Hands on hand — Smiles on their faces. It didn’t even burn me. After all, ashes don’t catch fire. Rather I thought,

“Wow! How peaceful they look... I wish I could someday be that peaceful.” I said — Now sprinting.

“But boy, you know you will endure this turmoil for as long as you have to.”

“I have nobody.”

“So?”

I took hard breaths and ran harder as I said,

“It’s so unfortunate.”

“So?”

“Why should they get what they want?”

“The fuck is your point?”

“Why can’t I be happy?”

“Because you chose to fight.”

“Why is it so unfair for me? Why doesn’t my father help me? Why can’t my brother help me? Even *Blitzkrieg* went quiet.” I slowed down — Jogged — Decelerated — Stopped to unlock #59, and kicked the door in.

“Are those serious questions? Or are you just trying to throw useless excuses and play the victim?”

“I have nothing...” I panted as I entered my room and continued,

“I have nobody.” I tossed the keys on the table.

“You do.”

“Who?” I asked as the door shut behind me.

I brushed my hair back with my hand as my eyes fell on that mirror again — I heard my voice,

“You.”

Chapter 12

Man is at His Best When...

Making a career out of social media, teaching, automobile engineering, and management category jobs — I even thought of starting my own Personality Development program and my own Podcast. Years after those daunting days and haunting nights, I often wondered why these ideas never came to me when I had both time and resources. We hate being backed into a corner — We are terrified of rock bottoms, but the truth is that your life does not change when you are comfortable and secure. It does in adversity.

Now you might think,

“Necessity is the mother of invention. So, when I have no options, I am forced to think differently, and those ideas change lives.”

That’s what I believed with certainty for the next 5 years, and then I realized that it was just partially correct. You might not have noticed, but you get ideas all the time. How many times have you sat with your friends in a bar with a beer bottle in your hand, and you get an idea of a startup? Whatever the number, I am sure the number of times those ideas came to nothing equals that. Thoughts, ideas, and visions don’t change lives. Actions do. Actions are what compulsorily come with Adversity. You are forced to think, but more importantly, you are forced to act.

30th June 2018, 6:15 p.m. | FTH Mess

Following are the messes I have experienced:

1. Engineering college in the mountains where all we got were potatoes. In 4 y they made each of us eat a truckload of potatoes.

2. Delhi PG mess where I am pretty sure that their effort on making food surpassed by the effort to make whatever shit they were made to look like food. So that they could grab some extra cash by their teeth in the name of 'compulsory mess'. And then,
3. STH mess, which took one-fourth of our salaries only to make us spend huge amounts in their canteen to get food that won't kill our taste buds — Gotta business model, by the way — Gotta applaud the hustle.

But somehow, just when I thought it was impossible, FTH Mess surpassed them all in making disastrous food, and they didn't even have a canteen.

I would make most of my food on my own. However, I would still check in FTH mess every evening for a cup of their fake coffee as it was my only break-time and because there was nowhere else to go without spending a penny. As usual, I picked a time when the least people would be at the mess and a spot that ensures solitude. That day, I spent the last 6 hours in library — Studying for ISRO interview that nobody believed would happen. While sipping that coffee, at that one time of the day when I'd unwind, I heard,

"Sumit, please fill the bottles. I'll wait here." said Simar.

Sumit was holding two bottles. I knew that the steel one was Simar's. I remember the smile on her face when she unpacked it in the STH library back in August. The other gay-looking purple one must be of Sumit, who looked at me and passed a smile. Before I could show him the finger, he walked into the water filter section. Simar stood there in front of me for about ten seconds — I knew she was looking at me. I was determined to not let her fuck this precious, once in 24 hours coffee time.

"How are you?" she asked,

I took a sip, looked carefully at the wall, and said,

"All good."

A sinister silence which she didn't know how to deal with, diffused in the air around us. It was the same place where she told me about her 3-year-long relationship.

"Aaa... I... I heard that you haven't yet started your project..." she said.

I let the silence speak for me. Meanwhile, Sumit came back with two full bottles of water. He said,

“Let’s go, Simar.”

“Take care of yourself.” She said to me.

I replied this time with a *Sruuuuuupp* of a sip — Maintaining intense eye contact with the wall.

That night, I received an email. After 20 demo rejections, *Crackify* finally accepted me as a tutor. On July 2nd, they officially gave me a contract to take 30x15-minute lectures on any topic of my choice for Rs 300 per lecture.

— I signed immediately —

A week later, I had made just 14 lectures when they called me and told me that they were scrapping my contract.

“Ashwin, based on your performance so far, we are considering the earlier contract as null and void...” said Javed. Then he continued,

“... We are delighted with your quality of work and would like to sign you up for our *All-Star Tutor* program. You will need to make 200 lectures a month. 100 in Hindi and 100 in English. We’ll be paying you Rs 80,000 in total.”

The contract was sent to me the next morning.

— I signed immediately —

11th July 2018, 9:00 pm | Vishvenpuram Beach

“Hey, Topper! Long time!! How are you?” Said Akash on a call, now working as a software developer at Infosys, Bangalore. He replied with the same calm but excited voice.

I told him all about the mess I was stuck in. After listening to me for 20 minutes straight with pin-drop silence, he asked,

“Topper, are you alright?”

“I am fine, Bro... But both Placements and ISRO are long shots. I am most likely going to need to run away. Can’t go home, can’t go to my brother... So I’ll just get

a cheap place in some city close by. The most appropriate for now would be Bangalore. That's why I called you... Maybe you can help me find a place in Bangalore. I don't know how you find places for rent there."

"Not to worry, Topper... If nothing works out, you take an overnight bus to Bangalore on 31st... And don't you worry about getting a place for now. Deposits here are crazy. You stay with me. I got a 1-BHK flat... I'll establish a good internet connection. You do your thing with online teaching and stay here as long as you need to." he said.

I was never good at making friends because of my introverted nature. But I think because of that, the friends that I did make, turned out to be really good ones. Which means I was actually pretty good at making good friends. That's the kind of answer I was hoping for from my father or perhaps my brother:

"Just come on over. You stay with me till you figure it out."

But it ultimately came from someone who had no blood relations, someone who was just my gym partner 2 years ago, and someone I had talked to just for a few minutes since we graduated.

19th July 2018, 9:00 pm | #59 | When the room gets heated up...

A-4 sheets spread all across my bed — My laptop on the study table — My ass planted on that plastic chair — Preparing slides for my lectures. When the lectures were to be recorded, there must be no background noise, or the quality team would reject 15 minutes of my content which took an hour of work. The audio recording source was just the low-level omnidirectional inbuilt microphone of my *Motorola E4* with a broken screen. So following had to be checked before the recording could start:

- The fan had to be turned off - A constant metal clinking sound came from : fucking tonne fan placed in that quarter half a century ago.
- The lights had to be turned off - My tube light would make a persistent n courtesy of corruption happening somewhere in the country.
- The windows had to be closed - Even birds chirping would create a disturb. leading to rejection of a lecture. Plus, every now and then, some drunk tra would get hyper-excited and shout because it was the epitome of his career.

- Door had to be closed - Even Mahi did not know about my new side employment and I intended to keep it that way. I just told him that I am rehearsing answer the ISRO interview.

So, in July — South-East Coast of Vishvenpuram — Fan turned off — Door shut — Windows closed — In a dark room, lit only by the light of my phone screen — Exerting energy on the top of my lungs — Speaking for 15 minutes straight and repeating it for 8 times a day to finish 200 lectures in 30 days. The room was literally at 50 degrees Centigrade. Every 20 minutes, I would rush out of the room to get some fresh air with sweat dripping off my chest, which looked like I had just taken a shower.

When the room gets heated up, everyone looks for an Exit. Everyone but the one for whom quitting is not an option. You are advised that when you enter a closed hall, you should always know where the Exit is — Just in case there's a fire, an earthquake, or an alien invasion. That advice is for a Civilian walking into a theater, not a Warrior marching into a Battlefield. Warriors are supposed to see trouble and run towards it — Dig their heels, rub some dirt on their palms, and get ready to fight. When things go bad, they know that this is the first step to getting what they want. All they have to do now is *Persist*, and the majority will quit or perish by the inherent design of humans. Fight the remaining few, and you got what you came for.

Days passed by, and I fell in love with the turbulence. The Convocation day was announced to be on 26th of July. We were supposed to report to our respective departments on 1st of August, 9:00 a.m. sharp. I maintained the act, even though there was no call from the Director yet, and I kept preparing for the Interview even though there was no call from ISRO yet. Even though the girl hadn't talked to me since the placements, I was in constant touch with Junaaid. Though I would not recognize him if he stood before me, he kind of became the only person I used to talk to. He would tell me his and dozens of others' stories — Those who did what they could to challenge the system. Everything he said had a flavor of contempt for the bureaucracy. Strong, bold, fantastic speaker, his own values, his own principles, and an immortal sense of right and wrong. He was the kind of person who, if in the wrong place at the wrong time, for better or worse, would start a revolution.

“Arre... they can't tell you now, or there will be havoc on 26th. A lot of graduating scientists will have their parents in the audience. Academy will never risk them finding out that a placement has changed. Not to mention the freshers of 62nd! There will be a rampage!!” he said on a call.

Made sense, but I had my doubts, and so I booked a ticket for 31st of July to leave for Bangalore.

22nd July 2018, 1:00 am. | #59 | We Need to Act Now!

I was solving a numerical once asked in an IISc interview when I got a call from an unknown number. I knew who it was but was surprised by the timing.

“See Ashwin... we are running out of time. Action is necessary.” she said.

“Did something happen?” I curiously asked.

“I'll be honest with you. We expected the Director to privately call you and give you the placement slip with a non-disclosure by now. It did not happen. Maybe they are testing you and playing their own games. You need to do something drastic, or they might take their chances and not change your vacancy. We will lose the bluff.”

Her voice had an evident panic, which was rare given her charisma. I asked,

“What can I do?”

“We need to get their attention. So, to anyone who ever asked you, what would you do if your placement doesn't change, what did you say?”

“That I will not join.”

“Alright, your convo with Sudha went well... So that's a positive... They also don't know about your exit strategy... umm... wait, let me get Junaid on the line.”

After a few beeps, I heard that jolly carefree voice again,

“Yes, *maddam*. tell me.”

“Junaid, Ashwin is on the line. We need to act now, we can't just sit on our asses, or we are gonna miss the bus.”

“Arre maddam... Nothing will happen. Jayant already told me that his name has not reached MP...”

“I know, but Surekha just told me that a blank vacancy has been created at MPE, Chikkalduti. That might be for him.” she interrupted.

Now, all of a sudden, Junaid’s tone transitioned to a worried one. He responded with a nervous surprise in his voice,

“W-what?”

“Yeah, we need to do something this week. You have experience in this. What do you think they’ll do next?”

The unknown but known male voice, probably from the girl’s side, said,

“Sir, I think they are not sure themselves. Just like us. So they are testing the waters. I think they have kept two vacancies in reserve.” As of this moment, he was the only one calm among us.

“You are right, this week will decide which one they’ll hand over to Ashwin... Aaa... I think they will talk to the person closest to him to ensure what’s really going on.” said Junaid.

“Ashwin, does ANYBODY know about your act?” She immediately asked.

“Nobody.” I responded without hesitation.

“Who is closest to you?” asked Junaid.

“My flatmate, Mahi. He doesn’t have a clue.”

“Can you trust him?” Junaid followed up.

“Yes.” I responded rapid.

Junaid took a pause and said,

“Tell him about the act and...”

“Are you crazy?!? This can compromise everything we have done!” The girl, in her high-pitched voice, interrupted.

Junaid, back in his calmer self, responded,

“Or, it can make everything work, maddam. Look, Ashwin... tell him that it is an attempt of yours and yours alone to try and get the vacancy changed. Strike the

Blitzkrieg part. Tell him why you are doing it. Ask for his help. Very soon, Bala will sit him down and interrogate him regarding you. Politely but thoroughly. It can make or break the whole thing. He knows about your ISRO preparation, right?”

“Right.” I replied.

“They’ll try and confirm if it’s a bluff. For that, I know they’ll go straight to him. If he cracks even a little about ISRO or all that productive shit that depressed people don’t do, we are done. Make sure he does not.”

“This is the only way, do it.” said the unknown male voice.

When the conversation ended, it was 2:00 a.m., and Mahi was already asleep. I decided that the first thing he hears post-sunrise would be my disclosure. I scheduled the alarm for 7:00 am, but I was instead woken up by a key click.

“Oh! Bro, you are awake.” said Mahi in gym shorts, tank and running shoes — Sweating and panting — Peeking through the half-open door.

“How are you awake so early on a Sunday?”

“Don’t know, bro... I just felt the motivation to go to the gym... you know... had a good workout. I think I’m gonna join you every morning from now on.” he said as he pushed open the door and took a step in.

“I doubt it. What’s the time?”

“Why would you say that, homie?... It hurts... You’ve been so cold lately.”

“What’s the time, dude?” I asked again.

“You think I can’t be regular?”

“Dude.”

“Do you?”

“Fine, bro... We will go to the gym together every morning from tomorrow onwards. Will you tell me the fucking time now?”

“Why? About 1:00 pm.”

“FUCK!!”

“Yeah man... Early bird gets the worm...”

I kept silent as I regretted not checking my phone's battery before sleeping, while Mahi kept blabbing all the new motivational quotes he learned from YouTube Videos he watched that morning.

"... Lose an hour in the morning, bro... and you will be all day hunting for it... you know.... And yeah ... speaking of '*Hunting*'... I need to tell you about this weird shit that happened just now. You won't believe it!" He said.

Knowing Junaid's track record with predictions, I knew exactly what might have happened and was worried I might be too late.

"What?" I asked.

With confusion still on his face, he responded,

"*KGB* just invited me to his house today at 5:00 for a cup of tea!" he said, scratching his right eyebrow. Already knowing why but concrete on my idea of giving less information and taking more, I asked,

"Why?"

He planted his ass in nasty sweat-drenched shorts on my table right next to those holy interview notes and said,

"Well... He met me outside the mess, asked me a couple of bullshit questions, and then asked, *how is Ashwin?*... He then masked it with more bullshit talk, but I think it was mainly about you. It seemed like he was waiting outside the mess for a while, especially for me to finish my lunch. I can say that because he left immediately after he invited me."

He chose the mess instead of #59 for rendezvous, probably to avoid me finding out about it. I got up, crossed my legs, and said,

"Listen, bro... you know that I didn't sign on the 12th. But you might not know why."

"I actually do." said Mahi in casual confidence.

I gulped, then asked,

"You do?"

"Yeah... Everybody does."

"Ahh... aa... why?"

“Cuz you lost your shit, obviously. Been worried about you, bro... Are you alright?”

“I am fine, but no, that’s not it. Now listen carefully, Mahi... I have been acting to have lost my shit for the past 2 months. If they believe I am clinically depressed because of the vacancy, which will conduce actions like not joining NEA... then they might change my posting to FBRC, where a vacancy was created because of Sumit. This is why I don’t talk to anyone, stay isolated... didn’t even talk to you. I think this is a good way to naturally send a message to NEA. Hence, they cannot know about my ISRO preparation, my YouTube channel, going to gym every morning at 6:00 etc. You know the most about me, so they are after you now. I know that I should have told you about it, bro. I am sorry, but this was the only way. What did you say to him outside the mess?”

Mahi’s ass slipped off the edge of the table. He placed his palm to regain balance and said,

“Dude, you are fucking crazy. For two fucking months?!”

He looked at me with shock as he pulled the plastic chair and sat on it.

“Mahi... What did you say bro?” I asked again.

He replied with a shoulder shrug,

“I told him the truth... I said that I don’t know him anymore.”

“That’s good... But he will inevitably ask you more about me this evening. When he does, tell him that I don’t talk to you anymore... That I don’t sleep at night and speak randomly to myself behind closed doors. DO NOT talk about my YouTube at any cost... You already know better... to not talk about ISRO. I’m the guy who has lost all hope. He, along with the top authorities, needs to get that signal. That would be sufficient. Rest, enjoy the tea, and walk out.”

Mahi breaks into laughter as he says,

“They should change your vacancy not because you are depressed but because you are a psycho!... But I think this will work. You should have told me about it before, you idiot!! I was freaking out.”

What happened next was that Mahi returned in the evening and told me that Bala was now shitting his pants.

“I told him that Ashwin has completely changed since the vacancy was announced... That he doesn’t say anything anymore. I told him that I’m afraid he might take some wrong actions because of the wrong things that have happened to him...”

“Perfect!” I said with a smile on my face,

“Not an issue, bro... Honestly though, your days are bad, but I’ve not seen anyone working harder than you in my life. The day your coin shines, you will surely grab a big take in life. That I know for sure.” he said.

I saw the *belief* in his eyes. Trying to hide my bitch emotions, I gave him a fistbump and said,

“Thanks, man. I knew I could trust you. Someday, I’ll tell you the full story.”

Not once had I sat down with Mahi and asked,

“How are you doing, brother? Are you stressing too much about where you will be posted?”

It must have been horrid being boycotted by the lobby and extremely stressful to slide down the ranking, especially when his career depended on it. The guy who would run after classes to let me know when it was time to move — Bang on a locked door when he had his own placements to worry about — The one who would lie for me. Years later, I would often wonder how I survived the Rock Bottom alone, abandoned by my family, and people I knew had the power to help me. It’s only writing this book that made me acknowledge that, in reality, I wasn’t alone — I was just too self-centered to identify the people who believed in me. It was people like Mahi who did what he did not have to. It was people like Akash, who did not need to know how the Topper of his batch was now a Botommer and offered me a place to stay when he did not have to. It was people like Arun, who vouched for me to his employer when he did not have to. It was faceless people from *Blitzkrieg*, who tried to save a career even though their own careers could never be fixed. It was people like Ganesh who, instead of celebrating his own SCAR placement after 10 months of struggle, paid attention and ran after a Botommer in the shadows. There are always people who believe in us. It’s just that they are not the ones who we expect them to be.

Blitzkrieg just wanted the Agency’s attention, but instead, I had created a turmoil. Early next morning, my presence was requested by Sudha. She informed me that

Bala would pick me up at 4:00 p.m. for a “*Counseling Session*”, which was a politically correct way of saying that they had booked a session for me with the NEA Hospital’s Psychiatrist.

23rd July 2018, 4:00 pm | NEA Hospital, Vishvenpuram

“Why don’t you try to appear for GATE again, Ashwin?” asked Bala while driving.

I enchanted the memories of all the girls I had ever approached — Imagined all of them rejecting me at the same time — Showing me the double middle finger while they walked with Sumit in his favorite blue capri as they held him tight under their butter-smooth arms. The pain that it produced easily depicted the depression on my face that I needed to portray. With that look of a man who hates life, I replied,

“I don’t wanna give any exam anymore.” and got back to looking out through the window.

We walked to the first floor of the NEA hospital, outside the Psychiatrist’s chamber. A board on the door said, “Dr. Murali Chelladurai”. His assistant directed me to go inside and asked Bala to stay outside. Dr. Murali was a tall man in his mid-40s. As I saw the stern look on his face, I wondered if there was a real psychiatrist in the room past this where patients go after this one scares them out.

“So Ashwin, I’ve been told that you are showing symptoms of depression. Tell me, what’s wrong?”

“Nothing, sir. I’m good.”

With no tint of softness in his voice, he said,

“I’ve heard you haven’t signed the documents on the placement day. Why is that?”

“Because I do not believe I deserve that posting.”

“Why not? Salrutpattinam is a great place.” he said.

“*What kind of fucking psychiatrist gives you career advice?*” I wondered and said,

“Not for me.”

“What will you do after the 31st of July then?”

Even though he was trying hard and probably was well-planned, the questions were predictable. I said,

“I don’t know.”

“Will you resign?” he asked immediately.

Desperation was engraved on his forehead even though he was trying to hide it with his stare. It was clear as day that this guy was Academy’s second attempt at predicting what I was going to do.

“No.” I said.

“Why not?”

“Why should I? Let them fire me.”

“What about your parents? Are they wealthy?”

“No. Father is retired... Mother is a housewife. They require my financial support.”

“Then why don’t you join your posting?”

“Because I’m the only son, and I cannot stay that far away from my aged parents.”

Now a little nervous, Dr. Chelladurai said,

“Then what are you going to do?”

I knew exactly which area he was trying to confirm. I knew which response would say all I needed to.

— I stayed silent, gazing out the window —

He wiped the sweat off his forehead and said,

“Do you ever get thoughts... of hurting yourself?”

I continued my research on the window and stayed quiet for a few seconds. Then I said,

“I think everyone has those thoughts every now and then.”

Now with all the attitude washed away, he leaned over the table and asked anxiously,

“B-but... aaa-everyone doesn’t act upon it. Have you ever tried taking actions?”

— I stayed silent, gazing out the window —

He wiped his palm on his trousers and said,

“Have faith in God... God has a plan for you. You can leave now but remember: GOD HAS A PLAN FOR YOU.”

I got up and walked out — He asked his assistant,

“Please send Mr. Bala inside.”

As Bala walked in, he asked me to wait outside. The second he walked in, I made my way out of the hospital.

“God has a plan for me... yeah, right! Feed this crap to someone afraid of taking charge. Your life is yours as long as the choices and responsibilities are yours.” I thought.

This was as much as we could have done to change the vacancies. At the latest, they'd give the official changed placement slip by 26th, EOD. If they don't, they are ruthless murderers, and in that case, I would be on my way to Bangalore — They can keep searching for me for the next five years. If they do change, I will stay at Vishvenpuram till I resign for ISRO. We left for Mumbai the next day for the Convocation, where the trainee scientists would officially become scientists.

26th July 2018, 10:00 a.m. | SCAR Auditorium, SCAR, Mumbai | The Cycle of SCAR

We found ourselves sitting in the same place as a year ago. The only difference this time: We were the ones graduating in those Navy Blue Blazers. They made us graduates sit rank-wise based on our percentage scored. So naturally, I found my place at the edge. Custom was that Topper would walk last to receive the certificate like a king. I would be inaugurating this shit. They had invited the director of IIT Madras, Dr. K.R. Mookiah, to hand over the certificates and medals.

“Ashwin Taksh, Mechanical Engineering.” the anchor announced.

I walked towards the stage, and for some weird reason, everyone started to clap. I wondered if they even knew that I was the Bottomer, not the Topper. Later, I found out that they clapped just out of common courtesy — Something I was way too broken to understand. When I stood in front of Dr. Mookiah, who was 5'2" tall, my anatomy had to naturally bow to receive the certificate — He bowed back

as if it was fucking Japan! Behind him stood Chatterjee. With a look on his face that said,

“Don’t you fucking pull some of that revolutionary shit over here, dude! For fuck sake, parents and the next batch are in the audience!”

Standing behind me was the head of the JRF Program, Dr. Kumereshan, who was literally standing with his hands in a cricket wicketkeeper pose as if the moment I made a run for it, he’d dive and go *Dhoni* on me. As I clutched my certificate in *Nuclear Science and Engineering*, the photographer took pictures — In my head, I was thinking that if at all they made me sign some documents right there — I would grab my certificate in between those crooked teeth of mine and go full on *Usain Bolt* on these motherfuckers. Where would I run? I had no idea, but I’m a pretty good runner, and I was confident that these nerds won’t be able to keep up. Thankfully, all of my dark paranoia never turned into a reality, and I walked away with the degree.

Once all the peasants got their certificates, the respective department toppers received the *Souresh Chattopadhyay Medal of Excellence* for being the best at mugging up a lot of Xeroxes and doing precisely what they were told. Dipesh got an extra medal for being the overall topper, the same medal our respected Director had won about a thousand years ago. Before we could enjoy the only good aspect of this day: Food, all the department toppers got to live the peak of their careers by giving a 5-minute speech.

As I walked in the courtyard with my overburdened plate, a bunch of fresh TSs swarmed me.

“No, guys... the first one to go on stage was the Bottomer, NOT the Topper.” I said with food stuffed in my mouth.

Eight of them surrounded me, two even tried to climb on my shoulders, and none listened to what I said.

Random guy #1: Your strategy

Random guy #2: Hi Ashwin, sir

Random guy #3: Guidance

Random guy #4: What Should

Random guy #5: Give us some tips

Random guy #6: I watched

Random guy #7: I do

Random guy #8: YouTube video

That's when my tube light lit, and an "Oooooohhh..." along with a few nasty chewed chunks of *Mattar Paneer* came out of my mouth. I chewed the remaining and asked,

"Did you guys watch my YouTube videos?"

This time a unanimous chorus answer came as,

"YES!!"

Out of my WhatsApp group comprising 40 SCAR interview candidates, 12 got selected. That's a 30% success rate in an interview with only a 5% chance (1:20 selection ratio). My Strategy works. They knew it better than anybody else, and so they were here.

"Give us some advice." they said.

"Guys... I shouldn't be saying this, and you shouldn't be listening to me... but, fuck it... Use the time and money to get the fuck out of NEA."

That's when I noticed Bala from a distance of 200m keeping close attention on me.

"Meet me in the evening at the playground behind the canteen. I'll explain it all... take a plate and start eating guys... you'll not get this kinda food every day over here." I said and left for STH.

That night around 7:00 pm, I was sitting in #804, preparing slides for *Crackify* lectures with the A4 sheets scrambled on the bed. After two hours of work, I cracked my knuckles. I had just finished the slides of the 200th lecture. I took a look at my cell phone — There was a notification of 104 unseen messages on my SCAR Interview Whatsapp group. This could mean only one thing. I tapped on the group — It was loaded with a lot of "*Not Selected*" and a lot more "*What is the cut-off*" messages. I scrolled hard to get to the gentleman who had uploaded the result pdf. Till I scrolled to the top, the group was bombarded with 100 new messages. I finally reached the pdf — Mailed it to myself — Opened on my laptop. My heart beats, creating the compressions and rarefactions which sent shockwaves sufficient to shake the walls of an already decaying 50-year-old Government building.

I opened the document — Took a deep breath — Pressed *Ctrl+F* — Digit by digit, typed the registration number,

2131... — — — — — “5 results”

..002... — — — — — “2 results”

Before typing the last two digits of 76, I thought,

“if it shows ‘Not Selected’, this laptop will not survive. Neither that wall that it’s going to punch a hole through.”

I typed the final two digits. It said,

85. ——— 213100276 ————— 195 ————— *Selected*

A couple of breathless seconds to let the idea sink in that the same exam that rejected me twice now wants me to proceed to the next round. The interview was on 17th August 2018 in Chennai.

We waited till 9:00 p.m. that night for some message about the placement change, but there was none. By now, *Blitzkrieg* had come to an agreement that we could not save my career. Though, we were just happy that we showed the Agency that it’s not going to be easy anymore for them to just throw the last ranker wherever they need manpower. We were happy of what we did. If nothing, we sure as hell made a permanent dent on the system. A few instantaneous changes that happened were:

1. They re-started the NFRFC, Hyderabad Academy, from where they’d post TS industrial centers like NFRFC and MPE.
2. In SCAR Academy, they clearly mentioned who all were being recruited research and who were for plant-based maintenance work. This meant that we would know, before joining, what kind of job profile they were signing up for.

“Get off at Madiwala bus stand, Topper... I’ll pick you up there.” said Akash on a phone call.

I had already had all my stuff packed when I left #59. I could stay at #804 till I left for Bangalore on 31st.

27th July 2018, 10:00 a.m. | SCAR Academy, Mumbai | A Late Goodbye

I walked to the Academy for the last time to submit my Identity, Library and Medical Cards. I walked towards Sudha's office, where I had walked in multiple times to submit apology letters about why I bunked the class — Where I was told numerous times that my stipend would be deducted. My year-long companions stood with bright smiles on their faces — All of them saying their goodbyes — Everyone was a little emotional. They all had a year-long journey, just like me. It was about to end — Just like mine. They had their own stories and struggles — Just like I had. May it be the struggle to beat others in the line, but that must have been difficult nonetheless. Unlike me though, they had friends and unlike me, they had made good memories that they would cherish for the rest of their lives. It was there that I realized, I missed the opportunity to have fun in my second chance at college life as well. It seems like regret is inevitable, no matter what you choose.

“In choosing the kind of life you want to live, you also choose the regret you can live with.”

On the right side of the entry door to the hall stood Simar beside Sumit — Both holding their posting slips to Vishvenpuram. Truth be told, at this point, it did hurt that Simar was not standing beside me but Sumit. This was the regret I chose — The one I could live with. I did not look at her even though I still retained the sense to know that she was looking at me. Too stubborn to look back at her but not ignorant enough to not look at a parallel trajectory of my life where I would have done things differently. I was bound to ask what life would be like if I had not approached her that evening in front of STH but had rather waited? Get to know her first, try to be friends with her first, and give her time to get to know me as well. If only my approach did not appear as an attack, she just might have opened the doors instead of raising an impermeable wall around her. What story would I be writing today if I had decided not to have the mentality where I looked at life as a war?

There is absolutely no way to see both sides of the coin simultaneously, but what I can say is that maybe, I would be standing where Sumit was. Perhaps, by knowing Simar more, I would have really fallen in love with her. Maybe then I would have finally understood what love is. Because hundreds of pages of aims, ambitions,

drive, choices and consequences later, I still have no answer to, “*What is Love?*” and, “*How does it feel?*”

I’ve heard them say that Love is the most powerful force in this world. If all those cliché lines are just as true as the quotes by the legends that I operated upon, then maybe I would have flunked ISRO exam as well. Maybe, I would have seen my career in NEA with Simar. Perhaps, where you are and what you do does not matter when you are in love. Maybe, wherever you are, if she is with you, it becomes Home.

But if I was standing besides Simar today with the tickets to our life in our hands, who would be standing alone in front of Sudha’s office? Who would be having an interview call from ISRO? Because above all, the conservation of energy must hold. Would it be Sumit? Would the pain of Simar light a fire under his belly so furious that he takes that pain and fuels his childhood dream of becoming an ISRO Scientist? You and I are not much different, Sumit. We both did our best, and somewhere in some parallel universe, we have lived each other’s lives. And Simar, as much as I hate to say it, you played a significant role in making me who I am today. I genuinely respect you for telling me that night straight that you do not want to be with me. Many people in this world are not strong enough to do that. Whatever is your side of the story, whatever is Sumit’s side, I’d like to sit down one day and listen to it. The problem is, for that, we’d have to sit down as friends and that we certainly are not — One of my biggest regrets coming out of the Academy. But then again, we choose the regrets we can live with, just like we choose what we cannot live without. I was happy that I was on the verge of finishing what I started 3 years ago. Sumit gets the girl he wanted — I get the career I wanted — Sadly, we both had to sacrifice something or the other.

I knocked on the door of Sudha’s office. She asked Rohit, who was in the middle of submitting his cards, to hurry up. She took her glasses off, gave me a smile, and said,

“Yes Ashwin, please come in... Bala, *kathavai moodungal.*”

I walked in and stood before her desk with my right palm resting on the chair’s wooden back support.

“How are you, Ashwin?” she asked.

I responded with a nod — Depressed character was my character by now.

“We thought you won’t show up. This is going to be quick.”

She reached to the lowermost drawer on her left and took out a small piece of paper — The width of which was folded 4 times — Like one of those chits I fabricated to pass Academy exams. She placed it on the center of the table and leaned back — Directing me with her eyes to pick it up.

I bent and picked it up. Before I opened it, I took a look into her eyes — She looked at me with an expression that said,

“I know everything.”

Not caring even if our entire machination somehow didn’t amount to a change of one placement, I unfolded the chit. It said,

“Ashwin Taksh is supposed to report to the Moderator Production Entity...”

“It’s alright... we did something good. Something that was never done before. Something which will create a positive impact for generations to come.” I consoled myself.

But the moment my eyes moved right, my mind said,

“We get so immersed in the journey that we forget that this time is bound to pass. We get so used to the darkness that we ourselves are surprised when the Sun starts to rise again.”

The piece of paper further read:

... Mumbai.”

— Signed by Dr. S.K. Chatterjee, with a Government Seal —

Last in the Academy, not just the Bottomer in Mechanical Engineering but the overall Bottomer, probably the lowest scorer in Academy’s history. There wasn’t a single Academy exam I walked in intending to get Mumbai placement, and here was my placement slip. Where people like Kunal fought an entire year to get at, and people like Poornima fought just as hard, if not harder, but still could not get it.

I took a look at Sudha in surprise. She smiled — Kept quiet for a moment, and then said,

“You know what you have to do.”

I folded the chit back — Placed it in the back pocket of my jeans — Silently placed all my cards on the table — Turned 180° and walked out of her office.

With nobody to say goodbye to, just before I exited the main hall, from my peripheral vision, I saw on my left Sumit and Simar still standing at the gate — Him saying something to her while she looked continuously at me. Time slowed down as I felt like my life was designed for me to act at this moment — Like I might be at a junction in space and time where inaction would be regrettable. Maybe there was something she wanted to say. Perhaps there was something she wanted me to say. But whatever it was, it was better left unsaid — I walked away.

As soon as I reached #804, I informed the *Blitzkrieg* that the placement had changed — Booked a Mumbai to Chennai flight for 13th August — There was no refund for the Bangalore ticket.

On 1st August 2018, I checked in and took my position as a Scientist of NEA at MPE Headquarters, Mumbai. First few days were just a bunch of formalities and paperwork. I could invest my time mostly towards interview preparation. To provide me with specialized training in heavy water production, they decided to send me for a 2-week training at a nearby place, Alibaug, where MPE had a production plant. The place was 3 hours from Mumbai by road and an hour by ferry. Alibaug was absolutely gorgeous. My MPE superior, to whom I had to report, couldn't care less if I was learning anything, which made two of us. NEA gave me a 2BHK flat, a car, and a driver that picked me up at 9:00 am and dropped me back at 5:00 pm — Being a *Group A Gazette Officer* had its perks. They even gave me an air-conditioned office to study plant manuals. Because of what I had been through, I knew the value of what I now had. All of these facilities were strictly used for my ISRO interview preparation.

Act was over. I could now sleep at 11:00 and wake up at 5:00 am again like I used to before the Rebellion. Days were getting brighter — I felt as if I finally got the ability to breathe in air at 100% capacity again. I cherished the light but now also knew the value of darkness. I now knew that,

“Man is at his best when he is put to his worst.”

For me to get 5 days of Casual leave (CL), my imaginary cousin had to get an imaginary wedding. I landed at Chennai International Airport two days before the Country's Independence Day.

Chapter 13

When the Door Opens

3 days that had No Date & Time | My Insanity deserved Freedom

The flight landed at Chennai Airport at 5:00 p.m. — It was raining heavily — The 10 seconds that it took to get out of the cab, put my bag over my shoulders, and get under the hotel shed was sufficient to leave me dripping wet. I entered my room and locked myself in for the next 3 days. No human contact, no phone calls, nobody to even share text messages with. 3 years, 3 attempts, and 2 failed ones in the history books, — I had put way too much on the line to leave any loose ends. I had a clear roadmap and plan for the next 3 days. There was a mirror in my hotel room — A classic dressing table. I stood relentlessly in front of it, explaining and elaborating all the potential questions — Answering all the whys there could be, paying attention to all the whats they could ask, making sure I was capable of answering all the hows that they could possibly imagine. After one-hour speaking sessions, I would take breaks of 10 minutes and then back in front of the mirror with a new set of questions. ISRO interviews usually lasted for a maximum of 20 minutes. Still, just in case, I was building speaking stamina for an hour — Ready for all. This went on for 14 hours a day in those 3 days. 17th August could have a lot of parallel universe possibilities:

- In one, I get a cool set of interviewers. In another, a set of rough ones.
- In one, I get asked, “What were you doing for the last 2 years?”. In another, I not.
- In one, I get asked about my major project. In another, I am not.
- In one, I will be cornered to disclose that I was currently an employee of NEA then will have to deal with the barrage of questions regarding that.

- In one, my interview can be focused on my strong subjects. In another, on weaknesses. In some others, a mixture.
- In one, there is a cab strike on the interview day.

I can go on and on — Various parallel universes — Various events — Various hurdles — But in all of those, the outcome remains the same: I become an ISRO scientist. I could not let the randomness of this world dictate my fate.

To get an exact idea of how it would feel to give the interview, I wore my formals — The exact clothes along with the shoes, the tie, the pen tucked in the front pocket, and the watch I would wear for the interview. I imagined myself being in the interview hall in front of ISRO scientists. If there was a hidden camera in the room and you watched those 72 hours in fast forward, you'd see a boy who wakes up 5:30 am and works out in a closed hotel room for half an hour — Has no social interactions — A boy who dresses up sharp every morning but doesn't go anywhere — Stands in front of a mirror, talking to himself for 12 hours a day — A boy who eats brown bread with peanut butter 3 times a day. I had let my over-obsessive control freak mentality go free — Succumbing to the madness. I made a deal with the Devil. Do I have to lose my mind? So be it. I cannot live one more day not being an ISRO scientist. I wanted it that badly. I wanted to prove that I was correct that badly. I wanted to prove the audience wrong that badly. I wanted to see eye to eye with everyone who rejected me and murder their soul that badly. Everyone who left my side when I needed them the most, I wanted to be a permanent resident in their heads — I wanted to be so big that they won't be able to ignore me as long as they breathe. You shove a lost, lazy and mediocre aside, brush him off every time, reject him and demean him — He becomes dangerous just on the sheer principle that he has nothing to lose. Now imagine what would happen if you did all those to someone who had potential, worked hard, and was better than you. You did not give a shot to someone who deserved it the most — Not once but again and again — What if that person does not give up and keeps coming? — Imagine what a monster you have created.

17th August 2018

I woke up at 5:30 a.m. with the first ring of my alarm — Turned off the air conditioner — Stood in front of the mirror — Not an ounce of extra fat on my body — It's not for the hunters anyways. My stomach felt good — Dinner digested

well — Eyes not burning — Head felt fresh. I sat down, drank a glass of water, and began warm up. Light movements — Switching stances — Jabs-cross-hook combos — Front kicks and sidekicks — A dozen push-ups and about a hundred crunches got my blood flowing in 20 minutes. I took a bath and was ready by 7:00 am. I booked a cab, and in 5 minutes, I reached the ISRO SDSC SHAR Guest house, Pallavaram. Just before I handed Rs 50 to the cab driver, I realized I had forgotten something vital. I forgot to carry a pen — Should have prepared a checklist.

After entering through the main gate, I walked around 500 meters to find the first building. Along the way, I saw a three-storied building with a giant logo of ISRO — Took a deep breath of that fresh air — That blue and orange gave me goosebumps every time, regardless. I walked further in and finally reached the building where the interviews were supposed to happen. After the document verification process, I was directed toward the interview hall on the ground floor. There were benches in the main hall for the candidates to wait. As I took an empty spot, I saw a happy face walking out of the Interview room — He immediately got swarmed by a bunch of candidates whose 90% of the preparation strategy was to grill everyone who walked out of the interview hall and ask them: “What questions were asked?”

They were already done with the rest of the 10%: Worshiping their favorite Gods. I knew that box was checked as it was evident with the *Tilak* on their foreheads.

“These scavengers are present in every interview you go for.” giggled the guy sitting on my right.

He wore a white shirt, blue tie, tweed trousers, and a watch with a steel belt — A giant black bag with black straps still over his shoulders.

“Scavengers... so true... does any of them ever actually make it?” I asked.

“Sadly, yes... my 6 years of experience says that many of them will get selected... A lot of the interviewers are dumb enough to repeat their questions throughout the day.”

I was in this game for 3 years, which seemed like an eternity, and now this gentleman says he had been here for twice as long. I was surprised because he didn’t look like he was 28 at all. Curiously I asked,

“6 years?! Which year pass-out are you?”

“I graduated in 2012. That was my first GATE attempt... wasn’t any good. Then I worked for a year... left my job, and went to Delhi. There I prepared for competitive exams for 2 years, 2 more attempts, but couldn’t get AIR below 2000... Joined IIT Madras in 2015 and completed my M.Tech in 2017. Now I’m pursuing my Ph.D. from there itself.”

“Whoa! That’s one long journey!”

“Yeah... are you a fresher?” he asked.

“N... Yeeah... I graduated this year, *bhaiya*.”

I thought I was better off with him believing I was a fresher. That way, I wouldn’t have to explain much. Or in other words, would not have to lie much.

“Competition is getting tougher every year.” he said.

“True... Hey, do you have an extra pen?”

“No... only one, bro... sorry.”

“What the fuck have you stuffed in that huge bag then!?” I thought as I said with a smile,

“No worries, I’ll see if someone else got it.”

As I heard the guy blab about his philosophy of Science, Engineering and Competitive exams, I scanned the hall for someone who would be Sumit enough to carry two pens but Mahi enough to lend one to me. At around 10 o’clock, I saw a person who smiled and waved at me like he had known me longer than my mother. His every excited step toward me made me question one more time,

“Do I know him?”

Now just 8 feet away from me, he raised and dropped both his eyebrows multiple times — He finally stopped and said,

“Hey brother, how are you?”

“Hi!... umm... fine... do I know you?” I asked in confusion.

He took a step back in surprise, recuperated, and said,

“Yeah, bro!! I watched your video on *How to crack SCAR!!* It was very helpful... you are in SCAR, right?!?!”.

“Ok, first of all, this dude needs to understand that him knowing me doesn’t automatically mean I know him too. Second, for fuck sake man, can you please NOT announce to everyone that I am in SCAR?!? I’m kinda trying to maintain a low profile here!” I screamed in my head.

In a voice louder than his, I heard someone from behind saying,

“Ashwin Taksh! You’re next. Get in.” Called the management guy.

I saw a few heads turning and felt them thinking,

“Is it really him? What the hell is he doing here?”

Seemed like the internet world was now starting to merge into the real one. I had to get out of the spotlight fast, but before that, I had to try my luck one more time. I asked that hyper-excited guy,

“Hey man, nice meeting you. Do you have an extra pen?”

With the same enthusiasm, he shouted again,

“No, man!!... But you can have mine! I actually have my interview in the second half... All the best, bro!!”

From the rear, that 2012 graduate guy looked at me as you’d look at your fiancé who cheated on you. I checked my watch to avoid any eye contact.

It was 10:05 a.m. when I walked towards those interview hall doors — Around 11 feet tall and each flap at least 4 feet wide. I pushed the right flap inward — Took a step forward — The crowd noise behind me fades as that door opens. Through an 11 feet tall vertical slit, I got the first glimpse of the Indian Space Research Organisation. The more I pushed the door open, the wider the slit, and soon I had entered the realm of Space Science & Engineering. I saw a giant table around 25 feet long and around 5 feet wide — Sitting on the other side of the table were 10 scientists with ages ranging from 30 to 60 — Some sipping tea — Some talking amongst each other. Still standing at the door, holding the right flap open, I asked,

“Please, may I come in?”

“Yes, please come in.” said the man at the center.

Judging by his seating position, he was the panel’s Chairman. The room was dark with warm lights — A giant wall with photos of Dr. Vikram Sarabhai, Prof. Satish

Dhawan, and Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam behind the panelists. I was partly trying to remind myself that this was not a dream and partly that the job was not yet done.

“Ashwin, please sit down.” said the lady sitting next to the Chairman, who was in her mid-40s and had a welcoming smile.

“Thank you, ma’am.” I responded with a smile and sat down on the only chair on my side of the table.

Back straight — Shoulders wide but not too wide — Hands on my lap — A decent smile on my face — Confident eye contact with the audience.

“So Ashwin, please introduce yourself.”

Making sure by my expressions that they never figure out that I had rehearsed the answer a thousand times, I said,

“Sir, my full name is Ashwin Taksh. I was born and raised in Ranchi, Jharkhand. From there itself, I did my schooling. In 10th standard, I got a CGPA of 9.2, and in 12th, I had a percentage of 75.5%. Until then, I did not have much direction regarding my career, but when I started my B.Tech in Mechanical Engineering at Axis Institute of Technology, something changed. I found Engineering to be very interesting, so I started to spend more and more time learning. By the end of 4 years, I had a CGPA of 9.57 and a Bronze Medal from my University.”

The idea was simple: Keep it Short — Keep it Crisp — Keep them Hooked. I wanted the attention of each and every panelist. I didn’t want to be in a situation where I was explaining my answer of deflection of beams, and some interviewer was thinking about why the heat shield didn’t separate in the PSLV C-39 launch. I also wanted to make it clear to them by my personality and way of speaking that I was not just any other candidate. I knew that even they must be bored with the same regular engineers coming one after another — Same old introduction, same old nervousness. Time was limited for them, but their absolute attention was imperative for me — So I inserted a little bit of a story — An average student with no direction in life finds passion in Engineering and turns into a college topper. After all, who doesn’t like stories? I continued,

“... I like to utilize every last second. Hence, I invested all my vacations learning and sharpening my skills in Engineering. By the end of 4 years, I had done 5 internships and learned 7 different designing software, including *CATIA*, *Ansys*,

Solidworks, and *Creo*. In my 8th Semester, I published a research paper on Internal Combustion Bore Distortion. My ambition was always to get into ISRO because of my inclination towards Space Science & Engineering. I directed all my focus and hard work towards one goal: To crack ISRO-ICRB, which has finally brought me here.” With confidence addressing all the panelists regardless.

They all were observing me carefully. I had collected everyone’s attention. Meanwhile, judging based on how the lady was silently but continually noticing my body language, she was from HR. She held 10 marks. The Chairman held 10 marks and the final *Yes* or *No* for my selection. The other 8 had their own subject of specialization and would start asking technical questions once I was asked to go to the whiteboard behind me. Each of them had 10 marks which I would get if I answered their questions correctly. All of them were nodding — Most of them smiling — This meant they wanted me to go on. Otherwise, they would have interrupted — Another reason to avoid being boring and repetitive. So I decided to continue with my hobbies,

“I am highly interested in Sports and Public Speaking. I like to constantly work on my Communication Skills, which I believe is a very important aspect of one’s personality.”

They did not need any proof for that. My voice was my certificate. I wanted to show them these qualities of mine as I knew that life in ISRO is fast, and thus they would prefer active people to work with them. The Chairman, who still had a smile, now raised an eyebrow — His upper lips raised as his *Stalin-mustache* entered his nose — He asked,

“What sport?”

I was premeditated but waited for the question to pop up as it would sound braggy otherwise. Now that I had it, I decided to stay calm and said,

“Sir, I like participating in track and field competitions like 100m races, 400m and 800m races...”

I took a quick look at the panel again. They were still not interrupting. This meant it was time to drop the nuke,

“I am also a practitioner of Martial Arts. I’ve been doing it for the past 16 years and am a Black Belt in Shotokan Karate.”

From the sleepy grandpa in the left corner to the newly married dude regretting his choices in the right corner, all eyes on me now.

“Gathering Attention: Mission Accomplished. To all my competition trying to be an ISRO scientist, try beating that.” I thought.

The Chairman, with now even wider smile this time, said,

“That’s great, Ashwin.”

The HR lady chuckled and said,

“Oh! We would have never guessed that!”

“I know, ma’am. I get that a lot.” I said with a smile.

I knew that smiling was essential. They are not looking for a scared student but for a future colleague, they’d like to work with. I rehearsed smiling extensively in front of the mirror in the past few days so that my smile is neither a creepy *Joker* one nor an uninterested *Monalisa* one. So far, the interview was going great — In just 3-4 minutes, I was able to show all my qualities — There were no threatening cross questions — I was able to look confident on the outside. Furthermore, I could immerse them in my introduction in a way that they didn’t notice that I never mentioned my graduating year. Since I looked much younger than I was, I wanted them to assume that I was a fresher — Which meant they did not have to bother about any previous or current employment. So far, what was happening was the *“Best Case Scenario”* amongst all the possibilities I had prepared for.

“Alright, Ashwin. Very well. Tell us your favorite subjects.” said the Chairman.

“Sir, Strength of Material, Fluid Mechanics, Heat Transfer, Machine Design and Thermodynamics.”

“Please proceed to the board.” He said.

They started with the basic SOM — My answers were quick and to the point — The Chairman seemed to be the most impressed out of the bunch. He didn’t ask much questions of his own but mostly asked follow-up questions. After SOM, they got into Machine Design (MD), both of these subjects I had taught on *Crackify*. 2 months of teaching experience clearly helped my explanation skills. After MD, they plunged into Fluid Mechanics, then Heat Transfer and then into Engineering Drawing, which would be unexpected to some as I hadn’t mentioned that in my

favorite subjects. But it was unexpected only to those who did not study the pattern of ISRO interviews well. Contrary to SCAR, ISRO interviews always tended to be extrinsic.

While dusting the board, I took a look at my wristwatch. It was 10:35 a.m. The interview had already lasted longer than any ISRO interview I had ever known of, and trust me, I had heard or read about almost every ISRO interview experience that was possible to find out about. On top of that, it looked like at least 3 more interviewers were lined up to ask questions. I guess making everyone feel important has its own side effects. On the bright side, this solidified my selection. The only problem, I was now in the realms where neither any candidate nor any ISRO panelist had ever gone. I, firsthand, witnessed the ISRO interview morph into a SCAR interview for the first time. What only I knew was that I was the best candidate to deal with this cataclysm.

Next, they went into Material Science and then into Production. When they asked 5 favorite subjects — I answered 5 — But I had prepared 13 fucking subjects — That's basically the entire Mechanical Engineering B.Tech. syllabus. Though they were in the position of power, the decision was not in their hands — The panel could have Sumit as the Chairman and Simar as the HR, and they'd have to say in the end,

“Fuck it, the boy has it all... we can't stop him. He has decided... not even the Gods can stop him now.”

But when you challenge the Gods, you also invite their wrath. The seventh interviewer got into TOM. Soon, five to six interviewers got involved in cross-questioning. They dove deep into Casting, Thermodynamics, and Hydraulic Machines. I felt a little tired and fatigued, but it was nothing compared to the *Heated Room* I was used to — It seemed like everything that happened so far was preparing me for this day.

“Ok, coming back to Fluid Mechanics...” said a panelist who had earlier asked some excruciating questions from Heat Transfer.

At this point, I was more surprised than happy about the time they were investing in me.

“Yes, sir.” I said with the same energy with which I introduced myself.

I could have gone for 5–5 minutes MMA rounds, ran for 3 km, hit the speed bag for 25 minutes, and then stood in front of them, getting grilled for 5 hours, and the energy would not drop.

“Have you seen an air balloon?” he asked.

“Yes, Sir.” I responded quick.

“Why does it fly?”

“It is because of the buoyancy effect. The weight of the air it displaces is more than its own weight.”

He scratches his gray beard and responds with a smile after a brief pause,

“So it will keep on going up into outer space?”

A long time ago, I had heard this question — I was still an undergraduate. I knew that it would stop at a particular height but never gave it a thought about why it would stop. Hoping that they wouldn't follow up with a *‘Why’*, I answered quickly and with confidence,

“No, sir. It will stop at a particular height.”

“Why?” He asked.

I took a pause and hurled across the physics in my head. As Sir Isaac Newton once famously didn't say but would have if you asked: *“When in doubt about Mechanics, always make a free body diagram.”* So I did in my head and said,

“Sir, as we keep going to higher altitudes, the air becomes thinner. Hence, its density decreases. At some point, the weight of the fluid displaced will equate to the weight of the balloon along with the gas within. That's where it stops.”

Happy in my head that I had answered the last question successfully, I was about to click on the shutdown button for my brain — Ready to say, “Thank you, everyone.” and walk out.

“So, have you seen that we use a heat source placed at the bottom of the balloon?”

“Here we go again! Guess that's what I'll need to do in ISRO, make fucking balloons!” irritated, I thought, but reminded myself that I gave 3 attempts and 3 years to get to where I was standing. I responded with the same enthusiasm,

“Yes, sir.”

“Why do we use it?” He followed instantaneously.

The answer was easy and straightforward. Then he asked a few more basic questions related to the topic — I answered all of them, but I knew that there was only one direction this was going — This is how you start an abstract question. After tiny rebuttals, he got to the business,

“Why can’t we have a big hole?... Like a semicircular hot air Balloon?” he asked.

To avoid seeming dumb and to buy myself more time, I gave a bullshit answer,

“Sir, it’ll be costlier to manufacture, and the burner size will increase.”

The interviewer smiled and replied,

“Don’t worry, say you have all the money in the world... Have you studied about the stability of the body?”

“Yes, sir. Ok, I get it. For the stability of a submerged body, the center of buoyancy should be above the center of gravity of the body.”

“why?”

“If we tilt the body in any direction, there will be a restoring couple.” I explained it with a diagram on the board.

“How?” asked another interviewer who had covered MD earlier.

“Making a spherical shape must ensure the balloon has the Center of Gravity below the Center of Buoyancy.”

“Hmmm...” the Chairman, with a smile.

I knew it needed the final nail to the coffin. I took a deep breath and a couple of seconds of thinking it deserved.

A submerged body can only be unstable if it has a differential density. This was something that I noticed back in 3rd year of B.Tech. Back then, I found it interesting but also dumb at the same time: Dumb because it was pretty obvious — Interesting because nobody ever talked about it. What a smaller fire hole does is it decreases the region directly in contact with the fire, i.e., it reduces the volume with a sudden rise of temperature and sudden drop of density. This helps maintain a relatively uniform density so that the balloon remains stable in case of winds and

bad weather. All these were running in my head, and I forgot I was in the interview room. I exclaimed in a voice louder than any they had heard from me,

“YES!”

I rotated my body quick toward the whiteboard — Placed the marker on the board, and said,

“If I have a balloon in the shape of a sphere...” and drew a strong circle, almost creating sufficient shear force to create a circular slit on the whiteboard. As soon as I did this, the chairman, with a smile, said,

“Ok, Ashwin. That’s it. You can go now.”

I immediately nodded — Kept the marker on the chair — Thanked the panel — Pushed the door out. When the door opens, a bright, gradually widening beam of light almost blinds my eyes for a moment — The color then returns, and the blur clears past. A swarm of *scavengers* started asking me the same old questions in the chorus. I used basic Fluid Mechanics — Made my physical self more aerodynamic by creating a frontal arch with my arms and cruised through the turbulent crowd. The guy who lent me the pen was roaming around right there.

“Hey man, here’s your pen. Thanks a lot.” I said, handing over his pen

“How was it, bro?”

“Was nice.”

“What did they ask? Any tips?” He asked.

“Say you have all the money in the world. Would you be spending your time making fucking balloons?”

“Fuck no!” he smiled.

“Right, but don’t tell them that.”

“Huh?!” He reacted, confused.

“Thanks again for the pen, and all the best for your interview.”

“Thanks, man... and thanks a lot for your videos. Because of you, I cleared the SCAR written test. Keep up the good work.”

“Congrats! You’re welcome. Will do.”

“So, are you currently a SCAR Scientist?” He asked.

“Ex-SCAR Scientist.” I said.

Chapter 14

Light at the End of the Tunnel

I took a look at my watch. It was 11:15 a.m. Walking out the same lane of the guesthouse campus with beautiful green lawns on both sides, it felt like the storm had finally settled — Like a weight had been lifted off my chest — Like I had finally earned my freedom. When I returned to my hotel room, for the first time, I didn't have to revise any notes — No test series to be given — No plans to be followed — I could sleep for more than 6 hours — Maybe even more than 8 hours. I could go anywhere — Do anything I wanted to do. Self-imposed restrictions could now be lifted — Boundaries and targets constructed by none other than me — They had now served their purpose.

My flight back to Mumbai was the next morning. I went out and ate as unhealthy as I could — Came back to the hotel, and without even taking off my shoes, I layed on the bed and just dozed off without an alarm. When I woke up, it was 5:00 p.m. — I decided to go to *Golden Beach* — There I sat in peace till the sunset and thought about how close I came to losing my mind. I promised myself never to compete again. It made me better and propelled me far, but by now, I had realized that nothing would be left to be propelled if I burned any longer.

I expected the ISRO Interview results to be out by the first half of October and joining by December. The inflow of cash from both *Crackify* and at least 4 months of salary from NEA would help me pay back the bond and, in fact, afford a good time in Mumbai. The following day I left for the Chennai International Airport — I felt like I had just got a Thai Massage and a French Blowjob — I walked the slowest I had ever walked — Observed others for no reason — Gazed at the trees — Dropped DMs to random hot girls on Instagram — Scrolled through Facebook without any purpose — Laughed at memes — Watched roasting videos on YouTube. You know... things that normal boys do in their 20s. I didn't even know

who the President of the Country was — I was literally living under a rock — But it was time to be normal and sane for a change. I reached the airport 3 hours before time and just sat in a corner alone — Listened to songs — No visualization anymore — I was already standing where I wanted. I got a response from 2 fine girls — Fixed one date for Tuesday and another for Saturday. By 12:00 pm, I had reached back to my quarter at Alibaug. I took a look in the mirror, and the hair over my head looked like the hair of a guy who had been hit by either a series of hurricanes or a series of Government Job Exams. Let's just say that my hair was 'Undateable' — Which pretty much made me 'Undateable'. Also, I was skinny as fuck because of that whole *insomnia-act-sleep-cycle*. It was time to get these fixed.

24th August 2018, 5:30 p.m. | MPE guest house, Alibaug

My driver had just dropped me back at the guest house. It was Friday, which meant I was going back to Mumbai for the weekend. Life was finally being kind to me. The next day, I had a third date with Shayli — Originally from Pune and currently working in Mumbai. The plan was to watch a movie and have a chill weekend. After freshening up, I checked my phone and saw an overload of messages in my SCAR Interview preparation group. Time slowed down — Clock's ticks dilated.

"Well, I'm dead sure that I did enough to have my name on the list, but for some God-forsaken reason, if at all it isn't, then I'm dead for sure." I thought

I opened the pdf file with my nose breathing in the fresh air and my lungs throwing it out superheated. It felt like I had to compress and expand my chest manually to keep my heart pumping the blood, which was soon to experience a phase change due to this enormous decay heat. The pdf was in front of me, but I didn't have the courage to search for my name, typing alphabet by alphabet.

It was challenging every time I did it, but this time it was impossible. Anyways, based on my performance, I was pretty confident that I would be Rank 1. It was easier to scroll than to type and wait.

Rank - 1 Not Me.

Now, I could really feel my soul inch by inch leaving my body

Rank - 2 Not Me.

Rank - 3 Not Me.

With my hands shaking, I immediately scrolled all the way down to see if I was the last one on the list. I wasn't. Then I started to scroll upward. As I kept seeing other people's names, my soul on my side was already saying its goodbyes to the world that was not worth living in. It held a suitcase with a tag of *'Afterlife'* and sat beside me — *Tapped* on my shoulders and said,

"Ashwin, it's time for me to go... It was fun while it lasted, brother..."

Tap-tap again — But I was frozen — Trapped in the infinite loop of scrolling all the way up — Then down again,

"It's okay... just search the name, and let's end it. A stab to the heart is kinder than a thousand cuts." he said.

With my left hand's middle finger, I pressed the 'A' key, which had surprisingly developed a supernatural resistance — *7 Results Found*.

Left Index finger now on 'S' — *2 Results Found*.

Taking a deep breath before the third alphabet because I knew there were barely any other Indian names starting with "ASH". I imagined what my future would be like if I didn't make it? — That future was blank — Nothing at all — Pitch black — A side effect of securing all the parallel universes.

I pressed 'H' with my right Index finger — *1 Results Found*.

*Rank - 4..... Name - **Ashwin** Taksh*

I immediately checked the roll number — Memorized by heart — I checked it about a dozen times — Left to right — Right to left — A couple from center to the left then right. It was me. My soul zapped back in, but I couldn't breathe anymore. I tried hard to create a negative pressure in my lungs by increasing the Volume while the Temperature and Mass remained constant — So that the air could be sucked in, but the ideal gas law failed in real life. With my hand on my chest, I took short panic breaths for about 20 seconds until I realized this wasn't a dream, but it was as well. Now there were no more doubts. It just happened. I rushed out to the main hall, threw a *Jab-Straight* followed by a *Round Kick* and a *Tornado Kick* — Pushed the door open — Walked out, and started running in hopes of stabilizing my breathing — To feel normal again. It was however, a futile endeavor — For this was not a normal moment. I always wanted to live it, but there was no way to know how it would feel until it happened.

The first person that I decided to inform was my father. As a boy, no matter how much you fight it, you crave your father's voice — You crave his approval — You would go to any extent for his pat on the back. After all, your dad was your first idol. He was your first superhero. In the past 2 months, I had, for the first time, felt a physical pain of being separated from those I was bound by blood. I, for the first time, understood what it was like to be detached from your family.

“Yes, Ashwin... How are you?” He said.

Trying to stabilize the shake in my voice, I took a deep breath in and said what I had waited to say for the past 3 years,

“I got selected in ISRO.”

His voice all of a sudden brightened, and he exhaled,

“CONGRATULATIONS, BETA!!”

A father proud of his son and a son happy to pay back his debts by giving his father the honor of the credits of success. With such a beautiful moment I was standing at, I could have seized it and written a rainbow of an ending. But this is not that kind of story — The kind fabricated to please the common audience — The kind I was hoping to have when all of this began — The kind you would like to tell your son with moist eyes — It's the kind you remember Ashwin wrote about when it happens for real to you — The kind of story I call, *Reality*.

Instead of making peace, I decided to spray gasoline from my mouth and sparked a fire with a scratch of my fangs — Hoping it would somehow quench the inferno within me. I spoke with arrogance oxidized with that repugnant hate,

“Now you listen to me carefully, father...”

I pulled him into the ominous haunted silence that was my home for the past 2 months — Took a pause to make sure all his 5 senses were active. Then I continued,

“... From now on. You will... NEVER... Tell me what to do regarding my career... I have come so far all on my own, and I will go farther just like this.”

That was the day I realized that the pursuit of achievements teaches you many lessons along the way, but the one of forgiveness, it does not. It gives you the endurance to survive pain but doesn't teach you how to live free of it. With so

much venom held in my throat, I somehow leashed myself from disrespecting him. From saying,

“Remember what you said that evening? Remember what I told you?”

What I had not expected though was that his voice continued to be just as jolly and cheerful. My harsh words were not sufficient to ruin his day. I think he lost me at, *“I got selected in ISRO”*. Twenty-Seven when I write this, I’m not a father, so I can’t possibly imagine how he felt, and even I am not ignorant enough to pretend that I understand. Throughout this book, I have had several surges of urges to use the phrase: *“I cannot express it in words.”*

But instead of using that, I decided to explain it in words anyway. Every time I told myself: *“If you can’t explain it in words, then you have no business being a Writer.”*

But this one, I can’t. He chuckled and said,

“Son, I always wanted you to succeed in life, but what you were trying to do in resigning SCAR without anything in hand was wrong. All I want is for you to go as far as you want. Here, talk to Mom. She is dying to talk to you.”

“Congratulations Ashwin!! You did it! I’m so proud of you, *beta*. I always knew you would do it. This time your dart is on the bullseye.”

Her voice melted all the anger but wasn’t enough to melt my black ice ego. I laughed and said,

“I told you that I’ll do it!! Now there’s nothing left to prove, All India Rank 4. All the doubts have now been answered. I did everything that I wanted. Your son is now a Scientist at Indian Space Research Organisation.”

25th August 2018, 10:00 am | Starbucks, Churchgate

I made a video on my selection in ISRO — 20K views in one day. I was now officially a “Double Scientist” — Cracked a job while helping others to build a career, and people loved me for that. I was sipping my coffee while replying to comments on my channel when in a voice I recognized,

“Hi, Ashwin!”

It was the jolly voice of Shayli — Curly hair — Around 5’6” tall — Lean, probably weighed 40 kgs — Had a distinct fashion sense — The kind you’d call *Boho* — Her

clothes loose and full of color — Her hair had beads of blue, yellow and red — Skin complexion about the same as mine: Wheatish. What I liked about her was her crude Marathi accent and stoner attitude of not caring about anything. With an automatic wide smile, I gestured her to sit and said,

“Hi, Shayli! Coffee?”

On the seat in front of me, she allowed her body to go loose and let the gravity accelerate her ass downwards — Lucky gravity — One fine ass it was. The moment it touched the couch — On a cue, with rhythmic artistry, she raised both her legs — Crossed it in mid-air, and placed her heel on the chair adjacent to mine.

“Already ordered... So? Congrats on 1K subscribers, man!! How does it feel to be famous?” she asked with a shine in her eyes.

“I’ll consider myself famous when I don’t have to say my name to the Barista at Starbucks.” I said and took a sip.

“Well, at this rate, you’ll probably reach there by Christmas... 2050.” she responded with a giggle as she tucked some of her hair logs behind her right ear — Exposing her waist underneath her top — I noticed a Tattoo — Something in Japanese. I said,

“Famous at 60, something we all discreetly desire... Hey, what does it say?.. That Tattoo.”

“Shayli!” Announced the Barista.

She went to collect her coffee — Came back, and sat down — This time on a seat right of me — Leaned towards me with her elbows on her knees and said,

“Glad you finally asked! I flaunted it throughout the day the last time, but you never asked!! It says: *Art*.” she winked, and a cute dimple formed on her left cheek.

Shayli was into Sketching, painting, and fashion design. Last time, she showed me her clothing designs for an hour. Which, honestly, were fantastic. She told me that all the clothes and accessories she wore were both designed and stitched by her. Her creativity fascinated me. There was a sexiness in her uniqueness. I tried not to gaze at her too much, and so steered the conversation,

“So, why MBA? You don’t look like a manager.” I asked.

She rolled her eyes — Leaned back — Took a sip of coffee, and said,

“Well, thank you. I take that as a compliment... I had no directions about how to monetize my designs at 18. My Dad told me to get a job and then pursue whatever I wanted. He didn’t, however, tell me that it’d take 5 bloody years to get a job! And when you are in that world for that long, you are kind of become a different person, made by people around you... What about you? Why Rocket Science?”

I found it hard to keep my eyes off her lips, which she had undoubtedly noticed by now. I jolted out of that sight when she bit her lower lips — Waiting for my answer. I blushed like a newlywed bride and said,

“Well... ahhh... I became an Engineer first, primarily because I literally didn’t know any other career path at 18. I fell in love with machines in first year, and so I chose Mechanical Engineering. The more I studied, the more I wanted to make a career out of it. I was fascinated by Space Science & Engineering... So naturally, I made ISRO my target.”

Her eyes lit up as she said,

“Wow! You make it seem so easy, Ashwin...”

— She deepened her voice, mimicked my accent, and continued,

“... Oh... I had no idea what I wanted to do. I found Mechanical Engineering to be cool, and *Boom!* Now I am a Rocket Scientist.”

We laughed around and discussed our college lives for 2 more hours over 2 more cups of coffee. Then we decided to go to the nearest theater. 5 minutes into the movie, Shayli clutched my left arm tight — 20 minutes in, she rested her head on my shoulders. It had been over a year since I felt the touch of a girl. The first thought that came across my head was,

“God Damn! It’s outstanding how soft a girl’s skin can be.”

But for some reason, I did nothing in return. There was no reason to trust her.

“*Why?*”, “*Why Now?*”, “*Why not when I was alone and needed this touch?*” were a few questions that wobbled in my head. I couldn’t understand it then in that dark theater, but years later, I finally figured out that it was majorly because I met her a fucking week ago! Somehow a bad response from certain people at a bad time twisted me enough to question everyone with those questions.

I saw her shivering — Her hands were ice cold — I took my red flannel out and gave it to her. After 2 hours, as we walked out of the theater, Shayli, still in my shirt, said with her hands on my shoulders,

“What is it, Ashwin? You were lost somewhere throughout the movie.”

“I was lost trying to figure out why they spend millions for such crappy stories?” I responded with a shoulder shrug.

“Fair point... But in the movie’s defense, a guy and a girl don’t go to a theater only to watch a story.” she giggled and gave me that delinquent wink again — Her lips now prettier than ever. I couldn’t believe I didn’t kiss the shit out of her in there.

“But seriously though... you alright?”

“ahh... nothing, It’s aa..”

I had no idea what I wanted to say. Simar, the Rebellion, or the family were the things I hadn’t discussed with her. I wanted to but couldn’t. She smiled and said,

“It’s a girl, isn’t it?”

Confused again, I could not say anything. I placed my right hand on her waist and just took a few steps with her wondering what it really was. Shayli hopped ahead of me with that wide, mischievous smile of hers — My shirt slid down her left shoulder — Lucky shirt — She turned towards me and started walking backward — Stretching her arms, she said,

“So mysterious... so dark! I like it!! Who is it? Your ex? Come on boy, you can tell me.”

I wanted to tell her it’s not just a girl but a cocktail of events. I wanted to have one of those deep conversations with her and figure out that twisted one-year I had never expected. But instead, I said,

“Aaa... ummm... aaaaa... uhhh.” And then wrote a fucking book about it.

Seeing me tongue-tied, she blushed herself and said,

“Your eyes are so innocent... What a Devil she must have been.”

I tried to get out of this uncomfortable situation by relocating the spotlight. I asked her,

“You look like you’ve had a fair share of heartbreaks.”

“It’s so fair that it’s unfair!...” She said as she slid her top near her left shoulder and showed me another one of her tattoos — A black heart.

“He was a Professor... back in college. Twenty-five. Handsome guy with tattoos across his arms... He sang, dressed expensively, and played guitar... dream of every 19-year-old girl... Convinced me that we were in love. We were together for 2 years... or so I thought... We live, and we learn Ashwin. Whoever she was, whatever she did or whatever she didn’t, just remember that you haven’t even lived one-fourth of your life, and there is no way in hell that she was the one for you if you weren’t the one for her.”

On 31st August, at 4:30 pm, I received the official offer letter from ISRO. It was Friday. Monday morning, 3rd of September 2018, I dropped my official letter of resignation from NEA on the table of Padmanaman — Reason for Resignation: *Personal*. He was first shocked, then furious — After a few weeks, he accepted — I was to be relieved on 3rd October 2018.

30th September 2018 | Ridhdhi Apartment, Powai, Mumbai

It was 2:00 am. After a walk at Marine Drive, I brought Shayli with me to my friend Pratyay’s apartment. The two of us had the company of Pratyay, his roommate Ravi, some pizza, and weed. Shayli had her left arm around my neck — I could feel the silk fabric of her sleeve on my neck, which she used as support to keep her from falling — I could smell her perfume — Her earrings created a melodious jingle that was as effective as the weed that I had just dragged — Her curly hair braided on my left cheek. I had no clue what she was laughing about. Every oscillating sound wave with origin as her lips caused earthquakes down my chest. With her eyes barely open, she said,

“Ashwin... if only everyone could smoke this plant... there would be no wars...” she slurred the last word as she laughed.

Ravi smoked a drag and coughed so hard that we feared he might cough his lungs out. Pratyay, who was lying on the bed with a Pizza slice clutched in his hand, started laughing uncontrollably seeing this and somehow managed to say,

“You were saying no, Ravi? That you don’t get high no matter what... Now, you’ll soon be launched to the moon!”

“EXACTLY!!” shouts Shayli.

Everyone looked at her — She was still hanging by my neck — When I turned, my nose got lost in her curly hair, and a little tickle made me shake like I touched a live wire. This made Pratyay laugh even harder, but Shayli was dead serious. She pushed off my shoulder — Stood up, and continued,

“You see, we have been fighting forever! Going to the Moon was also a fight... We are all so dumb.... Umm.... but smart...umm... But dumb...hmmm...what... what was I saying again?” she asked Ravi, trying to recall.

Meanwhile, I was already missing her touch. Ravi shrugged his shoulders — Took a bite of pizza, and said,

“Something related to Moon.”

Excited again, she raised her right hand with her index finger pointing at the ceiling and exclaimed,

“Yess!! But weed can save us all! You know how Ashwin?”

Confused about what she was talking about and what I was thinking about, I said,

“How?” as I pushed myself backward on the bed — Gave my back the support of the wall and crossed my legs to take a comfortable seat. The Shayli Show continued, and I got lost in my own thoughts,

“Now that the ISRO target is accomplished, it is time to look forward. I can either let being an ISRO scientist be the peak of my career like my former colleagues did with SCAR, or I can keep moving forward. If this was what I achieved in 6 years with the laws I have learned, what can I build in 60 years to come if I continue? I need to get a higher education, maybe a Ph.D., start giving talks, start a Podcast and build my own Brand. Because one thing that SCAR taught me the best was that you cannot rely on a job for an income... you cannot even rely on one job for a career. I must build a career independent of companies, institutions, and organizations... I need to use them all, work with them but never let them use me. So the question is, what am I going to do next? What will be my next pursuit that will shadow my achievements of the 2017-18 era?”

“Where do you get lost all the time, Ashwin? Are you making rockets in your head?” Shayli snapped her finger and said.

Both Pratyay and Ravi were dead asleep by now. There are two kinds of people on this planet. Ones who sleep soon after smoking weed and those who can't sleep for hours. I was the second type, and so was Shayli.

She stepped on the bed and sat on my lap — Wrapped her legs around my waist — Looked deep into my eyes, and whispered,

“How does it feel?”

I placed my hands on her waist — Felt her soft skin as I slid them down until I felt her shorts — Clutched her butt, and said,

“Feels freaking fantastic.”

She smiled and came closer till her nose touched mine and said,

“and now?”

I made a gable grip around her waist and pulled her closer till her breasts pressed against my chest. I could feel her exhaling. I whispered in her ears,

“Now it smells fantastic as well.”

She pressed her forehead against mine — Looked into my eyes, and said,

“Let's see how it tastes.” and brushed her gentle hands through my hair.

I placed my lips on hers, and we both, with no care in the world, got lost in the beauty of what just happened.

We left for her apartment soon after. At 5 in the morning, we stood on her balcony, waiting for the sunrise with a cup of coffee. That's where I told her the whole story of what happened at SCAR.

“... I've got a lot of questions, but first...” she said, then took a look at the cup — Ran out of coffee — She walked towards the kitchen — I followed — She completed the sentence in confusion,

“... How come Simar's hair was naturally brown? Wasn't she... like, born and raised in Delhi?” She asked with air quotes over *Naturally* and then unlocked the espresso machine's portafilter.

“I don't know... Don't some people have it?” I asked as I passed her the ground beans.

“Not in India!” she giggled as she tamped — Her hands now weak as she couldn’t stop laughing.

“I’m telling you, Shayli... her hair was really brown.” I said as I took out milk from the freezer.

“I bet it was...” Still trying to catch a breath — Pressed the double shot button — Took a breath and said,

“... You are so cute when you dumb out at the most commonly known stuff... Ashwin! She fucking DYES her hair... It’s obvious!...” she got back into laughing while I still half believed she must be mistaken.

“Damn... You sure?” I asked, pouring milk into the pitcher.

“Obviously! I don’t even need to take a look at her to know that it’s not real, and you followed her mesmerized for a year without knowing that! O’ boy... I should have dyed my hair blonde before I met you... You would have totally bought it!... But apart from you not knowing basic stuff that even my 16-year-old brother knows... That’s one heck of a story!” she said as she took a sip and passed me the mug — We walked back towards the balcony. Staring at the stars, I took a sip, exhaled and said,

“Yeah... I’m thinking of writing a book on it.”

Her eyes widened as she said,

“That would be great! Writer Ashwin Taksh... What would you name your book?”

The title she gave me weirded me out a bit as I never thought of myself as anything other than an Engineer or a Scientist. I passed back the mug and said,

“Ahh... I have no idea. I don’t even read novels... Don’t know how the fuck I’m gonna write one! I suck at grammar and spelling in general too... which basically means I suck at writing.”

“Well... Didn’t you use to suck at science stuff too? You should get started ASAP...” she said as she punched my shoulder gently — Took out her pocket diary and continued,

“... Give me your autograph. I want to be the first...”

“Get out of here!” I laughed.

“What?!.. I know how girls go crazy after skinny romantic writers with long hair and drug addictions.”

“You can’t be serious!”

As it turned out, she was. I scribbled my signature on her diary — That was my first autograph. Within a year came the dawn of Instagram and selfies, and nobody gave a shit about autographs anymore.

On 3rd October 2018, I paid Rs 4,38,000 to NEA and broke my bond. At 4:00 p.m. sharp, I submitted my NEA Identity Card and was handed my official relieving letter. I walked out a free bird with chills down my spine and Rs 4,000 in my bank account. That evening I met Shayli to celebrate. She acted different — Sad, confused, and gloomy for the first time. She took two hours to tell me that her Ex had returned back in her life and that he wanted to get back with her. I told her it was alright and she could tell me what she felt. She said nothing and cried for the next 2 hours. Then she said that she didn’t know what to do but knew that she still loved him. I stepped back — Told her to take her time and to call me whenever she wanted to talk.

I decided to go back to Alibaug to get some silence — Mumbai gets too noisy in just a month — I also knew that this drinking and smoking weed had to end as ISRO selection was just the beginning of my career, not a successful end to it — For the next 3 days, I cleaned myself up — No intake of any more intoxicants — No junk food — Worked out and sweated a lot to flush out the remnants from my bloodstream — Made a couple of videos for my channel — Filled about a kilo of ISRO pre-joining forms — Personally guided a lot of kids getting into the competition of GATE, ISRO & SCAR over phone calls — Packed my stuff. Meanwhile, The following happened:

- My parents started getting mad respect on the streets.
- The college from which I walked out unemployed had printed that their student Ashwin Taksh, had gotten placed in both SCAR and ISRO.
- Started getting invites for interviews.
- Got sufficient time to talk to a few friends I had lost touch with.
- Started taking writing a book seriously.
- Shayli never called me again.

On 7th October 2018, I left for Trivandrum.

7th October 2018, 3:00 pm | Mumbai International Airport

Straight hair — Cat-eye glasses — As she took them off, I saw a smile in her eyes — Confidence on her lips — mischief on her nose. Around 5'8" — lean waist — Model material body measurements — Dressed in a white crop top exposing her perfect waist — Sky blue jeans that would end slightly above her ankle — Simple and sober slippers with white straps. There was something about the way she walked, which I, after some unknown period of time figured was in my direction. I just couldn't help but stare at her. Maybe it was the distinct sparkle in her eyes, which I, after some unknown period of time figured out was looking right into mine.

My logical side said,

"Theorem #1 of approaching a girl: You approach her. No matter how awesome you are, unless you have a guitar or a dog, she won't approach you."

I checked if there was a lost dog around me or someone else's guitar lying around. There was none. By now, she was just 4 ft away and moved to take a seat.

"Corollary of Theorem #1: If you have neither a dog nor a guitar. It is a prank."

"Hi! How are you doing?" She said as she sat down.

"Where are the cameras?" I asked as I took a sip of my coffee.

"What?!" She giggled.

"This is a prank, right?"

"Prank?!" She laughed for a few seconds. Then she said,

"No... Not a prank." as her focus changed to someone behind me — She raised her left eyebrow, winked with her right eye, and pointed towards me with her eyes to someone behind me. Before I turned, he sat beside me and rested his right elbow on the table. Long Silky black hair hanging a couple of centimeters below his ears — Clean shaved — seemed to be in his mid-20s — His skinny wrist had a *Casio* watch with a white dial — Brown leather belt strapped around it, which didn't go at all with the black tank, joggers and slippers he was wearing.

“Experiment-based alteration in Corollary of Theorem #1: If you have neither a dog nor a guitar. It is either a prank, or she is with another dude.”

He turned towards me, looked straight into my eyes like he already knew who I was, and said,

“Nice to finally meet you. You are taller than I thought.”

“Oh, now I get it. They must be my subscribers on YouTube.” I thought and said,

“Hey man, I get that a lot. You don’t get proper dimensions when you see just half of me, and that too without any comparison.”

“Seems like your flight is delayed. An all India server crash problem.” he said.

I don’t know how he found out that I was there to leave for Trivandrum, but it was pretty obvious to my followers, given that I was joining ISRO.

“Yeah... what to do... will be pretty late by the time I get there. Gotta look for a hotel too. You guys going to Trivandrum too?”

“Nah... LA... But we’ve been to Trivandrum before. Beautiful city.” he said.

He and the girl were holding passports. I looked at that pretty girl again, she had a constant smile of excitement on her face. Every time I would be approached by a fan, this would be an expected expression. But she was hotter than any of them. When she found me checking her out, she turned her vision towards me within a fraction of second and gave me a warm smile.

“But wait, I’ve met my subscribers before. They are all struggling chaps, none of them look like these two. Are rich people also preparing for Government jobs now? Or have you met them before? Maybe I guided one of them on a phone call. I did so many of them...” I wondered. Being famous has one disadvantage. So many new faces approach you and know more about you than you do about them that you start to develop a habit where you just pretend that you recognize them till they give some clue which awakes some buried memory of them. Hopefully, you would be able to recall where you met them, and if you’re lucky, you’d remember their name. Meanwhile, the guy said,

“I just wanted to see you face to face and tell you that you did a great job. We never thought we’d finally get a guy to pull it off. It’s completely your choice, but we would appreciate it if you could help us in the future as well.”

“Sure sure... I will do my best. By the way, what’s your name?” I asked with a smile.

“Anyways, bro... it was nice to finally meet you. I’ll contact you soon...” He said as both of them got up. He placed his arm around her shoulder and said,

“... We’ll miss our flight if we don’t go now. All the best for a new life! And yeah, don’t pay for a hotel. Go straight to ATF guest house. Type *VSSC Public Relations Office* on Google Maps and take a cab. They’ll give you a room once they see your call letter.”

Now I couldn’t resist anymore and asked,

“Hey! Do I know you guys? What’s your name?”

He smiled and said,

“Never ask that... You don’t need to know... Not yet, let’s go, *Maddam*.” he said, taunting the girl — The girl gave a cute and angry smile to him — He pulled her closer as they turned around in synchrony. Post few steps, the girl turned back at me and said,

“You should meet Junaid someday. Give him a treat. Go to Chikkalduti if you have to. You owe him that much.

That shrill in her voice was obnoxiously familiar. Till I could recover, they had already walked past the gate into the immigration section.

On 1st August 2019, *Crackify* published a 40-minute-long interview of mine. I was a lean, tall boy with a fancy hairstyle — Good dressing sense — Looked like I was 18 — Was considered smart enough to be both a Nuclear Scientist and a Rocket Scientist by the Government of India — Degree in Nuclear Science & Engineering from SCAR Academy, Former SCAR Scientist, ISRO AIR-4, Current ISRO Scientist, Martial Artist and on top of that, fiery with my voice — Perfect combo to grab attention. My interview got twice as popular as Arun’s interview — Competing for views with Civil Services toppers who had 100 times more eyes on them. I embraced all of it and torqued it to build a brand. My YouTube channel skyrocketed to 75,000 Subscribers — Started doing seminars all across the Country — Mumbai, Ranchi, Chennai, Bengaluru, Delhi, Kolkata — I was there to get your attention — All you have to do is scream hard enough, and long enough and you’ll get it — I then invested on my website — Streamlined consultancy session

bookings — Started my own Podcast and my own Personality Development course. Kept getting more and more interview invites, invites for talks at Universities, TEDx events, you name it. This was the point in my life where instead of running after a single opportunity, I picked and chose which ones to give the opportunity to. Not to mention, this was all on top of having the best career an Engineer can possibly have: Making rockets for a living.

11th October 2019, 9:00pm | Stage Preparation Building, SDSC-SHAR

“Ashwin, sir! How much to remove?” asked Vinay, standing 6 feet higher than me near the throat of *Vikas Engine*.

“150ml, do it slowly. Last step. Be careful, or we’ll be here till 12!” I shouted with a checklist in my hands.

My shirt was painted with patches of grease, and my hair smelled like hydraulic oil — Barefoot with my sleeves folded, I found myself at the tail end of a Rocket Engine nozzle — I looked into the opening and drove my vision across the ablative lining into the combustion chamber.

“Don’t worry, sir! One ml at a time!” said Vinay.

“Ashwin, filled the Checklist?” asked my boss, Karan Kumar, as he hurriedly walked into the clean chamber.

“Yes, sir. All ready. We should start preparing for the *One-Bar test*.” I responded quick in attention.

“*Sari...* Jaya! Talk to the facility about checkout. Tell them I’m coming.” he ordered.

It was the routine oil filling operation — A pre-launch activity of the *GSLV Mk II S4* engine. I was one of the Scientists from the engine team — Sent to SHAR, the Launchpad of Indian Space Research Organisation — For the launch campaign to finish a few of the final operations — To check if everything was perfect before this piece of metallic art launches off to leave our planet. Our team had reached SHAR a day before and had finished the pre-launch activities of two *L40* engines for the *GSLV F10* flight.

At ISRO, I enjoyed the work a lot — More than I had ever expected — Seeing those giant rocket engines through my own eyes was something I had never imagined, even in all those wild visualizations of what ISRO would be like. Not only just witnessing but playing a role in making them and then seeing them fly off the launchpad was an out worldly experience.

“Be careful in Sliding the Piston, Vinay!” I said as I climbed the ladder to the skirt region.

Vinay was a new technician sent to SHAR to get acquainted with the work.

“Yes, sir.” He responded promptly.

“The piston is of Steel and the body of Aluminum, Vinay. If a Harder metal hits against a softer metal, the dent will always be on the softer one. A minor scratch might leave the entire body useless, which would make the engine useless, the stage, the launch vehicle and the mission.” I explained as I helped the technicians unscrew the jigs.

“Nice, Ashwin! you are learning quicker than I expected.” said my boss as he walked away with a file.

Shankar took a step closer to me — Chuckled, and whispered,

“He still doesn’t know about your past. Did you learn this back in SCAR?”.

Shankar was my senior and currently a Scientist D. I was here to learn things quickly and replace him so he could take on bigger responsibilities by next year. To speed up passing the baton, I was sent to SHAR 5 times in the last 2 months.

“Yes, sir... Kind of.” I responded with a smile.

“Man, we also need a one-year training program for our Scientists. SCAR Academy teaches you so many things.” He said.

“It sure does, sir... It sure does.” I said as I rubbed my thumb on the circular ISRO logo on my badge, which was tucked on my chest pocket — A regular reminder routine that this was all real — Hanging by the logo pin was the vertical card — White in color with my picture at the center, and text that read:

Ashwin Taksh
Scientist/Engineer ‘SC’
ISRO Propulsion Complex

Indian Space Research Organisation

Epilogue

The Diamond Path

Everyone doesn't have a story. Everyone's life is not worth reading. But everyone can build a life worth writing — Worth reading. I believe that every life is made for a story. You were given life not with a story but with the consciousness to make your own choices and write your own story. You were given life, but it's your responsibility to give life to your story. What actions will you take today that you will be proud to put in your story? What decisions will you take that the world disagrees with but yet you prove right?

My mother was a writer. She wrote hundreds of stories, comics, and poems. Not one of them was published. I partially remember, as an 8-year-old, looking at those rusty papers where she had scribbled her Worlds. She never told me any of those stories, neither did she ever push me to write. I would get by through the next 10 years not caring about what I wanted to do — In the subsequent 6, trying to be a scientist. On 17th August 2018, I was sitting on the last seat of a shaky bus moving on the crooked and muddy road from Panvel to Alibaug, trying to share my ISRO Interview experience on the internet. Then I thought of writing the experience of that day since the morning — Then, since the written test on 22nd April — Then, since GATE 2018 — Then, since the SCAR 2017 interview, and that's when I realized that I have a story to tell. I had a story not because I was an idol. As you can see, I made a lot of stupid decisions in just one year that this book spans. I made some correct ones as well — Some easy ones and some tough ones. But correct or wrong, tough or easy, what matters is that they were my decisions — Which made my life mine — Which, in turn, gave life to my story.

Like your potential recruiter, life often offers you a contract that looks appealing. Attractive enough for you to reconsider what you really want to do. A contract for which the world will consider you 'Lucky' to have the offer. A contract that can improve your standard of living, status in your society, and relaxation from suffering. It takes a crazy individual and a tough decision to choose not to sign that contract. Why would you not sign? Why would you choose to fight a war that can be avoided? Why would you suffer when comfort is on the table? On the 12th of June 2018, I did not sign the contract that said:

"This is what happens when you don't obey. When you don't keep your mouth shut and do what you are told not to. We will punish you for what you did and set an example for anyone else who dares question us. You will pay for it, and as punishment, you will suffer. We will, however, support your existence. Do you agree?"

What leverage does life have on you if you are not afraid to suffer and embrace the chaos? These contracts that are offered for you to compromise are not only a possibility of an easy life but also the death certificate of your dreams. It takes all the courage that one has and sometimes what one doesn't, but develops, to Not Sign.

"Life, you do not understand. You do not get to give me a contract. I will write exactly how my life is going to play out. I'll put it on a contract, and you are the one who is going to sign. Sooner or later, you will, just like you hoped I would, for I will keep coming until you do."

It's a fight to get to live the life you want. It's a fight against the inertia of this world, and we fight it every day. The *Diamond Path* is that unique path that you build by not only taking the decisions that you want to but also by fighting every day to prove those decisions correct. We do what we can to get what we want. If that does not work, we push harder and do what we cannot. The only thing we say we can not do is to compromise with what we want,

*"If it is possible, I will make it happen.
If it is impossible, I will make it possible."*

Few Words from the Author

Thank you so much for taking out your time to read my words.

*Please leave a review where you bought this book from! It helps the author a lot.
Thanks in advance!*

Find my content online:

Youtube Channel: **Torq4712**

Instagram: **ashish_torq**

Website: **ashishtorq.com**

Podcasts:

1. Ashish Ranjan Talks (English)
 2. Momentum (Hindi)
- Available on YouTube, Spotify, Apple Podcast, Google Podcast, Amazon Music all the other audio Platforms.

Appendix

Let's face it, this book has a lot of names, and the world in which the story is set up is complex! So to save you from getting confused, here are all the important names. You may flip back here whenever you have a hard time remembering a place, person, or a full-form.

Full Forms: ESE: Engineering Services Examination FM: Fluid Mechanics GATE: Graduate Aptitude Test in Engineering ISRO: Indian Space Research Organisation K3: Nickname for a tight group of three friends: Kabir, Keshav and Kunal MD: Machine Design NEA: Nuclear Energy Agency PG: Paying Guest SOM: Strength of Materials TOM: Theory of Machines TS: Trainee Scientist UPSC: Union Public Service Commission VSSC: Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre Places: #804 • Location: 8th Floor, STH • Ashwin's room at Mumbai Campus. #59 • NEA Township, Vishvenpuram • Ashwin & Mahinder's quarter at Vishvenpuram Campus.	Names: Abhinav • Origin: Ranchi • Ashwin's brother (6 years elder) • HR at Garnier Akash • Ashwin's batchmate at AIT. • Ashwin's gym partner during college. A.K. Thakur • HOD, Mechanical Engineering, AIT • Faculty, Mechanical Engineering, AIT • Ex- Hostel Warden, AIT Amar Pratap Singh: Chairman of the Placement committee Arun Rathore:
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Axis Institute of Technology (AIT) - Location: Sikkim - Engineering College Ashwin graduated from. Chikkalduti: Unknown Location (MPE Plant) Cryogenic Technology Research Center (CTRC) - Location: Delhi Cyclotron Research Center (CRC) - Location: Kolkata Fast Breeder Research Center (FBRC) - Location: Vishvenpuram - NEA's Second largest research Center - Specialization: Plutonium-based Fast Breeder Nuclear Reactors FBRC - Bureau of Reactor Design (F-BRD) - Location: Vishvenpuram - Department under FBRC - Responsible for design and development of fast breeder nuclear reactors Moderator Production Entity (MPE) - Responsible for production of heavy water for NEA Nuclear Reactors. - It has multiple production plants. Few that we know of: Salrutpattinam, Chikkalduti, Odisha, Rajasthan. - Headquarters at Mumbai. Right next to SCAR Mumbai. Nuclear Fuel Rod Fabrication Center (NFRFC)	- Discipline: Mechanical - GATE 2017 AIR-6 - Origin: Unknown Arvind: Ashwin's roommate at AIT Hostel Ravi: - Ashwin's batchmate at AIT - Lives in the room opposite to Ashwin's at AIT hostel Ashwin Taksh: - Discipline: Mechanical - Origin: Ranchi - Graduated in 2016 from AIT, Sikkim Ashwin's Father: - Name: Unknown - Origin: Ranchi - Employee at Coal India Limited - Mechanical Engineer from BIT Sindri Ashutosh Rana: - Discipline: Mechanical - Graduated in 2013 from NIT Kurukshetra - Worked at Bajaj Auto - Nicknames: Ashu, Bald Motherfucker Chandan Sahu: - Discipline: Mechanical - Origin: Shimla Dipesh:
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- Location: Hyderabad Nuclear Regulation Entity (NRE) - Known centers: Mumbai, Chennai, Delhi Salrutpattinam: Located close to Kanyakumari (MPE Plant) Science Center for Atomic Research (SCAR) - Location: Mumbai - NEA's first and largest research Center - Specialization: Uranium-based Heavy Water Nuclear Reactors - Location: Vishvenpuram SCAR Academy: - Institution under NEA responsible for conducting a 1-year training program on Nuclear Science & Engineering. - Governed by SCAR SCAR Trainee's Hostel (STH) - Floor 7,8: Boys Hostel - Floor 6: STH Library - Floor 5: STH Mess & Girls Hostel - Floor 4: JRF hostels & Central Library Souresh Chattopadhyay Building - Location: SCAR, Mumbai - Located on its first floor: Waiting Room, Green Room The Bridge	- Discipline: Physics - Origin: West Bengal Faiz: 60th Batch Bottomer - Appears in Chapter 2 Ganesh: - Discipline: Electrical - Origin: Kerala - Previously JRF at VSSC Himanshu: - Discipline: Electrical - Close competition for Ganesh Javed: Ashwin's Point of Contact (POC) with Crackify. J.S. Mishra: Former head of SCAR Academy Kailash: Ashwin's batchmate at AIT and Delhi coaching Kantharaj Gowardhan Balamurugan - Manager, SCAR Academy - Nickname: KGB Mahinder Pratap - Discipline: Mechanical - Origin: Sonipat M. Swaminathan - Scientist at F-BRD, Vishvenpuram - Specialization: Fluid Flows Padmanaman: Deputy Director, Moderator Production Entity
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- Location: SCAR, Mumbai
- Located close to STH

Vishvenpuram:

- Location for FBRC
- Located Close to Chennai, Tamil Nadu

60th Batch: 2016-17

61st Batch: 2017-18

62nd Batch: 2018-19

All Mechanical TSs:

1. Adil Khan
2. Arun Rathore
3. Ashutosh Rana
4. Ashwin Taksh
5. Chandan Sahu
6. Gyan Kumar
7. Kabir Ram
8. Kunal Kapoor
9. Mahinder Pratap
10. Nishant Sharma
11. Rohit Kerketta
12. Raj (Nickname: Raju)
13. Sumit Timewala
14. Varun Jaiswal

Rajeev:

- From 60th Batch
- Posted at MPE Chikkalduti

Rajat

- HR at Maruti Suzuki
- Ashwin's Uncle

Ravish Chaturvedi

- Head of Research & Development of 6 Cylinder IC Engines at Tata Motors.
- Ashwin's advisor during his 8th Semester Internship.

Simar Kaur:

- Discipline: Physics
- Origin: Delhi

Souresh Chattopadhyay: Founder of SCAR

S.K. Chatterjee: Director, FBRC

S. Velmurugan:

- Scientist at F-BRD, Vishvenpuram
- Specialization: Structural Design

Sudha Goswami: Head of SCAR Academy

Sumit Timewala

- Discipline: Mechanical
- Graduated in 2017 from IIT Delhi

Suresh P.S.

- Professor of Reactor Engineering.
- Scientist at SCAR

Vaishnavi

- Discipline: Physics
- Origin: Asansol
- Simar's close friend

All Physics TSs (that we know of):

1. Dipesh
2. Poornima
3. Rashmi
4. Simar Kaur
5. Vaishnavi

About the Author

Ashish Ranjan started his career as an Engineer. In 2016, he Graduated with a B.Tech. in Mechanical Engineering as a department topper with a CGPA of 9.58 and a Bronze Medal. In 2017 he got selected for the Scientific Officer position at Bhabha Atomic Research Center, where he then joined and entered the one-year training program on Nuclear Science & Engineering offered by BARC Training School. He completed his training and received the degree in July 2018. On August 1st, 2018, Ashish joined the Department of Atomic Energy as a Scientific Officer but also simultaneously secured an All-India Rank of 4 in Indian Space Research Organization's National level Entrance exam for Scientist position. He then resigned from DAE and joined ISRO, where he worked in Liquid Propulsion. Ashish had been active on social media and was organizing educational events all across India ever since he joined ISRO. In January 2020, he resigned from his position in ISRO and continued working independently. He is publishing his first book inspired by his journey in India's most premier research organizations, named: "The Boy Who Did Not Sign". Ashish's Youtube channel, Torq4712 is currently at 2,37,00 subscribers and he runs a weekly Podcast called Ashish Ranjan Talks (ART) which is popular amongst the youth.